lost (i'll forget you now)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29698083.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Magicat OCs, Original Characters, Original Female Character(s), Original Male Character(s), Original Trans Character(s), Original Non-Binary Character

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Not Canon Compliant, Catra (She-Ra) Leaves the Horde, Set in season4, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Abuse, Past Abuse, Nightmares, Panic Attacks, Catra breaks down, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Self-Reflection, Self-Esteem Issues, Princess Catra (She-Ra), She finds her family, Flashbacks, Mostly from her time with Adora, POV Catra (She-Ra), Unreliable Narrator, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Hurt/Comfort, Healing, It Gets Worse Before It Gets Better, Yearning, POV Adora (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Internal Conflict, Identity Issues, Fate & Destiny, The heros don't always come out on top

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of fate keep pulling

Collections:
Banco Fic, Completed stories I've read, Catra finds her moms

Stats:
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by wiinterchild

Summary

"Are you threatening me?"
"Am I?" the other challenges. "As I said, we are on the same page."
"Wrong, you are with the Rebellion. I," Catra points at herself. "have nothing to do with the princesses. I'm out of this."
"You can't quit a way where you were the one calling the shots! You can't decide to just quit, life doesn't work like that! You owe the people who suffered because of you, because of your actions!"

Catra left. It's very simple, or she wishes it was. No matter how far she goes from the Fright Zone, the ghosts of her past, the mistakes she made, and those consequences follow her around relentlessly, haunting her. As she roams around Etheria, trying to find her place and peace she learns about herself, faces with secrets she buried deep within hoping for them to never come to the surface.

But no secret can hide forever, no matter how strong the magic is what buried it.

Notes

First of all, thank you to my dear friend Tara for the support and help she has shown me while I was writing. You are a literal angel.

Second, everything is already written down until chapter 9, I will update every week on Mondays, it will be a long ride so

buckle up folks! For the heads up, everyone is above 18 (except Frosta, sorry buddy), Catra is 20, and Adora 18. It doesn't follow canon storyline either.

If you want, you can check me out on Twitter @wiinterchild where I cry over catradora and have a daily she-ra brain rot! Unless you are a minor, then please wait until you turn legal age!

I also made a spotify playlist

I will also add a few visuals through hyperlinks!

Please enjoy, kudos and comments are appreciated!

See the end of the work for more notes

out of reach

❝ I kneel into a dream where I am good & loved.

I am good. I am loved.

My hands have made some good mistakes. They can always make better ones. ❞

- Natalie Wee


LOST
i'll forget you now
"You are not meant to drown, Darling. It's time for you to see it."
THE FIRE FINDS A HOME IN ME
Let the moons be yoir guide, the fire your light and the stars your companion. May your journey bring glory and peace to your soul. warrior of fire, welcome home.
@winterchild

"Hey, Scorpia. Where are you? It's not like you to be late." Catra complains sighing, then presses her badge.

She hears nothing but radio statics. Maybe Scorpia's badge isn't working well? She curls her tail around herself and hugs her knees to her chest. She sits at one of the broken statues of the Sea Gate looking over the endless sea, it still flips her stomach.

"Listen, I'll *kill* you if you tell anyone this, but... I thought winning would be...different. Or at least, more...I don't know... Fun?" She says hesitantly, her voice barely above a whisper.

Is it how victory should feel like? Empty? Lonely? She is almost at the top of the world, but she never felt so alone in her life before. So wrong.

Eventually, Catra tries again, pressing her badge. "Come on. Don't tell me you're still mad at me about before, are you?" She rolls her eyes, then a frustrated scoff leaves her mouth. "Stop being so sensitive. Get over it and *talk* to me, Scorpia!"

Yet again, only radio statistics.

"Scorpia? Scorpia?!"

She knew something wasn't right when she tried to contact Scorpia for the third time and she still didn't hear a single word from the scorpion princess. Now that she recalls it, she didn't see Scorpia among the soldiers this morning.

With a swift move, she jumps down the statue, landing on her feet with ease. She runs towards their set up camp.

"Octavia, did you see Scorpia?" She pants, her heart hammering wildly.

Did something happen to Scorpia?

The answer comes instantly. " *I didn't. She was supposed to lead the third and fourth squadron but didn't show up. Grizzlor took it from her.* "

"And you didn't think it was worth reporting?!" She shouts the need to scratch out Octavia's other eye too is rising strongly in her. "Bunch of idiots!" A growl leaves her mouth. "Prepare a boat for me, I'm going back to the Fright Zone." She tells a soldier who is fumbling with some paperwork.

"But-"

"I said to prepare a boat!" She slams her hand to the table, claws drawn out. " *Now.* "

The soldier hurries out, leaving Catra alone in the makeshift station building. She takes a deep breath and pushes her hair down. She presses her badge again, but no sign from Scorpia.

It took almost 3 hours from Salineas to the Fright Zone but as soon as Catra's feet touch the ground she bolts into the main building, to Scorpia's room.

She might have gotten sick? No. Knowing Scorpia, she would have barricaded her room and told Catra not to come even near her, because she doesn't want her to get sick too. But again, being sick is being weak in the Horde. Or did she do something stupid again and didn't want to come around? Although, it was Hordak's order to assist him and Scorpia would never disobey orders.

She stops at her door.

You are a bad friend.

Or simply, Scorpia just didn't want to see her face anymore.

Catra hesitates to push the button, her hand lingering above it. She gulps dryly, pushing down her hesitation and the door opens.

Revealing nothing but an empty room. A room that looks like it hasn't been used in days.

She steps into the room, noticing Scorpia’s badge on the bed, on top of the jacket from the Crimson Waste and a folded note. Catra stares at these three things like she expects Scorpia will magically appear by one of them, or she would jump out from somewhere. But deep down Catra knows it's not true.

Catra takes the note from the bed and reads it. Simple words, still, they push Catra down. Down to something deeper and nastier than where she has been hanging from all these years.

Turns out, no one has seen Scorpia in two days.

Since she gave Catra the broken recorder.

The only thing you've ever done is get in my way! What did I expect, I mean, how could you possibly be this useless?!

Catra crumbles to the floor.

I'm sorry Wildcat.

Scorpia

Nightmares weren't uncommon for Catra.

They have been haunting her since she could remember. Every night another round of memory would come to the surface, grab her with sharp claws and never let go until she was screaming and crying. Sometimes it would be memories of Shadow Weaver and red electrical lights dancing around her violently, other times it would be Adora leaving her again and again while Catra was left

behind in the dark. But nowadays, it would be about the portal. That damn portal.

It would appear in front of her, drawing her in and no matter how desperately she would try to crawl away, there's nothing she can cling onto, no one who would hold her hand. Although she wouldn't admit it even to herself, she screams for Adora, hoping that she would hear her and help Catra.

But she never comes and Catra is startled awake by her own dark memories alone in her room, with a wildly beating heart and cold sweat covering her body. Left alone to deal with her demons.

This night wasn't an exception either.

Catra woke up with a harsh scream stuck in her throat, her claws sharp against her skin, leaving ugly red lines as she clawed herself in her sleep. She sits up slowly, holding her head in her hands breathing harshly, her tail thrashing around anxiously. She takes a shaky deep breath, trying to calm herself down, she barely slept at all. The deep circles around her eyes are a harsh contrast with her tan complexion.

She eventually kicks the blanket away, freeing her lower body and coldness envelops her body, as strange as it is, the cold grounds her to this world, away from her dreams.

"This is ridiculous." She hisses, anger creeping into her heart.

Because being angry is better than being afraid.

Her way leads to the control room, steps are determined, powerful even, dark circles are prominent under her ice-cold eyes, she won't let anyone see her as weak. The moment she enters the control room, another Horde soldier comes after her, saluting rigidly.

"What?" Catra asks flatly while looking at him. "Do you have news about Force Captain Scorpia?" Her pupils narrow down into a slit, a hopeful sparkle lighting up in her heart.

"Uhm, no...no we have no news about where For-"

Catra growls at him out of a sudden. "Then why are you bothering me?!" She snaps at the soldier, her voice full of venom and anger.

"W-we got a report that the Rebellion is trying to take back Elberon." He squeaks, taking a few steps back when Catra fully turns towards him.

"Then send more troops there!"

"Our troops just got back from another mission, they are exhausted and our weapons..." He trails off, his back hitting the door, Catra tracks up to him, her face nonchalant no sign of the previous anger.

"Are they exhausted? Aww..." Catra tilts her head, voice sweet as honey her tail slowly lashes around. "Everyone is tired, we are in a *war* ! I don't care if they will crawl their way into Elberon, I don't care if they will have to fight with teasers, they will march there and defeat the Rebellion, do you understand?" She hisses at him, the man nods rapidly. "Great. Now get out of my sight."

The soldier hurries out of the room, the door closing after him automatically. Catra stands in her place for a few long seconds, her breathing becomes uneven, her claws bite into her palm.

A roar leaves her mouth followed by a dull thud on the metal wall where her fist landed.

"Where are you Scorpia?"

The question rings in the silence of the room. It's so overbearing. So alone. So pathetic. Catra takes a deep breath and pushes her hair down, she turns around and looks at the monitors, each of them showing a rebellion town that's under the Horde's control. Salineas, Dryl, Erelandia, Thaymor and many more. They are winning, the Horde is winning. They are pushing down the Rebellion each day, gaining more power.

That's what Catra wanted, that's what she has strived for, yet everything just feels empty.

She feels empty.

It takes a few hours to hear from Elberon, they have got the town back. Of course, they did, Catra smirks to herself. Her mind is working on yet another plan to take more and more, eventually, destroy Bright Moon and the Princess Alliance with it.

Wildcat.

She whips around the chair almost tumbling down. Scorpia, she would call out the name but she sees yet again nothing. She closes her eyes, willing away any thought that can distract her again. Scorpia is not here, they are not here.

The door once again opens and Lonnie walks into the room, her armour has a few cuts here and there, a faint bruise slowly blooming on the side of her face. She stands there a little awkwardly, the other obviously not paying any mind to her. Lonnie coughs to have Catra's attention on her.

Catra groans in response. "What is it, Lonnie?"

"We've got Elberon back, the Rebellion soldiers retreated." She reports to Catra, the feline not even looking at her. A minute passes without Catra saying a thing. "Uhm... Is everything okay Catra?" She asks hesitantly.

Catra snaps her eyes open and looks at the soldier with narrowed eyes, her tail moving slowly. But says nothing. Does she look weak? Defeated? The thought makes her stomach flip, sickness creeping up on her slowly. She isn't weak. She doesn't need anyone's pity. She is Hordak's second in command, she basically *runs* this fucking place.

Catra is much stronger than them, then why is Lonnie looking at her like she is a little frightened kitten in a box.

A growl begins to form in the back of her throat just at the thought. “Get-”

“We have information about Force Captain Scorpia.” Lonnie rushes before Catra could yell at her. “We were able to capture a Rebellion soldier, he might be able to tell us something about her.”

Catra hesitates at first, throwing a sceptical look at Lonnie. “Why are you so sure about that?”

“He is close to one of the princesses, Mermista.”

Catra’s eyes widen for a second, then her initial shock forms into a cruel smile, her eyes lighten up with something unsettling. Her tail moves almost excitedly. The last time Loonie saw Catra like this was when she demolished a Rebellion town.

This won’t have a nice ending.

“Take me to him.”

Lonnie brings Catra to where Sea Hawk is, he is bound to a metal column in one of the makeshift establishments. He looks war beaten, and tired. Catra doesn’t really care. Her mind is playing a cruel trick on her again. Why would a Rebellion soldier know anything about Scorpia? Especially someone so close with a princess.

Of course, the answer is almost evident, but Catra chooses to ignore it and banishes it to the deepest part of her mind.

Scorpia didn’t join the Rebellion.

They must have captured her. Yes, that’s what happened.

“Oh.” Sea Hawk looks at his visitors, recognizing Catra instantly.

“One of my Force Captains is missing. Does your pitiful Rebellion know anything about her?”

Sea Hawk hums, furrowing his brows. "You need to be a little more specific here I'm afraid."

Catra's eye visibly twitches. "And I'm afraid that if you don't get your brain working, you will be sent back to the princesses in pieces."

Sea Hawk glances at Lonnie for a second, the Horde soldier just nods. She isn't kidding.

"W-well, we don't have to be so threatening do we?" He chuckles nervously.

Catra grabs his jaw and locks eyes with him. “I will ask you again. Do you know anything about Scorpia?"

The question hangs in the air and for a moment Catra thinks that Lonnie was wrong. This dumbass knows nothing, and then...

“You mean that big half scorpion half-human lady with white hair?” Sea Hawk asks, deep in his thoughts. “Oh, she is in Bright Moon!" He announces and Catra lets her go.

"Lonnie, get a group. We are going to bring Scorpia back. I can't believe she let herself be captured by these idiots!" She pushes her hair back with an annoyed groan, walking away from Sea Hawk.

"She wasn't captured."

Those words are like lightning through her body, she stops dead in her tracks. "What?"

Sea Hawk either doesn't have any respect for his life or just a very brave idiot. “Well, my dearest Mermista said that she has joined the Alliance! Well, after all, she is a princess so it was kind of inevitable, right?” He chuckles to himself. “Must have been hard for her.”

“What did you just say?”

Sea Hawk looks up and sees Catra looking at him with a slit pupil, anger and betrayal written all over her face.

"What did you say?" She repeats herself, her voice dangerously low. "Scorpia… has joined the… Alliance?" she starts to laugh surprising everyone in the room.

Lonnie jumps in time, grabbing Catra by her waist before she could pounce on Sea Hawk with a violent growl and draw out sharp claws. She trashes in Lonnie's hold, clawing at her armour violently.

"Catra-"

"Don't *lie* to me!" Catra screams at Sea Hawk seeing red, anger boils under her skin. "Scorpia would NEVER join the pathetic princesses! She wouldn't! WHERE IS SHE?! Where's Scorpia?!" Her voice booms around them, echoing back from the metal walls.

Lonnie manages to drag her out leaving Sea Hawk alone and shocked at Catra's unexpected outburst. Catra's whole body shakes as she tries to get rid of Lonnie's arms and at least claw a souvenir to Sea Hawk's face.

"Let go of me, Lonnie!" She breaks free from her hold, kicking the soldier in the stomach sending her to the ground. She heaves, claws once again digging into her palm. "How dare you-"

"Catra calm down!"

"Don't tell me what to do!" She snaps at her, her voice almost hysteric. "Didn't you hear him?! Scorpia is with the princesses! The *princesses* !" And suddenly Catra throws one of the cargo away that was next to her, almost hitting Lonnie. She pants heavily from her anger. "She… She left the Horde… She left… Left…" Her breathing slowly evens out, her claws retract back, she blankly looks at Lonnie. "Scorpia… Left…" She repeats it yet again.

And it's all back again.

She's alone. All alone. Scorpia left her for the princesses, just like Adora.

"Catra-"

Without paying attention to what Lonnie wants to say, Catra turns around and leaves. She walks away, eyes staying wide open, her heart beats so fast her breathing is picking up again. Her steps start picking up the pace, soon she is jogging and now she is sprinting through the corridors where the bedrooms are and eventually stops at Scorpia's room. She pants harshly, tears blinding her vision.

She pushes the buttons and walks into the room, the door closing behind her. She takes the room in sight, the drawings and posters on the walls, about her, about them, about her stupid super pal trio. The picture of her family, a scorpio plushie. The jacket from the Crimson Waste.

With a frantic look she tears down the posters, they fall to the floor in front of Catra.

Scorpia left. She left. This is all your fault. *You* did this. *You* pushed her away. Just like you pushed Adora away. Just like you pushed *everyone* away.

The ugly side of her mind tells her and she finally blacks out, destroying everything in the room. Because that's the only thing she is good at. Destroying things. Destroying everything around her, so why shouldn't she just keep destroying?

Everything that makes her *weak.*

When she is done with the room it looks as if a hurricane ran through it. The mattress is torn, thrown at the other end of the room, the family picture lays on the floor with broken glass. The posters and drawings are torn into pieces just like the plushie. Catra is heaving at this point. Mix of numbness and alertness keeps her heart beating fast, her body shaken. She pushes her hair down again, with a deep sigh.

Her body reacts to the raging emotions of betrayal and anger coursing through her veins, but her mind, it's almost blank.

"You've made your choice Scorpia." She whispers before leaving the room.

Catra has no idea what time it is, everything is calmer and quieter so it must be night time by now. The distant sound of the machinery gives her some kind of sick comfort. Makes her feel just a little bit at peace. Makes her feel like she is a machine as well. For everyone to use and throw away when they don't need her anymore. She was one for Shadow Weaver, something to use and throw away, she is the same for Hordak even if she wants to believe otherwise. Adora left her so simply, Scorpia too. Entrapta…

She is all alone.

Once she thought it was her on the top, but now, it simply feels like she is falling again into a pitless chasm while everyone around her disappears. Shadow Weaver, the one who made her life miserable, made *her* miserable, is in Bright Moon, allied with the princesses. How fucking ridiculous.

And Adora? Adora gets to live the life of the hero, everyone loves her, everyone wants to be around her. It was always like this, Adora the one who shone so brightly, the shadow she cast annexed Catra. Adora meant to be the good guy, Catra didn't.

She stops abruptly in the middle of the corridor, looking out of the window. The Fright Zone buzzing busily, soldiers working through the night, war machines striding across the route, supplies thrown into vans. Her reflection looks back at her, tired, blank and numb. She reaches out, hands on the cold glass.

"How… Disappointing." Her claws sink into the glass, scratching it with an empty star.

She walks through the hallways, the blankness on her face not giving away the storm in her soul. Her way leads back to the

control room, the monitors flashing an unnatural blue light all over the room. Illuminating her tired, bloodshot eyes.

Destroy everything that makes you weak.

The first blow to the monitor sends burning satisfaction to her soul, she tears down the second one throwing it to the other side of the room. Catra doesn't hesitate to take this whole room apart, yanking off the monitors and other electronics. She mashes the control panel with one of the smaller monitors. And then, she hears Hordak's voice.

"Report Force Captain Catra. How is our operation working?"

Catra almost laughs at him.

Our ? He did nothing. He was hiding in his pity lab, playing with his little robots. It was all Catra. Every town, every city, every plan, every mission. It was all Catra. Not Hordak. Not Hordak *and* Catra. Just Catra. Even if he finally dug himself out to the world, everything was laid out before him. Catra got him the weapons, the resources, *everything* .

"We did." Catra answers, her voice almost way too calm to her usual temper. "Everything is under control." A smile appears on her lips.

"Come to my sanctum, we need to launch the next act of the Plan soon."

"Of course."

Hordak's call ends here. Catra grabs the last monitor and tears it down from the display throwing it out of the window, it crashes loudly against the concrete. Broken glass scattered around her, one cuts her cheeks, one single drop of blood falling to the floor.

Catra takes a deep breath once again, but instead of pushing her hair down like usually, an act of control, she takes off her headpiece. She looks at it, swiping her finger over the piece

before she snarls and throws it away, buckling down onto the floor letting out a loud sob, letting it rip out of her chest after she has surpassed it for so long. Her mismatched eyes are shining with tears, droplets falling against the ground as Catra leans forward, gripping her hair. She bites her lip to surpass her cry, fangs easily pierce into it, drawing blood, but Catra doesn't care.

Not right now.

Her chest tightens each time she lets out a sob, her head is pounding so heavily it makes her sick, tears running slowly. She shakes and shudders with each new wave of panic running through her body.

Emotions that she has buried deep down for years break to the surface, ripping her old wounds, leaving them to bleed with new ones. She wanted to be stronger and powerful, then why does she feel so weak and vulnerable? It shouldn't be like this; she shouldn't end up like this. She was supposed to be the victorious one.

But then why did she lose everything?

Disappointment. Failure. Insolent child. Nuisance. Pet. Waste.

Shadow Weaver's voice rings in her head as if the sorcerer is right next to her. But no one is here. She is all alone.

Was Shadow Weaver right? Is she really so worthless?

"No..." She whispers weakly. "She wasn't right... I'm not... I'm not worthless." Catra shudders for one last time before she forces herself to stand up, looking at her shaking palms. "I'm not a failure," She tells herself, wiping away the remains of her tears.

Destroy everything that makes you weak.

Everything.

Everything.

"I'm not weak."

Catra's body moves on its own, it's almost like she sees herself from the outside. She leaves the control room, coming down to one of the transporters where they store one specific weapon. Explosions.

She opens it easily, kicking down the lock, stepping inside. Catra takes three small ones with herself. The feline jumps out, depositing one right to the door of the control room, she times it to 20 minutes. It would be perfectly enough for everything.

Then her next target is the supply room, the last one is the hangar.

But she doesn't stop here, no.

She walks away, to the place that will either be her grave or the place she will spit at before leaving this miserable place.

Hordak's sanctum.

No one stops her, why would they? She is the second in command, she can freely go wherever she wishes. The door opens behind her, she steps into the lab and lets the door fall shut before she punches the controller so it can't be opened again. She turns around, seeing Hordak's back. She draws her claws out, her tail swishing around wildly. As if she is ready to hunt.

“Report on our troops in the Whispering Woods.” The order comes naturally to him, Catra’s ear twitches lightly.

No answer, she walks closer to him.

"Catra?"

Catra's laugh soon fills up the whole lab, it's not cheerful, more like a bitter, empty one. "You know... I always knew what the Horde was up to, I knew it since I was 8. I knew after Shadow Weaver first shocked me with her power. I knew it when I've seen

the orphans just like me, brought here and raised as nothing but ruthless soldiers." She wanders around the lab, scraping her nails against one of the containers of Hordak's failed clone.

"And we were made to believe we are nothing, but weapons in your hand. We were taught to feel honoured that the Horde has *chosen* us. What can I say, it looked appealing as a child." She looks at Hordak, her eyes reflecting nothing but emptiness. "I've had dreams, goals, ambitions. But they all crumbled to pieces, what a shame."

"What is this about, Force Captain?" Hordak narrows his eyes at Catra, he is clearly annoyed.

"You've made me this way. Shadow Weaver made me this way. The Horde made me this way. This... broken, miserable, pathetic someone who lost *everything* ." She hisses aggressively. "But *you* ...you have so much!" She slashes the air in front of her as she points around. "You have the Horde, the empire that you would offer to Big Bad Horde Prime." Catra smirks at him and her fist breaks the container suddenly. "I'm going to take that away from you."

Hordak fired his gun the moment Catra jumped toward him, the catgirl rolling away from the shot. The laser has destroyed half of the clones. Catra disappears from Hordak's sight, crouching on a pipe a few feet above him.

"Don't be ridiculous!" Hordak growls, looking around for the girl. "No one ever made you do whatever you've done. No one made you this way, you made yourself suffer! You would be *nothing* without the Horde *.* " He says mockingly. "I will throw you to the deepest dungeon and offer you to Horde Prime, a traitor, a defect-
"

Catra jumps down to Hordak's back, sinking her claws to his face, slashing the flesh without mercy.

"Am I a defect?" She laughs, kicking the alien away. "Look at you, your armour holds you together, you were sent here to die because you are nothing but a failure! You can't even clone yourself!" She snarls at him, running away from yet another laser beam, behind her a tank has blown up, the wall melted away leading to the hallway. "Didn't you notice?! I run things here! Without me, you would be still licking your wounds, because of Entrapta's betrayal!"

Hordak attacks her again with a shout, Catra easily jumps out of each. She is about to jump up to another pipe when Hordak aims at the pipe and she falls to the floor with a pained moan, the parts of the destroyed pipe falling on her.

She rolls away, trying to stand up with a tumble, a sharp pain striking at her side and leg. Her tight is injured, her side bleeds a little. She sways around, finding support in the wall.

"Do not speak her name again!" Hordak attacks her again, more viciously, more wildly blowing up his lab and Catra jumps out to the hallways. Hordak follows her.

Catra lets out a laugh, jumping away from yet another attack, wincing at the sharp pain. "Entrapta didn't betray us, you know." Catra stops, facing Hordak. The wall behind her has a huge hole from Hordak's previous attack. At this point, every rational thought about survival left her brain. As if she is toying with death, would it catch her today? Or tomorrow? " *I* sent her to Beast Island."

The laser beam came too fast and Catra wasn't quick enough, the blow getting her, and with a scream, she fell back. The familiar feeling of her heart stop beating for a second, then beat again with newfound life rushes over her.

She has lost a life.

She groans and catches herself quickly on a ledge, pulling herself up to it. She doesn't have enough time to recover. Another light

beam is aimed at her, Catra jumps away, Hordak following her yet again.

Catra lands on a bridge connecting the two biggest buildings. She stumbles forward, falling to one knee panting heavily, her side covered in red.

Hordak appears on the other side, his face painted red with the ugly wound Catra has left on him. The fight taking a toll on Catra, her wound doesn't help, the throbbing in her thigh subdued by the adrenaline coursing through her veins.

She glances up, she sees a bunch of cords hanging from a higher level, she readies herself.

"You are wrong… I didn't need the Horde. I didn't need Entrapta. I didn't need Adora, or Scorpia..." The echo brings Catra's voice far away, it's trembling with power despite the pain throbbing in her body.

Before Hordak could get her again she jumped, grasping one of the cord. "And I don't need YOU!" Catra flings herself at Hordak, kicking him, the claws on her toes scratching his neck. Hordak stumbles back and Catra attacks again, punching him right in the face, then with a well-aimed kick she destroys the laser gun around his arm.

Hordak's other hand closes around Catra's neck, pinning her to the floor, his red eyes glowing violently. Catra chokes, the pressure becoming stronger. She claws at Hordak's hand, blood dripping down the floor and her, staining her hand, clothes and under claws. She kicks him in the neck again, the man stumbling back with a pained groan. Catra quickly leaps and tears out the First One tech chip from his armour, sending Hordak to the floor as electricity runs through his body.

Catra is panting above him, coughing for air. Her neck is red from the choking; her side is still bleeding. She stumbles to the side,

unsure on her legs. She looks down at Hordak who is still twitching from the electricity of his malfunctioning armour.

An explosion shakes the whole ground coming from the control room. Catra looks back, seeing thick black smoke going up to the sky. She can't help but laugh, her giddiness takes over her body. She looks back at Hordak, and drops the chip down to the floor, stomping on it.

"It's over Hordak. Good luck impressing Big Bad Horde Prime." Catra flashes her a fanged smile, dripping from venom and hatred.

Another explosion. The supply room.

She takes a few steps back, then jumps off the bridge, catching herself yet again and climbing down until she lands on her feet. She winces at the sharp pain spreading in her leg. She takes a deep breath and runs away towards the hangar. If she calculated well, she still has 5 minutes until the hangar would be blown up too. Catra just needs a skiff and she would be free from this place.

The door of the hanger opens easily with a forceful kick, and she runs into the massive place. The ticking of the clock could be heard faintly from where she has placed it. Adrenaline rushes through her body as she jumps up to a skiff, turning it on and dashing out of the place she is halfway away from the place when it blows up.

Her ears flatten at the sound of the explosion. As she looks back all she can see is thick black fog and flames stretching up to the sky.

What she doesn't expect is Kyle.

She abruptly stops the skiff; they are at the border of the inner part of the Fright Zone. She narrows her eyes looking at Kyle and the boy looks even more scared than he usually is. Catra thinks

she must look like a mess with bloody hands, unruly and dirty hair and some bruises and cut on her body.

"Get out of my way, Kyle." She hisses at him. "Or do you want me to run over you?"

Instead of saying a word, he throws something at Catra. She half expects it to be a grenade, a weapon or anything that could hurt her. But it's a bag instead. It lands in front of Catra.

"I... I've seen you place the explosions, I guessed you wouldn't...uhm, wouldn't come back." He explains nervously. "There's a few ration bars in there and... Water, also uhm, some gauze."

Catra blinks at Kyle, understandably confused over the situation. Suddenly, the alarms blare all over the Fright Zone. They will be coming for her.

"Shit" Catra hisses looking back, then to Kyle again. "Why?"

"You... uhm, you are m-mean Catra, but...we've grown up together, and...just take...take care?" Kyle tells her, looking worried at her as he anxiously fondles with his hand.

Catra stares at Kyle, then looks at the bag again, she nods. And then she sets off the skiff again, sailing through the Fright Zone with full speed.

She looks down at her chest, taking the badge from it. The badge stares back at her, then with a simple move, Catra crashes it in her hand, letting go of the pieces.

Destroy everything that makes you weak.

She is *not* weak.

The skiff glides easily in the air, the scenery around Catra seems familiar, but her mind is too numb to fully understand where she is exactly. Her whole body hurts, she has hastily wrapped her side with the gauze, but it will need a decent cleaning and wrapping up at some point.

It takes her a few minutes to recognize the trees stretching up to the sky with intricate fauna growing around them under the moonlights. She stops the skiff, her heart beating vehemently.

"The Whispering Woods." She speaks softly, barely even a whisper.

The memory of Adora comes to her mind when they first came here, how quickly everything has changed after it. Part of her, probably that hopeful child that she was able to protect from the horrors of the war, tells her to go to Bright Moon. Go to Adora. Because Adora means safety. Adora would understand, she would hug Catra, telling her that everything would be okay. Like she used to.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.

She slowly manoeuvres the skiff to the direction she knows where Bright Moon is, and for a second, she would have believed in that childish hope in her heart. But it disappears the moment she remembers Entrapta, the portal, how Adora had looked at her, the Queen. A strangled gasp leaves Catra's lips and she turns the skiff around hastily, racing through the woods, the wind catching in her hair, now that her headpiece is missing her hair dances around messily.

Adora doesn’t mean safety anymore, Adora wouldn’t understand anymore. Adora wouldn’t hug her anymore.

To be honest, even Catra doesn't know where she is going. She just knows one thing, away. Away from everything. Away from the

Fright Zone, from the Horde, Hordak, Shadow Weaver, the war, her memories, the stupid princesses, Adora *, herself.*

Just away from everything.

Shadow Weaver's voice in her head says that she doesn't deserve to run away, tells her she doesn't deserve peace. It would be hypocritical even from her wanting to get away from everything when she has hurt so many people. And for a moment Catra almost drives into a tree. Because Shadow Weaver is *right.* Like she was always through all these years. She is nothing but a failure, a disappointment, a nuisance. Someone who can be easily thrown away.

CATRA.

Adora's voice rings in her ears as if she is screaming into her ears. She stops the skiff barely avoiding the crash with the tree. Catra's chest heaves, her head throbbing with a building headache, her tail moves around uncontrollably.

Wildcat.

Catra turns around, scanning her surroundings with her mismatched sharp eyes. Scorpia is not here, of course, she is not. But a part of her hoped that the tall woman would suddenly appear out of nothing.

"This wood..." She whispers to herself. "It's just playing games with me." She tells herself, letting herself calm down, as best as she could but her mind is chaos, a whirlwind of memories, old and newer ones, haunting her. She eventually restarts the skiff and drives away.

The moment she leaves the woods it's like a weight has been lifted from her chest, she gasps for air, tears running down her cheeks. She finally breaks down, a loud and pathetic sob rips out of her chest. She surges forward, hugging herself, she wraps her tail around her waist a small act of comfort, her ears are flattened down. Her heart beats against her ribcage painfully, and for a

moment Catra wouldn't mind if it would just stop beating at all, it would save her from all of these pain and memories that have been haunting her for years.

"I'm sorry....sorry, I'm so sorry–" She whimpers weakly, she doesn't know who is saying this.

To the people, she has hurt before? To Adora? To Scorpia? To herself? Or that little child who has always hoped when she grows up she will be strong and happy, and she will be a leader. But instead, Catra is here in the middle of nowhere, defected, broken and miserable. When she wrecked the control room and left stealing a skiff she didn't think through where she would go. The Horde is obviously going to hunt her, Hordak finding pleasure to finally kill her off. And the Princess Alliance? Catra is sure that they would happily skin her.

After a time, she has calmed down and now just sitting on the floor, back leaned against the bench. The skiff is still turned off. She looks at the bag, taking a ration bar from it. A scoff leaves her lips as she notices that all of them are grey ones.

"How many lives do I have still?" She furrows her brows, eyes tiredly looking up at the sky. The moons are shining brightly in the night sky. "I... have lost one at Princess Prom, another when that spider got me, Hordak suffocated me," she counts on her fingers as he tries to remember every time she has died but came back thanks to her nine lives. "I... I- I let myself go into the portal, then again. And Sparkles's magic did a number on me too. Hordak blasted me with his laser." She sighs to herself. "I still have two lives." She concludes to herself.

A scowl forms on her face, pushing her hair back with a deep sigh. She takes another bite of the bar. "I need to be careful...do I... need to be careful?" She questions herself with a furrowed brow, holding onto her ankles. "It's not like someone would miss me if I ran out of lives, right? I would even do a favour for everyone." Catra sits up, her voice nonchalant as if she is not talking about dying.

But if Catra thinks about it really, she has given up caring up about living for so long. Maybe in the Crimson Waste, she has said that she has nothing to lose, but she still desired Hordak's trust and acknowledgement. She had dreams, ambitions, goals. She *wanted* something out of this life.

Some people have a bad day. I've had a bad life. If I want something, it's taken from me. If I win a fight, I lose the war. Threats only work on someone who has something to lose. But me? I've already lost it all.

But now? She has *nothing.*

With a heavy sigh Catra stands up, and turns the skiff on, driving away from the Whispering Woods.

Seeing Loonie, Kyle and Rogelio again on the other side of the war is always going to be strange. Adora can't deny that she is worried for them, she doesn't want to hurt them of course, but they are still with the Horde. The same Horde that is trying to conquer Etheria and kill all of them.

Adora knows how well Lonnie can fight, Rogelio too, Kyle was always a little clumsy and unlucky even when they were cadets. But now, all of them are captured, they were able to catch them as they tried to go through the Whispering Woods to transport some supplies to another Horde camp.

But the fact that they have been captured so easily and didn't put up any fight when they brought them to their camp makes this whole situation unsettling for Adora. Are they trying to use the three of them as bait? Well, it wouldn't be a surprise from Catra, she never really liked them, especially Lonnie. Adora goes into the tent where they are guarding the Horde soldiers, not truly knowing what to expect. Glimmer and Bow soon follow her too.

She sees Lonnie first, who is in a silent war with Kyle, looking at him angrily.

"Lonnie?"

The girl raises her head, her hands are restrained and she is sitting on the floor. On a few plush pillows. She looks tired, exhausted. There are a few fresh bruises on her body, a healing scar on her left cheek. Her armour is scratched and worn out, it's not only the Rebellion who are drained. Rogelio and Kyle in the same position, a bag thrown between Kyle and Lonnie.

"Adora." Loonie answers simply then she looks at the other two behind her.

"What are you all planning?" Glimmer cuts in whatever Adora planned to say. "You Horde scums don't get captured easily, but you didn't even put up any fight. *Why* ?" Glimmer gives the girl a hard look, expecting some devious masterplan behind everything.

Rogelio lets out a few low growls, Lonnie snapping her angry eyes at him too. He silences himself.

"There…there's no plan behind this, I doubt Hordak would even notice that we are missing," Kyle tells them, he nervously looks at Adora and her friends.

Lonnie scoffs mockingly. "Of course, he is *too* busy hunting down Catra." She rolls her eyes. "We wouldn't have been captured if it wasn't because of her."

"It's not Catra's fault though." Kyle encounters, losing his confidence the moment Lonnie looks at him.

"Oh yeah? I don't know who blew up our supplies Kyle, must have been a fairy!"

"Why would Hordak hunt Catra?"

Adora breaks their little bantering, visibly confused over everything she has heard now. Catra did what?

Lonnie scoffs at that. "Are you joking? Why would he hunt Catra?" She asks, almost laughing, but Adora and her friends give her an equally lost look. “She blew up half of the Fright Zone then mopped the floor with Hordak before she ran off." Lonnie deadpans.

“WHAT?!” Bow and Glimmer shout in union.

“Wait... You, you didn't know?" Loonie mirrors Adora’s look.

Adora slowly shakes her head."So Catra…”

"Catra has left the Horde. She defected... We... We thought she was here, in Bright Moon." Her eyes widened at the realization.

"She is not here? She didn't come here?" Kyle asks disappointment flashed through his eyes for a second.

Bow and Glimmer look at Adora before answering. "No... She, Catra wasn't here..." Bow answers instead of Adora, who seems to be still processing the information from Loonie and Kyle.

Adora's head is spiralling down with so much thought it dizzies her. She should have known, the recent attacks were all sloppy, weak and uncalculated with old and damaged weapons. Catra would never proceed with plans like this, she would rather bite her arm off.

She surges forward, grabbing the front of Lonnie's armour, she locks eyes with her childhood friend. Half-heartedly, she hopes Lonnie would say that it's a joke or a sudden attack would take off, but nothing is happening. Instead, she looks into Lonnie's eyes, but can't find any hint of a lie, which she searched desperately for.

"What... What do you mean that she defected? Catra would never-.. She would never defect, that's impossible." She shakes

her head stubbornly, her voice quivering.

Lonnie scowls at her. "Well, she did. " Adora lets her go and the ex-Horde soldier slumps down to the ground.

“She obviously wasn’t in the right mind,” Kyle tells and a painful yelp leaves his mouth when Lonnie kicks him. “Well, that’s the truth!”

“How can you still defend her? We were nothing but expandables for her! She wouldn’t even care if we would have died!”

“Because we grew up together, we’ve known each other since… Since we were kids, we… You’ve… You’ve seen her Lonnie how she was before…Catra was always mean and angry at the world, but now... She wouldn't sleep, she was always up either searching for Scorpia or planning out something for Hordak.” He takes a deep breath, remembering the last time he has seen the commander. “She went mental. She wrecked the whole control room and blew up the supplies and the hangar, attacked Hordak then disappeared." Kyle tells them, rather not looking at Lonnie but Adora instead.

"She was searching for Scorpia?" Bow understandably sounds like he has a hard time believing it.

"Catra got angry at Scorpia, I don't know why and then Scorpia left… Serves her right.” She shrugs dismissively. “She always did this, pushing everyone away from her. She deserved it, Scorpia at least woke up from her pink induced Catra is a good person world.” She says mockingly, earning an angry look from Kyle.

"Where... Where is she?" Adora looks at the three Horde soldiers, her eyes are almost frantic. "You must know, you all have trackers especially the Force Captains if Hordak is hunting her… He-he must know where-“

"Adora, when I mean disappeared I mean we know *nothing* about her. We don't know where she is, who she is with or even if she is alive." Lonnie cuts through her sentence. Seemingly not

understanding her. “Why do you care… Catra leaving the Horde should be something good for you.” Then she glances at Bow and Glimmer. “You guys finally have a chance to win.”

Adora's brain stops for a second as she registers Lonnie's words. Catra could be dead. Her heart beats heavily at the thought, different images of Catra flashes before her eyes, alone in the cold, or against a tree with bleeding wounds, an explosion.

No, Catra can't be dead, right? She knows how to get around, she is smart and sly. She wouldn't die so easily. How many lives has she left anyways? Adora would swear it's around 7 or 6? How many times did Catra die and come back?

Bow steps closer and places a hand on Adora's shoulder. She looks up at her friend and sees him giving Adora a small smile, comfortingly squeezing her shoulders. Adora then looks back at Lonnie and looks down at the bag.

"It still doesn't explain why you let yourself basically get captured." Bow breaks the silence in the tent.

Rogelio and Lonnie look at Kyle, who squirms under their eyes. “Kyle here wanted to know if Catra is in Bright Moon or not.” She scoffs.

“Look, I’m... I’m not trying to justify Catra’s actions, they... They are horrible, she did horrible things, but… We never were good friends or anything like that, she was demanding and mean especially after she has technically taken over the Horde," at that Glimmer winces. "but we were all worried about her.” Kyle shoots a look at Loonie and Rogelio at that

Lonnie sighs, turning her head to Adora.“It was like witnessing how she has lost control over everything and finally broke. I couldn't help, not like she would have let me. Or any of us. We thought she had come to Bright Moon, that she came to Adora." Lonnie looks at Adora, who looks equally defeated.

“Catra wouldn’t come here Lonnie… She-she hates me.” Adora looks down at her hands in her lap. “It’s pretty clear, I mean she tried to kill me. Multiple times.” She sighs, shaking her head.

Lonnie stays silent for a few seconds. “I think she hates She-ra, not you. Catra hates princesses - no offence -” she looks at Glimmer. “I don’t think she could ever hate you.”

“Why are you so sure about that?” Adora asks, voice small, a little hopeful.

“Because then you would have been already dead. Catra knows how to get around, she knows you the best… If she wanted you dead, you know… You wouldn’t be here.” Lonnie shrugs, looking down at the ground.”Still, I hate her guts, and I’m damn happy that she left… She could have walked away without being so damn dramatic.”

Adora chuckles lightly. “That’s so Catra…” She hates how that stupid little hope is sparkling in her heart. She shouldn't. Catra hates her, and even if what Lonnie says would be true, Catra still didn’t come here. Didn’t come to Adora.

It would have been complicated, Catra did so many messed up things, hurt so many people. The Horde would have been hunting her, and even if she would come here, the Alliance would have thrown her into a prison - not a nice one - and have a trial. Adora isn’t sure if she could have helped, but damn she would have tried to save her.

Enemies or not, she wouldn't have let Catra die.

Kyle kicks the bag towards Adora, pulling her back from her thoughts."In the bag... There is her headpiece, she has left it behind. Rogelio found it, I uhm… I took it hoping that I could give it back to her. You can have it if you want, I think... It would mean much more to you than me or anyone in the team."

Adora reaches for the bag and opens it, taking out Catra's signature headpiece. She still remembers the day Catra has found

it among the trash in the Fright Zone, she cleaned it up so diligently and with excitement in her eyes. It was always shiny and well taken care of, but now, it's scratched and a little bent like it was thrown away with a strong force and collided with the wall. She swipes her hand over it, her vision blurring in front of her. She takes a deep breath and looks back at the trio, clutching onto the headpiece.

Adora smiles a little at her old friends. "Thank you... For trying to look after her. Even if she is a difficult person."

The three of them leave the tent after that. Adora walks ahead of Glimmer and Bow, looking down at the headpiece still.

It’s been almost 2 years since she has left the Horde. She never had anything from Catra, only her memories. Bad or good, but she cherished them all, trying to remember all, she was afraid that as time would pass she would gradually forget about Catra’s soft laugh or her warm smile that was only for Adora no one else, or the way she would nuzzle her in her sleep whenever Adora had a bad dream, purring lowly to calm her down. Her playful teasing, the secrets they have shared on their secret rooftop. The way Catra’s hand would feel against hers.

But now, she has her headpiece in her head. It feels wrong and right at the same time. It’s like a piece of Catra has come back to her, but it also means that Catra is far away from her, she can’t reach out for her, can’t take her hand or call her name again expecting a teasing smile.

She didn’t see Catra for months, and even then she remembers how strange Catra was. She seemed too rigid like an arrow pulled tautly. She can’t even imagine how she is now. What could send her down to the spiral so much that she basically set her life on fire?

“Adora…” Bow steps next to her and the three friends stop. “It’s okay... We will, we will find her.” He smiles at her, trying to cheer her up a little.

And Adora appreciates the effort, but it’s not just Catra who knows Adora so well.

“That would be impossible Bow, Catra is way too good at hiding. If she doesn’t want us to find her, then… It’s not going to happen.” She shakes her head with a sad smile. “If she… Wanted to be here, she would have come here already, but it’s been days.”

“You don’t know Adora… Catra seems to do things no one thinks she would do.” Bow tilts his head a little. “I mean; she blew up the Fright Zone? Went against Hordak? Not a very Catra like thing to do.” He points out.

Glimmer clears her throat, the two of them looking at her.

"I... You do know that Catra is a hunted defected soldier now and she is basically a war criminal." Glimmer points out slowly, Adora furrows her eyebrows. "I'm just saying that I get it, you want to save her, but she is still our enemy! *Your* enemy. She attacked Bright Moon, Adora... She almost destroyed the world."

In the background, Bow is frantically trying to sign her to stop from behind Adora.

"Do you think I don't know that?" Adora furrows her brows. "I know Glimmer what Catra did, okay? You don't have to remind me constantly! But she is still my... she-... She wouldn't do something like this without a good reason." She looks down at her shoe. There must be a reason.

Glimmer scoffs at that, rolling her eyes. "Yeah, she finally went crazy."

Adora groans frustrated, turning towards Glimmer. “You would too if you stayed in the Horde!”

“No one told her to stay there! You asked here to come!”

“Would you have welcomed her with open arms if she comes here?! You would have thrown her into a cell, and you know it

too!” Adora’s voice rises, and a few guards look at them both curiously and anxiously.

Glimmer doesn’t stay behind, her voice angry and loud.“She is a war criminal! Of course, I wouldn’t let her walk around freely! She needs to pay for what she has done, Adora!”

“You would have done the same with me too?!”

“You are She-ra! It’s different!”

"Glimmer! Adora!" Bow warns them before they would get into an uglier argument "I know that everyone is frustrated, but we can't afford to have a bridge between us." He looks at Glimmer then Adora. "Maybe we should tell the others and then see what we can do."

"What?! What do you mean *we* can do?" Glimmer turns to him.”Are you siding with Adora?!”

"I’m not on anyone’s side!” He takes a deep breath. “While I agree that Catra is dangerous, I mean... She almost killed us a few times, but she also knows valuable information about the Horde and Hordak, their plan etc. If we could find her maybe she could help us? She is clearly not on the Horde's side anymore." Bow explains to them. "I'm not saying to actively search for her, because we don't have enough people for that, but if we find her accidentally or something about her that could be true, we should run with it."

Adora looks at Bow, considering what he is saying. Would Catra help them? Does she hate the Horde more than she hates princesses?

"We could try." She agrees, Glimmer says nothing. "I will tell the others” She turns around and walks away from her friends to the tent where the rest of the princesses are.

Looks like only Scorpia and Perfuma came back, Frosta sits at the other side of the tent looking at the two curiously. The others

haven't come back yet probably.

"Adora!" Frosta jumps up, stretching her limbs up."Finally, I was..Oh... What happened? You don't look good."

The others look at her, Perfuma stands up and goes to her, putting a hand on her back, comforting her.

"Is everything okay, Adora? What did the Horde soldiers say?" She asks worriedly, fearing from dreading news.

"Catra... Catra has defected from the Horde."

The gasp that runs through the tent followed by a heavy silence. They all look shocked which is understandable, every one of them knows how many times Adora told and asked Catra to come with her. To join the Rebellion, the Horde isn't for her. It's not her home, not her destiny.

It's Scorpia who speaks first. "What do you mean... Catra has left the Horde...?"

Adora nods. "Lonnie and Kyle said that Catra blew up a few Horde buildings, and fought with Hordak then disappeared. Most of his troop is after Catra, that's why we win our fights so easily... He has no focus on us, but Catra."

"Oh, Catra..." Scorpia looks down.

"What we should do now?" Perfuma asks, looking at Adora. "If you say that the Horde isn't interested in us now… Maybe we should take advantage of that?"

"I don't... I don't know..."

The others look at each other with a worried look, there's no answer to Perfuma's question.

"Did they say why Catra left?" Frosta blinks up at Adora.

She shakes her head. “Nothing specific, she just… Left.”

Nightfall comes sooner than before, Adora particularly disappears from the others. She doesn’t want to meet with any of them, especially Glimmer right now. To be honest, Adora has no idea what they should do, they must take advantage of Hordak's blind spot towards them, but her head is filled with Catra and thousands of questions. Even as enemies at least she knew Catra was alive, where she was. She knew that she was just a reach away, but now?

Catra could be anywhere.

She is sitting up on a tree branch, looking at the moons. No matter how hard she tries she can't shake off how worried she is for Catra.

"The others are searching for you."

Adora glances down, seeing Scorpia standing at the foot of the tree. After Adora doesn't say a word, the scorpion settles down to the ground, silently sitting. Adora never hated Scorpia, she thought that the scorpion is very friendly and she did tell them about Entrapta too, and after all, it wasn't just the Horde that connected them, but Catra too.

"Catra was searching for you," Adora mentions, remembering what Kyle said.

"Oh... Oh, boy... I did not expect that." Scorpia chuckles nervously, looking down at her relaxed pincers. "I...We didn't part very prettily, I just left her, leaving a note..."

Adora looks down at her, still hugging her knees close to her chest. "Why... Why did you leave?"

It never really came up between them, of course, Scorpia said she wants to be a better friend, but something tells Adora that there is much more than what the scorpion princess shows. She sits in silence, waiting patiently.

"I guess, well..." Scorpia tries to find the words, collecting her thoughts. "I always tried to see the best in Catra, you know? Even when people said that she is a lost cause or evil, or any other mean thing, I've... I've tried to see her in a good light. Catra is... Hurt, she has been hurt a lot and... I'm not excusing her actions," She ads quickly. "No matter how hurt she was it doesn't excuse anything she has done, but... I thought that maybe I can help her, open up and heal, I guess."

"But it didn't happen." Adora finishes it for her.

"Yeah... It didn't." Scorpia agrees in a whisper, her eyes filled with sadness. "I think there's no going back for her, Adora. If she left the Horde... I think she has neared her end." She tells her, cutting the grass absentmindedly with her pincers.

Adora looks up at the moons, basking in their moonlight. She closes her eyes, in front of her she sees Catra.

Catra from their childhood the little girl bundled up in Adora's blanket crying. Catra from their cadet years with an unruly mane and teasing smile, Catra from the day before she has found the sword. Catra after they have become enemies, standing at opposites sides of the battle. Catra in the Crystal Castle with her pained eyes that soon hold nothing but emptiness.

Catra from the Crimson Waste, how different she has seen from before as if she has finally tasted freedom.

And the portal. Catra when she has pulled the lever, activating the portal.

"I'm not giving up on her..." She breaks the silence, opening her eyes. "I... I promised her we would always look out for each other."

Scorpia looks up at the girl. "Adora..."

"I know what you think, what the others... think." Adora takes a deep breath. "I know how all of you feel about Catra, but... I

know Catra differently than any of you, and I have to believe that Catra who I knew is *still* in there."

"I don't understand..." Scorpia knits her brows together in confusion.

Adora smiles sadly. "If I don't believe in her, then who would?" She sighs, pulling on the end of her jacket. "She is so much of a brat to even come here and say Adora I fucked up, or Adora you idiot I blew up the Horde, your welcome. But she… She just left, she… She could be anywhere, she could be hurt or injured… Catra is smart of course, but… I still worry for her…"

Scorpia glances up at Adora, still a bit confused. "I always thought that you hated Catra."

Adora shakes her head, even if Scorpia can't see it."No, I don't think that there was a day where I hated her. I was angry, yes. Angry at her for what she has done, but never hate… I could *never* hate her. Did Catra think I… hated her?" She asks hesitantly.

"I think she did…I'm sorry."

"It's okay.."

"Do you feel it's okay?"

"Huh?"

"Well… " Scorpia starts a little absentmindedly. "Perfuma said, if things don't *feel* okay, then they are *not* really okay. So… Do you feel it's okay that Catra thought you hated her?" She questions, looking up at Adora.

The blonde stays silent for a little, her heart churns at the thought of Catra thinking Adora hates her. How could she? Catra was her best friend, they were always together since they were kids, looking for each other, protecting the other. Catra, was oftentimes her anchor, the one who could nudge her to get up if she felt like

giving up everything. She was so precious to Adora, important. How could she hate her?

The war morphed them into real soldiers, they didn't fight against simulations of princesses, but each other. And no matter how many times Adora spent training, nothing could compare to the dread that struck into her whenever she had to face Catra.

The catgirl was her enemy now, not her friend. She always reminded herself. Yet, it was still hard to raise her sword against Catra. But she had and still has a duty as She-ra. And if Catra turns out to be their enemy in the future even after she has left the Horde, what could Adora do?

"No, it...It doesn't feel right…"

Later she walks back to the camp. She doesn't pay attention to the others, even if she feels their pining eyes on her back, her strong demeanour disappearing the moment she steps into her tent. There she sees Catra's headpiece sitting on the bed.

She remembers how they used to share a bed, Catra usually slept at her feet, but at nights when life was particularly cruel to one of them, or both, they have cuddled close together, trying to will away the other's demons. Even if it meant that their own would eventually annex them. Catra always looked the stronger one, no matter how many times Shadow Weaver tried to break her, she just became tougher.

Maybe Adora should have paid more attention, she should have brought Catra with herself. She shouldn't have let her go so easily, not at Thaymor, not anywhere. She should have held onto her strongly.

Adora didn't notice that Catra was hanging by a thread and below her, there was a gaping abyss ready to swallow her.

That night, Adora sleeps with the headpiece hugged close to her chest. Hoping that Catra is okay, that she is alive. Before she falls

asleep, she remembers their promise to each other. A tear escapes her closed eyes at the thought.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.

the star and the moon

Chapter Summary

> “I’m afraid that someday I will lose you Catra.” Adora stumbles over the words. “The Fright Zone is not a kind place, I’m afraid that if I’m not doing well enough they will… They will take you away, and I-“
>
> Catra huffs lightly. “Pft, don’t be stupid. You would never be able to get rid of me. We will always be together, as we promised."

Chapter Notes

> Please enjoy! At the end notes there will be a question for further questions, please leave your suggestions!
>
> Note: trigger warning for implied abuse, panic attack and talks about dissecting body parts.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had to face the rude awakening that travelling isn't easy with an open wound on her side, a throbbing leg and she also may have eaten all of the ration bars already. The exhaustion seeping into her bones doesn't help either. No matter how we look at it, Catra has been running on the adrenaline rush of the previous night, and it finally starts to leave her body with each passing hour, leading her into complete exhaustion.

"Great." She grimaces shaking the bag hoping that there would be another one hidden somewhere, but nothing, she throws it at the back. "It wouldn't be smart going to a town. Okay Catra, think. What to do."

She looks around her surroundings; she is at the edge of another little forest. She knows from memory that Thaymor is close, but judging that it hasn't been even 24 hours since she left everything

must be swarmed with Horde soldiers. Her eyes catch onto something in the distance, a *river.*

"Oh." Her ears peak up. "A river, I know how to hunt for a fish." She falls into deep thinking, her hands on her hips. "Right? Of course, I know" She scoffs cockily, then drives the skiff towards the river, slowly climbing off after she turned it off, bringing the gauze with herself.

Catra scans the field with her sharp mismatched eyes and listens carefully if she would hear any noise from the forest. Everything is calm. Such a strange concept for her.

So she sits down close to the river. Before she would do any hunting, she takes off her garment that covers her collar and right arm, she drops it to the grass the other glove follows suit. From her right wrist up to her arm, and across her collarbone, a little bit of her neck is completely covered in another set of gauze. Around her nape, side of her neck, palm tendrils of burn scars stretch along her skin.

A relict left by the portal.

Catra prefers them hidden. An ugly reminder.

She struggles with the leotard, her side aching, eventually, it falls to the ground too, leaving her in her sports bra and her leggings. Her hands are still coloured red from the dried blood. For the first thing, she washes it off, almost scraping, her hand, especially around her nails. Next, she washes off the blood from her gloves.

The leotard has a horde symbol at the middle of it where her shoulder blades would meet. She stares at it, then with a slash of her claws, the Horde symbol falls to the ground and Catra drops her top to the grass.

It’s useless to wear that symbol anymore.

"Okay... Now the wound." She takes a deep breath as she unwraps the gauze slowly, the blood dried around the wound

sticking to the gauze and her skin. She inspects it carefully, it's not deep, still ugly with all the blood around it. Although it will leave a scar, Catra doesn't mind, just another one. She has a bunch.

"Mmmhm, maybe I should go into the water?" She mumbles to herself trying to clear off the wound with some difficulty. "No, I'm okay." The conclusion comes quickly.

Stubbornly Catra struggles more, but eventually, the wound is cleaned up from the dried blood. It doesn't look infected; it would be better if she would have some ointment or something that could disinfect the wound. Rather than dwelling into it, she takes a new roll of gauze, wrapping herself up again carefully.

Next, she inspects her right thigh by rolling down the waistband of her leggings. She is welcomed by swollen reddish angry skin, with dark purple spots, it's about the size of her palm if not a bit larger. She pokes it gently, letting out a hiss.

"That's okay, I thought it was worse." She nods to herself.

Now, Catra is more set on hunting a few fish for herself. She remembers how to do it, it's like etched into her mind, although it was years ago since she last tried it. She needed a few failed attempts to get a hang of it, and a wet face, because who would have thought that her palm could just slide away and her face would end up in the river. She hisses angrily, she knows how to disable a weapon at the first try, and doesn't know how to catch a fish?

Ridiculous.

She ended her hunt with two not very big fish, it's better than nothing. She fills up the flask too with water, throwing the two very dead fish into the bag for later. She will have to figure out how to eat it.

Catra is about to get her top when she hears a distant noise. Her ears peak up again, her eyes narrow staring at the distance to see if she can point out anything. Mechanics. *Robots*.

She gasps, understanding washing over her. Horde robots. She takes her clothes, grabbing the bag and runs to the skiff. With a swift move, she jumps in landing on her uninjured leg and drives away as silently as she could. The forest is a great hiding place in case there would be more robots or Horde soldiers around the area.

That's when she sees one of the robots from a distance getting closer. Not particularly to her, but the spot she was in a few minutes ago. She stops the skiff and follows the robot's movement with her eyes.

"No, there's nothing here."

She spots a soldier, probably reporting to someone. Catra isn't sure if they are looking for her or it's just a routine patrol searching for Rebellion soldiers. They wouldn't know where she headed, she made sure to destroy the tracking of the skiff the moment she left the Fright Zone’s border. Still, she can't be cautious enough, her tail wraps around her waist, gently laying around her wounded side.

She needs to go.

Whether it's a search party for her or a patrol, she can't stay for long.

So Catra drives off the skiff, navigating around the trees carefully not to damage it.

"Wait." Her ears come forward, twitching a little, her eyes sparkle with an idea. "There's a Horde camp. I could steal some supply." She scratches her chin, thinking deeply about it. " I need first-aid for my wound anyways and fuel to the skiff…Yes, I will steal it." She turns her skiff off, climbing out of it.

A sigh leaves her mouth, pushing her hair down. "I need to be quick, I doubt that I can fight with my side like this." A grimace appears on her face.

Then, Catra disappears into the shadows of the wood. Being stealthy is one of her specialities, she knows how to move in the darkness, be absolutely invisible until she needs to strike. And even after that, how to blend back to the shadows.

She finds the camp easily; it's heavily guarded just as she thought. "Hordak must have sent more soldiers here." She whispers, her tail lashing lazily behind herself as she is looking out of the unruly shrouds.

The camp is located in the forest, conveniently. Catra chuckles, jumping up to a branch near her, she looks down at the camp from the high. She counts 15 soldiers and 5 robots in total but doesn't know how many of them could be in the buildings or patrolling nearby. She pursues her lips, dwelling into her thoughts. It's risky, but she needs the supplies or else her wound will eventually be infected, and fuel to get around if she doesn’t want to be stranded somewhere.

"Oh." She notices a soldier moving away from their spot and an idea struck into her. "Oh." Catra smiles smugly, moving on the branches following the soldier.

He is well hidden by thick trees and the wall that hides the camp. She waits until the perfect opportunity, and when it comes, Catra jumps off landing on the back of the soldier - which maybe wasn't the wisest idea, her thigh throbbing with sharp pain - hitting his head against the ground. She stays still for a few seconds, waiting to see if he is out of the blue or someone has heard her. But nothing.

She huffs amused, quickly she sheds the soldier's clothes and puts them on, hiding the soldier away in a bush.

With a sigh, she rolls her shoulders and walks to the wall. With ease she climbs it, jumping over it, making sure to land on her uninjured leg. Cautiously she looks around, no one has seen her. Perfect.

"Now, where is the hangar." She mumbles to herself, walking away trying not to limp and wince each time she puts a little more pressure on her injured leg or takes a sudden breath and her side throbs with pain.

No one is paying too much attention to her, which is excellent. Maybe fortune does smile on her once in a while. She looks into every building, finding one, with bunk beds and two soldiers sleeping. She stalks away quickly. The weaponry, the command room. Then, when her already low patience is about to run lower, she finds it.

"Perfect."

She hurries in, closing the door of the hangar behind herself. She doesn't take off the helmet, in case someone would come in suddenly.

There are only two skiffs in which Catra isn't interested at all, she rather goes around the small makeshift hangar, searching for the container they store the fuels. After a few minutes of searching, she finds them, medium-sized containers, she grabs one turning around, then the door opens.

She hisses in surprise, about to hideaway-

"You. What are you doing here?" The other Horde soldiers ask, voice a little muffled with the helmet. "

Catra straightens her posture, about to lash out at the woman for how she is speaking. Then she remembers, she is not Catra right now, just an ordinary soldier.

She coughs, deepening her voice. "I came to check on the skiffs." The answer comes in a croaky voice.

"By whose order?"

Catra is just a little away from hitting this idiot and running away with the fuel. Thankfully, to her luck, another soldier comes

running into the tent.

"Rebellion soldiers in Thaymor!"

He announces then runs off, Catra steps one back when the woman who just questioned her goes out of the room too, hurrying away to go to the town. She lets out a relieved sigh, reaching for the container-

"What are you doing?! Hurry up!"

Catra growls, closing her eyes to calm herself down. Can't lash out she tells herself over and over again, but someone grabs her elbow. "Hey!" She struggles, without much success she is being dragged out of the hangar far away from her actual goal. And thrown into a line of soldiers.

"It was reported that the Queen of Bright Moon is in Thaymor, destroying our troops controlling the town. We've already asked for back up, they will be here shortly. Everyone knows their duty, go!"

"Of course it's Sparkles." Catra groans to herself, her luck is stupid. Her luck is basically non-existent.

She can't go through this, it would risk her being revealed and that's something she can't afford. So she stalks away, behind a building out of the main sight, waiting for everyone to be out of the camp. It takes time, but eventually, everything goes silent. Catra stays still a little bit, just to make sure, then she takes off her helmet finally breathing fresh air.

"Ah, it's suffocating."

The helmet drops to the ground and she is off to the hangar again, grabbing the container, but stops at the weaponry.

"Do I... no, I have my claws. But I need first aid." as a reminder the stabbing pain is back at her side, making Catra tumble, taking

a sharp breath. With a groan she pushes herself father, she needs to be quick.

The infirmary is small but well equipped. At least for what Catra needs. She grabs a box, opening it hastily, she checks everything in it. Gauze, bandage, plasters, scissors and disinfectant plus a few swabs and linen pieces. She closes it again taking it with herself. Catra carefully points her head out of the tent looking around, then runs out of the camp as fast as she can, until she sees her skiff.

A relieved sigh leaves her mouth, she stops, panting, her leg spasming with pain but she can't stop now. She will worry about the pain later. She takes the container and places it into the storage the skiff has, the first aid next to it. She takes off the Horde armour throwing it to the ground then climbs into the skiff, setting it off.

She has food for tonight and water, for now, it's enough, the rest is future Catra's problem. As soon as she has left the forest, she increases the speed easily gliding on the open field. She is still cautious of course, Horde soldiers could be near her still. She sees Thaymor from the distance, the wall around it and the enormous Horde flag.

She could hear the faint sound of a fight.

She focuses her attention in front of herself instead.

It’s *not* her problem.

A memory she has tried to bury deep down flashes before her eyes, cruelly reminding her last time she has come to Thaymor. Where she has lost Adora.

She remembers how angry she was, Adora just… left. Without looking back, without thinking twice about it. She transformed into She-ra and destroyed everything.

I'm not going home. Not after everything I've seen. Come with me. You don't have to go back there. We can fix this.

Adora sounded so hopeful as if she had full faith in Catra that she would go with her, and would join the Rebellion with her.

At that time Catra thought it was ridiculous, what could Adora do? Against the Horde? And Catra could go with her? No. No, at that time it was nothing but childish wish in Catra's eyes. She was a Horde soldier, someone who just overrun Thaymor with a tank and a troop in her toe. Secretly she hoped Adora would come back, realizing that the Rebellion wasn't what she wanted. But Adora never came.

And Catra never went to her. Although, maybe, it would have been better.

Leaving the Horde shouldn't have sounded so bad, because they never cared about her.

Shadow Weaver hated her, betrayed her, despised her. No matter how many times Catra tried to be in her favour, Shadow Weaver just punished her harder. And Hordak? He wasn't better. At least he didn't hurt Catra. Well... Except when he suffocated her and shot her with a laser beam. Still better than Shadow Weaver.

"I'm sorry Adora..." She whispers, increasing the speed again.

The words die down in her throat, what could she do? Be happy? Get over Shadow Weaver's manipulation? Make peace with the past? Heal?

No, Catra is too bitter for that, she is broken, beyond repair. At least she thinks she is.

This will be better. Her being out of everyone's sight, this way she can't hurt anyone else again.

Eventually, Catra decides to stop after a full day of driving on the skiff, trying to find a place where she can at least hide for the

night. Without luck, she decides to stop and do a makeshift camp here. She takes out the bag, treating her wound first. She once again sheds her top to get access to the wound. The gauze is bloody again, but she washes it off, leaving enough water for herself for later. She disinfects it with hisses and growls, her tail lashing against the floor of the skiff with dull thuds. Then, she wraps herself up again.

Catra has no idea when was the last time she felt this tired, maybe after her first day of being a cadet? The training was pretty intense; she can still remember the soreness of her muscles, even moving her ears was painful. The next day she could barely move.

This is a different kind of exhaustion, Catra knows she could go, her body didn’t reach her limits, she knows she could go further, she pushed her boundaries enough times to know that. This is nestled deep in her soul. All these years washing over her, as if her body and mind are finally letting go as she gets farther and farther from the Fright Zone.

"Okay... How am I supposed to eat these?" She looks at the fishes, then pokes one with her claw. "Do I just bite it? Or cut it?" Her eyebrow gradually goes higher and higher as she sits on the floor trying to figure out how to have her dinner.

Her nose crinkles at the smell. "It stinks... Am I supposed to eat that at all?" The question of course stays unanswered. "Ahhh! That's ridiculous! How do I not know how to eat a fucking fish?!" she growls, her fur standing up in annoyance. "This wasn't taught in basic survival." She deadpans, sadly taking one of the fish and just straight up going for it, she bites into it.

It doesn't take a minute even until Catra is coughing, throwing away the fish, hitting her chest and drinking her water gullibly, it drips around her mouth. Once she doesn't feel like choking anymore, she takes a few deep breaths. Her eyes snap at the fish, throwing it off her skiff.

"No more fish." She hisses, with a groan she lays down looking up at the sky and the moons.

They are beautiful, as simple as that. She oddly finds peace in them. Sometimes when she would be so lonely, she would whisper to the moons, about everything and nothing. Would tell them about her wishes, how she would have changed certain things if she would have the power. But ultimately, her ramblings always end up at one thing: portal.

The portal.

The guilt has been gripping her neck for months. It’s back, tightening its long fingers. Part of Catra never knew how she survived, she wouldn't mind not coming back. She wouldn't mind dying, as horrible as it sounds. At some point, she stopped caring about whether she would wake up in the morning or would come back from a battle. She could have accepted the fact if the universe decides to not let her back.

Maybe it would have been for the better.

She sighs, closing her eyes instead, trying to discipline herself into sleeping. It takes a few errors and trials, tossing around on the hard floor, but eventually she curls around herself, her tail wrapped around her side.

Catra never was and probably never will be someone who can sleep so tightly that not even an explosion would wake her up. Catra's eyes snap even at the slightest chance of the sounds surrounding her. She lifts her head with furrowed brows, footsteps. She hears footsteps. She turns around, only to be welcomed with a fist and Catra stumbles, body dropping.

Before she would fully lose the world she hears "-the skiff, we are getting this cat with ourselves. They would give a fortune for the tail and ears!"

Then, everything goes black as she lets out a pained groan.

"Hey, Adora." Catra jumps on Adora the moment she sees the blonde, Adora's body falls back and Catra is on top of her, purring lightly and her tail moves excitedly. "What's up? What did Grizzlor say?"

They are in their teenage years, Catra's mane is still wildly going in different directions, and Adora is still holding onto that ponytail except she now has a hair poof too. What Catra occasionally likes to poke fun of. They are in their cadet uniform, waiting for their annual tests to be done. Adora was the last one to do it.

Adora doesn't even flinch when Catra jumps on her, she got used to it years before. "Uhm… He said I was okay." She simply says, looking away from Catra's curious mismatched eyes.

"You don't sound like he said you were okay." Catra furrows her brows, climbing off Adora and pulling her up too. "Do you want me to scratch him on the eyeball too?"

"Catra!"

"I was just asking! Although seriously if you want, I could totally put an eyepatch on him." Catra chuckles, Adora just looks down at the floor. "Hey, what happened?" She reaches for Adora's hand, an instinct by now, for both of them. Adora holds onto her.

"He said that I still need to work on my speed and strength and he will report it to Shadow Weaver," Adora whispers, her eyes shining with worry. Catra understands. Of course, she does.

They stand silently in the middle of the empty hallway, holding hands.

"Come, I know how to get your mood up," Catra says, pulling Adora with herself, her tail reassuringly wrapping around Adora's

hand.

"Catra-"

"Just don't worry okay? Everything will be okay." She flashes Adora a reassuring fanged smile letting her hand go. "Now come, the last one will give the other their ration bars!" Catra runs away with a loud laugh, Adora in her toe.

"That's not fair, you cheated!"

"All I can hear is a sore loser!"

"Catra!"

The two girls sprint up to their spot, a well-known route for them to hide from everyone, to hide from the world and the looming darkness above their head. Catra sits on the railing, giggling victoriously her tail lashing around, Adora is next to her looking at the Fright Zone below them.

"Do you remember our promise?" Adora asks out of nowhere, startling Catra with it.

Catra doesn't really have to think about it, it's carved into her mind deeper than anything she has ever known and probably ever will. The promise of two broken girls on a stormy night with bruises and tears. Catra doesn't know if it's their shared pain that linked their life together or the universe has planned it out perfectly, but she knows that Adora is someone constant in her life. Someone, she can lean-to in this damned place if she seeks warm, kindness or love.

Sometimes she still thinks that Adora is too good for this place, and fears that it will eventually break her.

"Of course. Why?"

But there's no answer, just Adora's eyes shining with tears again.

"Adora-"

"I'm afraid that someday I will lose you Catra." Adora stumbles over the words. "The Fright Zone is not a kind place, I'm afraid that if I'm not doing well enough they will… They will take you away, and I-"

Catra moves closer and pulls Adora, so she is standing between her legs, then envelops her friend into a hug. It's not something she initiates a lot, but in moments like this where it's the two of them and it's Adora who needs love and care, she will give her everything. Adora clings to Catra like she is her lifeline when in all honesty it's the other way around.

Catra huffs lightly. "Pft, don't be stupid. You would never be able to get rid of me. We will always be together, as we promised. We will conquer Etheria and rule together! If we ever see active duty of course." She grumbles trying to lighten up the mood. "Maybe I really should give Grizzlor an eyepatch."

Even if she tries, she knows damn well that Adora isn't worried about Grizzlor or the Fright Zone itself, but Shadow Weaver. She could easily get rid of Catra and they both know it. That's why they cling so tightly together, holding hands. So maybe, if they hold onto each other strong enough, they can't be separated.

"I will always be by your side, Adora. I promise."

That night, when Adora and the rest of the cadets sleep soundly, Catra is the only one who is up, staring at the wall. She sleeps in Adora's bed again, her own didn't even see her for weeks by now. Adora crying is something that's been haunting her since they have come down from the rooftop, a plan, a risky one has formed in her head. She won't ever see Adora cry again, not like this.

She slips away, stalking through the hallways carefully so no one would see her. They have a strict curfew, if anyone would catch her it would be disastrous. Especially that she is standing in front

of Shadow Weaver's sanctum. The door is wide open, which means Shadow Weaver is not near.

Her heart hammers against her chest, and her hands are shaking lightly. "Come on Catra, for Adora." She whispers to herself, taking the first step.

She has been here countless times, alone or with Adora. Some memories are harsher than the others, Catra likes not to think about them even though there are constant reminders engraved into her skin.

Seemingly, the room is empty except the Black Garnet what towers over Catra. But on the right side of the room, there are hidden shelves and drawers where Shadow Weaver collects their data, mainly Adora's and Catra's and other Horde matters in which Catra isn't really interested. She hurries and pulls them out hastily, finding files about armoury and weapons first, then some research that she just puts back quickly. She finds her drawer, then Adora's.

Grizzlor likes to get over stuff quickly, so Catra is sure that the reports of their annual tests are already here. She finds the folder of it and brings it out pushing the drawer back. She flips it through, finding the final report and they have rated Adora's performance as a 3/5 which is not bad, but for Shadow Weaver's expectations of Adora, it's horrible.

Her sensitive ears pick up noise from the hallways, surging her into action, she sneaks out of the room, the folder clutched onto her chest. She hides quickly behind a metal column, Shadow Weaver stalking by her. The catgirl lets out a relieved sigh, about to turn around and hurry away when she feels the familiar tingle of magic sweeping into her skin. She throws the folder before her whole body would go rigid.

She closes her eyes, trying to fight against the restraint, but she is still unable to move. Her body response to Shadow Weaver's magic, levitating into the room she has just left. The sorcerer stands in front of her, her shadows towering over Catra.

"Sh-"

"What are you doing outside of your dorm?" She narrows the white of her eyes at Catra, the girl unable to respond. "You really can't go a day without causing any trouble, how shameful. You don't just underperform, but can't even follow simple instructions."

And the Black Garnet lights up behind Shadow Weaver, the sorcerer striking down on Catra with red lightning. Catra bites her lips hard, until it bleeds and feels numb, refusing to give in to the pain and scream, fuelling Shadow Weaver's anger.

"But what am I even expecting from a filthy pet *."*

Another strike, this one is followed by Catra's scream.

Catra wakes up to a pounding headache and dull pain in her left cheeks. She grunts, opening her eyes blinking a few times, expecting to see the night sky instead, she is looking up at a… a rock? She gasps, memories flashing behind her eyes, she sits up quickly, looking around.

She tries to stand up, then realizes she is bound. She can barely move. A rope sits tightly around her from her chest down to her waist and even her ankles are bound together.

She almost lets out a desperate shrill trying to get free, her heart hammering against her chest, pure terror clouds her mind. She heaves, closing her eyes tightly, biting onto her lip to surface the building sob in her chest, she surges forward, her bangs covering her eyes completely. Catra's whole body is shaking violently. Memories of electrical red lightning flashes behind her eyes. They almost feel real again, the pain in her body, the way they struck down.

She yelps when a strong hand grabs her hair and tilts her head back, her eyes frantically moving around until she finally sees the person in front of her. A lizard woman, looking down at her cruelly.

"Easy kitty. You don't want to hurt yourself."

Catra is unable to say a word.

She turns around still holding Catra by her hair. "Tan, send a message to the others, tell them we are going back to the Pit." She turns to the other who is a half human-half man, he simply nods, leaving the cave.

Catra's mind barely registers the words, the woman lets her go and her head lulls forward. She is still panting, confused and shaking.

What's happening?

The bull-man is back, Catra has no idea how long he was away if it was a minute or an hour. Everything seems to just blur together. She lets herself be hauled up, her legs shaking with each step. Every ounce of power has left her body, she doesn't just feel weak, she is exhausted, tired.

A few minutes pass until she realizes that she is on her skiff, the lizard woman driving it and the bull-man is guarding her. The fog around her brain starts to clear up slowly, the wind against her face helps.

She doesn't dare to move against the ropes, every little friction from the rope against her skin makes her shake with absolute dread.

Her eyes move up to the lizard woman, seeing a familiar tattoo on her neck. A swirl ending up in a whip. Strange.

What did they say? Where are they taking her? Oh, the Pit.

The Pit.

"The black market." She whispers to herself, her brain starting to catch up. "You want to bring me to the black market." it's not a question, she looks up at the lizard woman with a disoriented look.

"Ah, she speaks at last." She chuckles mockingly, it's a weird mix between a squeak and a cough. "We would get great money for your tail and ears."

Catra doesn't react to that, just furrows her brows.

"Aren't you a little worried?"

Catra blinks a little, worried. Yeah, she should be. "Give me 10 minutes and I will probably kick your ass down from my skiff."

"Big words from someone who can't even move." The lizard chuckles. "But don't worry you will be soon free," that Catra's ears move a little. "Of course without your adorable tail and ears, they worth a lot you know." The woman's eyes sparkle with something that makes Catra quiver.

This is not good, she concludes.

But again, Catra says nothing. She tries to push away the thick fog covering her brain, it's just as stubborn as Catra at the end, she sags against the side of the skiff. She has no idea what happened, she has never freaked out like this, not even when Shadow Weaver bounded her with magic.

That's why she hates magic, it's really after her just so it can make her life harder.

Maybe there is a curse on her. At this point, she really thinks that the universe is after her.

She tips her head back, leaning against the cold metal too. She closes her eyes, takes a deep breath, then lets it out. She repeats

it a few times until she feels in control again until the restrain of the rope doesn't feel like snakes ready to bite into her neck.

The rope must be enchanted, Catra concludes, as much as she tries to squirm around it, it gets tighter. Or simply she is finally going crazy, it was time, really.

Who would know?

She opens her eyes again, seeing the empty dark sky with the moons.

The Pit wasn't a myth, in particular, no one really knew where to find it. It is a secret place for everyone who wishes to meddle with business, not even the Horde would have anything to do. Talk about dark magic, demons, trafficking, selling Catra's ear and tail in this case. She sighs, of course, that's her luck.

Yeah, let's be captured by some idiot who wants to dissect her or whatever.

She decides to stay put for a while, at least until she will find a way to get out of this mess.

They eventually arrive at a chasm, Catra blinks slowly.

"I think you've turned left at the wrong time. You've brought us to-"

Catra's shriek echoes through the whole field as they ascend to the chasm, she closes her eyes tightly, because if she does at least she doesn't want to see that rock what will be her grave. However, instead of a crash, they are gliding in the air again, Catra opens her eyes with a frantic look, her tail and fur spiked up.

They are at the bottom of the chasm.

"What the..."

The lizard woman just scoffs. "Welcome to the Pit, kitty."

And in front of them, there is nothing but a huge stone, that's suddenly breaking down in the middle, each side moving away from the other like some sort of gate. Catra's eyes open in surprise and a little bit of awe too, as they go through the gate she can see a whole city laid out in front of her. There is a stone path that leads down to the deeper part of the city.

Everything is made out of stone mostly, the streets are crowded, she can clearly hear chatter even from that high from actual people. She doesn't see the end of it, so she concludes it must be huge. No wonder no one has found it yet, it's completely hidden.

When she looks up she sees the sky and the spikes of the chasm stretching up to the moons.

"We are here." announces the lizard, jumping off the skiff bringing her bag with herself.

"Hey-" Catra struggles when the bull-man lifts her up and throws her lithe body over his shoulder. She growls at him, but he doesn't flinch.

"Don't try kitty, you won't get out of here."

She huffs at the nickname this stupid lizard gave her. "I will wrap your tongue around your neck."

"Again, big words from someone who can't even move." She laughs and Catra's patience runs out incredibly fast again.

They go into a shop, or Catra assumes because as soon as they are in the only thing she can see is a giant eye in a glass looking back at her. She takes a deep breath, okay, don't freak out. Rather, she trains her eyes onto the floor.

"Ah, Ira! Tan! You are back, what did you bring me this time?"

A mix of a croaky and nasal voice hits Catra's ears, she flattens them instantly. She is being deposited onto the floor, hitting her tail bone, a growl rumbles in her chest.

"Oh... Oh! How interesting! Hihi." Catra looks where the voice comes from, she squeaks silently.

The one who is looking back at her is a human or some sort of human. He has three eyes and a forked tongue as he licks his lips. Gross. Part of his arm is mechanical, the other looks like a lizard's arm. Some kind of strange hybrid Catra concludes.

"Get out of my face." She hisses at him suddenly, showing off her fangs.

"She has fangs even!" but the hybrid just seems to be more excited than afraid. "Oh don't worry we've seen a lot of things here, I dissected a lot of things, I'm not afraid of you." He giggles, the implication behind his words makes Catra sick. He reaches out to her ears and roughly pulls on them, Catra winces in pain. "Oh, how very interesting. Yes, it would worth at least 5000 gold coins, creatures like her are rare. And her tail, hm, maybe more. They are very useful for dark magic." he nods to himself while the other two idiots look at each other excitedly.

"You really don't think that I will let you cut my ear and tail off right? You can't be that big of an idiot." She scoffs, rolling her eyes.

"Of course not, I will shock you. Until you are unconscious"

Catra's eyes widen, looking back at the hybrid again. Something in her shifts. Her ear flattens down and the eyes of her pupils narrow down.

"Hm, okay. I think this little game was enough." She sighs, closing her eyes. Her nails retract and soon the ropes are falling to the ground and Catra stands up stretching her sore joints, her tail lashing lazily. Her side is sore and she welcomes the pleasant dull pain in her thigh.

"W-what?!" Ira screams almost, seeing how easily Catra got out of the ropes.

"I appreciate the effort though." She stands before them, hand on her hips. "But it got kinda boring at the end, I just wanted to see the Pit." She shrugs simply, dusting off her clothes. "Oh, I'm sorry. Did you really think that you had the upper hand?" Catra looks at Ira with a cruel smile on her lips. "You had no idea who did you mess with, right? Shame."

The human hybrid steps back slowly. "W-wait, we can...we can talk this out surely, right?" He chuckles nervously.

"I'm sure we can work something out." She glances at him, and in a matter of seconds, she grabs him by the neck, throwing him out of the shop breaking the window.

The bull-man charges towards her, with his horn, she simply jumps up, landing on his back skipping away with a kick driving him into the wall. She chuckles seeing the man stuck into the wall, the lizard woman comes next, her whip in her hand. Catra looks at her, bored.

"Nice... I had a whip too, but I lost it. I want yours." She says, jumping towards Ira, the woman trying to lash her with the whip but Catra is faster ducking down. Instead, the bookshelves got damaged.

Catra draws out her claws again, slashing forward with them, wounding Ira from her stomach to the chest, then Catra kicks her in the face, the lizard colliding with the wall hitting her head.

"Well, that was boring." She concludes, picking up dust from under her claw.

She goes to the lizard, taking away her whip, fastening it to her belt. "Let's see. Surely there is something interesting here." And with that Catra starts exploring the shop, mainly searching for money what she finds, not even a little. With a mischievous giggle, she takes it along with a cloak that reaches around her

midthigh. It would be useful if she goes to town, or hide her face from someone who could recognize her.

"It was a *pleasure* doing business with you!"

She skips into her skiff, she puts away the sack into her bag, the cloak is already on her, drawn to her face hiding away her ears – what are flattened against her skull -, and her tail is wrapped around her thigh.

"Why are you so obsessed with my tail and ear." She shakes her head, navigating through the city.

Many interesting shops catch Catra's eyes, one sells charms for curses, others offer summoning spells and talismans. She spots a mercenary guild too, contemplating to join for a second then throwing the idea away. Now that she has a whip again, there's no need for another weapon so she skips the shop that offers intricate weapons.

She goes around the city, looking around. Stopping at a few displays, eyeing what she could buy or even if they are worthy to spend her *hard-earned* money. Along the way she has scoped up a pear, munching on it. Eventually, she stops at a store that offers maps.

"Hm, if I go around Etheria it would be smart to have a map." She tells herself with a few nods, biting into the fruit again. Catra jumps off the skiff, going into the store with a curious look.

Her knowledge of cities goes as far as what's close to the Fright Zone. Other than that they have always used technology to navigate them, so Catra never really bothered to really learn what is where. But now she is alone, without tech to navigate her around, it's not just about travelling but also surviving. She needs to be smart where she goes.

The inside of the store looks quite cosy and even inviting compared to what kind of place they are really. Catra looks at the two displays on either side of the shop, they have strange tools

that probably would be perfect to hurt someone. There are also maps hung up, rolls of papers stacked up and a big table at the other end of the shop. The light is coming from two big lamps on the ceiling.

"Welcome, what do you need?"

Catra looks at her right, spotting a young man bringing out some more paper, although they are much bigger than the ones on the display.

"A map of Etheria." She answers shortly, walking into the shop a little.

"Treasure, general, topographic, province or ones that can show you where your target moves?" The man turns towards Catra, dumping the rolls on the table.

It's a rare occasion where Catra feels absolutely clueless, but this moment is one. She blinks, scowling.

"What did you just say to me?"

The man burst into a quiet laugh. "Treasure maps speak for themselves, general maps are the ones who show you roads, cities and rivers. Topographic ones usually only contain the outline of that specific land, it is great for beginners. Province ones show the borders of the kingdoms and the main roads, the last one is a magic map that's great for mercenaries." He explains it simply, Catra just nods a bit.

"Oh. I want the general one then."

"I will bring it out in a second."

The man disappears again, leaving Catra alone in the silent space. So she decides to entertain herself, she goes to the displays taking a look at the fastened maps. They look somehow fascinating and interesting, how a piece of paper can show so much and contain important information. On the other side of the

shop, it's all tools being displayed, Catra never saw something like this before. Their maps were mostly digital thanks to their robots.

"Are you perhaps interested in the art of map-making?"

He appears again, map in his hand, it falls into the medium-sized ones.

"So that's what these are for." Catra mumbles to herself, taking the map away from the man. "Is it hard to learn?" The question surprises even Catra.

"Well," He thinks about it a little. "If you have the proper tools it can be quite easy, and of course with a lot of practice. But thankfully now we have tools that are more advanced and could scan the territory without spending hours on calculating different matters."

Catra hums, looking back at the tools. It's not like she has much to do anyways or is hurrying to anywhere.

"How much are these?"

"Oh, depends. If you want the tech ones-"

"I want those." She cuts him mid-sentence.

"Then with the maps too, it would be 100 gold coins."

Catra lifts an eyebrow, of course, the man can't see. That's a lot.

"Fine."

"Do you know how to use these?"

"No, but I will figure it out. Pack them up, so I can leave."

Catra pays and then leaves with her new things. Part of her is a little excited to figure out how to use them and perhaps draw maps. She also bought a bunch of paper for them. The storage space of the skiff is considerably big, so everything fits easily

without trouble. She climbs back into it, feels as if someone's eyes are drilling a hole into her skull.

The possibility to ignore it hangs before Catra, instead, she turns around locking eyes with a woman and a man. Her fur rises, she can recognize a vicious look anywhere, and these two look at Catra as if she has killed their little pet in front of them.

Something crackles in Catra, maybe the need to beat them up for looking at her like this, like a piece of new meat, or she is thriving for another dance with the thought of death. Her side still hurts, although Catra promptly ignores it.

"What are you looking at?" She snaps, turning fully around.

"You don't find a skiff like this anywhere in Etheria." The woman says, stepping next to the vehicle looking up at Catra.

Both of them are humans, they sport the same tattoos as the lizard woman and the bull-man. She scoffs, did those two snitch up on her? Although they can't really know if she was with the Horde. Catra still has her hood up, it grants her some anonymity at least.

She pats the side of the skiff. "Must have been hard to get it."

The catgirl simply narrows her eyes on the human, without saying a word. Until the cloak, her hand slowly reaches for her whip.

"Funny, because two of our friends just arrived with a skiff like this. Allegedly bringing a catgirl with it, but we only found the messed up shop and them unconscious." The human tells her, nonchalantly.

"And it should care me, because?" Catra mirrors the woman's voice.

The human chuckles humorlessly. "Those three always try to play the bad guy, they are quite ineffective I have to tell you. I,

however, play a different game. I will rip off your pretty little tail and ears." She grins up at Catra with a sickening smile.

Silence passes between them. Catra has two options, jumps down and fights, probably getting more of these people onto her neck, but her wound would probably slow her down. Or, try and throw them off with the skiff.

Suddenly, Catra moves kicking the woman in the face with every power she had in her legs,

"Oh, try it, sweetheart." Catra smiles down at her mockingly. "Only if you can catch me though."

Then, the catgirl turns driving away from the two, the wind against her pulls her hood revealing her wild mane and ears. People either jump away from her way or get hit, she doesn't really care about them at all. Her ears pick up a sound behind her, the two following her with some type of motor.

So Catra does what she is the best at.

Ensuing chaos.

She takes a sudden harsh turn to the right, driving to another street, promptly destroying two or three displays by how wildly she drives the skiff. Catra knows how to manoeuvre without hurting herself and she does enjoy the chase. What she doesn't expect is another one from their gang showing up on the opposite side driving in Catra's direction.

"Fuck." She groans, pulling the lever to leave the skiff turning, barely missing the wall.

Her heart beats so wildly against her rib it borderline hurts but also refreshing in a morbid way. She doesn't even know when was the last time she had this much fun. This is nothing but a chase to her, Catra knows she will win it at the end, but toying with these idiots are small revenge on what their idiot friends did to Catra.

"Oops!" She giggles when she hears the crash behind her.

They play this mouse and cat game between them when Catra decides it's time to stop it.

She turns the skiff again, but this time it faces the woman who threatened her. A wicked smile stretches over her lips, as she pulls down the lever. The skiff start-up at a high speed, driving directly towards the human and her vehicle. Catra has no intention to drive away, and it shows from the way she stands there so confidently.

It's the woman who turns away her own vehicle, driving into the rock wall with a loud crash.

"Boo, boring!" Catra laughs, stopping the skiff. She looks behind, the dust slowly settling down revealing the woman trying to stand up.

Catra jumps off from the skiff, getting her whip and with a strong lash, it curls around the woman's ankle, Catra yanks on it sending the body down to the ground with a dull thud.

She ignores her own pain, walking towards the human who struggles to get up. Catra stops in front of her, the human looks up at her but sees nothing just mismatched eyes filled with cruel satisfaction.

"What did you say? You would rip my ear and tail off?" Catra lifts an eyebrow with a mocking smile. "Aren't you a little full of yourself?" She tilts her head.

"L-look-"

"I don't care," She interrupts the woman. "Where did you get those vehicles?"

"Huh?"

Catra sighs, exasperated. "Are you that much of an idiot? Where did you get those? They are old Horde tech." She narrows her eyes on the woman, paranoia creeping up on her spine.

Did the Horde somehow track her and got a gang to kidnap her? Wouldn't be surprising.

"They are from the Horde?!"

"Yes, now where did you get those?" She nudges the woman's chin with her feet. "I don't have all day."

"We... We've found them not so far from here... It's... It's an abandoned village..." She stutters through her sentence.

The catgirl narrows her eyes at her. "Hm, interesting." Catra then turns around and walks away. "Oh." She stops for the last time, looking back at the woman over her shoulder. "If your lame gang tries something like this again, I will make sure you all end up 6 feet under."

Catra hops back to her skiff, landing on her right leg and drives away.

The village isn't just abandoned but particularly robbed of anything that could be useful. Metals, fuel, supplies, even weapons and they took some of the techs too.

The houses are nothing but ruins, most of them demolished to the ground others have their walls up, but the roofs have been busted. Windows broken, doors have been torn out. Even the plants have died out, a wasted place.

A Horde troop must have taken over the village, and drove off the villagers - or killed them - then the soldiers have vanished too.

Actually, they weren't far away from the Pit, but Catra truly doubts that any of them actually realized it. It looks like they have been attacked, which probably happened recently judging from the still fresh smell of burned metal. She recognizes most of the remaining

parts of the tech, it's old, used way before Catra even got her position as a Force Captain.

"Did I wreck the Horde that much?" She lifts an eyebrow, throwing away a piece of scrap. "Well, good job Catra." She smiles smugly, her tail lashing around.

Catra goes around, just to see if there is anything she can bring with herself. Mostly first aid.

No one is around anymore, her nerves a little less tensed up. She rummages through the ruins of the houses, finding burnt memories of the people who lived here. A torn doll, broken frames of pictures, abandoned dinner table. Her ears flatten and tail wrapped around herself.

“It’s not your problem Catra.” she reminds herself, leaving the destroyed room, only to step onto something.

She looks down, finding an old, frayed book. Catra tilts her head, a vague memory comes to her mind The cover looks familiar. She crouches down, taking it into her hand and dusting it off a little.

“Oh.”

Honestly Catra never really liked reading, it wasn't even that available in the Horde. They had no opportunity to read fairy tales and such stories. But she remembers one very clearly, Adora sneaked it around when she had found her headpiece. It was an old, a little torn children book that they liked to read when they were kids. It got lost during the years, Catra half sure that Shadow Weaver took it.

This is the same book.

Well, probably not the same that they had, but another copy of that.

A small chuckle leaves her lips. “Well... That’s a surprise…” She flips it open, finding little children doodles around the edges.

The small happiness from her eyes disappears in a second. Catra sighs and stands up, walking away, but taking the book with herself.

She looks around the Horde machines. What she finds it's a hundred per cent better. She gets her claw on a tablet, a little old and dusty, but working still perfectly. She leaps up to a busted robot, crossing her legs, looking through the tablet.

She mostly searched for information about stationing camps near her, so she could avoid them. She memorizes the names without a problem, swiping away then looking through them.

"Oh."

Catra stops at an order that probably every troop got the moment Hordak recovered from her attack.

Liquidate Order: Force Captain Catra

A picture of Catra flashes up, it's a recent one where she has her badge still and her headpiece. She looks miserable, there's no need to sugar coat it. She wonders if that's how she has always looked in the past years? Miserable and lost, trying to look strong and mighty. Part of her pity that Catra, but the truth is, she is still that person.

With a sigh she runs through the text attached to the order, it mostly tells that they either bring Catra in alive or dead. Hordak even had the audacity to offer the second in command position to whoever completes the job. She scoffs.

"Like anyone could do my job that effectively." She rolls her eyes with a grimace.

Honestly, she expected this, the order on her head. It's just pure luck that she didn't run into any Horde soldier. She is sure most of them would gladly try to take her down and bring her to Hordak. The keyword is: *try.*

She scrolls down, seeing the button at the bottom.

Order executed successfully.

Catra has tapped those buttons a few times in the past few years, knowing the satisfaction that runs through her body after a successful mission. When it was always about her seeking validation so desperately it blinded her, destroying and burning up everything for a few words that could satisfy the hole in her chest.

They never did. And the hole just grew bigger.

She stares at those words with empty eyes.

She taps on the button, for the last time in her life. The message goes through immediately, signalling everyone that the liquidation order has been carried out. The corner of her mouth tugs up to a small smile before she breaks the table dropping the two parts down to the ground. She leans back on her hands.

Catra looks at the distance, she is once again, alone.

Her day went a little crazy, but at least it was enough for her mind to be occupied. No memory, no guilt would have choked and haunted her. But now, alone in the silence of the world Catra feels agitated and frightened.

It's just her and the ghost of her past now.

"It will be better for everyone..." She tells herself again as if she tries to convince herself. "I particularly did them a favour."

Catra skips down to the ground, walking away from the camp leaving it behind herself. The last fragment of her old life was crushed to dust.

Force Captan Catra is dead.

"Catra, look!" Adora runs to Catra, her ponytail swaying wildly behind her. Catra however, doesn't look at her, she tries to clean off that smudge from the headpiece she has found. "Catra!" Adora nudges her, when Catra finally looks at her she flashes her a toothy grin, holding up the book in her hand.

Catra furrows her eyebrows a little and sniffs at the book, Adora giggles at her. "What's that? It's not food..."

"Of course not! It's a book, well not like what they give us here... I don't know what book is this actually." Adora knits her brows together with a frown. "What book is that?" She looks back at Catra.

The other just shrugs. "Not about fighting formation that's for sure."

"I can see that too!"

Catra chuckles at her, putting down the headpiece and turning fully to Adora. "Why don't we read into it?"

Adora nods at that, her face turning into a serious one like she is about to do a very important mission. She sits next to Catra, scooting closer. Adora turns around the book, squinting at the title.

"The star and the moon." She reads it with a little difficulty. "That's a weird name, there are no stars." She judges.

"Read, Adora!"

"Okay-okay," The book opens revealing a drawing on one page and a written part on the other side, Adora starts reading it.

"Once happened, that the stars from the sky disappeared. No one knew where they went or why they left. For a long time, it was only the moon's spirit who lit up the sky, and the people slowly

forgot about the stars. But the moon spirit felt lonely, her friends left her and they didn't come back to play with her anymore. Her shine became duller each day; she wasn't as bright as before. Until one day, she has fallen from the sky.

Without the moon's light, people got lost at night, no one knew how to help the little moon spirit. She was sick, the people tried to help her, bringing her nice warm blankets, or delicious food. But nothing helped her.

It wasn't until one night, when everything was so dark and cold, a little light lit up in the moon spirit's room. The ill spirit woke up, to see a glowing girl there, with a tiara made out of stardust. The glowing girl had healed the moon spirit, giving her glow and light back and the night sky was lit up again.

The moon spirit and the little star went back to the moon, playing around all day and at night, the star would join the moon in the night sky, quietly twinkling next to her friend."

Adora finishes the story, there is another drawing at the end, with two stars and the moon spirit who looked like two little girls with glowing white hair hold hands as they walked through the woods with a huge smile on their face.

"That's stupid." Catra breaks the silence, Adora shoves her away. "Hey!"

"It's not stupid, if it's stupid then our friendship is too." She pouts at Catra, the little cat girl looking up at her friend, her ears flatten down. She climbs back next to Adora.

"I'm sorry." She mumbles. "Did you like it? That's why you got angry?" Adora simply nods still pouting, Catra notices how teary her eyes got. "Then let's read the next one!" She nudges her friend and Adora looks at her surprised. "There are more, you see?" Catra points it out to her, flipping the page where another short story starts about them.

"But you said it's stupid..."

"I changed my mind! Now read it!" Catra leans her head to Adora's shoulder, purring lightly.

Adora giggles, but starts reading the next one, and the next one, and the next one, until they have fallen asleep on top of each other, their pinkies linked together.

Catra smiles at herself at the fond memory, she sits by a clearing, her wound cleaned and treated. Her body has all kinds of scars, battle scars, from her own scratching as a little kid, from Shadow Weaver's punishments. She has started to not pay attention to them as the years has progressed, they were trophies to her. I survived, she would say, even if her soul would be broken into million pieces, she will still hold these proudly.

Such a strange concept.

She sighs munching on a few dried meats she has bought in the Pit. It's not bad, definitely better than the fish or the ration bars. The little book is in her bag. After a time, she climbs back to the skiff.

"I wonder if you still remember the book." She whispers looking up at the sky. She lays back on the floor. They used to talk about the stars, how it would be if their night sky had stars, but, just in the little story. They have disappeared a long-long time ago.

The night is soon over, and after this whole mess, Catra just wants to rest a little bit before she has to wake up in the morning. So she readies herself to sleep, curling into herself, drifting to sleep.

That night, she dreams with the stars, a lullaby and warm golden eyes.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Kudos and comments are appreciated ♥

Question: Would you like to read part of Adora POV in future chapters or would you rather read a stand-alone fic with 2-3 chapters?

like a ghost

Chapter Summary

In another world Adora and her would lay on a field, no Horde, no Rebellion, no war, no She-ra just the two of them looking up at the night sky, getting lost in the infinite light. She would hold Adora's hand close to her, afraid that she would leave, but Adora wouldn't go, not without Catra. She wouldn't be afraid to feel, to be happy, to trust, to have Adora. She would be brave.

Brave to love.

Chapter Notes

The last chapter before the plot would really kick in!

Please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s been five days since Catra has left the Horde. And it all went by without action.

She has flown around, stopping only for the night or a small nap that mostly ended up with Catra waking up choking for air and terrified dreams of Shadow Weaver and the portal, poisoning her dreams. Other times she would be so exhausted that even nightmares left her alone, but waking up was just as hard and she felt just as tired.

For a change, she stopped by a village that had some celebration. Catra left in 5 minutes, the crowd making her anxious, and the fear of getting discovered still loomed over her head.

She has taken out of her mapping trinkets and spent a good chunk of her night trying to make sense out of them, slowly

figuring it out. Or reading the book, which somehow calms her mind even if it brings some bitter memories of the past.

They are a good distraction, nothing more.

Recently - yesterday night - she has decided to visit the Crimson Waste. It’s a good place to stay for a while, not a lot of people there, only outlaws and technically Catra is one.

The silence that surrounds her puts her on the edge, she got used to the constant sounds of metal hitting metal, the machineries running and people constantly shouting. She is not used to stillness, calmness. Before, if something was way too calm it meant that something would happen, usually, Shadow Weaver would call Catra for a “talk” or they would all get punished for their poor performance during training.

Relearning certain things is much harder than Catra thought.

Her wound started to heal, although she still had to change the gauze and clean it up occasionally. The bruise on her right leg shifted from red to purplish green, slowly healing too. It's easier to move and jump with it, but Catra is still cautious. To her pride, she got better at hunting, she also discovered that apples are not her thing, but pears are very delicious.

With the map, it's much easier to know where she is going actually. Currently, she is one day travelling away from the Crimson Waste. Here and there she almost ran into Horde soldiers but before anything could happen she was able to manoeuvre herself out of their way and hide from them.

Right now she is napping under a lonely osier, her skiff hidden behind its long tendrils.

Her dreamless sleep is interrupted as she feels something is poking her nose, she scrunches it up hoping that whatever bug is bothering her will go away. Well, it doesn't. She snaps her eyes open, clearly annoyed as she is face to face with a human child.

It's the little girl who screams at first, Catra following her, she is still dazed from sleep, barely grasping onto what's happening.

"Wait-" Reality catches onto her, it's just a *kid* . "What are you doing on my skiff?!" She jumps up, snarling at the kid, who suddenly starts to giggle and catches Catra's tail, accidentally pulling way too strongly. Catra hisses at the kid, pulling her tail back to her chest. "You can't just pull someone's tail!"

"Kitty!"

Catra backs away from the kid, and when the little girl runs towards her she lets out a shrill again. Drop her to an army of robots, she will know how to get out and what to do. But kids? No, thank you. She would rather face Hordak.

"Get away from me you demon!" She jumps up to the highest point of the skiff, crouching down her ears twitching a little and tail thrashing around. The kid just laughs, as if it's entertaining to her. Catra growls annoyedly. "Get out of my skiff, go-go. Go fetch your toy or something." She is shooing her away still at the top of the skiff.

Instead, the little girl plops down and giggles happily.

Catra groans, sitting down instead, looking at the kid as if she is the deadliest weapon in Etheria. In all honesty, Catra has no idea how old this kid must be, she is small of course, but not all mini-humans are supposed to be small? That’s the point. Although Catra doesn’t even have any idea how old she herself is, Shadow Weaver never bothered to tell her when she was born or when she was found. Birthdays weren't a thing in the Horde either, and the years blur together way too much to calculate how long she was in the Horde.

So, Catra is absolutely clueless.

She waits for a little, hoping that the kid would bore herself out, but it's Catra who gives up eventually.

"Why don't you go home?" She asks, tilting her head. "I have things to do, you know. "

Of course, the kid doesn't answer. Catra is no expert with children, doesn't know how to talk with them, the Horde isn't the best example of these kinds of behaviour either. The little girl continues to giggle as Catra moves her tail around now lazily instead of in distress.

"Grandpa' said no..uhh.. no talk with strangers."

The kid finally speaks, Catra snaps her head in the direction. "You get into *my* skiff!" She groans, pushing her bangs up.

They continue to sit in silence, the kid giggling each time Catra's tail moves around, finding it fascinating probably.

"Ugh, you won't go home on your own, right? Do you... Even have a home?" She wonders out loud. "You wouldn't answer, why am I trying." She sighs and jumps down to the floor of the skiff, stepping to the little kid. She giggles once again in amusement. "I will bring you home, but!" she holds up one of her fingers. "You don't get to pull my tail, it hurts." Once again she doubts that the kid even cares. So Catra just wraps her tail around her own waist, she takes her hood, flattening her ears against her skull, hiding them away.

She walks to the side of the skiff ready to jump out, expecting the little girl to come too when she doesn't hear footsteps she looks back seeing the kid in the same spot.

"Are you kidding with me?" She huffs, going back to the kid. "How do... How do I get you up? Do I just hold you or..." They look at each other, the kid's eyes sparkle with glee while Catra is lost more than ever. She crouches down. "So... Help me here a little you little rascal."

The little girl giggles one again reaching out for Catra's ear, the older woman leaning away in an instant with a hiss stuck in her throat. "Ears are off the table too."

Catra walks around the little girl trying to figure out how to hold her while her tail is still tightly secured around her waist. She tries a few times, but each time panic awakens in her. What if she drops the kid? What if she starts crying? Catra doesn't know how to stop a kid from crying, they don't have a button or a switch.

Eventually, she takes another deep sigh pushing her hair again. "Come." She kneels and hoists up the child standing up cautiously. She checks on the kid she is still smiling, that's good, right? "Okay, hold tightly, got it?" And with that Catra jumps off the skiff, landing easily on the ground the little girl giggling once again.

Catra scoffs at that, how easy it is to impress a little human. She puts her down letting out a relieved sigh, she is not crying."Okay, so where? I think I saw a village as I passed the forest." With that Catra starts walking away from her hidden skiff, the little child stumbling after her.

Catra jumps in surprise when a little chubby hand slides into hers, the little girl holding her hand. She just blinks down at her and then at their joined hands.

"Uhm... I mean, I guess... You can hold my hand or... Whatever." She huffs.

They walk side by side, Catra's eyes constantly looking for some incoming threat, she wouldn't be able to fight with the little human near. Maybe run away yes, but if they close in on them then there wouldn't be much she can do. She glances down at the little one, who seems to be happily skipping next to her.

"What's your name?"

"Alana." The girl answers giggling looking up at Catra.

Catra just hums, continuing to look at the distance.

“It’s rude not to tell your name if you ask someone else’s.” Alana looks up at her with furrowed brows.

“It’s rude getting into my skiff and disturbing my sleep, little rascal.”

“Then I’ll just call you Kitty!”

At the nickname, Catra’s mind flooded with Scorpia’s voice, the first they have met the scorpion called her Kitty and stuck to that name until she found the ridiculous Wildcat name for her. Catra takes a deep breath, willing her mind away from these memories, guilt and shame raining down on her.

“Rose. My name is Rose.” She feels a little bad for lying to the mini human but doesn’t feel safe enough to tell her real name. “Don’t call me Kitty.”

Alana stops before their hand could separate Catra stops too. Alana crouches down for a flower and plucks off a poppy, she turns and gives it to Catra.

"Oh.. uhm, thank you?" She looks confused at the flower and then Alana. She seems to sense Catra's hesitance, so she pulls Catra down and slides the flower to her hair, Catra almost jumping away thinking she wanted to touch her ear.

"Pretty Rose!" She announces with a giggle and Catra feels her cheeks heating up.

Catra just blinks at the little human, her ears moving forward. Alana blinks at her with her big green eyes. “You are supposed to say thank you when someone says something nice to you.”

“Thank you.” Catra groans, feigning annoyance.

They continue their walk, Alana holds onto Catra’s hand again.

"Do you remember where you come from?"

"O' course!" Alana says proudly, and she takes on the lead, Catra following her because at some point the little girl is pulling the catgirl with herself.

Catra isn't that familiar with the place, and if the girl tells her that the village is in that direction, she should listen to her, right? Wrong.

"Alana..."

"What?" The little girl looks up at her, Catra's ears are twitching and she looks at the deeper part of the forest.

"Are you sure we are going in the right direction?" She lifts an eyebrow, looking doubtfully at Alana.

Alana just nods, leading Catra further into the forest.

"Look, look! Squirrel! Hello, squirrel!" Alana waves to the squirrel jumping from one branch to another."Why are you not saying hello to the squirrel?" She looks up at Catra accusingly as if she did something absolutely horrible.

Catra blinks down at the little human. "Huh?"

"Say hello to the squirrel! You will hurt their feelings." She tells Catra matter of factly.

"Squirrels don't have- ugh...okay. Hello, squirrel." Catra deadpans, but it seems to lighten up Alana's face again. The catgirl just shakes her head to herself, mini-humans are strange.

Alana says hello to every single creature they come across, birds, another squirrel, bunnies, even a passing fox who Catra hisses at, but Alana makes her apologize. That's the weirdest thing she has ever done. Of course, she has to say hello to the creatures too or Alana will look at her angry, something Catra learnt pretty quickly she doesn't like.

"Look, little human, I believe that we got lost," Catra says, eventually crossing her arms looking down at Alana. "You had no idea where we were going, right?"

"I have it! It's just...confusing." She pouts up at Catra. "The forest is confusing."

"That's the point?' She lifts an eyebrow, then she sighs. "Come, let's go back to then we will try again." She reaches for Alana's hand again, about to turn around, but Alana points behind Catra.

The older turns her head, only to be welcomed by a wolf prowling after them.

"Oh shit-"

"Grandpa says it's a bad word."

"Your grandpa wasn't followed by a wolf." Catra groans, taking a slow step back the wolf starts to growl.

Catra hisses back, shoving Alana behind herself and grabs her whip. "Stay behind."

Alana doesn't even have time to answer as the wolf charges against Catra, the girl lashing her whip, the strong thong colliding with the ground in front of the wolf. Catra strikes down again, her tail protectively wrapped around Alana's waist. The wolf only needed two or three shows of the whip before it decided that they weren't worth it and rather ran away. Catra lets out a relieved sigh.

She puts away her whip, turning around to see Alana looking up at her with big eyes. "What?"

"You are so cool." She says in awe, blinking up at the cat girl.

"Yeah, uhm.. let's go back? I don't want to meet another animal." Instead of holding hands, Catra just keeps her tail wrapped around Alana's wrist, but the little girl seemed contained with that.

"Where is your home, Rose?" Alana looks up at her, munching on some berry she has found.

Catra walks without answering, her mind not registering the name as her own. Alana held onto her cloak and tugged it.

“Oh, yes?”

“Where’s your home?” The little girl asks again.

"I don't have a home."

Alana furrows her brows in confusion, clearly not understanding what it means if someone doesn't have a home. Or a place to belong. Catra thinks it must be hard for a little human to grasp onto it yet.

"How?"

Catra just shrugs. "I simply don't have one. I just travel around."

"And you don't miss your family?"

The catgirl blinks, confused. "What's a family? Is that some kind of code for back up?"

Alana frowns, looking up at Catra as if she is joking, but the older doesn't laugh or smile."You know, papa, mama, grandma, grandpa and sisters, brothers! It's best when everyone is together and we eat loads!"

"What are those?”

“Huh?”

“What you’ve said. Papa, mama etc. Are these ranks?”

“What are the ranks?”

Catra takes a deep breath. “Just tell me what’s a papa?”

“Oh, it’s a… uh, parent? Yes, a parent!”

“Okay, and what’s a parent?”

Alana looks focused ahead of herself, as if she is trying to wild out some important information, then. “I don’t know.”

“This conversation is pointless.” Catra deadpans.

“So do you have a family?” Alana asks again, ever so enthusiastic.

“No."

"So are you alone?" Alana tilts her head up.

A few seconds pass, Alana not taking away her eyes from Catra who just looks into the distance.

"You can say it like that."

They wander around the forest until they finally get out of it. Catra tries to remember where she exactly saw the village. Alana is suspiciously silent, probably wondering about what Catra has said, on the other hand, the catgirl does her best not to dwell too much into it.

So what if Catra doesn’t have a home. The Fright Zone never felt like one, it was mostly just a place of pain and bad memories. And she *likes* being alone. There’s no one who would anger her, who would try to control her, tell her what to do, or leave her. Catra is *perfectly* fine with being alone.

She can see the outline of the village from here, it's pretty small as she noticed from the skiff mostly farmers live here, that pear orchard must belong to them too from where she stole a few earlier. She glances down at Alana, but the only thing she can see is her tear swollen eyes and distressed look.

"Alana-"

"Bad people..." She whimpers, getting out of Catra's tail and runs away.

"Alana!" Catra calls her name, looking back at the village one last time. And she sees.

Horde soldiers.

Her heart stops, she pales down stepping back one or two, running after Alana. Luckily she catches up with her quickly, holding onto her, she buries her head to Catra's chest as the older hugs her close to herself.

"It's okay, I won't let them hurt you." She whispers patting her head, she tries to control how her whole body shakes with anger and fury.

Why does it bother you? You did the same. You have hurt hundreds of people, destroyed their home, killed their family. You are not better than those soldiers.

When Catra looks up she sees Shadow Weaver standing before them, her presence still haunting her like a vengeful ghost. She looks at her, even though she knows it's just a hallucination, her mind playing tricks on her. Then looks down at Alana, the little girl looking back at her, and for a moment Catra sees herself as a little child. Unruly mane and big teary eyes.

Alana hiccups, wiping away her tears clumsily. "You promise?"

Catra hears Alana's and her childlike voice at the same time.

"I promise."

She takes Alana into her arms again, the girl buries her face to her neck, while she holds Catra's tail in one of her hands. Catra’s eyes quickly study their surroundings, finding a hiding spot for the little human.

Catra brought Alana to a nearby big tree, something similar to where her skiff is.

"Stay put, only come out if you hear my voice. Okay?"

"Okay."

Catra smiles at her once more, here Alana can be easily hidden. She stands up and walks away.

Catra easily sneaks around the village, she spots a few soldiers, 6 exactly, 3 robots. She narrows her eyes, why did the Horde send troops to a village like this? Oh, then she remembers. They must be low on supplies after all she blew everything up. She looks around to see if she could see civilians, and eventually, she spots them near a storage house without walls, bound to each other and two soldiers guarding them, 8 soldiers with them all.

That will be a piece of cake Catra tells herself. She knows everything, how they fight, how they handle emergencies, she was their commander.

She goes for the robots first, they are easier to take out and it also means she doesn't have to jump away from any laser beam. She sneaks around the houses until she spots the first bot, with grace she climbs up to a rooftop, peeking down at the robot. With a huff she jumps down, her clawed hands piercing through the surface, she grabs the adapter and yanks it out the robot collapsing to the ground without power. She throws away the adapter, leaving the robot.

The other two bots are just as easy until she is seen.

"Hey, you!"

"Oh shit." She hisses, jumping away from the attack, holding onto his shoulder as Catra flings herself over him, kicking him into the back and the man stumbling at the wall hitting his head. She decides to blow her cover, so she jumps out from behind the house landing a kick at the soldier's side, taking away his teaser easily teasing the other soldier who is running towards her.

Catra takes down the others too with ease, kicking, punching and clawing them she doesn't even need the teaser. The last one falls too, out of consciousness.

“Hm?” She furrows her brows looking over the soldiers. “Wait, that’s only 7-”

A scream rips out of her throat as she falls forward electricity runs through her body, it wouldn't have been that bad but her wounded side got the direct hit. She painfully huffs, trying to force her body to get up from the ground, she looks behind herself seeing the last soldier. And out of nowhere, Catra starts chuckling slowly standing up with little electric shocks shaking her.

“You know… I got stronger hits.” She simply says, flinging her feet, kicking the soldier to the side by her head. “Are you going to stay here or I have to beat you up more? Which I’m not against.” She narrows her eyes, drawing out her claws with a hiss.

The soldier scrambles to her feet running away.

Catra doesn’t even pay any more attention to her, she hurries to the storage where the farmers are, it’s only a handful of people. She hopes the other could run away at least.

“Don’t worry, I’m going to free you.” She says calmly before she slashes the restraints down. “Is everyone okay?”

“Oh, thanks to the Moons! A princess saved us!”

Catra grimaces at one of the men, he is older than the rest of us, his eye smile reminding her of Alana. “What? I’m not a princess.” She scoffs, her hands on her hips looking absolutely pissed at the thought.

“But then…”

“I’ve found Alana and wanted to bring her back but we’ve seen the Horde soldiers so I took care of them. I’m no princess.”

“But you are so cool!.” A little boy speaks up with awe in his voice.

“Well, uhm... Thank you? I guess… Anyways, who is responsible for Alana? I will bring here now that these soldiers are taken care of.” She looks back at the unconscious soldiers.

The old man who thought Catra was a princess speaks. “I’m her grandfather.”

The title says exactly nothing to the girl. “Great, I will be back in a minute with her.” She turns away and runs to the tree where she has left the little girl.

"Didn't we call the princesses?"

"They might have not gotten our distress call."

The voices reach her before she leaves the village. She feels out of her element suddenly. The princesses. They have called them which means they will be here soon, which means Adora will be here too. Maybe Scorpia too.

Do they know that Catra has defected? Do they worry about her? Or search for her? Or just straight up don’t care about what happened with her. And honestly, she can’t blame them.

“Alana? Alana, you can come out,” The little girl runs to Catra with teary eyes, hugging her legs, crying. “Alana?"

"I was worried!" she squeaks in between little sobs.

" Oh, you were worried about me?” Catra stares at the little girl, then she smiles at, patting her head. “It’s okay, I’m okay… Your grandfather is okay too. Do you want to see him?”

Alana nods, drying her tears up, reaching for Catra's hand what the older takes with the same warm smile.

"Let's go."

She can see how excited Alana is to finally see her grandfather again, she skips again.

"You can run ahead if you want. I will be behind you."

Alana smiles up at her and runs ahead towards the village, Catra chuckles a little at her. She walks calmly knowing that the soldiers won't be a problem anymore. Although maybe roping them together wouldn’t be a bad idea, or she could stay and scare them away.

What? No, she can’t afford to stay. No.

She nears the village and sees Alana being lifted by her grandfather, the little girl giggles. Catra thinks it's a beautiful sound. She stops a little away from them, suddenly feeling awkward for a long time, she has saved them she could just go without anyone noticing. Then why is she still here?

Alana jumps out of her grandfather's hold and runs to Catra, she holds Catra's hand and pulls towards the others.

"Uhm, Alana?" Catra is confused again, this seems to be a constant thing today. She looks up at the other farmers, mainly to the grandfather.

"If you want, you can stay a little longer? I think my granddaughter took a liking on you." He chuckles looking down at the little girl who plays with Catra's up and down moving tail.

"I... I don't want to bother, really and the princesses are going to be here soon anyways." She shakes her head, Alana suddenly pulling on her tail. "Hey, what did I say about tail pulling?" Catra looks down at the girl with a frown, finding herself eye to eyes with pleading big eyes. "Oh."

"Please?"

That's ridiculous. Did she really get fond of this little human? Staying here would mean risk, both to the villagers and to herself, especially if the princesses would show up.

Eventually, she lets out a defeated sigh. "Okay. But just a little."

Alana's face brightens up in a second, hugging Catra's leg again. Catra lets herself purr a little, she hopes none of the villagers had heard her.

She looks back at the soldiers, still out of this world. "I will take care of them. Did they hurt anyone?"

"No, a few villagers have run away, but they didn't hurt anyone, just bound us. They wanted our harvest." The grandfather explains it. "I'm Mar." He introduces himself and reaches out for Alana so Catra could go and deal with the soldiers.

"Her name is Rose!" Alana introduces her instead, excitedly telling him about her new friend to her grandfather.

Catra just grabs the soldiers by their arm or leg and tugs them out of the village, depositing them a little far away. One started to gain consciousness halfway so Catra just hit his head again, the man out of the world for the next hour at least.

The moons are still not up, but it's way past noon. "I have a few hours, but then I really need to go." She makes a note for herself. "And if a princess appears, then... I will just run. Yeah, that's a good idea. I can outrun them. Except for Sparkles and her idiot teleportation." She groans pushing her bangs a little. "Well, I can always just hit her in the head I guess...."

Since she is alone she talks more to herself, at first it was all weird and strange because she isn't used to talking about her feelings or thoughts. It's kinda therapeutic. And alarming.

Alana waits for her, leaning to the wall that surrounds the village. The little girls face light up when she notices Catra and waves at her, Catra smiles a little and waves too.

"Where are the others?" She asks, stopping next to Alana.

"They went for the others and checked the storage." The girl takes her hand again and leads her to a house, the door is open and Catra swears she never smelt anything this delicious.

Food in the Horde wasn't the best and she didn't really eat anything except that dried meat from the Pit, pears and some berries here and there. One that made her really sick. Inside the low table is full of food, ones that Catra doesn't know the names of, but they smell delicious so she throws out her concern over the identification of the food.

Alana brings her to the table, Catra sits down on the floor, Mar on the other side, and the little girl sits on Catra's lap, the older doesn't push her off, rather wraps her tail around the girl's waist earning a giggle. Her ears still hidden by the hood.

"You can eat as much as you want." Mar smiles at her and Catra's eyes widen.

"Wait... This is all for me?" She points at herself, shocked for sure. "Are you trying to poison me?" Suspicion takes over her because no way someone would do anything like this, but when she sees the confused look of the old man she just says. "Never mind."

Alana reaches the table and brings her some kind of meat on a stick. "This is very yummy, try it!

Catra's pupil dilates to the point it's all just black sparkling with pure joy, the moment she bites into the meat, her ears are peaking up and she is purring loudly, something very rare from her. Is this how food is supposed to taste like? Not like some weird mix of sand and mud and that's the better from the two kinds of ration bar they got.

"This is...delicious."

Alana giggles at her reaction and ever Mar lets out a chuckle. "I'm glad you like it. And thank you for bringing Alana home, helping us with the Horde soldiers."

"Oh, your welcome," Catra says chewing on the meat. "Do you have a lot of Horde troops around here?"

Mar shakes his head. "No, but I've heard they have come for other villages too, they take their harvest and if the people resist they burn down the houses and bring them with themselves." He tells her sadly. "Alana's father, he... He was dragged away too. She lived in a neighbouring village which the Horde took over. I could only save her." Mar looks at her granddaughter whose full attention is on Catra, holding onto her tail.

Catra's eyes fell to her lap where Alana is sitting. Guilt storms in her soul. Thinking about the other children, other families who have been separated from each other during the years of war. What if she was the reason because they couldn't see each other again. She reaches out and pats Alana's head gently.

"I'm sorry." She whispers, if it's for Mar or Alana, no one knows.

"And what about you, Rose? You seemed to know how to fight with those soldiers..."

"Ah...yes, I've had a few encounters with Horde soldiers during the years, I gathered a small knowledge on how to fight with them." She tells him, her ears twitching. She is still very good at lying. The cloak also hides the symbol on her back. They don't need to know.

"It must be hard. I assume you are not from any neighbouring village, I didn't see you or a family that would look like you." Mar mentions.

"Rose doesn't have a family grandpa." Alana turns to her grandfather with a scolding look. As if he would have known it.

Mar pales down at his granddaughter's words. "Oh...oh, I'm so sorry, I didn't know. I shouldn't have assumed." He apologises quickly, Catra blinking at him confused. Having a family must be a big deal.

"It's uhm... It's okay? I.. I don't have a family, but I had a really good friend." A small, nostalgic smile appears on her lips as she

thinks back at Adora, their childhood at the Horde when it was just them, no training, no Shadow Weaver, no She-ra or Rebellion.

Just them.

"Had?"

"I've lost her, 2 years ago." her voice changed from warm to almost clinical. "War is a cruel thing..."

"I'm sorry." Mar sighs. "You must miss her..."

"Yeah, I... I miss her terribly." She sighs, noticing Alana's big green eyes looking at her with worry.

"Rose?" She tilts her head, her brows knitted together. "Are you sad?"

Catra just smiles at her. "I'm okay." Catra glances out of the window, seeing moons slowly appearing with the stars. "I should go, thank you for your hospitality, but I need to continue my travel." She smiles once more at Alana, slowly rising to her feet.

"Can I ask you where are you heading?"

Catra thinks about it a little, then just shakes her head. "It wouldn't be safe for you to know where I'm going."

The implication is clear, Catra is running away from something or someone that's after her. It's still a question if it's Hordak or her memories, or if it's something deep inside her heart that she is afraid to face.

Mar stands up too. "Very well, let me give you this at least." He goes around and brings out a bag, Catra sniffs into the air. There's food inside. "Please accept it."

Catra blinks at the man, shocked. "I can't! You need food too, I can just eat whatever I find in the forest." Catra shakes her head.

"Oh no, forests are filled with poisonous berries and fauna, you better just take it before you kill yourself." Mar puts the bag in Catra's hand, not accepting the return.

She sighs, taking the bag and swinging it to her back, she can't deny the warmness in her heart. "Thank you."

"It's me who is grateful to you."

Catra looks down at little Alana, she crouches down to her and pats the little girl’s head. "I need to go now." She tells her, and honestly, she didn't expect Alana to start to cry.

Alana sniffs, wiping her nose with her clothing. "You must?"

"I have too, I'm sorry." and out of nowhere, she bobs Alana's nose. "But... If you want I can come and visit you, once in a while?"

"Like my birthday?"

Catra almost blurts out she has no idea what is a birthday, instead, she nods with a warm smile. "Of course, when?"

Alana looks at her grandfather for a little help. The old man chuckles fondly. "It's on the third day of the first winter month."

"Then I will come."

"Promise?"

The elder offers her a smile. "Promise."

She stands up, Alana holding her hand as they walk out of the house. But then, her legs root onto the ground when she hears a familiar voice.

"What... but, what...what happened here?"

It’s Scorpia’s voice.

"We got the distress signal, but...there's no Horde soldier. Everything looks calm and okay."

The flower princess.

"Oh, a girl just appeared and saved us all. We thought she was a princess but she looked rather offended at that"

"A girl?"

Scorpia again.

Catra's ear twitches anxiously her tail widgets around, wrapping itself around her thigh. She takes a step back, then two, letting go of Alana's hand. Mar looks at her puzzled.

"Yes, she is at Mar’s house."

Alana turns around seeing Catra standing just there. "Rose?"

Catra glances down at Alana, then back to Mar. “Look. I need to go. *Now* . Thank you for everything!”

She turns around and bolts away from the village. She just runs with all she can, her heart beats so fast it might just break out of its cage of bones. Catra almost stumbles, the poppy falling from her hair, but she can't stop. The moment she sees the osier, she moves her legs faster than ever

She jumps into her skiff turning it on hastily, she pants and all of her being is shaking, the panic and adrenaline fuel her body enough to actually drive out of the skiff from the tendrils, almost hitting Bow with it.

"ROSE!"

Catra glances back, hearing Alana’s voice, seeing the little girl run after her from the distance. She is crying, Alana is crying.

Because of her.

She made Alana cry.

Catra just pulls the lever more, increasing the speed of her tears falling behind her catching onto the wind.

"I'm sorry."

Catra doesn't know how long she is driving away from the village, she just knows that it's far far away from there by now. She still can't stop.

She didn’t see the princesses, but their voice was completely enough to set off her panic and make her run away from the slight chance of them even seeing her.

The moons are almost completely up, she should try to find a shelter for tonight. The valley may have not been the wisest choice to come through, it's known of its rockslides, but the other way would be through a highly weaponized Horde camp.

"I should be close to the Crimson Waste... Maybe I should stop for tonight..." She mumbles, the Crimson Waste is dangerous she should be in her best state. "I should eat something too." she looks back at the bag that Mar gave here.

Catra thinks about Adora and the princesses again. She made the right choice of slipping away, she tells herself. They would probably just attack Catra, and she really isn’t about fighting with them right now. Or even worse, they could have taken her to Bright Moon. Which could have meant meeting with Adora eventually. Because meeting with Adora, speaking with her would mean ripping up old wounds and Catra isn't ready for that. Doesn't think she will *ever* be ready.

She scoffs. "It doesn't matter. Adora hates me." She plops down and takes out some meat from a container and chews on it. "She hates me for what I've done. It would be useless."

Catra is so fixated on the fact that Adora hates her, that everyone hates her, it would be so hard to make her understand some

people still love her.

She finishes the meat, putting the bag away. She lays down on the floor of the skiff, curling around herself, trying to sleep, trying to silence her troubled mind.

It takes time and effort until her body finally takes a rest, exhaustion taking over her.

The moons are already up in the night sky as Adora hurries through the Whispering Woods, legs moving on their own while the girl is deep in her thoughts. The sword strapped to her back, afraid to even touch it since she has come back from Beast Island. Every time she touches or even looks at the swords she recalls the images of Mara holding them, screaming in pain as the sword tries to take over her, control her. How it was designed to control them, to make them part of the machine.

The key.

Once the planet is balanced, no one can stop it. Not even the First Ones could control it. That's why they left. When the weapon is activated it will channel all its power into you. You don't get to refuse.

You don't get to refuse.

Entrapta's voice echoes in her mind.

It makes her sick in the stomach, what did the First Ones do exactly to the planet and why? Why did they need a weapon? Why did they choose Etheria? So many questions and no answers.

The others don't understand, not like Adora. She has been lied to through her whole life in the Horde, which made her believe she was fighting for the good cause, that the princesses are the evil

ones and they are the ones destroying everything. She was nothing but a part of the machine to them too, and now, everything just repeats itself.

No, this time, Adora won't let it happen.

But, instead of the Crystal Castle like she expected to, she finds herself in front of Madame Razz's hut.

"What..." Adora furrows her brows, about to turn around. The trees stand so close to each other, she could barely even see past them, let alone squeeze herself through them.

"Ahhh, Mara dearie!"

Adora turns around, finding the old lady at the door of the hut, with a kind smile. Despite being late at night, she seems wide awake.

"Would you like to join for some tea?"

Before Adora could answer or correct her, Razz disappears behind the drape at the entrance of her home. Adora looks back to the trees one more time, then follows Razz into the hut. It is lit up by some candles around the hut, water boiling over the fireplace while Razz searches for two mugs.

"I really don't want to bother you Madam Razz, it's quite late." She stands in the door, a little awkwardly.

"Yes-yes, the moons are very beautiful tonight, don't you think Mara dearie? Aha! I knew it was here!" Razz throws away an old basket, holding up two cups, setting it down to the table. "What are you doing in the door still? Come on in!"

So Adora does. She sits down to the chair by the stone table, watching as Razz now searches for some dried flowers and berries for the tea. She stopped correcting the old women about her being Adora and not Mara. Eventually, Razz finds it and prepares the tea for both of them.

"It will help you clear your head and calm down, dearie," Razz tells her with a kind smile, drinking from her own mug.

"I... I'm not upset..." Adora tries to lie, drinking from the tea too. Raspberry and chamomile. It's strangely delicious. "It's just... I don't-... She-ra." She breathes. "Why does She-ra exist, Madame Razz? Isn't she supposed to protect the people of Etheria?" She questions, to or from herself or Madam Razz, is unclear. "Then why... Why did the First Ones try to use Mara as a key to their weapon?"

"My Mara dearie... She was brave and kind. She wanted the best for people." Razz speaks with a gentle voice, looking down into her tea, the dried chamomile and raspberry floating on top. "She understood her *true* duty and destiny as She-ra. Even if it eventually cost her life. She died doing what she was supposed to, protect Etheria from the ones who came before." She sighs, closing her eyes.

Adora just looks at the old woman, with eyes wide and unable to say anything else. Probably this is the first time she ever heard Madame Razz talk about Mara's death, and not just mentioning it. She sees the sadness in her weak smile and feels it in her voice.

"She-ra is a protector. But it is up to you Adora, what *you* choose to protect." Madame Razz opens her eyes, looking at Adora. "You are just like my Mara was, dearie. Brave and kind, and so full of love." She smiles at Adora, reassuring and gentle.

"I... I'm not like Mara, Madame Razz." She looks down at her hands in her lap. "I don't know what I'm doing, I couldn't protect the people who are important to me, I couldn't help them... Mara was brave, but I'm not."

"Are you, dearie?"

Adora just nods without a word, her inner turmoil about being She-ra and being Adora coming back to her. She-ra is supposed to be the hero, the one who will help the Rebellion and eventually

lead them to victory. Everyone expects her to know everything, to win every battle, to be the glorious hero of Etheria, to get rid of the Horde. But it's just getting worse. The Horde is gaining more and more territory, now threateningly close to attacking Plumeria too, while Adora is unable to stop them.

She doesn't know how to stop the Horde, doesn't know how to be She-ra *and* Adora.

"Maybe I wasn't cut for being She-ra after all."

Madame Razz shakes her head, then drinks the tea again. "She-ra is not another person, dearie. She-ra is you."

Adora looks up, confused a little. But Madame Razz doesn't explain it further. "She-ra is... Me?"

"Do you feel her in your heart?"

The girl furrows her brows, losing the thread of Razz's thought, which is not surprising. It wouldn't happen for the first time. Does she feel She-ra in her heart? Debatable. She always thought about She-ra as the sword, that's how she can become She-ra. The sword chose her to be She-ra.

"I don't understand Madame Razz."

"What you don't understand Mara dearie?" Razz narrows her eyes, her big eyes boring into Adora's, then, she goes back sipping from her mug.

Adora sighs, drinking from her own tea.

She might not understand it fully, she might not feel She-ra in her heart or know what to do as She-ra, or as Adora at all. But she knows one thing.

She won't let anyone use the Heart of Etheria. Mara's wish was to protect the planet, protect the people on it who she loved so

dearly she sacrificed herself for them, to keep them safe. She will keep up that legacy, she will have to. For Mara. For Etheria.

"Thank you, Madame Razz. This helped me a lot." She finishes the tea with a big smile, feeling lost and on track at the same time. "I will leave now."

"Visit me more, dearie! We can bake a pie!"

"I will come, I promise."

Adora leaves the hut, finding the path away from the hut that previously wasn't there. She chuckles to herself, the woods wanted her to come here. Now, she knows where to go. She steps away from the hut, following the path she knows well already. It leads her to the Crystal Castle.

Adora stops at the Crystal Castle. "Eternia." And the door opens, she hurries inside the dark place lighting up the moment she sets foot into the big centre room. "Light Hope?"

She looks around, waiting for noise or anything. Nothing happens.

She huffs. "I know about the Heart of Etheria. I know you've lied to me, about Mara, about She-ra, the First Ones." The calmness in her voice surprises even herself.

"I did not lie to you, Adora."Light Hope appears in front of Adora, the girl taking a few steps back. "Mara was compromised, turned against her people and nearly destroyed Etheria along with it."

"No." She shakes her head. "Mara died, trying to *protect* Etheria from what the First Ones did to the planet." She narrows her eyes on the hologram. "You... The Heart of Etheria, it's a weapon, it could destroy the whole planet! And you... You lied to me, everything about balancing out the planet, about the runestones, digging more into She-ra's power... It was just for you to execute this plan... To activate it." Adora finishes it, cold anger running through her veins.

Light Hope just looks down at her, without saying a word for a long time. The silence between them louder than hundreds of earthquakes.

"The Heart of Etheria project could have been a success of turning Etheria into a weapon no one has ever seen before, but Mara, instead of fulfilling her destiny, turned against it. She used She-ra's power to fight against the people who called her a hero. Who *made* her be a hero."

At the last words, the room which has been lit up by a blue and purple light turns into red and orange. Adora reaches for the sword in an alert but quickly retracting her hands as she remembers why this sword exists. Not to help her, but to control her. To control She-ra.

"Mara was nothing but a failed She-ra in the system, but you Adora, you could bring glory to the First Ones, to those who you belong to." Light Hope says, her voice echoing back from the crystal walls. "Etheria is not your true home."

"No! *This* is my home. *Etheria* is my home, you can't manipulate me into helping you. Not anymore." She bites back.

"You could make your parents proud."

This takes Adora by surprise. She looks up at the hologram with wide eyes, at the mention of her family. She shakes her head. "You've lied enough, this is low even from you."

"But your parents gave you to me, Adora. So proud of their daughter chosen to be the next She-ra, to fulfil a thousands year plan of your ancestors."

"You... You said Hordak... You said Hordak brought me to Etheria. That he stole me from my family, from my home!" Adora balls her hands into a fist, her body shaking. "What did you lie about too? How many lies have you told me, Light Hope?!"

Light Hope looks down at her, slightly confused maybe. "Would you feel better knowing your parents gave you up for a greater cause? They have seen the potential in you, Adora, now you could bring glory to their empire."

"That's bullshit, greater cause? A whole planet would have been destroyed, and for what?!"

"I see you don't quite understand it. The power of She-ra is for serving the First Ones, the hero you are today is because the First Ones wanted you to become one. You exist because of them, She-ra exist because of them, you cannot say no, Adora. Your destiny was set the moment you were brought here, the moment you touched the sword and left the Horde. You *cannot* walk out of it. You *don't* have a choice."

You don't get to refuse.

" *NO* !" Her voice bounces back from the crystals, eyes sparkling with blue light. "I have a choice! I'm not a part of their game, I'm not going to let you or anyone activate the Heart of Etheria, it will stay sealed for eternity. I will make sure no one will ever use its power." She reaches for the sword. "Now, I understand Mara, her wish."

"What are you doing, Adora?"

The sword in her hand glows up with power, her eyes sparkling with blue magic. "Mara wanted to be the last She-ra, so the First Ones wouldn't be able to use the planet as a weapon. She failed, as I was brought to Etheria. Mara couldn't be the last She-ra."

"ADORA!"

" ***So I will be*** ."

Golden glow envelops her body but doesn't transform her into She-ra. Adora slashes through the air, power cutting though Light Hope, who disappears. The power has damaged the wall, and Adora doesn't stop here. She destroys the Crystal Castle from

within, even if Light Hope sends spiders to stop her, Adora destroys them all, until the light dims and everything is covered in darkness again.

Adora stands in the middle, the stone in the hilt of the sword glows brightly, along with her eyes. She pants badly, every part of her body shaking with anger.

"I won't let anyone activate the Heart! Etheria will be safe from you and the First Ones!"

Unsurprisingly there's no answer. She can still feel Light Hope around, she didn't destroy her, but Adora didn't really expect to do so. She lowers her sword, waiting in the silence of the darkness. There are no spiders, no trace of Light Hope. She sighs, stepping away walking out of the castle, the door opening and closing behind herself.

Adora looks up at the sky, watching the moons of the night sky beaming in light, purple, blue and green.

"I promise, Mara."

Catra opens her eyes, blinking slowly.

She looks around, her breath hitches sitting up quickly as takes in her surroundings. She is in a cell, her arm bound to the wall behind herself. She is not in the Fright Zone cell, this one's different, it reeks of magic and sparkles.

"Hello, Horde scum."

Catra turns to look at the door, Glimmer standing at the door. Her eyes are filled with grief.

“W-what.”

"This is all your fault... you have killed them... It's your fault..."

The catgirl looks at the princess with widened confused eyes. "I... I didn't-"

"Entrapta... my mother... Adora."

The names are a knife to her heart, she scoots back against the wall, trying to hide away from Glimmer, her words.

"No... no, I didn't, I didn't..."

"Why did you do it, Catra?" It's Entrapta kneeling in front of the catgirl. The princess's eyes are watery, sad. "Why did you sent me to Beast Island?" She grasps Catra's shoulder with a deadly grip. "Why Catra, why? Why did you do it? *Why* ?"

Entrapta's voice echoes in the silence of the cell, pining Catra down to the wall with her eyes. Catra shakes, squeezing her eyes and turning her head away. She shakes her head.

"Catra... Catra, why... I thought we were friends, we... You hurt me, killed me." Adora's voice comes closer, Catra cracks her eyes open finding Adora's blue eyes boring into her own mismatched eyes. Splattered blood sticking to her skin. "Why did you kill me...Catra why? Why? Why?"

And suddenly Adora disappears and instead, it's Queen Angella towering over her. Around her hands, energy blasts circulating.

"You don't deserve peace for your actions."

She wakes up with a scream, sitting up on the floor of the skiff. Her eyes frantically moving, her whole body shaking with fear. Catra gasps for air, almost feeling like she is suffocating, a sob rips out of her chest, crying once again.

"Stop! Please just stop!" She shouts at no one in particular. "Please stop, leave me alone...Leave me alone." She begs, burying her face into her shaking hands, her ear is flattened down to her hair, bangs falling forward.

"Stop, stop... It hurts, please no more, please, please." Catra cries curling onto herself, trying to comfort herself with no success. Her mane falls along, ticking her off, her skin prickling from the touch of her own hair.

With a growl, Catra unsheathes her claws and without thinking, she slashes through her own locks, until they don’t touch her skin anymore. Tendrils of hair fall to the floor, Catra breathes heavily looking at them with tearful eyes. Her hair reached around her chin.

Her nightmares didn't leave, of course, they didn't. She still dreams about the portal, Entrapta, Shadow Weaver, Adora, Scorpia. Even Glimmer, as she attacks her screaming about her lost mother because that's Catra's fault too. If she wouldn't pull the lever, none of this would have happened. There wouldn't be a deadly Horde armada nearing Etheria either.

It takes her time to calm down, to feel safe again, although Catra never really felt fully safe in her own skin. She takes a few deep breaths, pushing her hair down out of habit, hands stopping at her shoulders. She blankly stares at her own feet, moving them side to side a little. Her mind is blank again just after every bad dream, break down or panic attack. She doesn't know how to control them, they don't stop but come back with a more powerful blow.

It was rare for her dreams to be pleasant and her nights to be calm.

Catra looks up at the sky, the twelve moons of Etheria are looking back at her, with their colourful surface. Catra never paid much attention to the sky, but being alone she appreciates and hates a lot of things at the same time. Like how serene a night could be.

She thought the constant buzzing of the machines, the strong smell of oil and fuel would be something she will never miss once she leaves the Horde. They have been something that followed her through her life, whenever she woke up or fell asleep. Whenever she was punished she listened to the rhythmic sounds of the machines, keeping her grounded. She knew one day she would rule that place, she would destroy everyone who ever made her feel weak.

And she did.

Yet she has never felt so empty and lonely, hurt. She knew it would be a long journey before she could feel whole again, or at least a bit happy.

Climbing up to the top was hard, almost torture. She has given up a lot, either voluntarily or by her own choice, pushed away people who loved her. And for what? She fell so easily, even if the fall was her own choice.

"I don't regret it." She whispers to herself, she has become a lot better at saying her feelings out loud. Even if just for herself. "I don't regret leaving, I just..." She reaches up to the sky, her mind drifting to the memory of Adora.

In another world Adora and her would lay on a field, no Horde, no Rebellion, no war, no She-ra just the two of them looking up at the night sky, getting lost in the infinite light. She would hold Adora's hand close to her, afraid that she would leave, but Adora wouldn't go, not without Catra. She wouldn't be afraid to feel, to be happy, to trust, to have Adora. She would be brave.

Brave to love.

But in this world, everything is much more complicated. She is an ex-Horde soldier, a haunted defect, a war criminal. She has hurt many people, including Adora too.

She lazily blinks up at the sky, eyelids becoming heavier with each second. She wants to fight against it, wants to stay in this

peacefulness a little longer. But eventually, she gives in and her head lulls to the side, drifting into a dreamless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading!

left your mark

Chapter Summary

And this is what Catra is doing.

Surviving.

Chapter Notes

This was a ride. It's also much longer than any of the chapters before.

Please enjoy!

3 months later

Another day, another war room meeting.

And, as it is always, just pure chaos.

Adora sits in her seat, hunched over the table, holding onto her head as the others are screaming over each other. Her hair let down, tired to even get it into a ponytail.

"We have to protect Plumeria!"

"We don't even know if the Horde wants to attack Plumeria, all we know they could go for Snows or Bright Moon!"

"Entrapta still couldn't tap into the Horde's system, maybe we should wait for a little?"

"Wait to what exactly, Scorpia?! To them to attack us again? Thanks, but no."

"Perhaps we should retreat and try coming up with a decision after we cool down?"

"I'm perfectly calm!"

"We should use the Heart of Etheria."

"I do agree with the Queen."

"And I do not agree with Shadow Weaver taking a seat in our war room meetings."

"I'm with Micah."

Adora groans, looking up.

She sees Bow on the other side, sitting silently looking worriedly at the others. Mermista is shouting over whatever Perfuma is trying to say, while Scorpia mumbles something to herself shaking her head. Glimmer, on the other hand, is up from her seat talking - yelling - animatedly to Sea Hawk who seems lost, Frosta just looks around not knowing what to do. Micah and Shadow Weaver are arguing, *again.* And Entrapta is nowhere to be seen. For two days.

"ENOUGH!"

She stands up from her seat, attracting the other's attention to herself. Adora seems to register the attention given to her and clears her throat anxiously.

"We won't be able to come up with anything if we jump at each other's throat. We already lost Salineas, we won't let the same happen to any of the other kingdoms, but we must work together. And Glimmer, we won't use the Heart of Etheria. That's it." She turns towards Glimmer, who narrows her eyes.

"We have a weapon that could destroy the Horde, and you don't want to use it?" She encounters, Shadow Weaver nodding along with her.

Adora surpasses the urge to yell at the sorceress. "Yes, Glimmer. Because it's a dangerous weapon, it could and probably will

destroy Etheria during the process. And we don't even know how it works exactly!"

"You don't know that it could destroy Etheria."

I know that it's dangerous and I'm not going to risk Etheria for it. We will find another solution."

"We are already running out of solutions, Adora." Shadow Weaver speaks up from next to Glimmer. "We did a long time ago."

"Why is Shadow Weaver allowed into the war room again? She is a prisoner."

Micah nods. "I'm curious about that too."

For a second, Glimmer is clearly taken back that her father sides with Adora, she shoots an unsure look at Bow who looks away. "Shadow Weaver helped us once, and she has deep knowledge about the Horde. She is useful." Glimmer says.

"Yeah, but didn't she like run away after Catra put her down?" Mermista arches an eyebrow. "She knows nothing about Hordak's current plan."

"This plan is not Hordak's." Shadow Weaver speaks up, eyes zeroed on her. "It's too well planned and organized, this was planned out by Catra," She almost spits her name with disgust. "He clearly uses it still, after she has defected."

"You still don't know anything about the plan." Frosta encounters, looking at Shadow Weaver. "This is a waste of time!"

"Frosta is right." Bow sighs, standing up. "Maybe we should take Sea Hawk's offer and take a few minutes break. We are all clearly worked up." He walks out of the room without even waiting for anyone's answer.

The others follow suit, Perfuma sticking to Scorpia who said to check up on Entrapta, wherever she is currently. Mermista warily

eyes Shadow Weaver who leans over Glimmer whispering something to her, Sea Hawk pulls her out. Frosta follows them, yawning.

It's only the four of them now.

Adora eyes Shadow Weaver, not trusting in the sorceress at all, feeling uneasy every time she is near or hears her voice. She just can't shake off this feeling. Bright Moon used to be a safe place for her, she didn't have to fear from the shadows which could be the sorceress' pet keeping an eye on her, like in the Horde. She didn't have to be wary of walking on the hallways, afraid of stumbling into her.

Now, Bright Moon feels like the Horde, just much brighter and less violent.

"I want Shadow Weaver out of the war room, not just for this meeting but for every other too." She says finally, looking at Glimmer hoping that her friend would understand.

"What? No! She is useful-"

"She didn't say a single word at all!" Adora raises her voice in anger. "For all, we know she could work with the Horde!"

"It's truly not safe or a smart decision for us to let her into our plans, Glimmer." Micah nods, stepping to his daughter. "Shadow Weaver isn't someone who you can trust in."

"You wound me, Micah." Shadow Weaver sighs, not stepping away from Glimmer. "You could say anything you want, but we are not trying to work up a strategy against my plan that's destroying the Rebellion. It's Catra's." She looks at Adora pointedly.

Adora refuses to back down, or lower her gaze. "What do you mean by this?"

"Do you think I don't know that you are trying to find that pet with your little friends from the Horde?" She asks, voice almost

amused. "The Rebellion's hero should be busy with her duty rather than chasing an insolent animal."

"Like you care." She scoffs. "And don't call her a pet, or animal."

"Even away from you, she does nothing but distracts you from your purpose."

"Shadow Weaver enough," Micah warns her, voice low.

"Worrying about Catra is useless, she is like a cockroach. She can live through everything." She says dismissively, and Adora's patience runs thinner and thinner with each second. "Honestly, I'm surprised she survived this long. Should have ended her a long time ago, now we wouldn't have thi-"

"Stop it!" Adora shouts at her, breathing heavily. Walking right into Shadow Weaver's game. "Shut up! Don't you ever dare to talk about Catra like that again! You've ruined her, you've ruined *us* !"

Shadow Weaver looks down on Adora, thanks to her mask it's hard to read what she is thinking. "It seems like you are trying to blame me for something I did not do. Did I ruin you and Catra?" She asks, her voice low and haunting. "Or was it you, running away with your new little friends, leaving the Horde and everything behind? *Leaving Catra behind* ." She points out rendering Adora speechless. "And now that Catra did the same with you, you are the one who feels the world is suddenly unfair to you?"

Adora didn't know when, but Shadow Weaver is suddenly in front of you, touching her cheeks like she used to.

Micah is about to intertwine.

Adora pushes Shadow Weaver away. "Get out of my head! I'm not going to fall for your little mind games. I've left because I've seen what the Horde did and I had a chance to change the future! Don't try to act like you know me, or Catra. You know nothing about us." She narrows her eyes on Shadow Weaver.

“I’ve raised yo-“

“You’ve *hurt* us. None of us asked you to be a horrible mother figure to us.” She announces coldly. “You are only here because you could manipulate Glimmer, but I don't care how close you are with her... If you talk about Catra like this ever again, I will end you." She threatens the sorcerer, her eyes glowing up with blue light for a split second. "I don't want you near the war room *or* me. Stay away from me."

Adora turns around and leaves the room.

Her hands shake next to her thighs, she balls them into fists, hiding it. She breathes heavily, her heart beating so fast it hurts. She quickly nears the next corner, hiding in the shadow she presses her back to the wall, squeezing her eyes close. Her whole body runs cold, yet sweat collects on her forehead.

Adora tries to breathe slowly, calming down her raging mind and heavily beating heart but only manages to do it twice before she takes a deep sharp breath and heaves. She crouches down, hugging her knees to her chest tightly, and pressing her forehead to her knees.

Like this, she feels her heart and hears how fast she is trying to take a breath as if she is about to suffocate.

In the midst of storms in her mind, she remembers Entrapta's voice, as once she guided Adora through an impromptu panic attack.

Take a deep breath, Adora, do you want me to do it with you?

Adora slowly takes a deep breath through her nose, until her lung almost hurts.

Now exhale it, slowly. Like this.

She lets it out through her mouth, aware of how heavily her heart beats.

One more time, okay?

Adora repeats it, again and again until she feels less like she is going to suffocate and more like she is going to live another day. Her heart calms down gradually too, her mind clearing up slowly. Her legs give in under her, sitting down on the floor staring at the wall in front of her.

She has no idea how much time has passed since she has left the war room. The shadows reach a little longer, completely enveloping Adora into itself.

Eventually, it's Frosta who finds her.

"Are you okay, Adora?" Asks the little princess, settling down next to her.

"Yeah." Adora gives her a weak nod, her voice rough. "Just had a little hard time, don't worry." She looks down at Frosta. "What are you doing here?"

Frosta shrugs. "I went back to the war room, we are taking a longer break. Glimmer and Micah are fighting." She mumbles the last part. "Then I found you."

Adora just nods, she closes her eyes for a fleeting moment. She feels Frosta leaning at her arm, she lets the little princess.

"Is it true what Shadow Weaver has said?" Frosta's voice is small, almost unsure as to if she doesn't know if she should have asked this or not.

"What do you mean?"

"About you searching for Catra? Sorry, I just... I heard it and... I eavesdropped. Sorry."

"It's okay." Adora sighs. "But uhm... Yes, Entrapta and Scorpia are helping me find Catra. Or something like that. We don't really have any lead."

"But why? Isn't she your enemy?" Frosta sounds genuinely confused, Adora imagines her with pinched eyebrows and a slight pout.

"Well... Uhm, yeah. Catra is..." Her voice falters, trying to find the right words. "Catra is my enemy. Or was. But she is also many more to me, we were best friends, we grew up together and... She is just really important to me, Frosta. I must try and find a way to bring her back."

Frosta nods slowly.

"If she would join the Rebellion would it be okay with you?" Adora asks hesitantly.

"I don't know... If she is not a bad person, then I guess? But she still did a lot of bad things..." Frosta's voice fades, and Adora knows she is right.

"She did."

Silence falls between the two, not an uncomfortable one. They sit there, Adora with closed eyes and Frosta leaning up against her. She tries to banish Catra out of her mind for now. At least Frosta didn't react badly, well, it wasn't a good reaction either.

She takes a deep breath, today will be a damn long day.

She opens her eyes a little, looking down at Frosta who is already fast asleep. Adora chuckles a little, slowly moving around taking Frosta into her arms and bringing her to the guest room she is staying in.

Adora carefully puts Frosta down to the bed, the little princess snuggling close to the pillows and sleeping soundly. Adora just sees now how tired she is, they were on a field for a few days without a much-needed rest.

Frosta is just a child, turned 12 a few months ago. She is fighting in a war while leading a kingdom and worrying about hundreds if

not thousands of people's safety each day. Even if Frosta didn't grow up in the Horde, Adora feels some resemblance between them. They both had a stolen childhood.

She eventually stands and leaves the room, she finds Bow at the other end of the door.

"We are starting the meeting again." He says, shoulders tense and his brows furrowed in a constant scowl.

"Thank you, Bow. Frosta fell asleep though."

"That's okay, she must have been really tired..."

"Yeah." Adora agrees, the two friends walking next to each other. Adora glances at Bow, knowing full well why he is like this. Why both of them like this. Their friendship with Glimmer is straining every day. "She will come around, you know? I'm sure. Glimmer just wants to end the war."

"We all want, Adora." Bow sighs. "But the difference is that most of us don't want to use a weapon that could blow up the planet."

"Bow-"

"It's just... I don't understand why she trusts Shadow Weaver more than she does with us? With *me* ?" He groans, angry and confused. "Let's just get over with this stupid meeting."

Adora sighs, following Bow along the hallway.

It's not just their friendship, but the Rebellion is slowly falling apart too.

Catra spits out blood, sweat trickling down her temple. Her mane is messy and unkempt, tendrils falling into her vision, it now reaches to her shoulders. She smiles, bringing up her hands, claws unsheathed.

"Come on," She pants, ready to jump into action. Around them, the crowd cheers loudly, screaming Catra's name and her opponent's. "I was just warming up, big guy."

In front of her, a lizard guy stumbles to his feet. His chest was wounded by Catra's claws, bruises and scratches all over his body. Catra is definitely in better shape with the only bruise on her arm and a little scratch on her cheeks. She blinks away the sweat clinging to her lashes, and for a quick second, she sees Hordak instead of her opponent. Another blink and it's the lizard again.

Her opponent charges towards Catra, taking her by surprise. She stumbles to the side as she dodges, the lizard taking advantage of the situation and his fist collides with Catra's nose.

The catgirl falls with a pained growl, blood trickling down from her nose. Her vision blurring together, tears swelling up her eyes. With a huff she rolls away from another attack, clumsily getting on her feet. She hisses, leaping into an attack, her claws sinking into the lizard's face, slashing through it, Catra sends him back with a kick, he loses balance but quickly regains it.

Their own harsh painting and painful groans are drowned by the loud cheers of the crowd up around them. Catra feels and hears her own heartbeat in her throat. She can't help but grin, she feels *alive* . Her tail trashes around wildly, mirroring how Catra feels on the inside.

Cherishes the way adrenaline pumps her heart, the way she moves and fights.

The lizard charges again, the last attack. The guy is close to her, Catra spins away, bringing her leg up and flooring the guy against the ground. Catra raises her leg from his nape, stepping away.

Silence settles down to the whole pit, waiting for what happens next. A second, then two passes. The lizard is still on the ground.

Catra grins at that, pushes her hair back, the familiar satisfaction of a victory sparkes her soul. Cheers and swears mix up among the ones who watched the match, most of them shouting for Catra.

She leaves the pit, walking out of it. Her back set straight, chin held up high, power and pride radiating from her eyes. Someone offers her a towel, which she snatches away, drying up the sweat on her forehead and neck, also swiping away the blood from her nose and the corner of her mouth. They will heal or not, she doesn't really care.

Catra walks to her skiff, which still serves her right, and climbs into it.

A deep sigh leaves her mouth, her calm and collected face forms into a painful scowl as she lets her muscles relax a bit. She snags against the side of the skiff, catching her breath. Her lungs almost burn by how heavily she gasps for breath, it was more tiring than Catra had thought it would be.

"Fuck, oh... Fuck, shit... That was a close match." She huffs, a small smile hiding in the corner of her mouth. "But it felt so damn good..." Her eyes fall shut, breathing slowly getting back to normal.

Eventually, Catra staggers to her feet, limping to the level and turning the skiff on. She gets her cloak up from the floor, clasping it around her shoulder and drawing her hood back.

The Crimson Waste looks the same as it did almost a year ago.

Dry, filled with sand and rocks and dire heat.

Catra glides her skiff through the air, the cloak hiding her face again, also it helps for the heat to be a little more bearable.

Her whole body hurts and begging for a rest, and some food probably. She ate yesterday once. Recently, her nightmares got worse, haunting her dreams and night. She has to remind herself they are not real and get over them.

Her days are busy with either fighting in the pit or travelling around the waste, practising her map drawing skills. A good distraction she has to admit. They keep her busy during the day.

The pit, or as Catra likes to call the theatre for the damned, gives her reputation, respect, and fear as her name spreads in the Crimson Waste. People still remember her, how easily she has beaten Lashor and got the gang on her side.

Coming to the Crimson Waste, Catra had to face the rude awakening that she is at the bottom of the food chain again. She was a newcomer, someone who knew nothing about how to survive the waste. And even though Catra could fight her way through days, and basically hijacked a whole gang the last time she was here, everything is different now.

She sees the real side of the Crimson Waste.

If you don't want to get swallowed and chewed up, you will fight to survive. She picked up fighting to stay alive, the first night here she almost got robbed and killed, by some gruesome bandits. She successfully got away, but not without a cut on her thigh.

And this is what Catra is doing.

Surviving.

But it’s not enough. It wasn’t. Until she started to beat up people in the pit, climbing up in an invisible rank until she was considered among those who are the most dangerous in the Crimson Waste. People now hesitate to try anything with her, if they see Catra they scarry away. Some idiot still tries her, thinking how easily they can beat her up. Oh, how wrong they are.

In mere 3 months, she has become one of the most feared ones in this part of the waste by simply fighting ruthlessly. She had to get used to the bruises, the blood pooling in her mouth, the sore muscles. It also distracts her brain from spiralling down. Fighting became her outlet of anger that accumulated in her through the years.

Once or twice a week some idiot would say *'I can beat C., watch me.'* and eventually it's Catra who crushes them to the ground.

People here know her as C. There's no need for anyone to know her real name, or why she is here. She doesn't need friends, partners or anyone.

Catra is better alone.

The moment she has left the Horde, turned against Hordak and broke her badge, she doesn't belong to anyone, to anywhere but to herself.

She is all she got. And it's better to get used to it.

Since she came here, Catra has gained a good amount of lean muscle. It’s not like she never had muscle build during her cadet years or the time she spent fighting in the open, but here it’s a little different. Her hair got longer, wilder, unkempt and tangled. Catra doesn’t really care about it either. It adds to her character. News scars appeared on her body in addition to the already existing ones. It’s okay, she says. She doesn’t care.

Travelling with a skiff saves her from natural traps like quicksand or three-headed snakes. Although Catra got better at identifying three-headed hiding a rock, sometimes she still gets fooled.

Eventually, Catra stops by a small little desert town. She gathers her bag - still what she got from Mar - turning off the skiff and climbing off the skiff.

She found a small house in this town, called Polaris, more like she won it from someone. Catra could spend days away, but

ultimately, she would return. She doesn't know a lot of people here, they know that she is C. though, that doesn't really bother Catra at all.

Catra walks up by the stairs, reaching her small home, opening up the door and closing it behind herself with a deep sigh.

It's a very simple house, Catra doesn't do decorating, she has her bed, desk and a small wardrobe. A door leads to the bathroom and her tiny kitchen is opposite the bed. She has a big window although, so that's nice and a fluffed up carpet in the middle.

She goes through her routine, drawing herself a bath - although she still hates water, she hates being sweaty and bloody more -, then after she would wear only her underwear around her house while her clothes dry too. Nowadays she leaves her burn mark out in the open when she is alone, still, an ugly reminder as it stretches over her skin to her chest, a little bit to her back, neck. But if she is going to have to live with this, better get used to it. She patches herself up, grabbing some dry meat. Her tail wraps around her waist as she munches on the meat, laying down on the carpet she likes so much.

Catra just stares up at the ceiling, in moments like this she has way too much time to think about everything. And she absolutely hates it.

"Ugh."

She gets her bag, climbing up into the roof where there's a little canopy Catra has assembled a few weeks ago. She settles under it, getting her cartography tools out.

Time passes quickly when Catra doesn't mull on her inner turmoils and just throws herself into things she actually enjoys. She could spend hours doing cartography, and she does. The first two moons are already up when she hears a strange noise coming from the distance. Her ears move forward, she looks up from the half-done map, squinting at the distance.

The only thing she can see is a sand fog in the distance, but there's no sandstorm nearby. It's not because of that. Catra waits a little more, and then she sees them.

Horde robots.

Her eyes widen, quickly gathering her stuff and jumping through the window. She gets her clothes and cloak. The skiff is directly under her window, she jumps down without a second thought, turning the engine on and driving away.

She knows the Horde started to spread out their power in the Crimson Waste, the valley is still under their control. But Catra does absolutely nothing about this. This is not her problem. The Horde is not her problem.

She has all her belongings in the bag, so she leaves without the guilt of leaving anything behind.

Catra arrives at a rocky dune. She stops.

For the last time, she turns around looking down at the town bending under the Horde's control, their power. She shakes her head and drives away eventually.

This is *not* her problem.

Everything happened so quickly, their plan just fell apart in a few minutes.

Adora can't find Glimmer, lost sight of Bow and Scorpia. She hears Mermista shout something, and see a speck of ice in the far distance. She turns, only to be hit with a baton, she falls to the ground with a pained cry, dodging the next one with her sword.

Adora swiftly fights back, trying to find her friends in the midst of the chaos that's the battlefield.

"Adora!"

She looks to her right, seeing Micah running to her. "Your Majesty." She breathes out in relief. "Did you see the others? I lost them."

"I've only seen Perfuma, she is at the Heart-Blossom." He informs her, then with an insignia drawn in the air, a strong blow of air pushes back the soldier, picking up a tank too and throwing it to the side.

"The Heart Blossom?" Adora furrows her brows, kicking away a soldier. "Why... Oh no," She retreats, running from her previous position to where she knows the runestone is.

Adora dodges and bypasses the soldiers, Mermista sending waves of water in her direction when a laser beam almost hit her. She still can't see her, dust and smoke lingering around them. She smells burn wood, the prickling smell of metal all over, not like before where it was only thousands of flower's scent mixed into a comforting scent.

She can barely see at this point, squinting her eyes.

"Please, I need to find Perfuma." She grits her teeth, talking to moons know who at this point.

The earth shakes beneath her, Adora stumbles to her knees. Sick green vines run through the ground, pulsating with power, the grass around it drying up in a matter of seconds. Leaves from the trees fall to the ground, dried and brown.

Adora gasps, understanding what's happening. Just like before, the Horde tries to poison the land, poison the Heart-Blossom. Despite the uneasy ground she gets to her legs and runs, the bluestone on her sword glowing gently with blue light.

"Perfuma!" Adora shouts for her, knowing well she is already close to the pink tree.

"I'm here, Adora!"

Adora turns to her left and runs, the dust settling down far from the battle she can see clearly now. She jumps into action as a soldier tries to attack Perfuma, she dodges the attack and kicks them away, the soldier hitting their head. Adora looks back at Perfuma, the princess has her hand on the weakly glowing runestone, the tree losing its colour and leaves falling around them. The root shivering.

Perfuma looks exhausted, she breathes heavily as her body gently glows in green, trying to supply and keep the runestone alive. Those green vines scooting higher and closer to the tree.

"I can't... I don't know how long..." Perfuma whimpers, squeezing her eyes in pain.

Adora hurries to her, looking up at the tree then Perfuma. "Perfuma-"

"I will be fine, just... Find whatever is causing this. " The princess looks at Adora, desperate and afraid. "I don't know how long the Heart-Blossom would hold up... It's too weak and sick already."

Adora is clearly torn. "But you are hurting too, and what if they will attack you?"

"I can protect myself, please Adora..."

She nods, reluctantly leaving Perfuma behind as she follows the vines on the ground and trees. They grow thicker and thicker, joining into two or three big ones, coming from a giant machine planted into the ground, pumping poison to the land. They are far away from where the battle is happening, out of reach, the noises of fighting just a distant noise. Adora still can see the smokes from here, reaching up to the sky.

Before she could even get near it, electricity runs through her whole body as the ground lights up under her, she falls to her knees.

"Well, look who we have here."

Adora looks up, twitching from the electrical shook, Octavia standing in front of her. Adora huffs, pushing herself up and attacking Octavia, the Force Captain pushes a button and electricity forces Adora down to the ground again.

"Octavia-"

"You won't win here, Adora. Time to give up, maybe Lord Hordak would even show mercy to you." She says mockingly, kicking away the sword from Adora's hand. "Enjoy the show."

"Octavia!" Adora shouts after her, she tries to push her up, arms failing to do so.

Adora struggles, watching as the machine pumps more and more poison into the ground, the vines growing thicker as they run under the ground. She manages to look behind herself, seeing the tree already without its pink leaves, the branches ashy brown, as if the tree is drying up and it spreads to its core slowly. She looks back at the sword, a few feet away from her.

She didn't transform into She-ra ever since Beast Island, thinking she could hold up with the fights alone as Adora. Tears swell in her eyes, can't she help them without being She-ra? Why can't she be as strong as Adora? Why does she need She-ra to protect her friend?

"Damn it." Adora breathes heavily, concentrating on the sword, her eyes light up in blue. "Please... I need to help my friends." She whispers, looking at the swords. "I can't do this without She-ra."

The blue stone lights up too, magic moving the weapon into Adora's hand, she grasps it tightly. "For the honour of Grayskull!"

Her body is enveloped into a golden glow, transforming her into She-ra. Adora moves away from the ground quickly, destroying one of the laser beam machines aimed at her with one hit. She destroys the other few robots, trying to take her down. Octavia jumps in front of her, trying to shock her with the laser baton.

Adora dodges it, kicking Octavia away. Her attention is back on the machine pumping the poison. Adora readies herself to destroy it with one swing of the sword, unleashing its power, then the sword falls from her hand, electrical whips winding around her torso and arms, shocking her whole body, forcing her to her knees. Adora breathes hard, her vision blurring slightly.

An annoyed Octavia steps to her, teaser baton in her hands. "You won't ruin this for me. Now that Catra is gone, I have a chance of becoming a commander finally. I won't let you little kids mess up this for me." She spits angrily, shocking Adora again, her She-ra form disappearing then reappearing again.

"Not to compliment Catra... But you will never reach up to her levels." Adora breathes, sweat trickling down her forehead.

Octavia crouches down, tilting Adora's head with the baton. Before the Force Captain can say anything, Adora headbutts her as hard as she can, sending the woman to the ground. Adora ignores the pain in her own head, gathering all her powers to get out of the whips around herself, her body glows granting her more power.

Adora stumbles to her feet, leaving Octavia's unconscious body behind. She reaches for her sword, not wasting any more time, she slashes through the matching, its right side falling to the ground. Adora repeats it a few more times, until it falls to the ground, completely wrecked. The vines stopped but didn't disappear.

Then, she hears it.

An explosion. Adora turns around, smoke and fire coming from the Heart-Blossom tree. Her body freezes in one place as the tree is engulfed in fire, licking up to the sky.

" **NO** !"

She abandoned the wrecked machine in a heartbeat, running back to Perfuma. Tears pricking her eyes, falling down her cheeks. She has failed, Adora tells herself. She failed to protect Plumeria, Perfuma and the runestone.

"Perfuma!!" Adora screams, finding the princess still at the tree, the runestone glowing in weak green light. Mermista runs from the other direction, commanding the water from the near river, washing away the fire around the tree. Frosta fights against the remaining soldiers, with the others. Adora runs to Perfuma, who is kneeling in front of the runestone.

"Perfuma, Perfuma, are you okay?" She questions, voice shaking. "Perfuma?"

The princess breathes heavily, fingers almost digging into the runestone she pushes them to the stone so hard, the fingertips whitening. Her body shakes with every sharp intake of breath. Adora notices something dropping to the ground, with terrified eyes she realizes its blood.

"Perfuma!" Adora tries to hold onto her, but Perfuma stubbornly stays in one place.

"I can't... I can't stop... I need to... The Heart Blossom can't die." Perfuma whispers, voice weak, blood trickling down from her nose. "But I can't heal it... I can barely feel its power." She breaks, tears falling to the ground.

Adora looks back at the runestone and Perfuma's shaking hand. She reaches and envelops it with her own, trying to use She-ra's power to heal and give power to the runestone. Her body glows up with a golden glow, while Perfuma's with green. Their powers flowing into the runestone, it weakly pulsates with power.

Adora desperately tries to give it more energy, unleashing more of her own power in hopes that it would heal the runestone, the tree. And although it does make the Heart Blossom glow more steadily, it is far from its usual strong radiance.

Perfuma whimpers next to her, Adora feels the exact moment Perfuma's hand goes lax under hers and the princesses body falls back to the ground with a gentle thud, unconsciously. Adora lets go of the Heart Blossom, which stops glowing and leans to Perfuma.

She hesitantly touches Perfuma's shoulder, the princess's chest moving slowly, blood trickling down from her nose, cheeks wet with tears. "Perfuma? Perfuma! Perfuma, wake up!" Adora calls for her desperately, hands shaking, She-ra's power leaving her body, transforming her back to her usual form.

She hears footsteps but doesn't know who it is until she hears Mermista's voice. "What... What happened?"

"I don't know! She tried to heal the runestone and... And... Mermista I don't know!" She almost screams throat closing, breathing raggedly. "Please, please Perfuma wakes up," she whispers, trying to use She-ra's healing power on her, barely being able to tap into her own powers.

"Perfuma?"

Adora looks up seeing Scorpia stand a few steps away from them, eyes wide with shock, confusion and worry. She has a blooming bruise on her left cheek, a scratch along her shoulder. Adora looks away from her, not being able to look into Scorpia's eyes. Or anyones. She slowly stands up, stepping away from Perfuma. Her knees feeling so weak, Scorpia hurries to them, kneeling next to Perfuma.

From this point, everything blends into a blurred mess of noises and visuals around her. At some point she is sure someone asked her something, she doesn't know if she answered or not. She sits

still, without saying a word, looking down at the ground as Netossa bandages her arm, apparently, she has hurt herself during the battle.

"You did everything you could, Adora," Netossa tells her, squeezing her shoulder with a troubled look.

Adora says nothing.

Because she didn't do everything she could. She could have transformed to She-ra sooner, she could have known the Horde was planning an attack on Plumeria, she could have known the attack was just a distraction so they could roll out their machine and poison the runestone. She could have helped Perfuma.

But now, Plumeria is in shambles, most of the trees are burned down to the ground, the flowers dried up and burnt. The animals long gone, ran away sensing the danger that neared the kingdom. The people have retreated, or so Adora hopes. She didn't have time to look around for any civilian. And the Heart-Blossom. Adora can feel its power, but so weakly it's almost nonexistent. The tree that holds the runestone dried out without any leaves and, the branches and the roots damaged by the fire, the lively pink colour is gone, instead, it's ashy brown.

She stands up from the rock, walking to where the others are. Scorpia has Perfuma's body cradled to her chest, the blood cleaned up. She looks pale, sickly pale, the usual red of her cheeks long gone. Micah and Castaspella kneel by them, probably trying to heal her. Judging from their faces, it doesn't go well. She notices tears in Scorpia's eyes.

Adora retreats, feeling Glimmer's and Bow's eyes on her back, she ignores them.

Perfuma needs to go back to Bright Moon, in hopes the healers might have a bigger chance at healing her. Micah sends Adora back to the castle too, with a gentle smile telling Adora she needs to rest too. Frosta, Scorpia, Entrapta accompany them too, while

the others stay back, scanning through the territory for remaining Horde soldiers.

They go back with Darla, Entrapta navigating sensing that Adora shouldn't be let near the control panel.

They don't exchange words.

When they lend, Scorpia takes Perfuma to the infirmary, Frosta follows them, needing to tend her arm too. Entrapta says she needs to tinker with Darla a little.

"By the way Adora, we could get a tab from the Horde! Maybe I can tap into it and try to get some information?" Entrapta tries, and Adora knows she wants good, but right now Adora can't really be bothered by the Horde or anyone. "Do you want to join?"

"Thank you Entrapta, but... Not now, okay?"

Adora says, then leaves the ship, walking into her room. She closes the door behind herself.

Adora sheds her jacket, dropping it to the floor, she leans her sword next to her desk and lets her hair go down. She takes a deep breath, standing in the middle of her room. Tears trickling down, her hands shaking. And Adora breaks.

She cries until her throat feels scratchy and rough to even talk until her eyes hurt until her mind feels numb and empty. Until her body gives in from the exhaustion and lulls her into a dreamless sleep.

"Catra? Catra!"

Catra stands in the middle of the Whispering Woods, she hears her name but doesn't know who says it. Voices blur together, and suddenly, the ground shakes beneath her.

The catgirl steps back, a purple light shatters through the ground, followed by hundreds of others. The ground cracks, the same light seeping through the cracks. Catra turns and runs away, but it's like her feet are carrying her to nowhere as if she is still running in the same place.

"Catra!!"

The world under her feet disappears, she falls into the light her body burns and rips and no matter how desperately she screams and reaches up, she continues to fall.

Catra gasps for air, laying on the floor of the skiff. She stares up at the moonlit sky with wide eyes filled with pain and fear. She grasps her clothing at her chest, feeling her heart beating frantically. Her mind needs time to catch up on the fact that she is in the real world, safe in her skiff and not falling into her death at the portal.

She covers her eyes by draping her arm over it, taking deep breaths, until her heartbeat falls back to normal and her first instinct isn't to either run away or hurt herself.

After some time she sits up, reaching for the bag and her water, drinking greedily onto her dry throat.

"When will it end?" She murmurs to herself, with a deep sigh she stands up and drives away, the moons are still up in the sky.

By the time the last moon goes down too Catra has left the part of the waste she has known for 3 months. Right now, she is heading to the place she first visited when first came here, the inn.

Most times the ground and the sky blurs together in the distance, Catra has to squint hard to see if she is going in the right direction

or not. "Last time there was a big ske-" She passes by an enormous claw skeleton. "Yeah, I'm going the right way."

She spots the inn from afar, the place hidden in a giant ribcage of some kind of giant monster that has died centuries ago. It never occurred to her what kind of creatures used to live in Etheria or here in the Crimson Waste. Part of her is glad that they are dead.

The inn looks just the same as it did a year ago, she turns off the skiff and jumps out of it. She shakes her right leg a little, sometimes it still goes numb, but at least it doesn't hurt that much anymore. She tosses the hood off her head, shaking her head a little and her ears are twitching to be finally free.

What she doesn't expect is to be welcomed by a very familiar face as soon as she pulls the drape away from the door. Catra freezes the moment she sees Huntara laughing with the bartender carelessly. She quickly hurries out as if nothing has happened, pushing her back one of the bones.

"What does a Rebellion soldier do here?" she mumbles, furrowing her brows, thinking back to the time where Huntara helped the princesses get back that First One ship.

Her bang falls into her eyes as she moves her head quickly. "Are there other princesses too?"

Catra turns around, hopping up onto the bone and climbs back at the top with ease, her claws finding solidity in the hard structure. She crouches up at the top, her ears tentatively twitching and tail lashing around lazily as she listens.

"And how does driving out the Horde from the Valley of the Lost go?" someone asks, Catra assumes from Huntara.

The answer is an irritated groan. "They are coming back each time I try to drive them off, the next day another troop would come."

"I've heard that they have suffered a great blow, some big guy has betrayed them so they are low on almost everything." a grating voice speaks up, chuckling.

"Serves them right," Hunatara says. "I hope it means that we can at least drive them out for real."

Catra hums to herself, her chest swelling up with a little pride. She knew the consequences of her actions would be hard on the Horde, but it sounds thousands of times better than what she has dared to imagine. Does this mean the Horde is losing? Yeah, serves them right. After that, the topic drops and Catra climbs off the roof.

"Former boss?"

"Huh?" Catra looks up, eye to eye with a girl who has long black hair, slit up brownish green eyes and brown spotted scales. Catra narrows her eyes on the snake. "You look... Familiar..."

"Oh, you were our leader for a while. You know with that scorpio lady and all." The snake shrugs. "Fancy seeing you here." She smirks at Catra mischievously.

The cat girl's eye twitches at the mention of Scorpia. "What do you mean *were* ?"

"You know after you left Huntara actually took us back. Now she is our leader. Again."

"Wonderful." Catra huffs, about to turn around, but the snake girl jumps in front of her. "If you don't want me to separate your head from the rest of your body, you will get out of my way." She deadpans.

"Oh, feisty. I'm just curious why our *former* boss came back?" Then she gasps. "Are you back for us?!"

"No! I don't need anyone, now get out of my way." She hisses at the snake, pushing her away walking to her skiff again.

The snake turns, following Catra. "Ah, a party popper."

"What can't you understand from-"

"Look, I'm not searching for a bestie. I want you to fight against Huntara and be our leader again, easy as that." The snake presents her idea, flipping her long hair from her face.

"Did your peanut brain get boiled under the sun?"

"Haha, very funny." she hisses. "Huntara is obsessed with getting rid of the Horde, it's not about who we should rob or what oasis we should raid anymore. It's about oh we have to get rid of the Horde from the Valley of the Lost, blah-blah-blah." She finishes with a mocking grimace. "It was fun being in the gang while you were the boss, former boss."

Catra blinks at her, clearly unimpressed. "I have better things to do."

"Like what? *No* offence but you don't look like someone who actually has something better to do." She lifts an eyebrow at Catra, crossing her arms looking up and down at her. "Or do you?"

The catgirl growls at the snake, her pupils are nothing but a slit. "You want to fight?"

"Not exactly." She raises her arms defensively, with a challenging look. "I'm just pointing out what I've seen. I know who you are, mysterious C. Your name spread here too. We could help each other."

“What exactly could you help me with?”

The snake shrugs. “Whatever you need help. I know that you are not here in the waste for such a long time, I could help you get around.”

A few seconds pass before Catra would say a word, the snake looking at her with confidence and peace. It ticks Catra in every

right spot to just punch her, but at the same time, she knows that the snake is right. Most of the Crimson Waste is unexplored, unknown for her. Maybe she can keep the snake around, at least until she will be able to navigate around.

She sighs, turning towards her fully.

"What's your name?"

With a sharp smile, the snake bows dramatically. "Kobra, at your service, former boss"

Catra groans at the name. "C. Call me C. or just simply boss."

"Got it, boss." She winks at him, Catra's patience, once again, running low. "So it is a deal?"

"I don't like to admit, but you are right," She crosses her arms, tilting her head a little. "I will help you if you help me. Simple as that, but we are not going to be best friends or whatever rainbow vomited shit. Just business." She narrows her eyes at Kobra.

"Got it!" She chuckles cheerfully. "Luckily for you, I'm not the only one who is tired of Huntara's new goal obsession." She sneaks around Catra, barely even touching her at the back before Kobra is being pushed against the wall, Catra's hand around her neck. "Okay... No touch, I get it." She puts up two of her thumbs.

Catra lets her go without saying a word about it. "So, what do you want me to do? Go in and demand a fight?" She lifts an eyebrow, her hands on her hip.

"Something like that."

"You don't have an actual plan for this, do you?"

Kobra clears her throat. "For my defence, I had no idea you would be here, and I really didn't expect you to go with my offer." She points out, innocently batting her eyelashes. "You better go before she goes to the valley again, you wouldn't see her for a few days."

"You don't want to get the Horde out of the Waste?" Catra asks out of nowhere.

"It's not about whether I want the Horde here or not per se, but I'm not a good guy, I don't liberate places or work with the Rebellion. I just want to live my days here and rob people." Kobra shrugs simply. "Uhm, what?"

Catra grins at the snakes, with something mischievous sparkling in her mismatched eyes. "I think we are going to get along pretty well."

Kobra mirrors her smile. "Of course, *boss* ."

Catra steps into the inn, Kobra in her toes with a smug smile on her lips. They spot Huntara easily, and Catra, with her confident steps, walks to her table, slamming her hand onto the wooden surface. Huntara looks up from her beer, eyes widening, seemingly she has recognized Catra too.

"You took my gang. I want it back." Catra demands simply.

Huntara gets over her initial shock, then lets out a laugh, some people follow her example but as they meet with Catra's dark look they shut up instantly. Catra mocks Huntara, then flips the table, the other's beer landing on the ground.

"I will wipe up the floor with you, kitty-cat." Huntara challenges, reaching for her weapon.

Catra flashes her a fanged smile. "I would like to see that."

Huntara attacks and Catra jumps away from her with ease, landing on her feet. They dance around each other, tension sparking between the two as they lock eyes and move at the same time. Huntara's spear cuts into Catra's cloak, while the catgirl was able to dodge, her claws slashing into the other woman's arm. Huntara doesn't stumble back, to Catra's biggest surprise, rather she is being hauled by her and thrown to the side,

Catra's body flies through the material fastened around the inn, toring it.

Catra coughs up some sand, quickly rolling over as Huntara attacks her again.

"Why are you here?" Huntara demands with another attack. "You are with the Horde."

Catra blocks the attack, kneeling on the sand still her hands above her head, holding onto the spear. "That's not your business." She hisses, yanking onto the speak, Huntara's body moving with it, her chin colliding with Catra's knees.

Huntara recovers fast. "It is my business if you want my gang." Huntara's about to grasp Catra's cloak but the girl jumps away. Reaching for her whip, she slashes through the air, the whip winding around Huntara's arm.

Catra doesn't answer, instead yanks the whip in hopes of sending Huntara onto the ground, it doesn't work. She growls, abandoning the whip and instead jumps head onto Huntara. The claws on her toes sink into her sides, while her other pair torns into the skin from neck to chest. Huntara falls back the moment Catra headbutts her with all power she has.

Catra falls with her, but she is still on top, panting she waits. Huntara doesn't attack.

"You give up?" She questions, her arms drawn back ready to attack with her sharp claws.

"Why are you here?" Huntara insists, painting from the pain and the weariness of the fight. "Horde soldiers-... You defected." Huntara's eyes go wide at the realization and the violent snarl from Catra is a confirmation. She grabs onto the catgirl, throwing her away from her. "We are on the same side!"

Catra scoffs, standing up. "Oh, I doubt that. I have no intention of jumping to the princesses' every whistle like a *dog* ."

"You don't want the Horde-"

"I don't give a shit about the Horde!" Catra attacks her again. "And I don't give a shit about the Rebellion either!" Huntara blocks the attack with her spear, holding onto her wound, and it goes like this for a while. Catra attacks, Huntara just dodges.

Catra's patience runs out by the nth time, grabs onto her whip and with it, she yanks out the spear from Huntara's hands. "Fight with me." Catra snarls at her. "Fight!"

"I will give you the gang if you help me drive out the Horde from the Crimson Waste."

The offer shocks everyone, not just Catra, even Kobra has gasped at that, watching the fight from afar.

"I don't need an easy win. I told you, I don't give a shit about the Horde. Now *fight* !"

However, Huntara doesn't even move. "Even if you win, the Horde will be here. If you have defected you would want them out of this place. Or are you so keen to be hunted?" Huntara questions. "I know you, I remember you. You were someone important in the Horde, they won't let you go easily if they get to know you are here."

Catra narrows her eyes at Huntara, claws still drawn out. "Are you threatening me?"

"Am I?" the other challenges. "As I said, we are on the same side."

"Wrong, *you* are with the Rebellion. *I,* " Catra points at herself. "have nothing to do with the princesses. I'm out of this."

"You *can't* quit a war where *you* were the one calling the shots!" Huntara snaps at her. "You can't decide to just quit, life doesn't work like that! You owe the people who suffered because of you, because of *your* actions!"

Catra's defence mechanism switches on the moment Huntara opens her mouth, her tail lashes around wildly, and the frantic look she throws at Huntara promises no good. No matter how much she wants to either run away from these words or punch Huntara to the point she wouldn't say a word again, feet root into the ground.

Those words are glasses against her skin, the truth she has been trying to avoid, to run away. That she is blamed for the Horde's actions in the past 2 years, what meant victory to her was suffering to another one.

"What do you know?! Why do you care?!" Catra shouts at her, her voice cracking.

"Because it's my home, and people who you have sent, are destroying it! You have no right coming here and demanding anything from me or this place. Fight or no fight." Huntara walks towards Catra, the catgirl unable to move. "Do something good, use your knowledge about the Horde and help me." She puts her hand on Catra's shoulder.

Catra is way too stunned to even push her away, she just stares at the taller with wide eyes. She feels it again, the familiar pick of her heart and the need to just run away.

Instead, she puts on a show, a facade. Something she knows well. Forcing down her rising panic, she simply scoffs. "Don't be ridiculous. It's not my problem that you people are *weak."* She narrows her eyes on Huntara. "It's not my problem that you can't push them out. It's not my problem that *you* are weak. Get away from me." She pushes away Huntara's hand from her shoulder.

Huntara says nothing more, just flashes Catra disappointed look and walks away back to the inn.

Kobra steps next to Catra, the two of them standing in silence for a few seconds.

"What? Do you want to hold a preach too?" Catra looks at the snake with dull eyes.

"No. I was just going to ask where are we going now?"

The question takes Catra by surprise. "You want to... Why would you want to come with me anywhere? The deal is off, I'm not the leader. It's still Huntara."

Kobra shrugs. "You seem interesting. And as I said, you need someone out here or else you would die."

"What makes you think it's not my goal?" She throws Kobra a dark look.

"Because you wouldn't go into my deal in the first place." Kobra crosses her arms. "Or if you want to die, then you can just go... I won't stop you."

Catra stays silent for a few seconds, Kobra patiently waiting for the answer.

"No, I don't want to die..."

"Then come boss, the Waste has plenty of space for all of us."

Catra watches as Kobra is walking away from her, probably to her skiff so they could set off. Her eyes wander back to where the inn is, and Huntara's words ring in her ears. Her fingers curl into a fist, the claws poking her skin.

Because of you. It's because of you.

Adora is woken up by a gentle shake on her shoulder, she opens her eyes finding Bow sitting on her bed with a small smile. She

blinks away the numbness, feeling a little disoriented. Then, everything comes into her mind.

"You missed breakfast."

"Sorry." She mumbles, sitting up slowly.

"It's okay. I did too... We could eat together?" He asks, holding up the tray in his hand, already filled with food they like. "I figured you deserve a break."

Adora takes one croissant filled with chocolate pudding. "The last thing I deserve now is a break." She murmurs, biting into the pastry.

"I won't let you blame yourself, Adora, it is just as everyone else's fault. We don't... We don't work well together lately, everyone is just angry and the only thing we do is constantly arguing." He grimaces, spreading jam on his bagel. "What happened wasn't your fault Adora."

"But I'm She-ra. I'm supposed to protect the people, I'm supposed to win over the Horde, and... I don't even know what to do Bow." She looks down at her lap. "I just want everyone to be safe."

They sit in silence for a little while, just eating and dwelling on their own thoughts. Adora is half thankful for Bow for this. If he wouldn't come she would probably not eat anything all day and spend her hours' training.

"How... Is Perfuma?"

"The healers said she is okay, physically. But they said her connection with the Heart-Blossom almost got severed, she exhausted herself too much. They.. Don't know when she will wake up." Bow tells her, spinning the butter knife on his fingers with furrowed brows. "Perfuma chose to do this Adora, don't even try to blame yourself. Got it?"

Adora looks at Bow, and for a second she thinks he wouldn't understand. But Bow was fighting against the Horde just as Adora, none of them could predict what could happen.

"I will try." She sighs, taking another bite. "What about Frosta? Or the others?"

Bow shakes his head. "Everyone is okay, minor scratches and bruises. Nothing new. Half of them are in Plumeria, trying to save what is savable. But, enough of this. Micah has said you are not allowed near your sword and you can only relax today, so, what do you want to do?"

"I think our last trip to Mystacor proved that I can't relax?" Adora arches an eyebrow, finishing up her croissant.

"Yeah, but now we don't have a crazy sorceress in her toe trying to take her back to the Horde." Adora winces at the memories. "Sorry. If it makes you feel better Micah forbid Shadow Weaver from leaving the East Wing."

That actually makes Adora a little relieved.

They finish off their breakfast, Bow taking the tray back to the kitchen while Adora refreshes herself and dresses up. They meet down at the west garden with the fountain. Adora finds Frosta there too, playing with Netossa and Spinerella.

"Good morning Adora." Spinerella welcomes her with a warm smile. "Do you want to join?"

"Yeah! So I can mop the floor with you all!" Frosta laughs, her fists covered in ice.

"No ice fists, Frosta," Netossa tells her with a chuckle.

The little princess huffs and the ice disappears. "I can still take you all down, I'm the master of this game." She says proudly, crossing her arms.

Adora smiles a little bit, walking closer. "What game is it?"

"It's called ice-ball. Netossa makes a net between the two teams, and whoever manages to hit the ice ball on the other side without the other's reaching for it, gets the point. I lead with 10." Frosta grins, explaining it to Adora. "Wanna try it?"

"For now I will just watch it, okay?" She asks instead, Frosta shrugs, while the married couple looks at each other worried. If Adora noticed, she doesn't say a thing.

They start to play again, while Adora cross sits on the stone bench, watching them with a small amused smile. Bow soon joins too, sitting down next to Adora.

"Sure you don't want to play?'

"Yeah, it's just nice... Sitting here, you know? Did you talk with Glimmer?" Adora asks out of nowhere, catching Bow off guard.

"Why are we suddenly talking about Glimmer?" He asks nervously.

"Because you two seem to be in a worse situation than me and Glimmer, and it says something. Plus, it's a good distraction." She chuckles.

"I'm happy that my pain has a purpose at least." He sighs, leaning back on his hands. "I... Tried to talk with her. She is still set on this whole Heart of Etheria thing. She thinks after yesterday... Well, uh... She said it would be better to use it before the Horde would attack another kingdom." Bow tells her, annoyance hidden in his voice. "I just... I understand Glimmer, I want to defeat the Horde too, but not by endangering my home."

"Yeah, I understand." Adora hums. "I don't know what to do Bow, and even if we would want to use it, we have no idea who that mysterious princess is. It's already a lost cause." She tries to convince herself. "Glimmer should admit it, and instead help us come up with something."

"Like in the old times."

"You say it like we are so old or something." Adora nudges Bow with a teasing smile.

"Might as well feel like 60 years old sometimes!" Bow sighs exaggerate. "I swear sometimes I feel my hip just cracking."

"I told you not to try lifting those crates."

"It's not my fault you are so strong."

"Oh, so you admit that I'm stronger than you!"

"I never said you aren't. I mean, come on, you can beat Sea Hawk in hand wrestling, I don't doubt your strength."

Adora chuckles at that, leaning back on her hands too. "Years of climbing up to the top of the Forge pays off."

"Huh?" Bow turns to her curiously. "Did they make you climb a forge in the Horde?!" He freaks out, voice cracking.

"No!" Adora looks at him confused. "That's just how the place was called, honestly I don't know why it had nothing to do with a forge, to be honest." She furrows her brows.

"Why did you even climb that?"

Adora is about to answer, then closes her mouth. Remembering back to the days she has spent on the rooftop with Catra, just dreaming about their future, and what they would do.

"It was our spot. With Catra." Adora speaks up again, voice much smaller. "We used to go up there when we wanted to hide, we could spend hours up there just... Talking about everything and nothing. We promised that we will always be together." Adora looks up at the sky, squinting her eyes a bit.

Bow listens to Adora, it is rare for the girl to talk about the Horde, let alone Catra. It always brought pain to her to remember those memories and felt like no one really was interested in it. They all saw Catra as a threat, the evil horde soldier. On the other hand, Adora saw so many other sides of Catra, she has seen her soft, sweet, kind, terrified, vulnerable side too.

They saw Catra's *mask* shown to the world. Adora had seen *Catra*.

"I miss her Bow." words tumble out of her mouth without thinking, the confession feeling a little liberating somehow.

Bow reaches out and takes Adora's hand into his. "We will find her, Adora."

"But could you trust her? Or anyone in the Rebellion? I mean... If Shadow Weaver is right, it is her plan what we are fighting against."

"Catra hurt us and tried to kill us many times. That's true. But if you believe that she can change and even help us, then I have too."

"Why?" Adora's surprise is genuine.

Bow takes his time before answering.

"I don't know much about Catra, what I know comes from the battlefield. I can't say that I know her, or what kind of person she is. But if you still want to save her even after everything, then I have to believe that you have a good reason for that. I don't say that I would feel instantly safe around her, or would trust in her in a heartbeat, but I'm willing to give her a chance." Bow finishes looking at Adora with a knowing look and a gentle smile.

Adora blinks at him, confused at best. "W-why are you... Looking at me like this?" She asks, suddenly feeling nervous.

"What would you do if you would find Catra?"

"Huh?"

"What would you do?"

"Well... I guess I would hug her? I don't know Bow, she would probably try to scratch my eyes or something, but it's okay. One time she tried to do the same, but in the end, we made up, she was just upset because I was playing with Lonnie. You know Catra was always like that, one time she *actually* scratched Octavia's eyes, she was only six! She didn't let Octavia live it down ever since. And then when I first found her, she was like a little wild ki-" She stops, blinking a few times catching herself in the rambling. "Sorry, got a little carried away." She clears her throat. "So uhm. Anyways, I would... I would probably hug her, and... Tell her that I missed her..."

Bow still looks at her with that stupid smile, like she knows something that Adora doesn't, and the girl just really can't understand what it is all about.

"Uhm... Bow? Why...Did I say something?"

"I mean I didn't expect her actually scratching out someone's eyes, so that's good to know. I will keep that in mind." He nods to himself, with a mildly terrifying look. "Did you know your eyes light up whenever you talk about Catra?" He asks, leaning a little closer.

"No, it doesn't? And anyway, why would it matter?" She arches an eyebrow. "Catra was my best friend... It's normal. Right?"

Bow shrugs. "Was she just your best friend?"

"I'm really lost here Bow."

"Okay, I will ask it instead. Do you love Catra? Or feel more for her?"

"Of course I love Catra." She says like it should be so obvious, Bow's eyes light up. "She was my best friend?" The light

disappears.

"No Adora." He sighs, clearly trying to remain cool while Adora is just lost. "Do you love Catra as Netossa love Spinerella? Or my dad love each other? Like a couple?"

"A couple?" Adora tilts her head, furrowing her brows.

"Did you ever want to kiss Catra?"

At that, Adora flushes a little. "I mean.. I... Yeah, I did... But that was like just a few times, whenever she would like to start to purr and snuggle close to me, or when she would laugh or have this mischievous sparkle in her eyes." Adora rambles again, pointing and gesticulating while her cheeks redden. "Or like this one time when she aced all her tests and I was really really proud of her. But that's like... Normal... Isn't it?"

"I mean, do you want to kiss me? Or Glimmer? Or Scorpia?"

"No, not really." She answers flatly. "I mean.. Sorry, but... You know... Yeah..." She sighs, slumping forward.

"Wait, how do you even know what kissing is? You didn't even know what an aunt was." Bow is genuinely confused.

"Eh, one time Shadow Weaver caught two cadets together, they were a few years older than us, and she got really angry at them. You don't really have relationships in the Horde. I knew about them, but I thought it was a normal thing to do? But Shadow Weaver made it very clear that we cannot have any romantic relationship. Sooo... Yeah, that's how I got to know about what's a kiss." Adora tells him with a grimace.

At the little story, Bow mouth hangs downwards and eyebrows pinched together. "I'm sorry Adora."

"It's okay... It's not like I wanted a relationship with anyone." She shrugs.

"Not even with Catra?" He tries again.

"I mean... We didn't really know what a relationship is... Or love. We didn't have couples, if someone had a relationship and they were caught they separated them immediately. But... Me wanting to kiss Catra relates to that because?" She looks at him curiously.

"I will be blunt, Adora. Do you want to have a relationship with Catra? Like a couple, like Netossa and Spinerella?"

Adora turns to the couple, who are enjoying the game with Frosta. They score a point, Netossa hugs Spinerella with a big ring, who then leans in and kisses her wife. Adora, for a split second, imagines herself and Catra in that situation. Her heart skips a beat, and her cheeks heat up.

The thought is pleasant. Nice. She wishes it could be them.

She wishes she could hold Catra like how Netossa holds Spinerella, how they smile at each other tender, and full of love. Catra was always gentle with her, well, not always, there were times when Catra was just angry at everyone, or times when they couldn't be gentle with each other or else Shadow Weaver would have punished them, mainly Catra.

"I... I think yes." She whispers, looking back down her lap. "It... Would be nice, I guess..."

Bow smiles at her. "You got your answer."

"What?"

"I would welcome Catra in the Rebellion because you love her Adora. And I think you always did, you just didn't know how to call it or express it."

Love.

She *loves* Catra. That's true. She always did.

She loved her more than anyone, more than anything. Leaving Catra behind was the hardest decision of her life, fighting against Catra was a turmoil each time, trying not to hurt her, but not losing against her at the same time. And now, with Catra missing, Adora wasn't able to shake off the constant worry towards her. Adora just wants to go out there and find her, bring her to Bright Moon and maybe wish that everything was like before.

Expect now they wouldn't have to hide when they hug or be afraid that someone would catch them sleeping in one bed, or be soft around each other. They could be free from that fear.

She could love Catra. Freely.

"I think... I think I love Catra, Bow." Adora looks at her friend with wide eyes and flushed cheeks, her heart beating fast, but not from fear. The warmth spreading in her chest. "I love Catra."

"Oh my moons, I'm in love with Catra." Adora's face pales down, holding onto Bow's shoulder with a deathly grip. "I was in over ith my enemy the whole time?!" She freaks out.

"I'm pretty sure she was your crush first before she became your enemy." Box squeaks, trying to get Adora to let gooff his shoulders.

"Crush? I didn't crush Catra??"

"No, a crush is like someone who you have feelings for." He explains, letting out a relieved sigh at Adora letting him go.

"Why would you call it a crush? That's stupid." She arches an eyebrow.

"What's up with you two?" Frosta asks out of a sudden, scarring the other two. They fall off the bench screaming.

"H-How long... How long were you there Frosta?" Adora asks nervously, leaning across the bench from the ground.

Frosta shrugs. "You two are weird." She simply says, walking away with the ice ball in her hands.

"Hey! We are not!"

Adora can vaguely hear FRosta asking from Netossa what's a crush. The woman looks at them with a knowing smug smile. With a whimper, she sinks back to the ground wishing for the earth to swallow her.

"At least we know your feelings." Bow grins at her, sprawled out on the grass.

"Bow!"

Catra sits on the floor, her legs crossed and tail resting on her lap as she takes in the vast land stretching in front of her to the horizon. Kobra is driving the skiff now, they have left the inn behind them a long time ago. There are no towns or villages, barely even a soul out there. Although Catra might have seen someone in the distance, that could be because the heat is playing a trick on her.

Huntara's words still didn't let go of her mind.

She suddenly thinks back to the day they have attacked and successfully taken Salineas. It wouldn't have happened without Catra's plan, or the rest of the operation she has left behind. Her perfectly crafted plan on how to take every kingdom. Whether she has left the Horde or not, that plan is at work. It will destroy the rest of the kingdoms.

Or the time she opened the portal - she was ready to toss the whole world into destruction.

At the memory she curls up to herself, resting her hand on her updrawn knees. A simple sorry wouldn't be enough if it wasn't for Adora...

"How big is the Crimson Waste anyways?" She asks suddenly, shutting her memories out.

Kobra hums tilting her head. "No one really knows. Some parts haven't been discovered or we just don't know if it was. There's no communication between places, everyone is on their own."

"So there are other places like the valley or Polaris?"

"Yeah, there is one south of here, it's smaller though and not as busy. And another at the west. Although there could be more." Kobra shrugs. "Why, you want to see them?"

Catra looks up at her. "I don't plan to sleep in the desert, so yeah, I want to go to the closest."

"Got you, boss."

They have travelled to the south, Kobra navigating them with ease. Catra's senses, however, are still high, expecting a trap, or an attack from every corner, mostly from Kobra. The snake does notice Catra's piercing eyes on her, and the catgirl doesn't even try to hide her stare.

"Did anyone tell you, you have trust issues?" Kobra glances down at her. "I don't plan to sneak attack you, relax."

"Yeah, that's hard to believe." Catra scoffs, looking at the scene of the waste again instead.

They don't exchange another word again until they arrive at their destination. Catra perks up from the floor, there's a canyon in front of them, a small city etched into the rocks walls, descending from the top to the bottom, there are even little alleys leading into the rocky wall. Shadow falls onto them as there are materials fastened around the air so the light wouldn't scorch them.

As they near the city, Catra could hear how noisy it is, her tail wraps around her waist instinctively. There are all kinds of creatures everywhere bustling through the streets, bidding and betting, a fight has just broken out in an inn tucked away.

"What is this place?"

"A trade city. Welcome to Southern Star." Kobra tells her, looking at the catgirl.

Catra doesn't answer. She was always amazed by how people can survive in places like this. She didn't pay much attention when they were in the Valley of the Lost, too occupied with the ship they have found, wanting to get it out of the waste as soon as possible.

But since she has lived here for 3 months, she has learnt so much about life here, but most importantly how to survive.

They glide into the canyon, a shadow falling over them too Catra finally stops squinting. People don't mind them, some throw them a dirty look because of the skiff but Catra simply hisses at them in response. She sees children running around with makeshift toys in their hand, laughing with each other carelessly.

The kids in Salineas had toys like them too. Catra remembers suddenly, her mind playing a cruel joke on her. She grips onto the side of the skiff, squeezing her eyes trying to will the memories away.

Because of you. Your fault.

She gasps as a hand touches her shoulder, she hisses more of panic than aggression, slapping away the hand. Kobra stares at her curiously. Catra says nothing, but takes a deep breath and pushes her hair down, ear flattening. She takes the hood and hides her face from the city.

"Let's go. We need food, and somewhere to sleep."

Catra jumps out of the skiff, landing on her feet easily. "Bring the bag too."

She walks away, blending into the crowd. Her head is filled with images from Salineas and other Rebellion towns where she has witnessed their fall. A little doll laying on the ground, abandoned. The houses burned down or destroyed. Families, lives ruined.

Her arms close around herself under the cloak, hugging herself yet again. Her claws scratch the skin.

You can't just quit a war where you were the one calling the shots!

Catra stops, staring at the ground. "Was I really that naive?" a whisper, nothing more. The first crack on her wall.

She lets go of her arm, looking down at her hands. She blinks and sees them covered with blood.

She stares at her hands, unable to tear her eyes away from the red covering her hand. The noise around her fades until it just inaudible whispers nothing more, then a child's laugh rings in her ears. Small hands reach out for her hands, clasping it into their smearing the blood around. Catra looks ahead of herself, seeing the 10 years old Adora looking back at her, the little girl looks up at her, opening her mouth.

Your fault.

Catra tears her hands away, small Adora keeps staring at her until someone knocks shoulders with the catgirl, both Adora and the blood on her hand disappearing.

"It's not real," Catra tells herself, pushing her hair down again with a deep sigh closing her eyes. She tries to ground herself to reality, but it's like she is floating around her brain clogged with fog.

She shakes her head and continues to walk around. Kobra will eventually catch up with her. A family walks by her, a mother holding onto her son smiling about something he must have said.

Then, something catches her attention. Something that absolutely shouldn't be here. Catra looks at her left, an alley leading into the rock wall, but what disturbs her is what's above the opening. An enormous Horde flag fluttering slightly in the wind.

We don't have all day! Make yourself useful, we have a whole kingdom to take!

She hears her own voice, another memory flashes behind her eyes, as she rolls down the Horde flag from the Salineas Gate. At that moment she felt nothing but pride, her plan worked and they have taken Salineas. But now? It's nothing but bitterness and shame biting into her soul like a wild animal.

Catra takes a tentative step towards the alley, her hand shaking again.

A sudden strong wind swipes across the canyon, pushing Catra's hood down and her hair catches into the wind, flaunting her cloak, revealing her back where the Horde symbol used to be.

Flashbacks and reality mix together, slowly blurring into a mess of Catra's shout, people screaming and the hollow in her soul growing. She doesn't even notice when she starts to heave harshly, or how fast her heartbeats, pumping adrenaline into her body, the world around her ceases to move.

You owe the people who suffered because of you, because of your actions

And Catra snaps.

She jumps, climbing up the rocky wall with ease, reaching up to the flag and with a sharp move she tears it down, jumping back to the ground, landing on her legs. The flag falling behind her and rouses up the dust, she can't make out what the soldier running

towards her says, the only thing she knows is that she has to get rid of them. Erase them, so she doesn't have to see them again, remember again.

She grabs the soldier by their neck driving their face into the wall. Another one comes with a teaser pointed at Catra. The catgirl jumps away from the attack, kicking the soldier on their side, taking the teaser away using it against them. The soldier falls to the ground with a pained groan.

Catra's body moves on autopilot, she doesn't need to think about how to attack or how to dodge, it all happens naturally. Her body trained to fight, the only thing she knows oh so well. She is about to slash through another armour of a soldier when they strike down, Catra unable to jump away tries to lean away the weapon catching on her forehead, barely missing her eyes, finishing at her temple.

She growls at the soldiers, catching onto one of the neck's with her whip, yanking them against the wall. She has to close her right eye, due to the blood dripping down from her newfound wound.

"Boss!!"

Kobra shouts for her, the skiff breaking through a few outdoor stores, grabbing onto Catra's arm, yanking the girl into the skiff, driving away from the soldier with full speed.

"What are you doing?! I didn't ask for your help!!" She screams at Kobra, looking frantic with her dishevelled look and bloody face. "Go back!"

"Are you a fucking idiot?!" Kobra shouts back, navigating through the busy street, Kobra looks back for a brief movement seeing the Horde soldiers are after them on their machines. "You could get killed!"

"Why do you care?! I should have died years ago!"

For a second the only sound that rings around them is the sound of Kobra's palm colliding with Catra's cheeks.

Catra recovers from her shock pretty quickly, ready to jump onto Kobra "You-"

"Can you *please* stop?! We need to get out of the city or else both of us will be dead, and unlike you, I want to live!"

They don't have time to continue their talk like a pair of Horde soldiers gilded next to them, ready to jump onto the skiff, but Catra moves, her whip slashing in the air knocking down the soldiers, their skiff colliding with a wall, bringing explosion with itself.

Catra looks back, seeing another two skiffs on their toe. She hisses in annoyance, quickly wiping away the blood around her eyes, only smearing it. She jumps up at the highest point of the skiff, crouching down for better balance.

"Keep the skiff in one line!"

"If you fall it's not my fault," Kobra mumbles angrily, balancing out the skiff as much as she can.

Catra jumps to the other skiff, closer to them. Grabbing her whip she disarms one of the soldiers, kicking them off the skiff. She snarls at the other one, punching them in the face, pushing them down too. Grabbing onto the lever, yanking it towards the direction of another skiff, driving onto them. Before it would collide, she quickly hurries back to her skiff, catching onto the back, climbing up with a huff.

All they can hear is the explosion. None of them looks back.

"You are insane." Kobra breathes as Catra lands next to her, heavily panting.

"Ah... They tend to say it about me." She says with difficulty, the rush leaving her body and the pain from the cut finally catches

onto her. She grunts in pain, trying to wipe away the blood again.

"Leave it alone, you will claw it open more!" Kobra snaps at her, Catra doing it more just so.

They eventually leave the city, not stopping until they are away from the city. Kobra drives them to a small oasis in the middle of the desert, she turns off the skiff, turning to Catra.

The catgirl gasps for air still, her palm over her wound a permanent snarl on her face from the pain. Kobra shuffles around the skiff until she gets the first aid box, looking at Catra.

"I can do it myself." She says simply, standing up the world spiralling around her.

"Oh sure, you look like you can totally manage yourself." Kobra lifts an eyebrow. "Come, we have to wash your wounds."

Kobra tries to help Catra get off the skiff, but the other is exceptionally stubborn and jumps off the skiff even though she is still not too sure about her legs. Regardless of that, she walks to the water, she focuses every cell in her body not to just fall, her legs shaking. Her forehead throbs with pain, causing a building headache.

The snake follows her to, putting down the box and Catra clumsily opens it, her right eye still closed. She takes a linen piece and wets it in the water, swiping around her face, washing the linen in between swipes as it gets too dirty. They don't say a word, Kobra doesn't prod about Catra's meltdown she just witnessed or the fact that the catgirl would have no problem with dying. Moreover, she would gladly throw herself into a situation that could endanger her life.

Catra looks into the water, checking her face, now both of her eyes open.

"Is it deep?" She eventually asks, almost a whisper looking at Kobra.

The snake scoots a little closer, squinting, not touching Catra. "Nah, it's okay. There won't be a scar or just really faint one." She tells her, scooting then back sensing that Catra needs her space. "It would look badass though."

Catra disinfects her wounds and patches them up looking at the water as a mirror, also asking Kobra if it's okay or not. The snake answering with a nod or a head shake.

After she finishes they just sit there in silence. Catra stares at the water, while Kobra is looking at her.

"Thank you. For coming for me." Catra breaks the stillness. "They have probably reported it to Hordak. I should be going."

"I might have destroyed their mechanics after I've heard the chaos you have caused." Kobra chuckles mischievously. "Your welcome, boss."

"How did..." Catra narrows her eyes, but the movement sparks a new wave of pain flooding her forehead. She groans, closing her eyes.

"I guess you have nothing that can dull the pain."

"A punch to the head would help so I could pass out." Catra grumbles, pushing her bangs back.

They sit around here until the moons are starting to reappear, but it's not fully night yet too. Kobra doesn't question Catra about anything, which Catra is grateful to some extent. She isn't sure if she could explain what has happened.

These hallucinations are getting worse and worse each day, it doesn't help that Catra barely can sleep, tiring down her body and brain completely.

Catra sighs, standing up slowly, her tail lashing our tiredly, wrapping around her thighs. "Let's go back to the inn."

Her words surprise Kobra, who was laying in the sand, enjoying its warmth. "What?"

"I..." She takes a deep breath pushing her hair down again. "Huntara is right. I could help, I came here to get away from the Horde and if I do stay I have no intention of stumbling into them."

Kobra gets up from the sand. "Got you, boss. I'm also kinda hungry and you have absolutely no food. The inn has some pretty good dishes, I'm telling you. Like roasted gecko, it's absolutely delicious." Kobra rambles as she walks to the skiff, bringing the first aid box with herself.

Catra looks up at the night sky, feeling once again, empty like the night without the stars. Train of thoughts stops. Stars? She has never seen them. Then why does she know how the sky would look like with millions of stars twinkling up in the night sky.

“Are you coming, boss?!”

“My head hurts, don’t shout.”

“I’m not even that loud.”

“Kobra, shut up.”

Catra finds herself face to face with Huntara again, to her surprise she has fallen asleep as they travelled here, awakened by Kobra's voice. There is this itching dull pain in her head, that makes her sick but she keeps her cool. Or at least tries.

"What... Happened with you?"Huntara questions looking at the bandages forehead and temple.

"Nothing."

Kobra chuckles from behind her boss. "She has wrecked the Horde army in Southern Star."

Catra throws her a look full of daggers. "As I said, nothing." She concludes. "But.. I've thought about what you've said. I will help you, but I have one condition. You cannot tell it to the Rebellion. If you do, I will gouge your eyes in your sleep and make you eat it."

"Ohhh, charming," Kobra comments inching away from Catra.

"If that's your only condition, I will take it." That visibly surprises Catra. "I help the Rebellion yes, but... Even if you are a Horde defect, you have more knowledge about them, I need your help. Don't get me wrong, I'm not better than you." She scoffs with an eye roll.

"Wait... Are you..."

"I was a Horde soldier once, yes. A Force Captain actually, I was sent here to get the waste on our side. It's richer and populated than it's rumoured. I spread the rumour that it's lifeless and dangerous, so people wouldn't come here. And then I disappeared." Huntara sums it up with ease. "They assumed I was dead. What... What about you? Why did you leave?"

Catra's throat closes at the question. Why did she leave? She had everything that she has worked for, yet, she felt miserable still.

"I was Hordak's second command. I... Left for some reasons."

"Second in command?" Huntara's eyes widen. "Wait... How old are you? You look so young, how long have you been seeing active duty?"

"Two years. And I have no idea how old I am." She shrugs. "You know, the Horde is not so fixated on caring about their orphan's."

Huntara looks very much impressed and Catra suddenly doesn't know what to do with it. "You must be a genius to be a second in command under two years..."

"I guess...But after Horde is out of the Waste, you will fight with me again. Fair and square. I'm not a fan of cheap flights." She points at Huntara, changing the topics quickly.

If Huntara noticed it, she said nothing. "Deal."

"If you destroy the robots first, you will easily gain the upper hands. They rely on their robots, especially in a place that's not their field. I suppose they have been here in the Waste for a long time, but most of them don't have the brain to actually map out the territory in case they will be attacked." Catra tells them over a makeshift map of the Valley of the Lost.

They are still in the inn, two days passed since their pact. Catra's forehead is healing, but it still needs to be bandaged and Huntara gave her some kind of root that actually ceases the pain but also knocks her out, so the past two days were actually very relaxing.

At the table, by a map, she feels in her element again. Strategy, planning. Her blood courses with excitement.

"While destroying the robots are important, we also have to think about their communication centre. We can't let them ask for a backup, or else no matter how well our plan is we will be cornered. In case they would want to escape, the main exits from the valley must be closed and monitored by us." She finishes off, crossing her arms in front of her chest. Her tail sways around gently.

"Therefore we need five groups." She counts back on her fingers. "One that will deal with the robots, another one for the communication centre, another for cutting the escaping route, who deals with the soldiers and one will be helping us from the heights. I know you use tranquillizer shots, and it will come in handy."

She looks up to the people around here, Huntara looking impressed and awe, even Kobra is blinking at her with wide eyes.

"Did you come up with this in two days?" Huntara asks.

"Actually, I only needed an hour." Catra points out, taking a sip from her beer that she got fond of in the past two days. Who knew it could be this delicious? "I know everything about how the Horde operates, it wasn't that hard." She shrugs without care.

"Amazing..." Huntara mumbles and Catra tries to hide her blush as her approving words are sweeping warm into her soul.

It's nice actually. She rarely got commendatory words even from Hordak, let alone Shadow Weaver. At the Horde, most people were betting her to fail, but she rose above everyone else who thought she wouldn't make it.

Catra clears her throat, willing her thoughts away. "We need to decide on the groups."

Huntara nods. "Of course, of course. I could go against the soldiers." She suggests.

"No, your strength will be needed for the robots. You could easily take them, just stay away from their laser beams and you will be okay. Kobra you will lead the communication centre group." Catra looks at the snake, who smiles excitedly.

"Yes, boss."

"I will go with the ones whose main focus will be the soldiers. Their armour is quite heavy, which makes them slower therefore they are not the best with hand to hand combat or a fight where their opponent is fast. You take their teasers away and they are helpless." She sighs. "We should have invested in more weapons, but whatever." She mumbles it to herself, pushing her bangs away.

"What about the ones who need to protect the retreats?" Huntara questions looking at Catra.

Catra hums, thinking a little bit. "I actually doubt that a lot of them would take the opportunity to escape, but if it happens we need people who can move fast and are good with restricting them. Not with ropes, they can easily cut them off."

"What about chains?" Kobra asks, pointing at some chains hanging off the bones from the ceiling. "They can't cut them."

"Excellent." Catra smirks. "And for the ones who are good with the tranquillizer shots, how many you can make until tonight?"

"We need a special root for that, luckily Sam and Dam collected a load of a few days ago, around 100-150 shots would be my tip." A gecko hybrid tells her, his voice is scruffy and a little bit nasal, but Catra can understand what he says. "How could we possibly get through their armour? We tried before."

"What point did you aim for?"

The man is taken back by the question, thinking about it. "Well, mostly the neck area. That's where it's more effective."

"Then change it to their side or calves. The armour is the weakest there, not so well guarded. If it takes too long for the venom to work, you can make stronger doses."

"Of course, boss." He nods.

"Okay, I think we have covered everything." Catra sighs. "First we take the robots, and then cut their communication. Second, once the robots are out of the sigh, we take the soldiers. It won't be easy, there are loads of soldiers stationing in the valley, but if we stick with the plan, it could work." She nods to herself, sitting down to the chair. "Question?"

"What will we do with the soldiers?" Kobra skips next to her, sitting down on the table.

"You do whatever you want with them... I don't really care to be honest. If you offer them an opportunity, they might even leave the Horde."

"They would?" Comes the question from the side of her.

"I mean... The Horde is not the happiest place. They are in a shitty situation with missing supplies and old, outdated weapons. They are clearly on the losing side, and as long as Hordak won't be able to recover the Horde from this a lot of soldiers won't hesitate to leave."

Kobra blinks at her. "Isn't the Horde so famous about their loyalty?"

Catra scoffs, amused. "Loyalty in the Horde doesn't exist. It never did, just great propaganda that they drill into your head as a cadet so you will be more motivated to fight." Catra says, her pipuls narrowed down into a slit, her voice dripping with deep-rooted hatred.

It was always silly expecting loyalty from anyone in the Horde, Catra realized a long time ago. Even she, who stood by the Horde for so long, so stubbornly, turned her back against it.

"I don't see any of you preparing for tonight." She speaks up again after most of them were staring at her quietly, maybe expecting more stories about the Horde or a moment where they could learn more about their new boss.

They scramble to their feet quickly, everyone hurrying to do their business they were tasked with earlier. Catra sighs, closing her eyes, snagging back to the char, her head bucks back a little. She winces a little, feeling another headache building up behind her eyes.

"You are incredible C.," Tells Huntara, putting away the map. "A true genius."

"Well, I'm not going to stop you with this." She snickers weakly, eyes still closed. "I kind of missed that.. Planning and going on a mission," Catra confesses absentmindedly, maybe it's the dull pain in her head that makes her talk.

"Do you miss the Horde?" The question comes from Kobra, way too close than Catra would have appreciated, she has no energy to snap at the snake.

"I don't miss the Horde, I miss the order from my life..." She opens her eyes, looking up at the ceiling, squinting. "The Horde was nothing but a misery." She furrows her brows, straightening her back. "And I wish nothing but destruction to them."

"That's why you are helping?"

"Partly. If I stay, I don't want to meet with any Horde soldier. I will try to keep my name or face out of the fight as much as I can, and as I said... You say also nothing to the Rebellion. If they ask, you did it alone." She instructs Huntara, who simply nods.

It would be better. Just because she has left the Horde doesn't mean she automatically with the princesses or the Rebellion. She can be just her own person, or this gang's leader if she is here. How ridiculous, she came here to be away from everything and now she has a gang in her neck and a Horde purging mission.

"What's the gang's name?"

"What?"

"What do people call it? It's kinda stupid to just call it gang" Catra grimaces. "you must have a name or something."

"We actually don't," Kobra says, picking her nail. "We always just went by the gang."

Catra blinks at them. "Yeah, that won't work."

"Well, it's yours now. You can name it." Huntara shrugs.

Catra hums, thinking about a name that would fit this group of lawless'. "Yeah, I will think about something." She massages her unbandaged temple. "I need more of that root."

"We actually run out of it."

"Kobra go bring some."

"Why me?"

"Because if you get eaten by a three-headed snake no one will miss you."

"Ahh, such a cruel boss. I know you would miss me." Kobra snickers and gracefully stands up, walking to the door. "But if I die, remember how incredible I was." She dramatically leaps out of the inn.

"Why didn't I strangle her yet." Catra mumbles to herself.

Huntara chuckles at herself. "How is your wound? Did it get better?"

"It got better. But it would probably scar too." She sighs. "I would look badass with a slit on my eyebrow though." Catra wanders to herself, drinking the rest of her beer.

Huntara doesn't ask unnecessary questions, which is nice. Catra isn't ready to talk about her past with anyone, neither with herself. It still sits in a dark corner of her heart behind a wall that Catra had built, concealing it away with anger and the need to destroy everything. The moment she is faced with them, that wall seems to grow gaps, slowly but steadily crumbling down and Catra doesn't know how long she can pretend. How long she can hide behind anger.

The night comes faster than ever, Kobra came back with some roots that could ease the pain of Catra's headache and wound. She is chewing on them as they get prepared, feeling the sweet numbness taking over her body.

"Are you ready?" She asks for the last time before she turns on the skiff and drives away where the valley is.

Her heart beats fast due to excitement. That's what she is good at, what she has been raised: to fight. For a moment, it's like she is holding hands with Catra before this whole mess, before she has left, when she finds a thrill in a fight.

They all go their separate way the moment they saw the approaching chasm where the valley is situated. Catra is set on one goal, driving out the Horde from the valley.

Her group consists of not more than 10 people, perfect as they are. Catra spent her time picking up each group carefully so their strength could be used perfectly. Soon, as the first moon appeared in the sky, all hell broke out.

She gets the signal in a few minutes in, robots taken care of, or at least most of them and the communication centre is also wrecked. No back up for the valley. Perfect. She pulls her hood up, preventing everyone from seeing her face, her tail curls around her waist.

Catra jumps, landing on one of the soldier's back, knocking them down to the ground. It takes no time for other soldiers to round on Catra, but the catgirl takes them with ease even with her wound, sudden movements still send her into a nauseous state, but she does her best to ignore it. Thanks to her night vision she can see everything clearly, while the soldiers have a hard time navigating through the night.

She actually giggles, jumping onto the next soldier, kicking them in the head, reaching for her whip she yanks away the teaser from another. She keeps that, fighting with her whip and the newly stolen teaser, getting the soldiers who can't keep up with how fast Catra is. She easily jumps and manoeuvres herself around the attacks, turning soldiers against each other by clinging to one's back as another attack with a teaser and she jumps away the moment the teaser is near.

"Even Kyle can fight better." She puts her hand on her hip, tilting her head, amusement in her voice. "Oh come on, I don't bite." Catra is about to attack again, but what she doesn't expect is someone who is definitely not in her gang smashing a soldier to the wall. "What... Hey!" Catra growls at him, the man turning around.

He is a scorpion hybrid. Like Scorpia. Catra is stunned for only a second as the stranger flashes a smile at her.

"It would be kind of infuriating if we let all of you get the glory here." He challenges, throwing himself into another attack.

And Catra just sees now, that it's not only the gang but others too. The ones who live in the valley and fell under the Horde's leadership.

Her heart hammers heavily, did she just... Start a rebellion?

"Boss, look out!"

Someone screams at her and Catra turns around, barely missing the laser beam aimed at her. It explodes on the ground, throwing Catra back.

"More bots?" She narrows her eyes, looking up at the upper level of the city, seeing a few robots nestled into the rocks aiming at people. She wastes no time, climbing up easily with her sharp claws as she tries to stay out of the robots' line. Catra sneaks around one of them, slashing into it with her claws, grabbing onto the cables and tearing them out with a heavy groan.

"Wait..." An idea sparks in her brain, with a smug smile she jumps to another robot, taking control of it and landing the blows to the incoming troops, throwing them to the ground. When the mechanics didn't serve any more purpose, she simply destroyed it like the other one.

She regroups with Huntara and Kobra after everything quiets down.

"The soldiers?"

Huntara shakes her head suddenly. "They are gone."

"What do you mean-"

The earth shakes around them, freezing Catra. Another rumble, this time louder. She can faintly hear something beeping above them, then another one. More rapidly. She slowly looks up, only seeing the flashing of the red explosions fastened into the high of the rock walls. Realization washes over her like cold summer rain.

"GET OUT! EVERYONE!"

She cries out, her voice booming around the empty place before one of the explosions goes off at one of the ends of the valley, bringing a landslide of rocks with itself.

Catra turns around and runs away, Huntara and Kobra in her toe, another explosion goes off nearer them. The rumble of the rocks sliding down and colliding with the ground sets another kind of fright in Catra's soul. Was it a trap? Or a last-minute cry for victory from the Horde.

Everything happens so fast, Catra could barely wrap her head around it. The explosion happens right above her, she looks up but only can see the nearing rock falling towards her rooted in one spot. A strong hand wraps around her arm, pulling her away, into a crack in the wall shielding her from the remains of the rockslide.

Catra opens her eyes, seeing perfectly in the dark. Huntara not so, the catgirl gets out of the other's hold quickly.

"What the fuck." She growls, more at what happened.

They can't go out of that way obviously, it's blocked by the rocks, and even with Huntara's strength, they would just endanger their own lives.

"What happened..." Huntara sounds just as stunned as Catra.

"The Horde being desperate." Catra huffs, her eyes glowing in the dark. "We can't go this way obviously..." She kicks one of the rocks.

She looks around briefly, it looks like the cave was carved out. Probably by the Horde soldiers, but why? There's no weapon here, they didn't use it for storage, or anything really. It's empty.

"Wait you can see in the dark?"

"Duh." Catra rolls her eyes. "I'm a cat... Partly? I don't know. Anyways, I have night vision. I can see clearly."

"Do you see any tunnel or something that could lead us out of here?"

"Let me look around." Catra walks around a little, obviously not as confident on her legs. Night vision or not, they are still in a cave or something that could hold many things that could kill them.

She squints slightly. "I think I can see a tunnel?" She sounds unsure.

"Let's check it out," Huntara suggests. "Not like we have other options."

Catra sighs. "Okay, let's go. "But before they could go, she unwraps her whip, giving the end to Huntara. "You can't see, I do. You wouldn't get lost."

"Aww, kitty doesn't want me to get lost?" Huntara asks, teasingly.

"You know what, give my whip back. I'm leaving you here." Catra grumbles.

Nonetheless, they continue their journey, Catra leading them along. Everything is so silent, it creeps Catra out, just their breathing and Huntara's boost against the uneven ground makes

any sound. They walk who knows how long, it feels like forever to Catra for sure.

"This is ridiculous." She growls, pushing her bang down a little too aggressively hurting her wounded forehead. She hisses lightly.

"Did you see it?!"

Huntara's voice echoes in the tunnel and Catra snaps her head around, searching for anything. She follows where Huntara is looking, but it's just darkness. She squints, thinking Huntara might just have imagined something, but then, a flicker. It's short, barely even a second, an orange light has just flickered.

"Uhm..." Catra squeaks.

"I guess you have seen it."

"Yeah..."

And it happened again. Catra takes a small step back, unsure of what to do. She glances up at Huntara who looks just as concerned.

"Should we go towards it?" The taller asks eventually.

Catra sighs. "As you've said, we have nowhere else to go." With that, the duo starts walking again, this time towards the flickering orange light.

As they near it, the ground changes from uneven rocks and sand to chiselled marble looking tables. Catra looks down at it, eyebrows furrowing. Why would it change so suddenly? Where does this tunnel lead?

"It's a... crystal?" Catra tilts her head, looking at the thing that's flickering with orange light. "Why would a crystal be here? Is it a mine or something?" She turns to Huntara.

Huntara shakes her head. "No. I never actually saw this tunnel or knew there was an opening on the wall." Huntara looks at Catra, suspicion rising in both of their hearts. "Do you think it's a Horde trap?"

"I don't know..." Catra whispers, looking back at the flickering crystal. She slowly raises her arm, reaching towards the crystal, touching it lightly.

It sends sparkles of warmth through Catra's body before it flickers and suddenly the whole tunnel is glowing in an orange glow by million little crystals nestled into the wall of the tunnel. There's an intricate drawing pattern on the wall, some swirling symbol, resembling fire. Catra's best tip.

"What is... Happening?" Huntara asks, completely lost, but to be honest, Catra feels the same.

Catra slowly shakes her head, "I have no idea..."

They slowly inch forward, knowing there might be danger lurking around, Huntara has her spear out and Catra has drawn her claws out just in case. The tunnel that was about Huntara's height, a little taller, starts to widen out as they go deeper, revealing a marble door at the end.

It has the same symbol in the middle, the frame is just as laced with a symbol like the walls. They feel somehow familiar to Catra, like when you know a word but it doesn't come to your tongue. It feels just like the same. She furrows her brows, stepping closer to the enormous door, she inspects it, there is no keyhole, knob or even a button that can open it.

"Wait, are you going into?"

"Of course? Maybe we could find a way out." Catra turns back to the door, with a sudden idea she pushes it.

Honestly, neither Huntara nor Catra expects it to work, it looks way too massive and no matter how strong Catra is, it wouldn't

budge.

However, the moment Catra's palm rested on the fire symbol it started glowing up with light, the same orange hue. And the door creaks open slowly, dust and small rocks falling to the floor for how long it has been closed off. Catra steps back with shock and awe mixed on her face. She looks down at her own palms.

What did just happen?

The door eventually opens wide, leading them into an enormous chamber basking in an orange glow, a chandelier made out of orange crystals hanging from the middle.

"Oh..."

Both of them just stand there, not knowing if they should go in or not.

Catra takes the first step, walking past the door, her steps echoing back from the walls. It's... Empty. Or at least looks like one. The ceiling is high, higher than maybe the main Fright Zone building, Catra looks up in awe turning around. It looks as if half circles are etched into the walls, but it stops before it could reach the bottom, maybe 4-5 meters up.

On the east side, there is something that Catra would call an altar. It looks like a flame made out of stone, dried flowers around it which have been lying here for a long time, half-burnt candles around it.

What Catra only registers now is that despite them being at the deepest part of the cave, she isn't cold. As if these crystals emit warmth all over the place. She walks around, suddenly stopping at one of the walls.

There's a mosaic picture, stretched up on the wall. Catra takes a few steps back to see it better, the moment she sees what it illustrates her breath hitched. She drops the whip, eyes widen with shock and confusion.

"Hey C... I think that it's a cry- " Huntara turns to the catgirl stopping mid-sentence as she takes in Catra's state.

Huntara looks up at the wall, seeing a figure in the pictures. A lady with a wild brown mane reaching down her thighs has a delicate golden dress with a red pattern sawn into it. She holds her hand up, reaching for an orange crystal. What catches her attention, is the pierced cat ears and cat tail with jewellery.

"Are there... Others like... Me?" Catra whispers, her body shaking. "Other... like me..." Her voice is so weak and wounded, Huntara never heard anyone like this.

Catra drops to her knees, looking up at the catwoman in the picture. Her mind is a storm, a heavy fog clouding everything. She doesn't even notice the tears falling onto the marble floor.

Disappointment, you are nothing but a failure.

Your parents have thrown you away.

A creature like you, no one would have wanted you.

Without me, you would have died.

A filthy pet, an animal nothing more.

Shadow Weaver's accusing cruel worlds swirl in her head. She hugs herself, her headache pounding as if her skull would split in any second. Her chest heaves with difficulty to breathe, throat closed and panic rising in her heart.

No one has ever wanted you.

You were thrown away, no one ever needed you.

Shadow Weaver lied.

She ***lied.***

There are others like Catra, other people like her in Etheria. She wasn't a failure, a monster. She wasn't an abnormal creature.

She had a family, a home and the Horde-

The face of a woman flashes before her eyes, golden eyes looking into hers, pained and desperate. A hand reaching out for her. She screams something, Catra can't make it out, voices are muffled around her, a mix of screams and shouts, Shadow Weaver's voice wavering over them. Shadows enveloping her.

Catra falls to the ground, curling into herself from the pain that's now radiating through her whole body. Like Shadow Weaver's lightning dancing around her body, but she feels them deep inside her bone. She feels Huntara's touch on her shoulder, making Catra aware of how much she is shaking, at this point the girl just hugs herself in the middle, forehead touching the marble.

Her lips tremble as she pulls her lips back to a snarl, tears falling to the floor.

"They… Lied… Shadow Weaver lied...The Horde..." Her voice trembles from years of pain and anger coursing through her blood, Catra sinks her claws into her upper hand.

She has no idea how long she has been sitting on the floor, looking up at the mosaic picture of the cat woman clad in gold with the crystal. She barely moved since she has recovered from the sudden shock, still unbelievable that others like Catra exist. Do they call themselves hybrid? Or what is their name? Where are they? Did they live in the Crimson Waste? What happened to them?

"Huntara..." Catra speaks softly, yet in the silence, the other can hear her clearly. "Who were they? You've lived here longer..."

Huntara was observing the catgirl from behind, making sure she was okay and didn't want to do anything reckless after her break down. For some reason, there is this pull in the woman to protect that cat, no matter how tough she looks, Catra is a broken piece.

Now she can see it the way Catra just sits there, like a child who is waiting for their parents to come back.

"I'm not sure..." Huntara says, looking at the mosaic picture. "They say that the Crimson Waste used to be a kingdom had another name... But their city disappeared under one night, and no one knew what happened exactly. " Huntara explains it to her. "I never had an idea that there is a.. crypt, so near the valley."

Catra hums in acknowledgement of her words.

"You know I... I was found as a child, the one who... Uhm brought me up, she never told me how old I was or even where did I come from... I've accepted the fact that maybe my parents didn't want me, or that my destiny was to fight on the Horde's side. Bring it glory and victory." Catra tells Huntara slowly, her voice empty and lifeless. "And now... Turns out there are others like me... How many times the Horde lied to us." She scoffs what turns into a mocking laugh.

"I'm sorry."

"Don't." She says harshly. "I don't need your sorry, or anyones. I never knew them. Never will." Catra finishes off the topic.

The picture's eyes glow up softly, radiating a light orange glow and the wall behind Huntara reveals a door. They both turn around, the tunnel leading into another hall full of orange crystals that show the way.

"This place gives me the creeps."

"It leads us out..." Catra stands up, dusting her clothes. Huntara asks her how she knows, and the catgirl just shrugs. She passes the taller, walking into the tunnel. Huntara follows her with a sigh, the door closing behind them.

They walk side by side in silence, the way slowly becoming stiffer, which means they are going somewhere higher. The clean marble ends turning into rough and uneven rock again, which means they

must be closer to the end of the tunnel. They eventually arrive, Huntara just has to push away a big rock and they are out of the valley.

Catra squints her eyes, getting used to the light. She looks around, then down to the valley, half of it has been destroyed and the overall place is just unsafe not knowing when something will blow up from what the Horde has left behind. The gentle wind against her skin and face gives her a soft wake up call.

She sighs deeply, pushing down her hair again.

"Don't tell anyone what we've seen down there," Catra instructs Huntara and walks away, searching for her skiff what she has left around here.

"But maybe-"

"No. Just... Not yet." Catra's voice changes from low to unsure. "I need time to think about it, that's it."

Eventually, Catra finds her skiff and brings it back to take Huntara with herself. The others must have left already, or maybe buried deep under the rocks. Catra is unsure.

Huntara sits on the floor, while Catra drives, her tail curled around her abdomen.

"Forsaken."

"Huh?"

"That will be the gang's name... Forsaken."

Huntara hums. "Quite fitting."

nothing left behind

Chapter Summary

> "She did us a favour with dying."

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Sorry for the small little hiatus, I took a week off from updating for personal reasons and to write this short, but quite an impactful chapter! It's more of an emotional-based / focused one than action. Hope you will like it!

Today's war meeting has stretched into the night, just like the day before, for once they are actually managing to come up with something. Now that Shadow Weaver is not here, and Glimmer doesn't try to sneak the Heart into every damn conversation. Adora feels a little bit more confident, but she can't shake off the guilt each time she looks at Perfuma's empty chair, Scorpia's too. The scorpion princess spends a lot of time at the infirmary.

The place Adora avoids like the plague, guilt eating up her heart.

"The sewer system under the Horde isn't that complicated, I can just pop the pipes off and they would be flooded," Mermista suggests with a tired voice.

They are planning to ambush the Horde before they could attack them again.

"It can plunge half of their machines off too," Adora suggests, the others are nodding along.

"Our main focus is still reaching Hordak. I'm sure he expects an attack at this point?" Glimmer looks unsure. "They have new weapons too."

"Perhaps we can ask Entrapta about it, " Sea Hawk offers. "She knows much more about the Horde's technology than we do."

"That's true."

"Did *anyone* see Entrapta anyways?"

Frosta yawns, eyes blinking rapidly. "She is trying to break into the Horde's communication system. Or I think that's what she said..." She yawns again, eyelids falling shut then opening up suddenly.

Micah chuckles a little. "Maybe we should end our meeting for tonight?"

"I'm not tired!" Frosta says stubbornly.

"But I am, so good night." Mermista stands up, about to leave the room only for the doors to bust open with Entrapta sitting on Emily, the Horde tap held close to her chest.

"Everyone! I got into the Horde's communication system!" She announces with an ear to ear grin. "Which means I have two bad news too." Her smile quickly falters, eyes zeroed on Adora, then, she glances away. Emily walks closer to the table.

"Two? In plural?" Bow's voice cracks.

"I'm afraid... Which one do you want to hear first? One involves the Kingdom of Snows, the other is about Catra." Entrapta mentions her usual enthusiasm nowhere to be found. It sets Adora off.

"Kingdom of Snows!" Frosta yells, standing on her chair.

"Well... Hordak has ordered his troops to march to Snows, I'm still unsure about their actual plan, he only referred to it as *the third act*. I don't know what it means... But there's definitely a planned attack against Snows." she confirms. "He gave that order yesterday morning."

"Wait..." Glimmer stands from her chair.

"If he gave it yesterday morning-" Mermista's eyes widened.

"It means the Horde troops could reach Snows by tomorrow morning." Frosta pales down, falling back to her chair.

"We don't have enough time to gather around Bright Moon soldiers."

"We need to leave, *now"* Glimmer orders, the others nodding along with her, Frosta hops from her chair almost out of the door.

"What about Catra?" Adora asks, the only one staying by her seat still. She feels the other's eyes on her, but she needs to know. "Entrapta... Did something happen with Catra?"

Entrapta looks down, the silence stretching between them.

She hops off Emily, walking to Adora. "I managed to recover older data too, and I went through them in hopes of finding something about Catra. I was sure Hordak would try to catch her, and I was right. He gave out an order against Catra, 3 months ago." Entrapta finishes, her voice small. She hands the pad to Adora.

Adora takes it, looking at the screen. She gasps, almost dropping the tab to the floor. "A... A liquidation order? Hordak gave out a *liquidation* order on Catra?!"

"It's not just that..." Entrapta whispers, if Adora wouldn't be so close to her, she wouldn't be able to hear her. "They received a signal, from a Horde camp the next day." Entrapta scrolls down for Adora. "The order was carried out successfully."

Adora drops the tab, it falls to the ground loudly. She looks down at Entrapta with wide eyes, not knowing what to do. With shaking hands, she holds onto Entrapta's shoulder.

"P.. Please tell me... Entrapta please, tell me that it's some kind of error..." The desperation in her own voice shocks her, body shivering.

Entrapta shakes her head, Adora surprised to see tears clinging to the older's eyelashes. "I looked through it multiple times... I

thought the data would be wrong, but... The data never lies." She hangs her head low, closing her eyes.

"Adora?" Bow steps to her.

Adora looks at Bow, she lets go of Entrapta. She opens her mouth to answer, but nothing comes off only a pitiful whimper, she hugs herself with trembling hands. Not able to progress from what she just heard.

Catra is gone. She is dead. They killed Catra. She won't be able to see Catra again. She has been trying to find her desperately, and Catra has been gone for all of this time.

"Catra is gone." She echoes her thoughts, voice so small and vulnerable, like a child's. "Catra is gone... They... They killed her. They... Catra is gone." She repeats it, words broken with a sharp gasp.

She feels someone touching her shoulders, with a shrill she slaps their hand away. "Don't touch me!" She cries, chest heaving, hurting and her sides are stung with pain.

"Adora?" Bow asks, but Adora can't comprehend more.

Suddenly everything is too cold and too hot at once, too suffocating and too loosen, too crowded and too empty. Her frantic eyes fall on the door, her body moving on her own, getting out of the room is her main priority. She doesn't hear the others, she doesn't see anything, doesn't know where she is going.

Just away, away from everything, from everyone.

Her mind can't string together any coherent thoughts, everything starts with Catra and ends with her name, Entrapta's words echoing in her ears. Memories of their past coming to her from the early moment to the most recent ones, to the hateful words, to the desire to hold Catra to bring her with herself.

Everything just seems too far away by now, as if they happened decades ago.

Adora breathes, her chest hurting. She is running by now but to where? She doesn't know.

By the time she stops, Adora drops to her knees in the middle of the Whispering Woods. Her body trembles, fingers digging into the dirt of the ground. She doesn't cry, far too out of everything to even cry. She heaves and her chest aches with years of regret, she clutches her hands over her shirt.

"Catra is gone." She echoes until her throat gets rough until the words hurt so much she can't even say them anymore. "I lost her... I lost Catra. I... I couldn't... I couldn't tell her... I couldn't..." She gasps, heart, beating heavily. It hurts, so damn much. "I... I lost... Catra-"

Words spill out of her mouth, repeating herself over and over, still unable to process everything.

I couldn't tell her I love her.

The Whispering Woods is quiet around Adora, no noises from animals who hunt at night, not even the cicadas are singing now. As if the woods could sense Adora’s grief.

She sits at the foot of a tree that hides her from the world, not like anyone would be able to find her, as the Whispering Woods lead people to where they need to go. And Adora wanted to be alone now, with her thoughts, her grief and regrets. Even though her friends are probably on their way to the Kingdom of Snow, Adora can't make her body move.

Her limbs are paralyzed with grief and deeply rooted regret for the past two years, even before that.

She should have brought Catra with herself, she should have found another solution, she should have tried harder. Adora tells herself, while she curls into herself with shaking shoulders.

Catra is really gone and Adora can't do anything to bring her back. Not anymore. And it breaks her heart into million tiny little pieces each of them reflecting a memory of Catra, whether it's bad or good, painful or lovely, dear or bitter. They are all part of their history.

A history that Adora wishes would be better. Would have been better.

She doesn't know how long she sits there, alone. Until she feels a tug in her heart, she knows this feeling well, Swift Wind is searching for her. Adora tries to become smaller as if the horse would be able to spot her from above. Eventually, Swift Wind does find her, after all, they are connected somehow.

And then, he pushes his head through the bush Adora is hiding behind. "Adora! Finally found you! Oh apples, I thought you like to run away or something. You know these woods are really confusing." Swift Wind scoffs, rolling his eyes.

His comment stays unanswered.

"Adora?" He nudges her at the arm with his nose.

"Leave me alone Swift Wind." Her voice comes out muffled and uneven.

"Hey, don't be like that..." He comes around the bush, laying down on the ground next to Adora. "I was worried, you know. Most of us were."

Adora doesn't say a thing, although she does feel guilty.

"I'm sorry Adora."

She looks up finally, looking at Swift Wind. "Thank you... I guess... I... I don't know what to do..." She whispers, looking down at the ground.

"They would understand if you stay, you know?"

"Are they? We are in a war... We... We don't have time to break down, yet..." Tears swim across her eyes. "Yet... Catra... She is gone..." She quickly dries her tear up. "I just want to hide away from the world."

"We can do that."

"That's not a very She-ra thing to do..."

Swift Wind snorts, shaking his head. "But you are Adora now."

"Maybe that's not enough... I'm not strong enough as Adora..." She whispers, standing up from the ground. Swift Wind looks at her confused. "The world needs She-ra... Not Adora." She tightens her ponytail with a harsh tug.

She will have to bury her grief and pain; she can't afford it. Not now. Now with everything on the line.

The world doesn't need Adora, it needs She-ra to save them.

Adora always found Snows a beautiful kingdom, with the sparkling white freshly fallen snow, sometimes, even the northern lights could be seen from here, dancing in green, blue and purple lights. Everything was just so incredibly calm and serene, even when the wind would blow wildly or a blizzard would run along the mountains.

Now, however, the snow is littered with scraps of Horde tanks, robots and machines. Traces of battles.

The battle for Snows has been going, and Adora just jumped right into it.

Being She-ra feels completely different like before, she feels disconnected from the ancient power, her body moving like a robot with already well-known moves as she breaks through the soldiers. She unleashes the power of the sword, sending energy blows across the field. But if someone would ask what she was exactly doing during the attack, she wouldn't be able to answer.

As if her mind switched off and someone took over her body instead.

They could arrive before the Horde would have attacked the Ice palace. Or at least the others. Adora arrived at the last push on Swift Wind's back, already transformed to She-ra.

She said not even a word to her friends, just charged into the battle and ever since Adora is in her She-ra form, she can feel how it's tiring for her body, but she doesn't stop. Even when Bow asks her, she just ignores him.

It's much easier, she doesn't have to dwell on the fact that Catra is not here anymore, that Catra has been dead for months now and Adora had no fucking idea.

Or, if for a fleeting moment, Catra's memory would cross her mind Adora would get more violent, aggressive with her own powers. It's not just pure anger, but grief and pain too, Adora hurts just as much she is mad at everything around her. She half expected Hordak to show up, but the Horde Lord didn't grace them with his appearance today.

When they were able to push back the last Horde offensive for today, Glimmer walked to her. Adora doesn't know what to expect, they haven't spoken since them going at each other in the war room. Adora still refuses to transform back.

The young Queen looks up at her, with exhausted eyes, bruises on her body.

"You will tire yourself down Adora, more than it's necessary." She tells her, for a moment Glimmer reaches for Adora's hand, but quickly changes her mind. "We pushed them back."

"For now," Adora notes coldly.

"Adora, please? You will exhaust yourself."

Adora looks down at Glimmer, then turns away with a scowl. Her body glows up in gold before She-ra's form would disappear and it's Adora again. "Happy?" She scoffs.

"Thank you."

She says nothing at Glimmer, instead, Adora walks away from her, or at least tries. But Glimmer holds onto her. Adora turns halfway, looking back at the Queen with a questioning look.

"Look... I... I'm sorry for Catra." Glimmer whispers, squeezing Adora's hand.

At the mention of Catra's name, Adora yanks her hand out of Glimmer's hold. "I don't want to talk about Catra." She turns away. "Not... With you..."

Adora's words may be nothing but a whisper, but they are loud between the two friends, the weight of it sitting heavily on their shoulders.

"You never cared about Catra... Or if I find her or not. I don't want to talk about her with you, Glimmer." Adora explains it, voice faint.

"But you are my friend, Adora." Glimmer steps around Adora, until they are face to face again. "I know you and Bow are still on good terms, it's only me who is left out! Why are you two doing this to me?" Glimmer asks, brows drawn in confusion and eyes swimming in tears. "We are supposed to be friends..."

"We *are* friends Glimmer, but you just... You are so stubborn! You listen to Shadow Weaver before us, before your own friends! You felt betrayed and left out, but what do you think about how I felt when you sided with her? What do you think about how Bow felt when you didn't even speak with him just because he didn't agree with using the Heart? We are hurt too, Glimmer." Adora finishes sternly, not knowing where the power came in her voice.

Glimmer looks down, hands balled into fists. "I just want this war to be over. I want to protect Etheria! Why is it hard to understand?"

"Because you will be hurting Etheria if we use the Heart!" Adora raises her voice, just like Glimmer.

"You don't know that!"

"I *know* it Glimmer! The last time it was active, its power almost destroyed Etheria! Mara put us here-"

"Maybe Mara was wrong, maybe she couldn't control it, but you-"

"I won't use the Heart of Etheria!"

"You are She-ra! You are supposed to protect us!"

Words stuck in Adora's throat at that, staring down at Glimmer with widened eyes. The Queen looked back at her with hard, stubborn eyes, seemingly not realising how close her words hit to Adora's internal struggle.

"Is this the only thing I am to you? Just, She-ra?" She questions, voice defeated.

Glimmer blinks, realization hitting her across the cheek. "No... Adora, no... No, you are my friend."

"If I wouldn't be She-ra, you wouldn't even give me a chance, right? I was just a Horde scum to you." She steps away from Glimmer, the cold air grazing her cheeks.

"Adora it's not like that."

"You've said in the camp that I was different from Catra because I am She-ra. So what am I Glimmer? Your supposed friend who you would have loved and accepted even if I wouldn't be an ancient hero or She-ra who is here to protect Etheria even if it means

sacrificing everything?" Adora pins the question over Glimmer's head."

"You are my friend! But we need She-ra to win over the Horde! We are losing our home, Adora."

"I know it Glimmer! Do you think I don't care about it?! But I'm not going to jeopardize the whole planet so we can *maybe* defeat the Horde!"

Glimmer is about to say something, but she rather closes her mouth and takes a deep breath, thinking over what to say. She exhales, and with a much calmer, yet desperate voice, she asks. "Why do we have to always argue?"

"Because you can't take the fact that sometimes people don't agree with your plans, Glimmer. You don't trust our plan. Why should we trust in yours?"

"It's not about trust-"

"Yes, the whole Rebellion, the whole Princess Alliance is about trusting each other. If we don't trust each other, then who should we trust in?" Adora asks, her blue eyes boring into Glimmer's. "But at this point, I can't even trust in you because you believe in Shadow Weaver's words over mine."

"Why do you always come up with her?!"

Adora rolls her eyes, barely being able to contain her composure. "She did nothing but manipulate and hurt me all my life! Do you think I love to see her around?! No! I don't Glimmer! And it hurts seeing you around her because I know she is just manipulating you to get what she wants!" Adora's voice cracks with emotions as she shouts, the voice carried by the icy wind.

"Stop treating me like a kid!"

"Then stop acting like one!"

Glimmer's eyes harden, her posture straightens. "I know my duty as *Queen*, Adora. I'm here to protect my people, Etheria, my home. I know what I have to do. But you?" Glimmer narrows her eyes, clearly hurt by Adora's words.

And Adora has half of her mind to feel guilty, an apology already on her tongue. Then Glimmer continues.

"Instead of fully helping the Alliance, you asked Entrapta and Scorpia to help you get Catra! Someone responsible for this whole shit we are in! And you know that Adora too! We've lost Salinieas and Plumeria because of her stupid fucking plan! But it's okay because? Why did you even want to find her?!"

"Because I loved her okay?!" She screams almost, eyes watery. "Because I loved that stupid brat! Even if she was my enemy for years!"

The answer clearly takes Glimmer back, shock evident on her face, eyes widened and jaw dropped. Then, she quickly recovers, anger flashing through her eyes.

"You can't be serious now Adora. Catra? She wanted to kill you!"

"She was my friend before my enemy..."

"Well, your friendship doesn't help us with her plan. Seriously Adora? And what did you think? That she would magically rethink her whole life and join the Rebellion? I'm pretty sure everyone, except you and maybe Scorpia, hates her."

"I..."

"She was a war criminal, she hurt us too many times." Glimmer reasons.

"Scorpia and Entrapta were Horde soldiers too!" Adora points it out. "They worked directly with Catra! And what about Shadow Weaver? Don’t act like she wasn’t in a high position in the Horde!”

That seems to break something in Glimmer. "They didn't activate the portal! My mother didn't die because of them! It was because of fucking *Catra*! And you know what? I'm happy that she has died because even if she would turn up in Bright Moon, I would have *never* exempted her. Even if she would come to the Rebellion, she would have been put up to a trial and her sentence probably would have been executed. So really, the Horde just did us a *favour*."

Glimmer speaks out of anger, grief and rage and a rational part of Adora's mind know it, but she is way too hurt by the Queen's words to even think rationally.

"*She* did us a favour with dying."

And without looking back, Glimmer turns on her heels, leaving Adora out in the cold as the gates of the Ice palace closes behind Bright Moon's Queen.

Adora only notices her tears when the cold wind hits her face once again.

"Frosta this..."

"This is a stupid plan!" Mermista lashes out, hands bailed in fists. "How could you give up your kingdom!?"

"I'm not giving it up!" The little princess shouts. "But we can't protect two places at once... Bright Moon is still unprotected. We will bring my people to Bright Moon, we can't protect Snows forever." Frosta concludes, looking down at the ground. "It's not

easy to leave my home behind, but this seems the best idea at this moment."

Silence settles in the throne room of the Ice palace. Every eye watching Frosta as the princess speaks. Adora stuck to the back, not wanting to be even near Glimmer, her words still ripping open fresh wounds in her heart. Bow looks back at her quietly asking with his eyes if everything is okay. Adora looks away.

"And if Swift Wind was right another Horde troop is on its way to here. We are too exhausted to push them back again."

"So what?" Glimmer's voice cuts through the still air. "Are we just going to give up?" She looks at Frosta. "We've already lost two kingdoms, and what if they will try and destroy the runestone?"

Frosta shakes her head. "It won't happen. The Fractal Flake is deeply hidden beneath the palace. No one can access it without my help. And I will bring up the guards in its chamber just in case." Frosta explains it.

"Still doesn't feel right leaving the whole kingdom without protection," Mermista adds, doubting in Frosta.

"Just trust in my decision, please?"

Bow steps in. "Frosta is right. We can't fight in two places. Do you need help to bring up the guards Frosta?"

"I just need someone to be there, it might take a lot of my power." She wonders.

"Right." The boy nods. "Adora, go with Frosta. Mermista, Glimmer and I will evacuate the people."

"Wait, how are we going to like move a whole kingdom of people in a small amount of time?"

"Glimmer has unlimited teleportation. If the people cling together they could be teleported in one group."

The small group of friends moves into action, Adora following Frosta whose shoulders pulled back taut with tenseness, while her face set in a scowl. Adora looks back one last time, catching Glimmer's eyes who holds her gaze, before looking away with unreadable eyes. There's too much emotion swirling in Adora's head for her to think straight. She is angry at Glimmer for what she has said, but at the same time tries to understand that it isn't easy for her too.

But it's not enough reason to hurt her friends. To hurt Adora.

They should all be working together, yet, lately, it's all argument and trying to nitpick on everyone's plan or idea. And it's not just Glimmer or Adora. Everyone is tense and worried as they are losing their grip on the war and the Horde gains more power.

Mermista desperately tries to save the other kingdoms as she wasn't able to protect her own. Salineas is still under Horde control, pirates and outlaws joining them too. While Perfuma is still in a coma without any knowledge of when she would actually wake up or if she would ever be able to use her powers, Scorpia barely even left her side.

And now Frosta. Giving up her kingdom basically, placing it in the Horde's hands just so they would be able to protect Bright Moon in the future.

No matter what Madame Razz has said, she isn't like Mara. She let down her friends, the people who believed in her. She isn't able to save them, whether it's from losing a battle or losing their lives.

"Adora?"

"Hm?"

"Thank you for coming and helping us..." Forsta's voice is small and vulnerable. Adora, once again, is reminded that Frosta is still a child with a heavyweight on her shoulders.

The world doesn't need Adora, it needs She-ra. Adora reminds herself again, she gives a weak smile to Frosta. "I will always help you guys, no matter what."

The pair follow hallways Adora has never seen before whenever she has visited the palace. They seem ancient, built before even the rest of the palace probably. Before them, enormous ice door towers. It opens with one touch from Frosta, sliding to the sides.

Coldness, more intense and chilling than the blizzard storm outside of the palace welcomes them. She looks up seeing the Fractal Flake up above a cliff that leads down to the darkness. Frosta steps ahead, near the end of the cliff.

The runestone starts to glow upon sensing the princess, who glows up in a light blue glow using her powers to bring up a guard around the ancient runestone. The chamber grumbles around them, Adora holds onto the wall watching as Frosta's power spreads through the walls. Massive ice thorns grow out of the walls, guarding the runestone and hiding it away from the world.

From the deep, new much bigger thrown grow, and from them, guards made out of ice appear standing along the cliff with massive ice spears and swords, ready to fight.

"Frosta!"

Adora hurries to the princess as she kneels onto the floor, panting from the use of her power. She helps her get back on her feet, they both look up at the runestone. Hidden behind thick, almost unbreakable ice thorns and spikes.

"It will be enough, right?" Adora questions, looking at Frosta.

"I think..." The answer is unsure. "I will raise more guards at the door and along the hallway."

Adora looks at her friend worried. "Are you sure? You already used much of her powers."

"I will be fine."

They leave the runestone's chamber, and the ice door closes behind them. Frosta with her power emits more and more ice walls in front of the door, until almost the end of the hallway. Hiding the entrance away.

Adora stays close to her in case she would use too much of her power and collapse. They eventually make it out of the palace finding their friends outside. Glimmer looks exhausted. Mermista is out on a small hill looking out of any incoming attack, while Bow directs people and tries to calm them down. Frosta leaves Adora's side, with the last of her powers, she raises ice walls along with the palace, for the last protection.

With the last of the people going to Bright Moon, they all load up to Darla.

In the distance, Adora can see Horde robots nearing them, and behind them more soldiers and machines coming in their directions. Adora stands at the cliff, she takes one step forward, Bow catching onto her elbow.

"Huh? Bow?"

"We are ready to go." He tells her, trying to read behind her stormy eyes. "

Adora looks away from her friend back to the approaching armada. "Do you think Hordak is with them?"

The question catches Bow off guard, his eyes watching the troops in the distance too. "I don't know...Adora, do you...?"

"Am I? Want to see him and ask him about Catra's... Death." She spits the words with anger. "Then, yes... But at the same time, I don't..."

"I'm sorry... I really do Adora."

Mermista shows up, with wide eyes and a terrified look on her face. As if the last of her hopes are leaving her heart. “Bad news. Bad-bad news.” She spits out, her hands curl into fists. “We are ditching Bright Moon, Shadow Weaver betrayed us. We are taking Darla to Mystacor.”

bitter past

Chapter Summary

"Why are you so afraid to let go of your pain, Kitten?"

Chapter Notes

I'M FINALLY BACK!! My exams are done, I'm free from the shackle of university (until September only) and! I can! finally! update! my fic! YAY!

Hope you will enjoy ♥

Two weeks have passed since the night they have discovered the crypt down under the Valley of the Lost. Huntara works on trying to clean out the valley and on days where Catra is particularly bored she would tag along, she would find a warm rock for herself, enjoying the warmth of it, while Kobra would lurk around her doing the same just on the sand.

Half of the valley has been already cleared off, they made sure to scan through the whole area and remove all the explosives left behind. Catra stays in the valley too, Kobra tagged along with her and of course the rest of the Forsaken, somehow even Huntara.

Most of the time she would sneak away and find her way back to the crypt.

She would sit there for hours sometimes looking up at the mosaic picture, in hopes it would give her answers or something that could explain everything.

Her wound has healed, leaving behind a light scar that crosses over her right brow, giving her a slit. Catra still thinks it's badass. She wears her hair in a ponytail or else the heat of the desert would actually make her go mad. The cloak is a constant piece to her outfit too.

"What happened to everyone..." Catra whispers into the silence. Going around the crypt-like she always does, hoping that something would serve as an answer, she even went through the stone coffins along the wall.

They give her no lead, it's obvious that this place has belonged to royalty, but they have stopped burying anyone here a long time ago. The past ruler's name is carved into the stone, some of them ringing some bell to Catra as if she has heard them, others just names on a stone. She has gathered that the woman in the picture must be a queen, which one she doesn't know and the orange crystal on the mosaic is the runestone of the kingdom.

She has a few theories now why the Horde started to carve their way into the rock wall. They probably tried to access the crypt, but obviously were unable to. As if like the tunnel only let them in until a certain point, because where the marble starts Catra couldn’t see any traces of Horde weapons along the walls.

She would sometimes light up one of the candles which brings rose scent with itself. Some kind of deep-rooted duty for this place she assumes. After all, even if this crypt belonged to a royal family, Catra and they belonged to the same place. Here, the Crimson Waste.

"I bet Scorpia would like this place..." She mumbles with a little nostalgic smile. "Or Adora..." She sighs deeply, the hole in her heart opening up to be bigger and bigger every day.

Does she miss them? She doesn't know. Catra has this idea fixated in her head that she doesn't need anyone, she is enough for herself. But then, at moments when she is alone and feeling particularly empty or lonely, she thinks about them. About Scorpia, Entrapta, Adora. The better version of them, not the accusatory ones she sees in her dreams.

They didn't cease, Catra thinks they will probably never will. Ghosts of her past haunting her alongside the consequences of her actions that she has to bear.

Since then, they have also driven the Horde out of the canyon city, Southern Star. It was much easier, and now Huntara plans to do the same with a west settlement, Venus, named after Etheria's third moon that always shines above the waste.

She has heard nothing about the outside world since she has left the Horde, she has no information about what's happening. If Hordak was able to bounce back or the princesses have the upper hand.

Catra closes her eyes, laying back on the warm marble floor taking a deep breath. For some reason, this place calms down her mind, the warmth that surrounds her is like a hug.

"I wish I could have known you..." she opens her eyes, looking up at the high ceiling and the orange crystal chandelier.

It's familiar, in a way that makes Catra want to reach for it like a lost strand of a forgotten memory.

She scoffs, pushing away these stupid thoughts. She jumps to her legs, dusting her clothes down and walks out of the door that only opens for her and closes after the catgirl leaves the crypt behind herself.

Each time the walk back up seems shorter, it's not even a surprise to see the moons appear when she emerges from the crypt. She could spend hours down there with no sense of time. At the mouth of the cave, she finds Kobra, the snake enjoying the warmth of the sand as she lays down on it.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks, stopping next to Kobra.

She opens her eyes, "Waiting for you boss. You disappear a lot these days, are you planning to leave us?"

Catra scoffs. "Even if I tried, I could never scarp you off of myself." She steps over her continuing her way towards the carved stair on the rock wall, leading down to the valley.

Kobra follows her with ease.

"What's up with that crypt anyways? Could you find anything about it?"

There is no answer for a long minute, Kobra never giving up her stare on Catra until she will answer. And for a second Catra contemplates not saying anything to Kobra, because really, she has no idea what's going on?

"I want to find out more about them."

"Them?"

"The people lived here before, people like me. Huntara said they have disappeared, but I don't buy this bullshit."

"Oh." Kobra perks up, curiously looking at Catra. "Are we solving a mystery?" She claps excitedly.

Catra sighs at Kobra's antics, knocking her shoulder against Kobra, almost sending the snake down the stairs. The snake throws her a glance.

"I wouldn't necessarily call it a mystery. But suit yourself."

"An entire kingdom just disappeared, without a trace, I wouldn't call it ordinary either." Kobra lifts an eyebrow at the cat. "Do you think your family is alive?"

The question catches Catra off guard, she didn't think about this possibility. For some reason, she already pronounced them dead in her head.

"I don't know. I... Never thought about that." Catra says looking down at the destroyed city. "Family was something I didn't know before, I don't know what to do with the fact that I could have someone out there."

"Hm? You didn't have anyone in the Horde either?"

Catra's mind wanders to Adora. *Of course* Adora. The girl was always there for her since they were kids since Catra could remember. Adora was a warm ray of warmth in the constant rainy days, a gentle hug after the harsh slaps, cheerful laugh after tears. Adora was her safe place, her haven where she could run to and be herself. The little broken girl she grew up to be. And Adora was broken too, by the same hands, maybe not the same way Catra was, but Adora was too. They understood each other perfectly, knew how to calm down the other, how to comfort and love. Or at least Catra thinks they knew.

Looking back, they had no idea what they did. Catra didn't. She still doesn't.

"No."

The single word rolls off her tongue easily, lying was always easy. Pushing away the pain was always easier than facing it.

Kobra says nothing after that, just looking at Catra with a weird look as if she doesn't believe in her words or knows better. If she noticed Catra's shaking hands that curled into a ball of fist, she said nothing. They just walk side by side.

To Catra's biggest surprise, she finds Huntara at the end of the stares, sitting with her knife cutting into some kind of fruit and eating it. She stops a few levels up, looking down at her, Kobra skipping down.

Huntara notices Catra's looming figure over her, she looks up at the catgirl. "Oh, you are back from the crypt. How was it?"

Catra is confused. There is no better way to put it.

Why are these people like this? Why do they care for Catra? Kobra would always tag along with her, except when Catra would explicitly say she wants to be alone, then the snake would disappear without question. Huntara is there looking out for her, always making sure she is okay, especially after a crypt visit. She makes sure Catra eats at least twice a day and that those meals

are not the grey ration bars they have found stacked in the Horde supply room. They ask her about the crypt, about memories. Never about the Horde. She also knows Huntara started to ask around for any information about the kingdom which used to thrive here.

Her mind constantly tells her, *they are seeing you weak, incapable of doing your job. They think you are weak. You are weak. You are nothing.*

But is she?

Is she weak? Is she nothing?

She survived in the Crimson Waste alone for 3 months, fighting her way through the days and coming out on top. She survived the Horde, the pain she has faced. She isn't weak or incapable.

There are moments when their caring is something Catra needs, to someone to ask her if she is okay, or if she is alright. Even if she would lie, the fact that someone cares somehow enough. Other times she lashes at them, storming away angrily and breaking down in the shadows of her room.

She can't trust anyone, her mind whispers to her. *They would just leave, like Adora, Shadow Weaver, Scorpia. They would abandon her too. There's no loyalty, there's no friendship.* She should be only trusting in herself and no one else.

But the last time she listened to these voices, she almost destroyed the whole world.

The last time she listened to these words, she had set half of Etheria on fire as she conquered it.

The last time she listened to the mean side of her mind, she pushed away someone who cared about her, someone who had faith in her when everyone else was already casting Catra down.

Maybe.

Maybe it's not Catra who is wrong, but the *voices*.

Catra takes a slow step down the stairs, reaching up and letting her down from the ponytail. "It was okay." She says shortly with a shrug. "I still couldn't find anything." Her feet touch the ground and she walks away, knowing that the other two would come with her.

Huntara pushes a fruit into her hand without a word, and Catra takes it. A silent routine they have developed, the catgirl has no idea what kind of fruit it is exactly. But it's really sweet and helps her feel just a little bit lighter in the soul. She doesn't know how that works, but that's probably the aftereffect of delicious foods.

"I actually have something that could lead us somewhere." Huntara mentions and Catra perk up at her curiously, munching on her fruit.

That was something they started to do too. Referred to this whole lost kingdom mess as theirs too. Not just Catra's. After a time Catra stopped correcting them.

"Let's hear it then!" Kobra says enthusiastically.

"An archaeologist used to come here often, he, for some reason, liked to search around this place. I don't know if he found the crypt or something else, but they said he could spend days out in the desert coming back as excited as a kid. He might know something about what happened." She sums up to them, Catra furrowing her brows deep in her thoughts.

"Where is this guy?"

"He lives in Moonlight, it's east from here."

"What's up with this place and their sky related names?" Catra groans, partly annoyed. Not like the Fright Zone had such a charming name.

Kobra laughs at her wholeheartedly. "Out of all the things, *that* is your biggest pet peeve here?"

"It just sounds stupid. That's it." Catra grumbles, eating the last piece of her fruit, throwing away the stump. "Is it under Horde control?"

Huntara thinks about it a little. "I didn't hear the Horde got it. It's a small oasis with a few residents."

"So when are we going?" Kobra leans into Catra's line of sight. "You know well without us you would get lost and probably get eaten by a three-headed snake." She says matter of factly.

Catra looks at her unimpressed, pushing the snake away by her face. "If you are not at the skiff when the last moon goes down I'm leaving you two here." She says walking away, her feet take her to the house where she currently lives.

It's a little above the ground house, not too big and doesn't have a lot of furniture, but it's enough for Catra. It's not like she had a lot of stuff before anyways. She closes the door with a sigh, letting the facade go, her headache pounding deeply making her wince.

Lately, she gets a lot of headaches followed by strange dreams or flashbacks to a place she has never seen.

"Probably just because of the heat." She reasons with herself, shedding her cloak down, putting it on the chair near her bed.

She looks out of the open window, the moonlight cascading into the room in a beautiful blue hue. Her tail sways around lazily, wrapping around her wrist.

There is this scenario, a little fantasy world in Catra's head. A what-if scenario. What if she had lived with her parents? What if she was never a Horde soldier? Would have she been happier? Would she turn out to be like this? Or a better version of herself.

Catra sighs, slowly taking off her dress, her gloves, top, thigh highs and pants, the gauze around her burn mark, leaving herself in her underwear as she plops down to her bed. She looks up at the ceiling, still hard to believe that almost four months ago she was a commander by Hordak's side. And now... Well, now she is a gang leader driving out the Horde from the waste and searching for the lost kingdom of the waste.

A turn for sure.

Catra's eyes become heavier with each passing second, the stillness of the night lulling her to sleep. She moves around with closed eyes, already half asleep as she curls around herself, her tail wrapping around herself.

Sometimes nightmares left her alone, other times her nights were dreamless, other times, however, when she was so tired, the control over her thought was weak. Her mind would dig deep into her heart showing her a life that she secretly wanted, but was afraid to tell it to herself. Tonight was like this too.

Catra's eyes opened, she was in a house she has never seen. Everything looked so warm and comforting, almost welcoming as if she just came home after a long time away. The room based on the light warmth of the morning, she tried to turn away from the light directly hitting her face. Catra blinked tiredly, feeling something warm wrapped around her.

She looked down and she saw Adora, snuggled close to her, the blonde's arm thrown over Catra's stomach, legs tangled under the warm blanket. Catra blinked, confused and shocked to see the girl

next to her, sleeping so soundly. Adora's face was so calm and content as if she was in the place she always wanted. Right next to Catra. Her blonde hair was all over the place, some sticking to her forehead.

Catra reached forward, gently moving the tendrils of blondes. Adora moved a little, opening her beautiful blue eyes that Catra could get lost for hours. They were so clear like Adora's soul.

Adora smiled at her, leaning closer, kissing her cheeks lovingly. Catra's heart stuttered, blush creeping over her cheeks.

"Good morning," Adora mumbled against her skin, laying her head to the catgirl's shoulder, tightening her hold around her. "Why are you up so early?" Adora wondered, blinking up at Catra.

Catra stayed silent, just looking down at Adora smiling softly. "The light... It woke me up." Catra frowned, turning to her side so she would be face to face with Adora. The blonde reached out to hold Catra's hand in between their bodies.

"Told you to draw the curtains last night." Adora giggled, Catra pouted at her. "You are cute."

Catra scoffed "Someone has to be in this relationship." In response, Adora pushed her away, Catra laughing at her with rosy cheeks.

"Oh yeah? Well then..." Adora slowly sits up with a smug smile on her face, pouncing on Catra tickling her, the room filled with Catra's shrieking laugh and Adora's snorty one.

They looked so different, happy, carefree, in love.

Catra stood at the door, looking down at the two with a sad glint in her eyes blinking away the swelling tears.

Could they ever be like this?

Adora. Adora looked so peaceful and calm. She doesn't know when was the last time she has ever seen the girl sleep so soundly.

And this warm feeling in her chest, she slowly raises her hand and puts it against her chest, feeling her heartbeat. It stutters when Adora leans closer and kisses the Catra in the bed, cupping her cheeks, stroking her cheekbones with so much affection.

Is this what she wants? A calm life? Happiness?

Adora?

Is it Adora what she wants?

What she always wanted?

The dreams freeze, slowly turning into dust and it's gone with the wind.

But it will always stay in Catra's heart, tucked away, like a heavy secret.

Catra is first at the skiff of course.

Just because she didn't have a nightmare that woke her up horrified it doesn't mean that she could actually rest. Exhaustion is still weighting her bones down and numb her mind, some days it's better. Some days it's worse. But she tries, and for her, that's the only thing that matters.

She tries to survive those nights or the moments where the worst memories would flash behind her eyes. Sometimes, Catra does wish these ghosts would just finally choke her and she would never have to deal with them. Other times, she is determined to win over them.

It's Huntara who comes second, Kobra waltzing in a few minutes after. Catra sits at the rail of the skiff waiting for them. They are not friends, at least Catra doesn't think, doesn't want it. They are... Partners. Yes. That sounds better. Partners who have the same goal, that's it. Nothing more.

"I was about to leave you two." Catra greets them, standing up on the rail then jumping back to the skiff. "Come on, we don't have all day."

"Did you eat?"

Huntara's question is expected. "Yeah, of course." As well as Catra's lie too.

"Let me drive," Kobra steps to the lever, but Catra is quick to shove her away. "Boss!"

"Last time you drove, you almost hit a rock. You sit down, and maybe you can navigate." She narrows her eyes on the snake.

Kobra huffs with crossed arms. "Fine." She sits down with a dramatic sigh. "Let's go darling then!"

Catra stops for a second looking at Kobra with surprised eyes at how she called her.

"Is everything okay?" Huntara comes to her vision with a concerned look.

"Yeah... Yeah, everything is okay. Get out of my face." She grumbles and ignites the skiff, driving away from the valley.

Kobra is actually navigating them, claiming she knows exactly where Moonlight is, Catra doubts it but says nothing. Not like she knows more about the waste. Yet. Huntara is by the rails, leaning against it looking ahead of themselves.

"What do you expect to find?"

Catra glances at Huntara, then ahead. "I don't really know. I obviously don't think he will know all of the answers, but... A starting point, I guess." she scowls, spitting away her hair which hits her face.

Huntara laughs at that. "Are you more... Interested in finding out about the kingdom or your family?"

"What's up with you two asking about my family?" She eyes Kobra and Huntara suspiciously, her tail lashing out. "It's nothing, I don't know anything about my family, and it's okay like that. For all, I know they could have given me to the Horde."

They didn't need you, threw you away. A monster like you.

Shadow Weaver's voice rings in her ears, she flattens them stubbornly as if this will leave the voice out.

She takes a deep breath, keeping it inside a little before slowly exhaling. She pushes away Shadow Weaver's memory. "This isn't about my family," the word is still a little foreign to her. "It's about knowing more about myself. For the longest time, I thought it was only me, but there were others too." Catra explains not looking at either of her companions.

Kobra hums at her answer, and Huntara simply nods.

"I'm curious about what he could tell us... I mean, if we could recover a lost kingdom, they would probably thank us generously." Kobra snickers to herself with that smug look.

"Why am I surprised that you are once again after money?" Huntara questions with a tired look.

"Excuse me, I need to live. Times are hard, and if a few royals want to give us a few sacks of cold I," She points at herself. "Not going to say no. You two can't either, but you can give me the money. I won't object, of course." She offers so graciously.

Catra laughs at her tactics, a smile reaching her eyes. "Such a generous soul."

"Practically a saint." Kobra agrees with a flip of her hair. "No, but seriously. If you don't need the money, I will take it."

"We will keep that in mind, Kobra."

The snake squints at Huntara. "Was that sarcastic?"

Catra just shakes her head, letting the two banter away their time while they arrive in Moonlight. As she looks at them, she remembers Scorpia and Entrapta. Their trip to the Southern Reach, the number of times they have spent their day hulled up in Entrapta's lab, Catra curiously eyeing Entrapta's newest creation while Scorpia and Entrapta were chatting enthusiastically about something, Catra didn't really pay attention. She regrets it. She wishes she knew what it was, so she could keep it as a memory too.

And Adora.

Her mind lately always ends up at Adora. No matter what happened throughout the years, it seems like Adora is still her safe place. Even if she is not here physically.

It's such a cruel thing, really. Catra tries to go against it, exhaust herself until her brain just can't work. But sometimes it doesn't work. It never really does.

She sighs, increasing the speed of the skiff a little bit. She needs to clear her head, this isn't about Adora, Scorpia or Entrapta. They shouldn't matter anymore, they all hate Catra, and the catgirl doesn't blame them for a bit.

It's about Catra now.

A part of her was always curious what she was, Shadow Weaver oftentimes called her a pet or animal, but there was really no name of what Catra was exactly. Or if others like her exist. She remembers asking Shadow Weaver about it once, when she was much younger and naive, thinking the sorcerer would answer. It didn't go as planned and Catra never asked more about her origin.

"We are close to Moonlight!" Kobra announces, standing up from the floor squinting into the distance. "See? You can see the oasis from here." She points ahead of them.

"It's... Smaller than I thought..." Catra lifts an eyebrow, only a few houses emerge from the sand.

They stop once they reach the oasis, turning the skiff off and jumping into the warm sand. It used to annoy Catra since half of her sole was uncovered, now she got used to it, and even enjoys the warmth radiating from the ground. She puts up her hood, just in case. Someone trying to cut off her ears and tail was perfectly enough, now she is just cautious. Her tail wraps around her belt.

Catra at some point expected some kind of life here, but everything looks like it's been abandoned for months. The doors are closed, windows too. The stillness of the village sets Catra's uneasiness off. She reached for her whip under her cloak, just in case. Huntara does the same.

The three look at each other for a brief moment.

"Is there someone?" Catra raises her voice, stepping ahead of the other two. "We are not here to hurt anyone... We just want to talk with the archaeologist who lives here!" She stops at one of the houses.

"Hello! Anyone here!" Kobra tries too, then huffs annoyed. "Don't tell me we just came here for nothing."

Catra's ear twitches under her hood, picking up a faint noise from the house next to her. Her head snaps towards it, her mismatched eyes narrow. She steps closer, at the door. For a moment she simply plans barging in and demanding answers, but instead, she knocks softly on the wood.

"I know someone is in there. I can hear you." Her voice comes out much friendlier than she has expected. "We really need to speak with that man, I... Please?"

The door opens a little, revealing two pairs of green eyes looking at Catra.

"Who are you?" The voice asks, unsure and afraid.

Catra looks back at Huntara and Kobra who are watching her with anticipation.

She turns back to the pair of green eyes. "I"m C., I'm... I'm not going to hurt you, I just need to speak with him. Do you know if he is here?"

The green eyes sweep up and down on Catra, taking her form in - or what it can see from the cloak - then it snaps back to Catra again. The silence stretches between them, and no matter how patient Catra wants to be, she is really close to just snap and kick down that damn door.

"Why do you want to speak to my father?"

"About the lost kingdom here in the waste."

"And why?"

Catra's eye visibly twitches at that. She forces the door open eventually, revealing the man behind the door, who was knocked down to the ground. "Look, I don't really have the patience to deal with your bitching. Where is your father?" Catra hisses at him impatiently.

The two outside quickly follow her in, towering over the man still sitting on the ground with a dropped jaw.

Kobra leans to Catra. "I think you scared him, boss" She whispers.

"Shut up, I did not."

"B-bandits! You are just bandits!" He points at them with shaking hands. "Oh, I knew father would eventually get into trouble!"

Catra sighs, closing her eyes counting back from five to one before she would punch the guy. Twice.

Instead, Huntara steps forward, grabbing the man by the back of his clothes and lifting him into the air with ease. The warrior lady smirks at him, the man lets out a terrified squeak.

"We are not here to attack you, my friend said it already." Huntara reasons with him, still keeping him up in the air.

"She barged into my house!"

"Because you kept asking stupid questions!" Catra snaps at him. "I want to speak to your father, not you!"

"I don't believe in you!"

Catra's patience wears out at this moment. Kobra just giggles at the background not even trying to calm down Catra. The catgirl holds onto the man's collar, yanking him towards her, the mismatched eyes are narrowed down on him. "Listen here you little shit, if you don't want to be the dinner of my three-headed snake, you will answer my questions." She threatens him with a growl.

The man just nods furiously begging Catra to not do it. The snake is a lie, but who cares. It works.

Catra lets go of him the same moment Huntara does too, so he lands on his ass again.

"You don't even have a three-headed snake." Huntara comments, amused.

The man looks scandalized, hurrying to his legs. "You've lied to me!" She yells at Catra.

Catra points her claw at his neck. "Boohoo," She rolls her eyes. "Now speak."

"And if you think you can run away or fight with us, I have to break down your plan." Kobra muses behind Catra with a sharp smile.

The man looks at the three women in the room, he is afraid that's clear from the way his body shakes and eyes them with caution. The silence grows once again, Catra pushes her claw against his neck as a reminder.

"Okay! Okay. I will... I will tell you what you want, my... Uhm, my father is in a ruin, he should return soon... I.. Just, don't hurt him... Or me. Not me." He stutters over his words.

"What ruin?"

"A Magicat one." He answers quickly.

Catra blinks in confusion. "A what?"

"A... A Magicat ruin, they... They were the ones who ruled this place before it became waste."

Catra shares a look with Huntara, she pushes her hood down revealing her black ears, her tail peaks out under the cloak. The man gasps in surprise.

"Like me? Is this what a Magicat is?" Catra questions urgently.

The man needs another claw on his skin to recover from his shock. "Uhm... Y-yeah, but... But we didn't... They have... Magicats disappeared."

Catra raises an eyebrow, yeah, that's evident from the lack of rambling Magicats in the waste. She retracts her claws, letting the man free.

"That's pretty clear. But where are they?"

The man shakes his head. "I... I don't know, my father knows much more about the Magicats... Uhm, he studied them in the past 35 years."

"Ohhh, that's good news!" Kobra cheers at that, stepping next to Catra. "What now boss?"

Catra thinks about it a little, eventually, she walks to the table, getting a chair for herself and sits down, crossing her leg. "We are going to wait." She says simply, picking up dirt from underneath her claws. "You said he will come back soon."

The man nods feverishly. "Y-yes... He always comes back before noon."

"What's your name?" Kobra asks then, curiously. She plops herself down on the table instead.

"Dolan."

"So Dolan, tell me. Is there a chance that these Magicat royals are alive? And have money?"

Huntara deadpans at Kobra's question and Catra sighs. Already tired.

"W-what?" Dolan looks at the snake, confused.

"Don't pay attention to her, she will stop if you ignore her," Huntara tells him, sitting down on a chair too.

"That's rude," Kobra comments with a scowl.

Catra closes her eyes, tipping her head back a bit. By now she has become an absolute master of filtering out Kobra and Huntara, so she just lets them bicker like they always do. Instead, she focuses on the part where Dolan said Magicats have disappeared. It brings up several questions in her, where could they go, why? And why do just a handful of people know what a Magicat is?

Huntara and Kobra had lived in the waste for such a long time and they had no idea? That's a little absurd. Their disappearance shouldn't be recent if only some know or the waste is littered with their ruins. Most of them must have been already robbed or discovered by people like Dolan's father.

Still, a kingdom can't disappear into nothingness without a trace or a clue.

And where is their runestone? They are massive and only the royal family can have any power over them, as far as Catra knows. But then there was Shadow Weaver who was able to tap into the Black Garnet.

"Dolan, son, I'm home!"

Catra opens her eyes at the voice, turning her attention to the door which opens revealing a man with silver hair and cloak around his body, a half-moon glass sits on his nose. His arrival gained the other's attention too, and when the old man finally notices the three new pairs of eyes that look at him he, understandably, freaks out.

"Bandits?! Dolan quick, bring the axe!"

Dolan is about to actually move, but Kobra grabs onto him, yanking him back to the floor.

The catgirl sighs. "No, why do-"

"Oh by the Moons, am I... am I seeing it right? A.. A *Magicat*? In my home? A living Magicat? Oh my-oh my. That's a discovery!" He

hurries to Catra with such enthusiasm it freaks Catra out instantly, climbing away from him to Huntara's shoulder.

"Get away from me old man!" She hisses at him, her tail before it wraps around her body.

The old man seems to realize his mistake and clears his throat. "Pardon my behaviour, but... I've never seen a living specimen of a Magicat!" He looks up at Catra like she is made out of gold, which should be a little bit flattering but Catra just wants to punch him.

"Well, he quickly forgot about the bandits part." Huntara points out, not fazed by a crouching Catra on her shoulder. "We have some questions about Magicats, we hoped you could help us."

"Your son was so kind, he let us in too." Kobra beams, Dolan saying that they barged into the house. "That's a different point of view. Anyways."

"Of course I could help! You know, nowadays not a lot of people are interested in the Magicat culture or who they were," He tells them while he searches around the little space in the house, he brings a bunch of papers, papyrus and notebooks with himself dumping them to the table. "But I truly think they had one the most fascinating kingdoms ever! Somehow they managed to supply every city from their main city, the oasis in their time were third the size and not to mention, their runestone was one of the oldest."

By now Catra climbed down from Huntara's shoulder standing next to the old man, peering over the papers. That's a lot of information for sure. She doesn't show it or tries to control it, but Catra for such a long time is excited. She could finally hear something about her kind, her culture.

"But no matter how hard I studied their ruins, writings or whatever they have left behind, I've never met with a Magicat." He turns to Catra. "I'm truly sorry how I acted a minute ago." He

smiles sheepishly. "If I can help you with anything, let me know please."

Catra narrows her eyes on him. "You don't even know what I want." Catra lifts an eyebrow.

"Well then, tell me."

"I want to know what happened to them, where they are... And why have I never seen someone like me, why have people never seen someone like me?" Catra wonders loudly, narrowing her eyes. "There must be an explanation."

The archaeologist nods. "I am willing to help you."

Catra huffs. "You only want to help because I'm a Magicat, right?"

"I can't deny that partly it's true, yes. But I'm also curious why I couldn't find anyone like you before, I travelled far and wide in the Crimson Waste, I've lived here my whole life."

"I grew up in the Horde." She explains it simply. "I never knew there were others like me."

At the mention of the Horde, both Lon and Dolan look at the catgirl with wary eyes. Catra just waves her hand. "I'm not a soldier anymore."

The archaeologist nods, relieved. "I may have a deal for you, young Magicat and her friends. I will help you in whatever you need, if, in exchange, I can observe your behaviour."

"What?"

"Not in an offensive way! I'm sorry my wording was wrong. We don't know how Magicats are behaving, how they live or what kind of powers and abilities they have. If you help me fill in the blanks of my research, I will help you too." He offers to her sincerely.

"Well... Not like there is anyone who knows much about them. Okay, I'm in." She agrees.

"Father, they might not be the best to have a de-" Dolan's voice dies down the moment he sees how Huntara looks at him from behind Catra. "Yeah, you know what... Forget it." He laughs nervously. "They are very kind."

The old man looks at his son with a furrowed brow, then turns back to Catra. "I'm Lon, it's an honour to meet with you."

"C.," She points at herself. "Huntara and Kobra." She introduces the other two.

"Oh, perhaps a code name?."

Catra just shrugs. "Perhaps. Now tell me something about the Magicats."

Lon reaches out to a rolled-up paper and he unfolds it, it's a map. A very old one, and quite different than what Catra has ever seen. They all huddle closer to the table.

"A few years ago I found this map in a tucked away ruin. It seems they had a different fauna many many years ago, instead of desert, the kingdom was rich with forests and mountains. It also appears it was called Halfmoon originally, not Crimson Waste. I guess after everything died down the name changed too." He pushes his glass up.

"What do you mean everything started to die out?" Huntara asks, looking up at Lon.

"Well, from what I gathered it appears one day the main city, Halfmoon has disappeared with the runestone too. That happened around 500-600 years ago, minimum, after that the kingdom started to die out." He explains it, taking a notebook, opening it hastily showing them his notes and calculations. "It seems their runestone has kept everything alive, supplied it with magic."

"Well, that's unfortunate." Kobra comments. "And no one has seen any Magicat since then?"

"Not that I know." Lon answers. "Until now." He looks at Catra.

Catra looks down at the map still, deep in her thoughts. "That sounds kind of absurd and unbelievable."

"Right?!" Lon asks enthusiastically. "It was always strange for me, then! I found a writing a few weeks ago, it was torn and very damaged, but what I could exterminate from that is the Magicats hid away from the world. With their city and runestone! Isn't that just mind-blowing?"

"I guess?" Catra blinks.

"You don't understand, C." He shakes his head. "If it's true if the Magicats hid away, it means that you shouldn't be here either. It means that someone has either found them *or* they do walk among us." He points it out. "How did you get to the Horde?"

"I... I don't know." She furrows her brows. "My memories start with the Horde... I was always a Horde soldier..."

"Interesting. Interesting." He mumbles to himself.

"Not really," Huntara says offhandedly, Lon doesn't comment on that. "Why does it matter anyway?"

"Oh... Well, I hate to suggest but it means C. was either taken or given to the Horde." He concludes cautiously. "Or her ancestors lived outside of Halfmoon for a long time, but I never heard about Magicats living anywhere in Etheria."

"Just because you didn't hear about them it doesn't mean they don't exist." Catra snaps at Lon harshly. She then takes a deep breath pushing her hair down. "I'm sorry." She mumbles. "It's just..."

"I understand, you want to get answers."

"What more do you know about them?" Kobra breaks the awkward silence that settled on the room. "No record on where they have gone?"

Lon shakes his head. "It seems they have kept it as a secret. I assume for times like this... They wanted to stay hidden."

"And what if there are no other Magicats? If it's really me who is the last one?" Catra questions, from herself or Lon it's unclear.

"I'm sorry, but it's a possibility too." Lon turns to her.

Silence settles on the room again.

Catra settles down reading the notes and the papers, they don't offer her a lot of knowledge. Mostly speculations about how did Magicats live, their relation with other kingdoms, some scribble about their mysterious runestone that no one knows if it's active or not anymore.

Are Magicats still alive or are we searching for a kind that does not exist anymore?

She stares at the scribbled down the question in Lon's old notebook.

Truth to be told, Catra doesn't know what to believe. Are they alive, still hiding? Or dead? Was she given to the Horde? Was Shadow Weaver right or was she stolen from her parents? But then, how? No one has found Halfmoon in centuries.

She sighs, rubbing her tired eyes. It's already darkening outside. They should go back now. Catra looks back and sees Huntara sitting on the floor reading too, while Kobra is outside enjoying the remaining warmth what the sand can give to her. Lon and Dolan are outside.

"We should head back, Huntara," Catra says, standing up from the table. "We couldn't find much."

Huntara looks up at her. "Are you sure you don't want to dig deeper?"

"Maybe a little later, it was... A lot." She confesses. "I don't know what I expected, but certainly not this. Anyways, let's go." Catra shuts down the topic fairly quickly, turning around and walking out. Her tail wraps around her again, an act of comfort. "Let's go Kobra."

"Are you going already?" Lon questions, sitting outside of a bench.

Catra looks back at him, she sees other people too around, probably the rest of the residents living here.

"Yes, but..." Catra stops herself, should she tell him about the crypt? Could he find something that Catra couldn't? "I've found a crypt, a Magicat one. Come tomorrow to the valley, I want you to take a look." She tells him, and the old man's eyes lit up like a little kid's.

"A crypt?! Did you find a crypt?! How?? Oh by the moons, that's going to be wonderful! I will be at the valley, do not worry C.!" He promises and for once, Catra doesn't doubt it.

She nods at him. "Thank you, Lon." Then, she walks towards their skiff.

Kobra in her toes, Huntara too.

"So?" Kobra pokes her shoulder. "What is the conclusion of today?"

Catra says nothing this time, no matter how hard Kobra is staring at her with her slit yellow eyes. The catgirl doesn't answer.

"Leave her Kobra," Huntara speaks, stepping into the skiff, taking up the driver's position now.

Catra sits down on the floor, closing her eyes, leaning back against the side. She let the gentle wind of the darkening night

calm her down; she didn't even notice how fast her heart was beating. She can hear Kobra and Huntara changing a few words, but the gentle rock of the skiff and the wind slowly lulls her to sleep.

The walls of Halfmoon reach up to the enchanted sky where stars are twinkling and the moons are shining brightly. A melodious laugh echoes through the garden of the royal palace, moonflowers and roses are blooming beautifully.

"Momma! Mom! Look!" A little girl runs towards two beautiful women sitting under the moonlight, a boy curled between them, sleeping soundly.

One of the women turns, her red hair braided together, a headpiece decorating her forehead. Her blue eyes lined with red and gold, her ears pierced with numerous earrings, her clothing is simply white and gold, not so intricate like she dresses when she is in the throne room.

"C'yra, darling." She smiles, reaching out for the little girl.

The girl, C'yra, takes her hand, plopping down in her mom's lap. She shows an orange flower, with red dots around the middle. The little girl's mane stands in every direction and her blue dress is a little muddy at the ends.

"I never see this flower! What is it?" She looks up at her mothers with her big mismatched eyes.

"It's a tiger lily, sweetheart." The other woman speaks to her, brushing through C'yra messy hair, the little girl starts purring instantly.

"Like our stone, momma?" C'yra blinks adorably.

Her momma nods smiling down at the little girl. She has short hair, the colour matches with C'yra's perfectly almost, she has expressive golden eyes filled with love and warmth. Her clothes match with her wife's, a relaxing garment for the early night spent with their family, the headpiece hangs on her forehead too.

The Queens of Halfmoon.

"When can I see it?" C'yra asks absentmindedly playing with her mom's tail that moves up and down, the jewellery clinking together.

Her mom chuckles, leaning down to kiss her daughter's cheeks. "When you turn 10, darling."

"But that's too looooooong." She draws out the syllables, snagging back against her mom's chest. She huffs adorably. "Can't I see it now?"

"No." her momma smiles at her, bopping her nose. "That's a tradition. I could only see it too when I turned 10."

"That's stupid." She mumbles, wrapping her mom's tail around herself. "Can we stay with the stars?" She peers up at the woman.

"Of course."

C'yra smiles at her, climbing out of her mom's lap and settling down next to her brother's, looking up at the sky. Stargazing was always C'yra's favourite. Her parents told her stories about them all the time, her favourite was when a little star came to Etheria and showed magic to people, she could listen to that story for the hundredth time and never get bored.

Her eyes eventually close down, she hears the lullaby her momma would sing to her. She curls into a little ball, hugging her tail close to her chest, falling to sleep.

Catra wakes up with a pounding headache hammering her brain, wanting to split her skull into two. She groans sitting up, brushing her bangs up. She looks around, puzzled seeing that she is in her room.

"Huntara must have brought me up." She guesses without much care.

Catra turns and gets out of the bed, everything is just too hot and too suffocating. She walks to the window, opening up to let in the cool air of the night, she takes a deep breath. It's a little better.

Then, she remembers the dream.

Or at least at the stars, the blue eyes and the lily. Nothing more.

Another wave of pain floods her head, she hisses in pain. The more she tries to remember the worse the pain gets. Catra turns and walks to her cabinet, searching for the root that could cease her pain, but finds none.

"Fuck." She curses, closing the door harshly, pushing her back against the cool wall.

At least staying like this helps a little, she closes her eyes taking a deep breath until it starts to get duller. It doesn't go away, but at least it isn't a sharp pain.

Her mind is a mess, everything that happened in the past two weeks is just too much for her to process. The questions, the speculations. It's too much for Catra right now. Living in uncertainty.

Was she given away? Was Shadow Weaver right all along? Did Shadow Weaver even know what she was? Are her parents alive? What the fuck happened with Halfmoon?

The headache gets worse each moment she thinks more about what Lon has said and then the dream. What was that? A flashback? A crafted memory out of desperation?

What's happening?

She feels sickness creeping up, her stomach flips and cold sweat covers Catra's body. With weak legs, Catra tries to stand up and climbs out of her window desperate for air. She takes a deep breath then climbs up to her rooftop.

The cold breeze of the desert makes her shiver, it's at least grounding on some level.

Time blurs as Catra sits outside with closed eyes, trying to calm down. She picks on her skin absentmindedly, at some point her claws slowly start to scratch her arm, leaving faint red lines.

Behind herself, she hears a noise, her ears picking it up quickly. She knows the scent.

"What do you want Kobra?"

"Just checking on you, boss." Kobra sits down, a little behind Catra. They sit in silence, but the snake's presence makes her uneasy. "Why did you come to the waste?" Kobra's voice startles Catra, she turns around way too quickly, stars are dancing in her vision.

Kobra just sits there filing her nails. "I mean, come on, everyone who comes here has something in their mind. They want to run

away, hide, even search for someone." She mentions with an amused chuckle. "Die. What did bring you here, *Darling*? I mean you could have gone anywhere, yet you chose the waste."

Catra needs a few minutes to fully understand the question, so tired even to get angry. "I'm not here for anything."

Kobra doesn't even try to hide her smirk away, sitting up walking towards Catra. "I think… You are trying to run away. But from what? The fact that you failed everyone?" She crouches down. "Or the fact that you are such a coward you can't even look into the mirror and face yourself. Because you Kitten," She touches Catra's cheeks gently, then grabbing her jaw. "so full of hate and pity towards yourself you don't even see what your choices caused to the world."

Catra snarls at the snake, slapping her hands away clumsily and pushes the snake against the floor, her arm against Kobra' neck. The snake, however, doesn't seem to faze.

"Don't act like you know anything about me," Catra says slowly, still panting staring into Kobra's eyes with her own narrow ones. "Don't speak as you know me. You, Huntara… Anyone, you know nothing about me."

Kobra chuckles, her eyes lighting up with amusement. And suddenly, her body is enveloped by dark green magic, revealing another body, another face. Catra gasps, stepping away. "Double Trouble?"

The shapeshifter smirks at her. "It took a while but I think I finally figured out your character." In a matter of seconds, they took Catra's form, stepping closer to her. "You try so hard to play the *big bad villain* but your heart has never been it, has it?" Their voice shifts from light to low and hard, the words punching Catra in the stomach, making her sick.

"Stop!" She demands weakly, stepping back.

Double Trouble takes another form. “People have hurt you, they didn’t believe in you “Shadow Weaver looks down at her, white eyes forming into Hordak’s red ones “Didn’t trust you.”

A hand reaches out for Catra’s, and in the next second her palm is pressed against Adora’s cheeks. ”Didn’t need you, left you.” They say cruelly.

Catra rips her hand away with a horrified gasp, tumbling back falling, Double Trouble reverts to their true form. ”But did you ever stop to think they are not the problem?” The question is a harsh slap to Catra.

“It’s you;” Scorpia stands before Catra. “you drive them away, Wildcat.”

“Why… Why are you doing this?” Her hands sneak around herself along with her tail, her whole body is shaking on the verge of tears.

Double Trouble crouches down to Catra. “Because Darling, you could do so much more, but you are drawing yourself down. It’s pain to watch, and concerning. I said the truth, however, we could help each other.” The shapeshifter offers their hand to Catra. “You are not meant to be drowned, Darling, it’s time for *you* to see it."

“What…”

“Oh, please. Without you, the Horde wouldn’t even move an inch.” at the mention of the Horde Catra winces. “You have successfully plummeted the Horde, became one of the apex predators in the Crimson Waste under 3 months and survived. You have so much to offer, why do you let them drown you?” Double Trouble asks, and Catra suddenly feels like the shapeshifter is in her brain, knowing well how she struggles with it.

“Leave me alone!” She gets up to her feet, panic in her eyes. “Get out of my head! You know nothing… I… No one is drowning me!”

Double Trouble looks at her blankly, clearly not believing her.“Really? How are your nightmares? Your panic attacks? Your constant desire to throw yourself into situations that can cost your life? The fact that you would happily die?”

Catra is rendered speechless, just looking at Double Trouble with wild glossy eyes, feeling like her whole soul has been just ripped out and pulled open. The shapeshifter reads her so easily, it scares her.

“Why are you so afraid to let go of your pain, Kitten?”

She is unable to answer, she doesn’t know what to say. She slides down to the ground again, pushing her bangs back, tears falling.

The shapeshifter goes and sits down in front of Catra. “Darling, I’m not here to hurt you. It’s you who is hurting yourself”

Catra hates how Double Trouble can see into her. How easy it is for them to see the most vulnerable part of her, and call out on her own bullshit and pain. Because yes, Catra knows she throws herself into situations when she can die. That’s why she started to fight, that’s why she didn’t care if Hordak would have killed her.

“I..”

But Catra can’t utter out a single word, instead, she curls into herself letting herself go and breaking down again in sobs.

It takes time for Catra to calm down, and come to her senses. The shapeshifter sits by her side, silently. They say nothing, even after Catra just stares down the valley with tired bloodshot eyes for minutes now.

"Did you follow me?" Catra eventually breaks the silence, her voice is tired.

"Oh, absolutely.” The shapeshifter nods. “It was fairly easy, especially after your appearance in that little village. You surprised

me, kitten. Wouldn't have thought that you would help them." Double Trouble lifts an eyebrow at Catra.

The catgirl turns away from them, bringing one leg up to her chest. "She was just a kid..."

"Yes, but that didn't stop you before." They point it out.

Catra furrows her eyebrows, her brain working through the fog. "I just helped, okay? It wasn't a big deal. Can we skip through that?"

"And you helped with the valley and Southern Star."

"Can you stop?"

"And you are planning to help Venus too."

"Double Trouble."

"I'm proud of you, kitten."

Catra was ready to push the shapeshifter off the roof, but their words surprise her more than anything. She blinks at them with wide eyes, thinking, expecting a mocking laugh or an insult, but it doesn't come.

"What?" Catra eventually asks.

Double Trouble stretches a little, leaning back on their hands. "Well, you have grown since the last time I've seen you. The Catra from 4 months ago probably would have punched me in the face if I tried to say something like this."

"I'm still thinking about it."

"I'm feeling a little unwelcomed here." The shapeshifter scoots away. "Healing is not easy, darling, but it's worth it."

"Will they ever stop?" Catra whispers. "I mean... The nightmares and the… The panic attacks…"

"Maybe they do, maybe not. I don't know the answer. You have a long journey ahead, but we are here."

Catra glances at them, Double Trouble looks at her with a small smile.

"I said what I said, darling. I'm here to help you, I'm quite fond of you, so feel special. Also, Huntara has a soft spot for you, so you have two supporters. Your welcome."

Catra chuckles lightly, turning away from Double Trouble. "Thank you."

“And of course discovering a rich old kingdom also has its benefits too.”

“I’m going to push you down the roof.”

you are still here

Chapter Summary

"I miss you."

Chapter Notes

A new chapter is here! Hope you will enjoy ♥

There are calm days in the valley and there are chaotic ones.

Today, choose to be the latter.

It wasn't enough that the far eastern side of the valley suffered a small explosion this dawn, because some idiot didn't look through the field before moving around anything. It was lovely waking it up, really, Catra was delightful. On top of that, some rival gang put out a price to the whole Frosaken's head, the moment Catra came out of her house one of the members welcomed her with this news.

"Boss, look."

The catgirl barely could react before the piece of paper was shoved into her face. With a groan she took it away, looking at the WANTED sign and the 1000 gold coins as the reward. Catra just scowled at it, crumbling up the paper then throwing away.

"We are worth more than 1000 gold. Only bother me with it if we pass 10 000 or something."

And now, Catra stands at the opening of the valley, her arms crossed and an eyebrow lifted in both question and confusion. She was just woken up from her morning nap, her brain still needing some time to catch up on things. Double Trouble is next to her, looking equally as confused as the catgirl.

"What is this Huntara?" Catra eventually asks.

"This is something called a sand slide," Huntara tells them, patting the vehicle with a proud smile. "Found them a little bit over here, they seemed to be abandoned so I took them. They are very practical for longer travel and we don't waste the fuel of the skiff either." She explains them, Double Trouble nodding along with it, seemingly interested.

Catra takes this sand slide into account.

It's made out of wood completely, the underside of it is smooth, so it could easily slide against the sand. It's quite spacious, it could fit the three of them and maybe two more people too, on the three sides there's a rail to prevent anyone or anything from falling off.

"That's quite a smart idea." Double Trouble smiles, hopping to the slide to look at it closer.

"Who are you again?" Huntara looks at them with an unsure look.

"Oh, pardon me. I'm Double Trouble, you know me as Kobra." They grin at Huntara.

"They are a shapeshifter," Catra explains shortly. "And don't worry, we have a history from the Horde. They are not a danger to us unless someone offers money."

Double Trouble takes a dramatic gasp, clutching their chest. "You hurt my pride."

"How does this thing move?" Catra ignores the shapeshifter and turns to Huntara instead.

"With a three-headed snake, usually... Although one time I've seen a slide hauled by a pair of desert foxes." Huntara scratches her chin thinking.

"We don't have three-headed snakes or desert foxes, Huntara." Catra points it out flatly."You two." She snaps her fingers looking

back at two gang members. "Bring this inside, quickly." She points at the sand slides.

"That's why we are going to go and get one for ourselves." Huntara grins at Catra excitedly.

Catra blinks up at her. "Yeah, no." and with that, she turns around ready to walk away.

"Don't be like this kitten!" Double Trouble steps in front of her, being cautious not to touch her, just hold up their arm. "This will be fun, you've never really seen the wild of the Crimson Waste anyways. Let Huntara and me show it to you." They say smugly.

"Do I have to remind you that I was thrown here once and made it out alive? With a gang behind my back? I know everything from the waste." Catra scoffs cockily.

"It doesn't sound like that to me."

Catra narrows her eyes on Double Trouble, who just grins at her with a doubtful look. "Huntara! We are going for that snake!" Catra hisses turning around, almost slapping Double Trouble with her tail. She trots away, grumbling passing Huntara.

The warrior lady just blinks at the shapeshifter. "Is this some kind of secret method?"

"Just play with her ego." They wave their hands.

"I can hear you two!" Catra shouts back at them, already out of the valley looking back at them, hand on her hip. "Come on, we have an archaeologist visitor in a few hours."

"Do you even know where we can find three-headed snakes?" Huntara questions walking next to Catra.

The catgirl looks up with a confused look. "Don't they just lay around at random places?"

"Of course not." Double Trouble deadpans. "They like it where the sand is a little deeper and warmer than usual, so they can hide and eventually eat their victim." They explain it to Catra, picking their nail. "Luckily for you, there is a place like this near." The smug smile from them and the low chuckle from Huntara doesn't soothe her nerves.

Turns out, Huntara and Double Trouble share a lot of experience with three-headed snakes, Catra just listens to them tentatively, making mental notes on what not to do or what to do around them. It's just like getting ready for a fight, get to know your opponents and since they are going to be in their territory Catra needs to be careful.

"I actually used to have one, when I came to the Crimson Waste," Huntara remembers with a nostalgic smile. "But I, unfortunately, lost her in a bet." She shrugs. "I never really learned how to ride them, so it wasn't such a waste."

"Wait-" Catra stops, her tail swaying excitedly. "You can ride a three-headed snake?" At this point, she is sure that her pupils have blown out, and a soft purr rumbles in her chest.

Huntara and Double Trouble share a look at that.

"Yeah?"

Catra grabs onto Double Trouble, almost yanking them towards her. "And you only say it now?!"

"I mean, it's not that easy, they are pretty wild-" Double Trouble tries to explain, struggling against Catra's strain. "Uhm, would you let me go? You are stretching my dress out."

Catra lets them go. "I want a snake!" She announces.

"That's why we are out here?" Huntara blinks at her.

"Yeah-yeah for the slide, but I need one for *myself* ." She points at herself. "If I knew sooner I would have already tamed one,

huh." Catra walks ahead of them, reaching for her hair tie and soon her mane is in a ponytail. "Let's go." She smirks confidently, looking into the mass of deserted land.

Turns out, nothing is easy in the Crimson Waste.

Catra learnt it the hard way or is still learning because each time she thinks she has mastered the waste and every wonder it hides, she is proven wrong. Like right now as she spits out sand, growling at a three-headed snake she has been tussling in the past 30 minutes, Huntara and Double Trouble sitting on a rock watching the catgirl with amusement in their eyes.

The snake spits towards Catra venomously, Catra hisses back jumping at the snake, catching herself on their middle head quickly climbing up. She gets her whip, looping it around the snake's mouth as it opens their mouth, Catra pulls back, trying to regain control over the head while the two side head tries to get her without much success.

Catra actually laughs, excitement sparking in her blood. She feels in her element once again. No, it's better than those pitty animations they were given as a practice during their cadet years.

The snake shakes their head vehemently, trying to get Catra down, but the catgirl doesn't budge. Eventually, the snake knocks their head together hard and they are shaking their heads. Catra just pats the head of the snake she is sitting at.

What surprises even Catra is that she enjoys it. The tussle and the wrestling, yes is a little annoying, but she enjoys being like this even for a few minutes. Without a worry, care of her looming dark past sitting on her shoulder.

The snake doesn't move, seemingly done fighting with Catra. The catgirl gets her whip back and jumps down in front of the snake. With a hand on her hip, she looks up at the snake, lifts an eyebrow at the animal. The snake towers over her, probably another 1 or 2 meters above Catra.

"Are we done, big guy?" She asks, amused.

The snake lowers both of their three heads, and Catra pats each of them.

"I will call you Fang."

"That was impressive," Huntara tells her, walking towards the catgirl and the snake. "Do you want to get the next one too for the slide?"

Catra scowls. "No, I had enough sand getting into my mouth and ears." She grimaces, her ears are jerking a little. It will be a nightmare getting the sand out and she already dreads it.

"It's okay, you did a great job already. I wouldn't think that you would be able to get this one, to be honest." Huntara looks at Fang, then back to Catra.

"My speciality is proving people wrong." Catra flashes her a grin, then walking up to where Double Trouble sits, plopping down next to the shapeshifter. Fang follows her, curling around them easily.

Catra shakes her head a little, getting the sand out of her hair too. "Hm? What?"

"Nothing. It was entertaining seeing you getting hauled by a snake." Double Trouble snickers, Catra pushes them down from the rock. "Hey!"

Huntara stayed behind working up with another three-headed snake that appeared from the sand. It looks similar to Fang, just their shade is a little different and the snake is overall bigger. Catra lets out her hair, her mane is getting wild again. Maybe she should cut it a little.

"You looked like you enjoyed it." Double Trouble comments, sitting on the warm sand.

Catra smiles a little at that, bringing her knees to her chest, curling her tail around herself. "Yeah. It was fun."

“How do you feel?”

Catra shrugs, adjusting around the rock until she sits cross-legged. “I’m okay. I didn’t have nightmares.”

“That’s good.”

“Are you going to be my therapist or something?” Catra looks at the shapeshifter with a scowl.

Double Trouble stares at her with wide eyes. “Oh, moons, no. I’m just trying to make sure you are okay and don’t hurt yourself.”

Catra says nothing. She subconsciously draws her hand back until they rest on her lap, hiding the inner part from the world.

“I’m okay.” She announces, stubbornly. They drop the topic.

What gets their attention is the nearing sound of a motor roaring. Catra turns back, seeing a skiff gliding towards them. She isn't worried, it's not a Horde soldier. They could recover more skiff from what the Horde has left behind and survived the explosion.

"Boss! Boss! There's someone who wants to talk with you!"

Someone from the gang shouts for her. With a sigh, Catra stands up her tail lashes around a little. The skiff soon stops in front of them.

"What happened?"

"An old man is searching for you, boss. He said you are waiting for him." The lizard man explains it to her hurriedly.

"Oh, it's already noon?" Catra asks, surprised. Then, looks down at the shapeshifter then Huntara who is still wrestling with the beast. "Come back after you are done." She says simply, jumping

into the skiff with a swift move, then the lizard man drives them away.

It wasn't that hard to get used to people calling her boss. It came in handy in fact, this way no one really knew who was behind the ominous Forsaken gang who started to clean up the waste from the Horde. She made sure no one would know her real name here too, they either call her boss or Huntara calls her C., Double Trouble just sticks to their usual nickname for her.

They respect Catra because she knew how to fight, survive and conquer. She didn't tolerate anyone trying to undermine her or what she is capable of. They have learnt it pretty quickly.

She still remembers that one guy, his name is already forgotten just like his face. Catra just remembers the fact that he thought he would have any chance against Catra.

"I don't need a boss who licked the Horde's boot." He said with a puffed-out chest. "You need to go."

Catra just sat at the inn, learning how to play cards and drinking her beer, and didn't even pay attention to the guy. "So I use the diamond one if the overall score is above ten." She nodded to herself, reaching for her stoop only for it to fly to the other side of the inn.

"I'm talking to you, cat freak!" The guy shouted at her, Catra's ear moved forward a bit.

"Are you done barking?" She seemed through her cards.

"Huh?"

Catra looks at him with her uninterested mismatched eyes. "Do you need a stick to run after to shut up?”

The man surged forward, grabbing onto Catra's collar, hauling the girl up. "How dare you speak with me like this?! I would throw you to the vultures!"

Huntara stood up, ready to take matters in her hand, but at the sight of Catra's smile, she stayed put.

"Oh, yeah?" She asked lowly, grabbing onto the wrist of the man. "Let's see who will be the vultures dinner." She grinned at him, her fangs on display and with a swift move she kicked him in the face while Catra landed on her feet smoothly.

The man tried to attack her again, but Catra just played with her like a cat would with her mouse. Until she had enough and punched him in the jaw, knocking the guy out on the floor.

She crouched down next to him, knuckling his nose, but the guy is out of the world. "Where can I find vultures?"

She chuckles lightly at the memory, an idiot fool, he was nothing more.

On a skiff, the travel back to the valley is much smoother and faster. She jumps off at the entrance where Lon stands, he has a big backpack and a few things attached to his belt that come off as a weapon to Catra, but she is sure that the old man probably uses it for something else.

"This is marvellous! I never knew that the Valley of the Lost would be this enormous and populated!"

"Eh, it's okay." Catra shrugs. "What's all of this stuff?" She points at his backpack and belt.

"Oh, they are just my equipment in case I would need to dig down or find something and have to clean it up a bit. And I brought a few of my research too, in case you would be interested in rereading them, they are pretty old, but they might serve as something." He pats his backpack with a smile. "So, where's the crypt?"

"You can't access it from here, we need to go up." Catra jolts her head towards the upper part of the valley.

Lon follows Catra excitedly as they are bypassing the valley to go up, from up here Lon can have a better look at the valley. Eventually, they stop at a smaller cave barricaded by a rock, which Catra pushes away.

"It will be dark for a smaller part, just hold onto my whip." She hands the end of the whip to the man.

"Can you see in the dark?" Lon questions with furrowed brows, they walk into the cave.

Catra smiles smugly, although the human can't see. "Yes, pretty handy, huh?"

"Stupendous."

Catra says nothing, just scoffs. She has never seen anyone being this amazed by simple things like this. Well, this is simply normal for her. A few minutes pass before the orange crystals would light up again, illuminating the whole tunnel down to the door. Lon gasps, stopping looking up to the ceiling and crystals, he touches the cravings on the wall too.

"What?" Catra asks.

"These carvings, I've only seen them at a temple ruin. Oh, and these crystals, they are warm? Oh!" Lon touches one lightly. "Would you mind if I extract a piece from it?"

Catra shrugs. "If you can, I don't mind."

Lon takes his chisel and small hammer from his belt, and ever so gently starts to tap on the crystal's surface, after a few seconds he increases the power thrown into the hammer, but nothing happens. Even the human looks surprised, inspecting the crystal. Not even a scratch.

"Very interesting." He scraps the crystal. "I've never seen a crystal with such endurance. Or even some that would emit warmth."

"Could it be magic?"

"It's unmistakably magic, yes. But what powers these crystals? There's no magic in the Crimson Waste anymore." Lon scratches his chin, putting away his tools. "Let's continue."

Catra leads him further, the ground changing from unruly to chiselled marble, which again, completely amazes Lon. They near the wall and the human looks seemingly confused, Catra simply touches the rock wall and with a rumble a door slowly appears, opening in front of them. Catra walks in, Lon in her toes.

"Oh by the moons, this place is... Magnificent..." Lon mutters, completely in awe by everything he sees.

Catra stands by the door until it disappears with crossed arms looking at the human. Lon quickly sheds his backpack and gets out of his stuff, it's mostly rolled up big papers, notebooks, some ink and other tools Catra has never seen before. She steps closer.

"The whole crypt is still intact, this is absolutely wonderful!" He lights up. "All the Magicat buildings I've seen so far were all ruins with little to no information, but this place... It gives us an insight on how the Magicats have tended their dead, what traditions they had... Oh, this is enthralling." He quickly grasps one notebook and pen going around slowly, inspecting everything with the utmost care.

"This was probably a royal crypt." Catra mentions, Lon nods along with her words. "But they stopped burying people here."

"What?" Lon turns at Catra from the altar.

She simply points up to the last grave. "You see? They stopped at that royal, which means they probably didn't use this place anymore."

"Can you climb up there?"

Instead of saying something, Catra climbs up with ease. She turns looking down at Lon. "What now?"

"Is there any craving or writing on the last grave?"

Catra looks back at the grave, she swipes away the accumulated dirt and dust. "Queen Harron." She pronounces the name which Lon scribbles down quickly. "There's nothing else."

"I have hoped that they have put up some sort of year or date." He sighs, disappointed. "That's okay, thank you."

The catgirl jumps back down, her tail swishes around. "Do you know who is that?" She looks at the mosaic picture. "She must have been important if they put such a big picture up for her."

Lon turns his attention to the picture too, he walks closer a little. "It must be Queen Nefi. The first Magicat queen who was able to use the runestone." Lon explains. "I've never seen pictures of her, only a few old writings I could recover from a temple north from here. They said she was a powerful queen."

Catra looks up at the picture of the queen, for a second it seemed like Nefi's eyes moved. Catra gasps, taking a step back. She shakes her head, she must have got a heat stroke or something.

"You can look around freely," Catra tells Lon eventually and the human does so.

He goes around every part of the crypt, scribbling down things even drawing them down such as symbols that Catra never paid too much attention to or names. She sits at the wall where the queen's mosaic picture is, following the human with her mismatched eyes.

Lon goes back and forth of his backpack and some item he has discovered, he never tries to take anything away and if he does, he asks permission from Catra. It's not like she owns this place or anything. Out of boredom, she starts picking on her nails and trying to get the remaining sand out of her ears.

"You know," Lon breaks the silence while he dusts some symbol carving. "When you said you've found a crypt I was expecting a place filled with sand and spiderwebs. But this is better than anything I've ever seen." He chuckles lightly.

"Why did you start studying Magicats?"

Long hums, thinking. "Well, one says that because I'm a fool. Others might say it's an obsession, but... Magicats, they have made the waste a paradise, they've ruled here for thousands of years and then suddenly their city disappears and the kingdom starts to die out. That just sounds... Wrong, unbelievable." He sighs, going back to dusting. "Something must have happened. Moreover, their culture was so rich, it's captivating learning more and more about them through the places they have inhabited."

"What... What were they like? From your research..." Catra asks her voice light and somehow heavy with emotions.

"They were someone you would call a true royalty." The human chuckles a bit. "Most of the writings I have found are about royals and people who belonged to the upper ring, like sorcerers, warriors or advisers. They honoured their traditions, they had loads, unfortunately, I could only recover three rolls about the customs."

Catra sits now with crossed legs, all her attention on the human. "What traditions?"

Lon takes his time to think about it before he answers."One that's quite interesting is called Moon Dance. Magicats had a deep connection with the moons, and I assume the stars too before they have disappeared. They especially had a great sense of honour towards one moon, called Isa."

"We don't have a moon called Isa." Catra points it out.

"Exactly." Lon nods. "I think they had different names for the moons? I really don't know. But the Moon Dance took place around the same time, it was a tradition a queen had to go

through. Asking the moon to bless their kingdom by performing an intricate dance, it had very strict rules, from what kind of colour and dress the queen could wear to how she should wear her hair. One scroll even mentioned a special amulet, but I couldn't find more about it."

Catra listens to what Lon says attentively, curiosity and grief rise in her heart. She will never be able to see these kinds of beauties of her culture, that she never got to know.

"You said you've brought your old research, can I take a look?"

"Of course-of course."

Catra stands up, taking one of the old-looking leather-bound notebooks, walking back to the wall, she sits down then dives into the book while Lon does his own thing. She flips through the pages lazily, they have all day. There are drawings from different places, they are mostly symbols, patterns or the ruin itself sketched down. Catra is halfway through when she comes across a page filled with moons and a drawing of a headpiece.

The writings from the temple of Isa were severely damaged, but if I could extract them well, they were detailed descriptions of the headpiece of the Queens. According to the writing, the structure of the headpiece was made out of some kind of meteorite (it could be something else, the wording wasn't clear), while the crystal gems were extracted directly from their runestone itself. I suppose they have done it so the Queen could have a stronger connection with their runestone and probably could use its power just the same even if they were far away from the runestone.

Catra hums interested, she flips the page.

I was able to find another scroll from the temple, it describes some kind of procedure. The writing is extremely damaged, only a few lines could have been recovered.

As Catra flips the pages, she feels dull pain building up behind her eyelid. She furrows her brows, slowly massaging her temple,

trying to relive some pain without much success. She flips another page.

Magicats seemed to use certain symbols for specific occasions. Their temple was filled with fire and moon symbols, some (presumably older) ruins had star imaginary. Could they have been built before the stars have disappeared from the Etheria?

Catra squeezes her eyes, another wave of pain washing over her, growing from dull to sharp in a matter of seconds.

"A soothing star! Look, mom!"

She whimpers, the voice in her head ringing sharply, behind her eyes the sky full of stars and moon flashes.

"Wish something."

Catra snaps her eyes open, holding onto her head, taking deep breaths to soothe the pain.

"What was that..." She mumbles to herself, breathing harshly.

She closes the notebook hastily, pressing her back against the wall. She pushes her bangs back, taking yet another deep breath. She had hallucinations before, visual or auditory. But never like this, this was something unknown to her, yet a somehow familiar feeling runs through her.

A surprised gasp from Lon snaps her out of her thoughts. She looks up, seeing Lon at another crystal. It's much bigger than the ones outside.

She stands up, walking to the human. "What happened?"

"I have a theory. You see the crystals on the tunnel, as I said they must be run by magic, same with these in the crypt not to mention the enormous crystal above our head." He points up.

Catra makes an extra effort to ignore her headache. "Yeah, what about them?"

"They must be powered by the runestone."

Catra looks down at him, then slowly lifts an eyebrow, confused. "But you've said the runestone disappeared? That's why the waste died out."

"Yes-yes, and I still stand by that theory. But this one doesn't provide life or magical help to anything, there is nothing that it should keep alive. The crystal's only task is to provide light to this place and warmth." Lon explains it to her, then knocks on the hard surface of the orange crystal. "I believe that the runestone is still active. Somewhere, it is. Or otherwise, these crystals wouldn't work."

The catgirl furrows her brows, looking back at the crystal. "Which means that as long as the runestone is active..." She touches the warm surface of the glowing crystal.

"There must be someone alive from the Magicat royal bloodline." Lon then looks at Catra. "There is still hope." He smiles at her. "There must be others out there too, you are not alone."

This one sentence alone warms up Catra's soul.

She is not alone.

She never was.

The moons are slowly starting to show up, the weather gradually cooling down a bit.

Lon left a few hours ago but made Catra promise to let him look around more, which is totally fine by Catra. He also left some notebook here for her, which are already in her house.

Right now she is sitting on a table outside, munching on some food Huntara shoved into her hand. Grilled meat, which is one of Catra's favourite (she really only hates apple and fish), while Huntara and Double Trouble are sitting on a chair on either side of the table, eating their own meal too. Huntara is being more quiet than usual, Catra eyes her curiously.

The valley, no matter what part of the day is, is always bustling with life. People come and go, trade, buy, scam or even steal. That's okay, life is like that in the Valley of the Lost.

People who have run away from the law live here, of course, they are not going to be saints.

Catra doesn't really care as long as someone doesn't try to steal from her.

"So what now?" Double Trouble asks eventually, following someone getting chased with their eyes. "We know that the Magicats are alive, what are we going to do?"

"I guess we search for them," Huntara suggests, uninterestedly looking at the chase too. The warrior lady looks at Catra. "What's bothering you?"

Catra looks at the chase turned into wrestling, but it's clear her attention is somewhere else. "They could be everywhere. It's not guaranteed that they are hiding in the waste."

Double Trouble throws her a confused look, especially at Catra's silence. They sigh, standing up stretching. "You never know darling. Anyways, I have a side job to fulfil." They say as they

take a new form, a human girl with frizzy red hair and big brown eyes.

"Good luck," Huntara tells them.

"Oh, I don't need luck." Double Trouble waves their hand, walking away from the other two.

The two of them stay there for a while, just silently looking at the busy life playing in front of them. Huntara glances at Catra a few times, just checking on the catgirl who seems to be detached from the world as she just stares in front of her. The warrior lady sighs, poking her at the shoulder.

"Does it really bother you that much?" And the question hangs in the air.

Catra bites the last of her meat, jumping down from the table. "I'm not leaving the waste." She declares lowly.

Her initial excitement quickly died down after she realized this important fact.

Catra came to the waste so she doesn't have to deal with anything outside of it, doesn't have to hear anything from the princesses (even if Huntara still a member of the Rebellion she doesn't talk about them), or deal with the Horde's shit (except when she is kicking their ass out of the waste). Here, she could have started a new life or something like that. Not even Catra knows really what she wants from this life.

But leaving the waste is something that she won't do, no matter what will happen.

It gives her a new start, a blank page. Even if her demons and past are following her in the forms of nightmares and hallucinations, they would eventually disappear. Right?

“But what’s bothering you? You seem to be down.” She furrows her brows, stretching her hands above her head.

Huntara doesn’t say a single word for a few minutes, the heavy look in her eyes unsettles Catra. Something has happened. She knows this look.

"Huntara?"

"There's a deserted Bright Moon soldier in the valley." She announces, looking up from the ground, blankly blinking at the stretched out busy street. Catra goes rigid, a Bright Moon soldier this far?

"And? It's just a soldier. They wouldn't reco-"

"The Rebellion lost, Catra. The soldier defected because the Rebellion *lost* ."

The ground slips away beneath Catra, the world spinning. She leans to the table next to them, staring at Huntara with wide eyes. "What... What? How is..."

"The Horde was able to bounce back, some sorcerer stood by their side and they were able to take down Bright Moon... I don't... I don't know what happened with the princesses. I'm trying to get a hold of Adora, but she doesn't answer my calls." Huntara speeds through her words, her fist shaking with anger.

"Sorcer-... Shadow Weaver." Catra pales down. Shadow Weaver was in Bright Moon, she could have gotten a pretty good look at their plans, their weaknesses. Shadow Weaver has betrayed them too, selling them out to the Horde and Adora... Adora. Catra's heart skips a beat, they don't know what happened with them. For all, they know she could have been captured by the Horde, or-

Killed.

Hordak wouldn't hesitate, he would have killed Adora. She means the biggest threat to him, to the Horde as She-ra.

"... find them and make sure they are okay."

She didn't even notice zoning out, catching on Huntara's last words. She stares at her.

"C., I need to go and find them."

"What?"

"I'm sure they are not captured, not yet, but... They could be safe here, in the waste. For a while at least. I know you said you don't care about the war-"

"Okay." She agrees, her mouth working faster than her brain.

"But you've said..." Huntara is clearly in shock, not expecting Catra to go with her plan.

"I..." Her mouth closes. Why does she care? They are not her responsibility. Not her problem. This war is not her problem.

You are wrong. Her rational part tells her. She has been the one who worked out the plan, an almost perfect, unbeatable plan that would take down the Princess Alliance. And it did. Except Catra feels nothing but shame and guilt. She isn't proud. This is her fault. Whatever happened with them, whatever happened with Socrpia or Adora is her fault.

And she will fix it. She has to.

“You were right…” She says finally. “I can’t… quit a war where I was calling the shots. I was naive to think I could run away from everything. I could have helped the Rebellion sooner, but I was... I was afraid to face everything I’ve done. It's my fault, Huntara. I've defected and left a plan behind that could destroy the Rebellion." She confesses, voice honest and sincere. "I need to stop running and finally face what I’ve done, and fix what I can. Or at least try.”

"Are you serious?"

Catra nods, slowly. Processing her words. She may never be able to face Adora again after this, but she can try to help her. Help her survive.

“Bring them to the valley, they will be safe here. For a while at least,”

Bring Adora to the valley, she wants to say.

They sit in silence after that, both of them processing the news, Huntara probably thinking about where to search for them. While Catra's mind is filled with both dread and worry. She can't meet Adora. And the rest of the Princess Alliance?

She takes a deep breath, pushing her worry away. "You can take a skiff if you want," Catra suggests.

"Do you know why I stayed?"

"Huh?"

"With you. Do you know why?"

The question takes her by surprise. "I assumed it was because of my charming personality." She sacs sarcastically.

Huntara chuckles at that. "Not exactly. You looked lost and broken in the crypt-"

"So out of pity"

"Let me finish. It wasn't out of pity. The last time we saw each other we were enemies, the Rebellion told things about you," Catra curls her tails around herself. "Called you evil. And even if I agreed to give you the Forsaken in exchange for your help, I still didn't trust in you fully." She confesses, Catra isn't surprised.

"So what changed your mind? Me breaking down?"

"Someone evil wouldn't have reacted like that. You are not evil C."

"What, now everyone can read me like a damn book here?" She growls annoyed." I don't need you or anyone to play my therapist. I'm completely *fine.* "

Huntara glances at her, a bit confused. "I'm not trying to be any of that. What I'm saying, is that I stayed because I realized the princesses were wrong. Yes, you can ultimately destroy a lot of things, but it was either because you helped me liberate my home or out of hurt and anger.

"You kinda lost me here, Huntara." Catra deadpans,

The warrior lady just sighs. "You are not an evil person."

"You don't know that." She remembers when Double Trouble it to her. How her heart was never in it. But if she is not evil, not the bad guy, what is she in this world? She isn't the good guy, she isn't someone redeemable, someone who can be fixed or saved.

"You really think so?"

"I was a Horde soldier. I hurt people, I destroyed lives. I... I'm not the good one here." She mumbles, curling onto herself. "I *have* to be the bad guy."

Huntara lifts an eyebrow. "Am I a bad guy too? I was a Horde soldier too."

"Nah, you are too soft." She scoffs, Huntara's eyes visibly twitch.

Suddenly, Huntara stands up abruptly. She looks at Catra with a challenging smile.

"I still owe you a fight." She announces walking away, to the entrance of the valley. "Coming?!"

"W-wait... What? Now?" nonetheless Catra scrambles onto her feet.

Huntara grins at her, daring. They stop outside of the valley. The moons are already up, night has fallen. "What, are you afraid kitty?"

Catra blinks a few, then mirrors the taller's grin. "Oh, bring it on." She unclasps her cloak, it falling to the ground.

They both move at the same time, Catra's claws unsheathed while Huntara's spear is out ready to strike down. Catra jumps before it could happen, kicking Huntara on the shoulder. The taller woman doesn't budge, grabbing onto Catra's ankle and throwing the catgirl away. Catra rolls in the sand, recovering quickly to dodge an attack.

The two of them move quickly and smoothly even in the sand, Catra feeling in her element again. The rush of the fight clearing her head up a bit, it's like fresh air hitting her again. Or Huntara's spear's end. That's debatable.

It's clear that none of them wants to hurt the other critically or seriously, they wrestle and attack for minutes, letting the rush of the moment roll on them.

Eventually, the two of them end laying in the sand, sprawled out breathing heavily.

Catra chuckles to herself a little, catching her breath. Closing her eyes.

"Feeling better?" The question comes from her side, Huntara is just as out of breath.

"Yeah. Thank you. And Huntara… You can just call me Catra."

A clap breaks through their silence, Catra opens her eyes, raising her head to look around. She spots Double Trouble in front of them.

"That was a fairly boring fight, I would have expected something better." They deadpan with a flat voice.

Huntara laughs, loud and bold while Catra smiles to herself.

"How did you know we are here?" Catra questions.

"Well, if you are curious. I just came back from a job, which I exalted in, on course. When someone from the gang runs to me, with a horrified look telling me that you two idiots started to fight?" They question. "But I see it was nothing but a banter."

After Double Trouble stopped grumbling, they joined them too. Not on the sand, but rather sitting down on a rock next to them. They tell them about Huntara's departure in the morning and what's going on outside of the Crimson Waste.

If someone would have said something like she would form a team with a Rebellion soldier and a mercenary and lead a gang together, on top of that trying to find a lost kingdom, she would probably laugh at them and scratch their eyes out. A few months ago it would have just seemed right away impossible.

It's somehow liberating.

"Thank you, for both of you."

"I do not know what I did, but your welcome darling, I live to serve. For a price of course." They say smugly.

Catra blinks, sitting up supporting herself on her elbows looking at the shapeshifter. "I hope you know that I have no money."

"What?!" Double Trouble looks at her scandalized almost. "You are the leader of a gang! What do you do with the raided stuff?!"

"Oh, I don't go on a raid with them. That's usually Huntara." Catra points at the warrior lady.

"We are going to die after Huntara goes." They groan, falling back to the rock.

"Oh, don't be dramatic. We can easily raid an oasis or something."

"Being dramatic is quite my thing, darling."

Not so long after they return to the valley, Catra goes to her house, feeling tired and drained from everything that happened today.

She sighs, opening the door of her house, closing it behind her. Catra could use the old lamp in the room, but her eyes work perfectly in the dark, there's no need to switch them on. She glances down at the notebooks on her bed, while she takes off her gloves. Her movement ceases as something softly glows on top of the notebooks.

"What..."

Catra hurries to her bed, pushing away the notebooks only to find an amulet sitting on the bed. It's small, the orange crystal is wrapped in copper wires and a small pearl curl around it. It softly glows in Catra's hand, warming up her hand, it's threaded to a copper chain. Catra raises it a little, hanging it in the light that the moon provides.

Suddenly, she can see a blazing fire in the small crystal. With a gasp, she drops it down to the floor.

"How did it..." She mumbles, confused. Lon didn't give it to her, which means that someone has come to her room.

Catra turns around, skeeming the small house if she would see something, someone or even a similar orange glow would appear from somewhere. But nothing. She furrows her brows, and then, a small noise catches her ears. She turns to the window, where it came from. Catra steps to the window, with soft almost silent steps, and slowly she looks out of the window, looking at the right and then the left direction.

She locks eyes with golden eyes hidden behind a dark hood.

A second pass, before the figure dashes away.

"Hey!" Catra shouts, stepping up onto the windowsill. "Stop!" She jumps out, landing on her legs on the rooftop, below running after the figure with ease.

Catra jumps around the houses, moving around with expertise now. "Out of my way!" She yells, pushing off someone who came out of the local inn.

Her eyes fixated on the figure from above, which she can still see despite how crowded the street is. She catches onto a batten, flinging herself over landing just behind the figure, she reaches for the cloak but the figure turns and kicks Catra in the face. The catgirl groans, needing a few seconds to recover, before she takes off again, chasing the figure.

Catra reaches for her whip, the figure almost reaching the exit of the valley. She flicks the whip, it catches onto the figure's ankle, Catra stops abruptly, yanking the whip so the figure has tumbled forward. Without letting go of the whip, she runs to the lying figure.

She yanks onto the figure, pulling off the hood. "Who are you and why did you leave that amu-"

A scream rips out of her throat, shielding her face from the sudden outburst of flames that came out of the cloak. When it's over, she opens her eyes, levelling down her guards. There's nothing in front of her, only pieces of the burnt cloak.

She just stares at it, dumbfounded at its best.

"Boss?!"

Someone from the gang runs after her, stopping by the girl, looking confused at the catgirl and then down to the burned cloak.

"What happened? Who did this?"

Catra stays silent, collecting her harbouring thoughts. "It was... Magic..."

"No one uses magic in the valley."

Catra reaches down, taking a piece of the burnt cloak. "Maybe you don't know the valley as well as you think..."

"Fire magic disappeared a long time ago."

Catra and the other look behind themselves, a wolf looking man takes another drag from his cigar. He looks at the two again.

"What?" Catra questions.

"No one has seen fire magic in a long time. Whoever is after you boss, has some trick up their sleeves." He comments on that with a scowl. "But yes, Dam is right. No one uses magic here, we rather use our fist or some weapon. Flashy moves don't suit us."

Catra narrows her eyes, dropping the clothing piece. "Whatever. Stand guard at the valley's entrance, no one can enter or leave without you looking through them. If you notice something strange, report to me." She tasks the wolfman, who salutes to Catra as the catgirl walks away, then jumps up to a rooftop leaving them behind.

She jumps into her window, landing softly. She looks down on the amulet, still glowing softly. Catra reaches down for it, without taking another look at it she just drops it onto the drawer next to the bed.

Her mind can't stay calm, too many questions, too many things that make her dizzy.

She sheds off her clothes, making her feel suffocated.

Catra plops down to the bed, curling around herself, just like always, looking at the amulet sitting in her drawer.

Familiarity floods her senses the longer she watches the glowing crystal as if an old memory is trying to scrape to the surface but mud and concrete are blocking its way. Catra groans in annoyance, turning towards the wall, closing her eyes, trying to lull herself into sleep.

Hours pass and she still lays awake, feeling the amulet staring onto the back of her neck, which is stupid because it's just a piece of glowing crystal. But it feels as it pulses with life. Which to some extent freaks Catra out. So she sits up and angrily throws the amulet into the drawer as if it will solve everything.

She just sits on her bed, pushing her bangs and hair back taking a deep sigh.

Catra stands up going to the bag she has just dropped at the corner of the room, she settles down on the floor, taking out the book she has bought from the Pit. A rare gentle smile stretches over her lips at the old memories. She opens it at a random page and starts reading the tale.

Catra would love to deny it, but part of her still clings to Adora, a part of her still couldn't let go of Adora. They are enemies, nothing more. Adora hates her and the blonde has every right to do so.

But she will try to fix it. An opportunity, this is nothing more than that.

" *I miss you.* "

A whisper, nothing more, but in the dark and lonely room it echoes in Catra's head.

Adora peaks her head up to Catra's upper bed, seeing the catgirl fast asleep curled around herself. The blonde's attention zeroes on the brunette's bound wrist, Adora remembers the whimper that left Catra's lips the moment she landed wrongly on her wrist but said nothing during practice. Only sneaking away from everyone to tend it.

Adora, of course, followed her. And even at Catra's disagreement, she has helped her, fastening the gauze around it to have at least some support. It was fortunately not broken.

A few months have passed since their yearly tests, but Catra is still wary around people, doesn't let herself be touched even by Adora. The blonde has a suspicion why, and it all leads to Shadow Weaver. Catra doesn't want to talk about it, so she won't prod.

"Catra... Catra are you asleep?" Adora whispers into the night, reaching towards Catra and poking her cheeks.

The catgirl opens her eyes almost in an instant, eyes moving frantically around only to zero on Adora, her expression changes from alert to calm in a second.

"What, Adora?" She grumbles with a pout.

"Can I sleep in your bed tonight?" She asks hair let down it gets into her eyes.

Catra blinks at her, then turns around. "No."

It's a simple word, but it crumbles Adora down pretty quickly. "Please?" She tries again, voice soft and if Catra wouldn't know better she would say it's shaking.

But the catgirl doesn't say anything for a while, just curling around herself more. Her ears flattened down to her skull stubbornly. Adora's heartbeat picks up, fisting the sheets

nervously. They stay like this for a minute or two, before Catra sighs turning around.

"Come up."

Adora's face lights up, quickly climbing up into the bed, facing Catra who looks at her with a fake nonchalant look, but Adora sees right through her. Always does. Catra's tail wraps around her ankle, an act of comfort from the other.

"Did you have a nightmare again?" Catra murmurs, her mismatched eyes looking into Adora's sky blue ones.

Adora just nods silently, taking Catra's wrapped up hand into hers, enveloping it and resting it in between them. She doesn't know how long they have done this, holding hands or being so close to each other, it already feels like an instinct by now. But Adora knows that she never wants it to end, she never wants a day without hearing Catra's laugh or holding her hands.

Catra doesn't show affection to others, but with Adora, she is so soft and gentle, Adora, truth to be told, feels special because of that. Because Catra chose her to be so vulnerable.

The catgirl blinks down at her, tugging her closer to her until she is hugging Adora, lightly purring, their foreheads are touching. Adora looks into Catra's blue and golden eyes, then smiles.

"What?"

"Nothing. I'm just happy."

Catra scoffs, closing her eyes. "You are easy to entertain."

Adora says nothing, just continues to smile at the warmth that's enveloping her, both her body and soul. Yes, she doesn't want to lose this.

Catra eventually falls asleep, it's always easier for her when she is sleeping with Adora, knowing that she is safe. And usually, it's

easy for Adora too, but instead, she is looking at Catra's calm and relaxed face. She feels a little weird, maybe stalkerish that she is staring at her best friend's face while the other is asleep.

But was Catra always this beautiful? Of course, she was, Adora tells herself. That's a dumb question.

"I wish you could always be this peaceful." She says softly, closing her eyes and soon Adora is fast asleep too, holding onto Catra's hand.

"Adora. Adora!"

Adora's eyes snap open, she sits up reaching for her sword and ready to go into battle. She stumbles out of bed, only to be welcomed by Entrapta looking at her with wide and confused eyes.

"Ohhh, strange reaction." Entrapta blinks at her.

"Entrapta? What... What happened? Are we under attack?" She questions, panic rising in her blood.

"We've got a signal!" Entrapta shouts enthusiastically, shoving her pad into Adora's face. The blonde just blinks at them confused and tired.

"Signal? What signal?"

Entrapta's hair sneaks around her, taking the sword away and placing it back in its place. "I've caught a signal coming from the

place called Crimson Waste in the past few days, but I was never able to connect it with the pad. Until a few minutes ago." She explains it to Adora, with buzzing excitement. "It seems something was blocking either my signals or theirs. It could be perhaps because of the Whispering Woods magic, I never thought about fusing tech with magic." She hums to herself, scratching her chin with pinched eyebrows.

"Entrapta, the signal" Adora reminds her.

"Oh, yeah... Sorry." She shakes her head. "So as I said, I caught the signal and was able to connect to it. It was an audio message, from a person named Huntara. Scorpia said she is with the Rebellion. She said she heard about what happened and will come here to get us!" She grins, tapping away something on her pad and showing the audio message to her.

"I really hope it will go through now, this Horde tech is confusing. Adora, or anyone from the remaining Princess Alliance, if you hear this stay in one place. I will get you and bring you to the Crimson Waste. It's Horde free, mainly Horde free, you will be able to regroup and stay out of sight for a while."

"Wait, what no! Huntara can't come here!" Adora jumps out of the bed holding onto Entrapta's shoulder. "It's dangerous! She could get cau-"

"Catra asked me to bring you here. She is fighting against the Horde here too."

And the audio message ends.

"Catra is *alive* !" Entrapta grins at her, holding the pad close to her chest while her hair claps enthusiastically. "And she is sending someone for us!"

lost child

Chapter Summary

> And for a second Catra thinks about just releasing the chains, letting her own body go to whatever is waiting for her at the bottom. It would be so easy. Freed from the pain, the constant panic settled into her heart, the dreams and the guilt, the shame.

The fire crackles in front of the little child, the sparkles dancing up to the starlit sky. C'yra giggles each time another pair of fire kittens would run out of the fire, circling her and then disappearing with an orange glow. She, of course, knows now not to touch them or else she would get burnt, it took her a little time though.

"C'rya, let's go."

A boy, little older than C'yra tells her, tapping his foot impatiently onto the ground of the great market. He has red hair that tickles his chin and blue eyes, ears and tail mix of brown and black. The prince of Halfmoon.

"Can't we stay a little longer?" C'yra looks up at his brother with a pout. "Please?"

Leo stubbornly shakes his head. "No, momma said we need to go back to the castle before the last moon shows up, and look! It's already up." He points up at the sky.

C'yra furrows her brows, tilting her head a little. Her tail swishes around playfully. "How do you know, they all look the same."

"C'yra."

"Okay, I'm going." She says, standing up from the ground, skipping to his brother, who holds his hand out.

As a child, C'yra didn't understand much of the world.

She didn't know why her parents were suddenly so protective over them, barely letting them out of the castle or the sight of a guard. She didn't understand why they couldn't stargaze like they used to, or why her mom would spend so much time in the throne room, she would hear her shout sometimes too when she wandered close to the throne room. Her mom *never* shouted. And her momma was always busy with the warriors, sometimes leaving for days, coming home with bruises.

C'yra didn't understand.

Neither did she understand when suddenly the stars disappeared from above, and the earth shook underneath them. She looked up at her brother, scared and confused. Then another shake, a much violent and stronger one.

"Leo?" C'yra whispers, tugging on her brother's hand. "What's happening?"

"We need to go back to the castle." He hastily took her into his arms, running away.

C'yra didn't understand but knew her brother was afraid.

She didn't know why, or why the stars had disappeared.

And then, an explosion shook the whole kingdom, the main gate crumbling down to pieces.

Catra gasps for air, it's almost like her chest is being compressed down by a heavyweight she can't wrestle down from herself. She closes her eyes, taking a deep breath and slowly exhaling it shakily. Another stupid dream. Well, something like that. She never really remembers them afterwards, only the stars and the feeling of warmth around her.

She looks up at the sky, it must be around noon or even a little earlier. She was napping on her rock at the top of the valley. Catra squints lightly, covering her eyes with her arm. Deep breath and exhale again. After the fifth try, she feels better.

"What's up with these stupid dreams?" She groans, rolling to her side. "Ah, at least they are not about *them* anymore..." Catra sighs, she closes her eyes for a few seconds just to enjoy the silence around her.

You are still here.

Her eyes snap open, sitting up to look around. She stills for a second or two, her ears moving forward in alert while her tail curls around her waist. Catra slowly stands up, climbing down from the rock landing in the sand.

"Who is there?" She yells, scanning the surroundings, cautiously stepping away from the rock.

You are still here child.

Catra turns around, slashing the air with her nails. There's no one behind her. Her heartbeat picks up, a growl building up in the back of her throat. She stops and stands in the sand, nothing around her where someone could hide and play mind tricks on her.

She hisses, claws unsheathed. "Show yourself!"

Her whole body pulled taut, ready to jump and attack at the smallest motion her eyes could pick up. But no matter how hard Catra tries, she doesn't see, smells or hear anything, anyone

around her. It's just her. Her nerves don't soothe still. Something is here, she can feel it under her skin.

Is someone really after her? Playing tricks on her with magic? How else could it happen?

Or.

Are they hallucinations?

Catra squeezes her eyes, trying to gain control over her storming brain before she would spiral down again. She can already feel her throat closing and the way her heart beats so vehemently.

"Calm down Catra, nothing is here." She tells herself over and over again.

Come, home child.

" *Nothing* is here." She punctuates the word with a groan.

We are waiting for you.

Her eyes snap open, breathing harshly. "Who?! Who is waiting for me?!" She shouts into the silence, her voice echoing in the endless desert. " *Who* are you?! What do you want from me?!" She tries again, anger and frustration boiling inside of her.

She doesn't understand what it is. Is this magic? Is this a hallucination again? Is her mind finally giving up on the last of her sanity?

" ***Answer me*** !!"

Catra cries finally, the mysterious voice doesn't answer again. The feeling of someone watching her also disappears, the prickling on her skin stops. The catgirl stands there, alone and confused about what just happened. The wind picks up, catching into Catra's hair and cloak, picking up the sand and hurling it around. She blinks, shielding her eyes.

What gains her attention, is the blinking orange light in the distance. Despite the sand dancing around her, more violent with each passing minute, her feet are rooted in the ground.

We are waiting for you.

It rings in her ears, spite bubbling in her veins. "Fuck you." She hisses, turning around, quickly getting down to the stairs that lead down to the valley. She lands on her rooftop, standing up from the crouch, shaking out the sand from her hair.

Lon's notebooks are scattered on the floor, some paper has Catra's writing on it. Her own notes, mostly about the voices she would hear and the strange flashbacks. She steps to her drawer, opening it up and taking the amulet out of what has been sitting there in the past week.

The fire she has seen the first time inside the crystal still flickers with life. She narrows her eyes at it.

"It's been happening since you've got here..."

Catra takes the amulet into her neck, reaches down to her navel, hides behind the cloak. She takes her bag and stuffs all the notebooks and papers into it. Without thinking twice she leaves her room, running up the stairs, right outside of the sandstorm, when Double Trouble calls her name.

"Where are you going Kitten?!" They shout up, a level down.

Catra stops, looking down her hood already hiding her face. "I will be back soon, don't let anyone try and overthrow me." And she runs up the last few stairs, disappearing from the shapeshifter's sight.

"Hey! Kitten!"

Catra runs to the rock that blocks the cave, she pushes it away, then dashes down into the tunnel what glows up in orange the

moment she nears them. The door waits for her to open. She rips off the hood, throwing down the cloak and the bag to the floor.

She stands in the middle of the crypt, looking up at Nefi's picture. It's only Catra's heavy breathing that echoes back from the empty walls. She takes off the amulet that seems to glow brighter here and shows it towards the picture.

"Is it you who is doing it right?!"

A desperate voice bounces back from the walls, echoing in the crypt.

"This magic... The amulet... It's all your tricks!"

The room is silent once again.

"Oh, now you don't want to talk... Answer me! Why are you doing this?!"

She throws the amulet against the wall, it falls to the ground. Catra breathes harshly, her body shakes all over again. The silence, which she treasured so greatly in the past month, is now nothing but a source of her frustration and anger. Part of her mind knows it's impossible that a dead person could do anything like this, let alone thinking screaming at a picture would solve everything.

Yet, Catra has no other ideas.

She doesn't know what could be. Why did she suddenly start to have strange flashbacks, remembering faces she has never seen or scenarios that never happened? Why is this place so familiar to her, why is the amulet's warmth awakens a deep longing in her?

"What do you want from me..." She breathes, dropping to her knees looking up at the picture. "Please." Her vision blurs together into a mess of orange and gold, she hastily dries up her tears.

Once again, it's the silence that welcomes her.

Catra doesn't know how many hours have passed since she came down here. The girl just simply sits on the floor, curled into herself, flipping through a notebook slowly, not even paying attention to what's written down. She feels completely numb, and at this point isn't sure if any coherent thought has forged in her brain.

She was waiting and waiting for the voice to come back, but absolutely nothing had happened.

We are waiting for you.

She remembers the words, she eyes the amulet still laying down on the ground, softly glowing.

The notebook closes as Catra walks to the amulet, taking it, and Catra glances up at the picture again, her mismatched eyes narrowed down.

"I know it's you." She whispers, before standing up and leaving the crypt without everything she has brought here, except the cloak and the amulet.

The door opens and closes behind her.

Instead of going back to the valley, she walks to where her skiff stations.

The skiff takes off with ease, gliding through the air leaving the valley behind. Catra doesn't even think twice before increasing the speed, driving towards the point she has seen the glowing orange light. She looks back after some time, the rocks of the valley have disappeared already, she must be far by now.

The desert looks the same no matter where she looks, occasionally she would notice a few giant bones scattered around, but apart from that, everything is just sand and rock. Catra reaches down to the amulet, closing her hand around it feeling the warmth against her skin.

Truth to be told, she has no idea what she is searching for exactly. There are no ruins around there, she remembers that from Lon's map.

"What? You don't have anything to say now?" She scoffs, mocking the voice with an eye roll.

Soon enough, Catra stops, turning off the skiff as she looks around. Sand and nothing more.

She angrily kicks the side of the riff before jumping off. "I know I saw it..." She tells herself, turning around hoping to see the orange light again.

"What the fuck is going on?!" She screams, frustrated and angry, confused at best. It's like she is slowly going crazy by hearing these voices and seeing things that are not here. But the thing is, she knows what she has seen, and that wasn't a hallucination.

A groan leaves her mouth, she rips down her hood. "Nothing smart to say, huh?!"

She scoffs, walking around. "Of course, you are talking to the voice in your h-"

The ground beneath her feet swept away, and Catra fell into a pit. She screams for help, trying to catch herself on the wall as she falls, her nails unable to catch onto them, the surface is too chiselled, made out of marble.

With a dull thud and a pained groan, she lands on the rocks ground. "Oh, fuck..." pain shots through her whole arm as she tries to stand up, putting weight on her arm. "Ah." she hisses, inspecting her arm, finding a large red bruise forming around her elbow.

Catra looks up, sitting on the ground. The tunnel that leads down is extremely high, and the walls are so smooth her claws have no chance of sinking into them. The light comes through the tunnel,

which gives Catra a great time to look around, where she is two tunnels are leading away, both fading into darkness.

"Congratulations Catra, you fucked up, *again* !" She pushes her bangs back, contemplating just banging her head against the wall because it would hurt less than her own idiotism. "Who follows a light that they have seen randomly? No one in their *right* mind!"

"Now how do I get out of here?" Ste stands from the ground, dusting down her clothes.

The amulet in her neck starts to glow brighter, gaining Catra's attention. The catgirl glances down, taking the crystal in her hand and dangling it before herself.

Catra grimaces at it. "Now what, you are going to be a flashlight? I guess better than nothing." She takes it off, wrapping the chain around her hand, her tail lashes around anxiously.

She then looks at the two tunnels at either side of her. Her ears move forward, trying to pick up any sound, but everything is dead silent. As if nothing has been in here for centuries. She gulps dryly.

"Okay, Catra, which one..."

She eventually sides with the one on her right, walking away from the spot she has landed. The crystal provides her light, not as bright as a real flashlight would, but it is enough for her not to stumble and actually see where she is going. For one last time, she looks back where the light cascades down from the surface before she turns on the corner leaving it behind.

It’s already weird that despite her night vision Catra can’t see through the darkness around her.

It doesn't feel like the tunnel at the crypt. It doesn't emit warmth, she tries to scratch her hand on the wall, to see if there are crystals around, but nothing, it's just a smooth wall. She walks around for a while when her leg bumps into something. It's too

light to be a rock, Catra looks down, her eyes go wide and her other hand lands on her mouth to muffle her yell.

A skull.

The crystal, as if it feels Catra's emotions, brightens up and Catra can see more of the tunnel ahead of herself. It's tight, the ceiling is barely above her and the walls are definitely narrowing down. What mortified her are the bones laying on the floor, scattered around. Some of them snapped in half, thrown away.

She takes a few deep breaths, taking her hand away. "Okay, Catra... Calm down." She encourages herself with a whisper.

That's when she hears the noise behind herself, echoing in the tunnel. Like a distant growl of pain and agony.

Instead of looking back, Catra continues her walk. Her fur stands up, and every instinct in her body tells her to go back, try to climb up that damn tunnel. She curses herself for coming here alone, but for her excuse, she didn't really think straight when she set off from the valley.

As she walks, trying to bypass the bones, she hears the echo getting closer and closer, louder. Her heart picks up, and sweat collects on her temple. She has no idea where she is heading, or what she would find if this tunnel has an ending at all.

Eventually, Catra comes across a door, widely open, the upper part ripped from the hinge. The side facing Catra is filled with claw markings. She steps closer, unsheathing her own and scrapping them against the markings. Whatever left those lines, is the third Catra's size, minimum.

She looks over her shoulder, seeing nothing lurking around in the shadows. But she can hear the noises, the bones cracking under something heavy and dangerous.

Catra hurries away.

After that the tunnel wides significantly, the ceiling is high and the walls widen away from Catra. She raises the crystal, the light becoming stronger. She doesn't see a lot, the darkness just doesn't want to lift. Like it’s not natural.

"Oh, don't tell me it's magic, please." She groans, her voices echo in the tunnel.

She squeaks, even her own voice sounding way too scary down here.

Catra's heavily beating heart skips when she hears the steps behind her, too close. Way too close. She freezes in one place, gulping dryly. Her ears flatten down in fear.

Come on Catra, she tells herself. Face with whatever this is.

And Catra slowly turns around, finding herself face to face with something she has never seen. A giant monster, a tiger with deep red eyes and a skeleton-like body enveloped in dark purple magic. It looked down at Catra, and the catgirl barely had time to jump away as it attacked her with its sharp skeleton claws.

"What... What is that..." She steps back slowly, only being able to jump away from another attack.

The only magic she has ever seen was Shadow Weaver's and Sparkles's magic, she never knew something like this could be born from magic.

Hastily Catra puts the amulet back into her neck before she turns and runs away from this monster. Darkness around her thickens, even the orange glow becomes subtle. Catra collides with the wall, not noticing it, she whimpers by the power of the collision and something sharp scraping her neck and ankle. She turns around, chest heaving.

Her eyes move around trying to find those red eyes looking back at her, and when she finds them her heart skips a beat. It looks at Catra like a predator enjoying the chase with their prey.

Catra growls, feeling cornered in this dark and unknown place. Her instincts running south.

When those red eyes move, Catra's body too. Out of sheer luck, she was able to jump away from the attack, judging from the rumble it either tore down the wall or damaged it pretty badly.

"Fuck." Catra pants, inching away from the tiger monster, following them along the wall.

Even with the amulet's light, she can barely see anything, it's like darkness thickens with each minute she spends more time here, her ears twitch but she hears nothing. Absolutely nothing. Not even her own steps. She swallows shallowly.

"I need to get out," Catra mutters to herself.

As she steps to the side, there's no more ground to support her. The catgirl's whole body slipped down into the water without anything to catch herself. Catra shouts in panic and fear, the cold water enveloping her body, she shuts her eyes, closing her mouth, repressing the urge to cough up the water she has swallowed.

Her hands jig around, trying to find some solace.

Mismatched eyes eventually open, the water almost burning them, she struggles to keep them open. Everything is just as dark, the orange glow almost dying out. She screams with a closed mouth, trying to work through the panic in her brain before she drowns.

Her hands bump into something that she identifies as a chain hanging from above. Catra clings to it with all her power, pulling herself up.

She does the worst she could do, looking down and finding hundreds of little red eyes staring up at her. She closes her eyes again, freezing in one spot. The fact that she is losing her senses just worsens the whole situation. Her lungs are burning, begging for air.

And for a second Catra thinks about just releasing the chains, letting her own body go to whatever is waiting for her at the bottom. It would be so easy. Freed from the pain, the constant panic settled into her heart, the dreams and the guilt, the shame.

Let go. Let go of it.

Catra's left hand lets go of the chain.

Her grip on the right one weakens too.

It would be better right?

Catra slowly opens her eyes. She feels lightheaded and heavy at the same time, shaking.

It must be because of how dizzy she feels, but she can swear she sees two women at either side of her. One with long red hair, the other with short black. Their gold and blue eyes are almost glowing. The red-haired reaches and wraps her hand around Catra's right hand, keeping it there. While the other guides her left hand back.

Come on, C'rya.

Your time didn't come yet.

The amulet's glow gets stronger, granting clarity not just around Catra, but the girl's mind too. She gasps water flooding into her mouth. She grasps onto the chain stubbornly, pulling herself up.

She takes a deep breath the moment she ducks her head out of the water, coughing up water too. She pants, pulling onto the chain, slowly climbing up as it's wet and slippery. But Catra holds onto it, her whole body shakes the coldness of the place enveloping her.

Catra looks around, the amulet still strongly glowing in her neck. She spots the ledge on her side, and with a well-coordinated

jump, Catra lands on the ground again. She leans to the wall, panting heavily, her chest still hurting and her mind is dizzied up.

"Fuck this place."

In the midst of the previous event, Catra completely forgot about the tiger monster, until she locked eyes with it. The monster right in front of her.

She tries to jump away again, just to be slammed against the wall by the tiger's enormous paw and pressing her down. Catra breathes shallowly, trying to push away the paw before it would crash her.

"GET OFF ME!" She screams, her voice stuck in her throat as the tiger leans closer, opening its jaw, and Catra sees nothing but complete darkness and razor-sharp teeth.

She closes her eyes, waiting for the inevitable, only to be able to breathe again. She gasps for air desperately, sitting up she tries to find where the tiger is, only to see something standing in front of her, growling at the enormous tiger. Jumping against it, Catra's saviour bites into the *magic* of the tiger, marring it with a vicious sound.

And Catra has witnessed something she has never thought she would be able to see.

The tiger is forced down to the ground by the other creature, ripping out apart from it until the dark purple magic slowly fades away and the bones are scattering down to pieces.

Catra scoots back, looking at the other creature which turns around looking at Catra. The catgirl just stays still, not knowing what to do once in her life.

The creature looks like it's some kind of cat, but the mane and the tail spiked up red magic, its eyes are red as well as boring into Catra's. It starts to growl at Catra, pouncing onto the girl, Catra falls back with a yell, shielding her face with her hands, expecting

fangs or claws, but, instead, she feels the creature nosing around her cloak until it reveals the amulet, shining brightly.

The spikes from the creature's mane and tail disappear, the red turning into blue. It climbs down from Catra and sits down next to her.

"What the hell..."

Catra stares at the creature, who tilts its head a little as if it's waiting for something.

"Uh... Thank... you?" She says unsurely.

Slowly, she reaches her hand out, lightly touching the creature's nose until it nuzzles into Catra's palm. And the whole tunnel is brought to light, the creature glowing brightly in blue while Catra's body glows in orange. Catra's jaw drops, her whole body enveloped in the same warm orange glow as the amulet.

Catra’s eyes tear away for a moment, taking into the whole place

There’s a pool next to her that stretches away to the other side of the wall, splitting the place into two, a small stone bridge in the middle. From the ceiling, chains are hanging down, and even from the walls, some goes even into the pool. It’s dark, dirty.

It dies down, leaving them again in the dimmed dark, but this time Catra sees through the darkness perfectly. She sees the whole tunnel, her eyes glowing in the dark. Then, She looks back at the creature.

"Your name is Melog."

Melog nods, blue eyes looking at Catra before it nuzzles to her cheeks. It takes Catra by surprise, she chuckles at the magical cat's antics. She pets slowly their heads.

"Thank you for saving me."

"Your welcome."

Catra scoots away with a squeak, almost falling into the water again. She looks at the magical cat with a hammering heart, today starting to be too much for her. Melog just sits there and tilts their head a little.

Their voice is quiet melodious, with a little echo. There's something ancient in it, that she can't explain.

"You... You can... Uhm, speak?" She clears her throat.

"Of course. Although it's only you who hears me since we've bonded."

"We did what?"

"The light that happened minutes before. Your soul and mind bonded." The magical cat smiles at Catra. *Smiles.*

Catra just stares at them. She must have seen it wrong, right? She takes a deep breath, trying to make sense out of the situation that seems to be getting too unreal for her. Everything just seems unreal since she has found that fucking crypt.

"Great. I guess. Can you get me out of here?" Catra finally asks, standing up and trying to shake the water out of her hair as much as she can.

"Of course. Follow me, Catra,"

Melog stands up and walks Catra out of the bizarre place in the first place. Her amulet glows subtly, while Melog's mane and tail guide her in the dark. Now that she can see in the darkness again, some of her nerves are soothed, but she is still uneasy about this whole place.

"Why are you afraid?"

The magical cat's voice startles Catra, she squeals lightly, tail bristled up. She clears her throat quickly. "I'm not afraid. Just... This place is strange."

"It's a prison, must be that's why," Melog tells her, and Catra squints at them. "At least part of it, the Pool is only a little part of the Great Prison."

"Prison? Why... Would someone have an underground prison with multiple parts?"

"Queen Harron thought that it would be a bigger punishment to those who went against her, not to see the moons and stars, than living behind cells," Melog tells her, their tail moving around calmly as they guide Catra around. "But they don't use it anymore, not for a long time." Their ears pin back, and Catra can feel the sadness in their voice. "Not since everyone disappeared."

Catra walks behind them, for a long time she just stays silent, processing the information. Harron's name comes to her like a whiplash, remembering her from the crypt. Her grave was around the middle section.

The catgirl stops abruptly. "Wait... You've known the Magicats before they disappeared?!"

Melog nods simply. "I was born a long time ago, from pure magic that surrounded Etheria and when the stars were still up in the sky. I served them for a long time, I was the guardian of the Great Prison." They say proudly.

"What... What happened to them? Why did Halfmoon disappear? What happened to the Magicats?" Catra surges forward, kneeling in front of Melog with a desperate look. "Please, you have to know.

Melog flicks their ears. "Do you not know?" They sound confused.

"Why... Why would I know?"

"Because you are a *princess* , I assumed you would know what happened and you came here to clear out the Great Prison from the evil and corrupted spirits."

Catra's brain stopped at the word 'princess' and the fact that Melog called *her* a princess. She just stares at the magical cat, who looks back at her with confused narrowed eyes.

"I'm... I'm not a princess." Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes.

"Yes, you are. You have the amulet."

Catra looks down at the glowing amulet then back to Melog. "That doesn't prove anything. Everyone can have glowing amulets."

"No," They shake their head. "This is made out of the runestone. It wouldn't light up to anyone if they don't have royal blood in them. Do you... Not knowing that you are a princess?" Melog asks, unsure.

"I think you have spent a lot of time here, your senses must have got fucked up." Catra tries to reason, clearly upset. She stands up.

"I don't think so. Do you not know that you are a princess, Catra?" Melog asks again, Catra feels like she is cornered again.

Is she a princess? That's stupid. She can't be a princess. She just can't. Catra glances down to the amulet, that pulses with life and she can still see the fire stirring in it. Catra shakes her head firmly.

"I'm *not* a princess." She punctuates. "Just... Get me out of here."

Melog drops the topic, although the magical cat oftentimes looks at her over their shoulder, checking on Catra. The catgirl doesn't even notice it, way too deep in her thoughts. She hugs herself under the cloak, body shivering from the cold that seeps into her bones.

That must be some misunderstanding here. She is being a princess would be a pretty cruel joke from the universe, and at

some point, Catra is sure the universe *can't* possibly hate her that much.

Too much is happening too quickly, they are like a cold shower to Catra and the catgirl doesn't know how to react to them.

For a second she thinks back at the two women in the pool who appeared to her. They called her C'yra. Or she assumes that was for her. Who is C'yra? And who were those two?

The usual dull pain starts to build up in her head, especially now that her head is just full of questions and strange flashbacks. She remembers those eyes, blue and gold. One from her dream the other from the time she has gone to the crypt. She has seen them before, she *knows* them. And their voices. So familiar, as Catra thinks back at them she feels nothing but warmth and deep longing she has never felt before.

Do they know her?

Were they close?

But again Catra doesn't even know when she got to the Horde, she doesn't know how old she was. How would she have any memories of those two?

For her, everything starts at the Horde. She sees Shadow Weaver at first, the sorceress quite literally dumping her into a box, and leaving the confused and shivering catgirl alone. Then Adora as the little blonde tried to make friends with Catra, and how easily they had clicked.

There's no memory of blue and golden eyes, no memory of C'yra, no memory of those two, no memory of her being a princess.

"I don't know what happened to the Magicats." They suddenly speak again, Catra glances at them. "After the stars disappeared, everything has changed. The land started to die out, eventually, Halfmoon vanished one night. We were all waiting for them to come back, but it never happened. I know that they are alive

because I can feel the runestone, but it's weak. Almost as if it's sleeping."

"I don't... I don't understand." Catra furrows her brows, the headache weakening for now.

"The Magicats were great warriors, that's why their royals could wield the power of the runestone. Because they were strong and determined, but since they have disappeared I feel the runestone's power getting weaker. As if it's sleeping, refusing to give power to the Magicats anymore."

Catra is just getting more confused over this whole situation. Her mind is a whirlwind of thoughts and speculations, she doesn't have the energy to dwell on this more. She just wants to get out of here and maybe sleep for a week or two.

"What did you mean when you said we are bonded?" She changes the topic instead.

Melog thrills a bit at the mention of the bond. "Well, I truly never thought I could bond with someone. It's a little complicated, but overall it means I'm familiar. I'm able to feel and channel your emotions and use my powers to your need. It also means that our life has been intertwined, if you happened to die, I would die with you." Melog tells Catra and the catgirl's eyebrow gradually moves up and up towards her hairline.

"Isn't that a little extreme? Also, why are you in my emotions? I don't like it..."

"Well..." Melog thinks about it a little. "If you want to I won't comment on how you feel, but I can't stop it. Also, familiars used to be very important, true companions to the queens and princesses. I'm not just your familiar, but a guardian too."

"I'm not a princess." Catra growls, the anger in her blood colours Melog's mane and tail red too.

"Then why do you have the amulet?"

"I... I don't know! I don't know anything, okay?! I have no idea where I came from or what I'm doing here!" Catra kicks a bone away from them, breathing heavily. "I don't know... I'm... I'm not a princess, I *can't* be a princess, okay?" She looks down at Melog who tilts their head in question, red turned into blue again.

"Would it be so bad?"

Catra stays silent for a few. She contemplates lying, but now that she knows Melog can feel her emotions it would be completely useless to just lie. She reaches down and pets Melog's head, the magical cat slightly purring.

"I guess yes." Catra agrees. "I.. Fought against the princesses my whole life, hunting them and destroying their home. I'm supposed to hate them, not being one of them."

"And do you hate them?"

She looks down at the magical cat, tail lashing around. "I don't know anymore."

"That's okay. Come on, we are almost out."

Melog leads Catra towards, they don't speak anymore but it's okay. It was enough information for today.

It's annoying and intrusive for Melog to see into her emotions, but at the same time somehow comforting. They know how Catra feels, maybe they could understand her better how to get over them. How to be calm when all she wants to do is stop existing.

Melog is seemingly the last one of his kind, left here and waiting for someone to come. Catra sees herself in them a bit.

Eventually, after who knows how long they arrive at a wall, Melog stands up on their hind leg, pushing their front paws to the wall, it glows up in orange. Melog steps back and a door starts to appear out of the wall. It opens simply and the magical cat walks out,

Catra quickly following them. She looks back just to see the door closing behind them then it disappears.

They are in a small canyon.

Catra squints, looking at the distance spotting her skiff abandoned.

"Oh."

Melog looks back at her. "What is it?"

"It's just... I need to get used to these walls appearing out of nowhere and then disappearing." She sighs, pushing her bangs back. "Thank you."

"Your welcome." Melog smiles again.

Catra needs to get used to this too.

"So... Are you going to come with me, I assume?" She lifts an eyebrow.

Melog nods. "I'm your familiar. But... If you don't want me to go with you, I can stay here."

"No, you don't have to stay here. You can come." Catra smiles a little at them.

Melog visibly lights up, at least their mane and tail. Catra can feel how happy they are.

"Let's go."

Double Trouble takes a deep breath, looking at Catra and the magical cat next to her. They are at their usual table in the valley's inn.

"So let me repeat it. You heard a voice, went somewhere because you've seen an orange glow, fell into an underground place, almost died twice and brought home a magical cat." Double Trouble finishes it with a sceptical look.

"Exactly." Catra nods.

"You see, that's what I was talking about!"

People around them look at Melog with unsure eyes, then back to Catra who looks absolutely soaked still, muddy and dirty.

Catra scoffs as if she didn't almost drown, then got her heart clawed out by a tiger monster. She kind of left out the part where Melog told her she might be a princess, and the magical cat didn't say a word either since they arrived back in the valley.

"I don't know what's your problem." She sits down, stealing meat from the shapeshifter's plate. "I'm alive after all, yay." She bites into it, then offers some to Melog but they just shake their head, settling down to the ground by Catra's leg.

Double Trouble drags their hand over their face. "I have no idea how you survived this long, kitten."

"You see, I have no idea either."

"Can we go back to the information that your kitty cat knows about the Magicats, and the time before their disappearance?" Double Trouble says after a beat of silence. "Is there a possibility that they know where Halfmoon is?"

The air stills around them, looking at each other than down to Melog. The magical cat noticing their eyes, looking up at Catra.

"Do you know where Halfmoon is?"

"No."

Catra sighs, pushing back her bangs. “Melog said they don’t know.”

"Wait, are you… Talking with your cat?”.

“Yeah, they speak in my head.”

It would be funny if Catra didn't freak out too. They quickly drop the topic as Melog continues.

"But I can feel the runestone's energy. Weakly, but I can."

"Can you lead us there?"

Melog hesitates, Catra feels it and she absolutely doesn't understand why would they? Wouldn't it be great for Melog too if they find Halfmoon? Or do they hesitate because discovering Halfmoon would mean they would know if Catra is really a princess or not? At the thought her stomach flips, Melog glances up at her.

Are they trying to protect Catra?

"It's okay Melog. Whatever will be the truth, it's okay." She reassures the magical cat, even though both of them know it's a lie.

"I can lead you there." They eventually say, looking at Catra. "But are you sure you want this?"

Double Trouble looks at them intensely, waiting for an answer. They, of course, can't hear Melog, only Catra can.

Catra nods shortly. "They can lead us there."

Melog looks up at Catra with unsure blue eyes, the catgirl ignoring it despite how fast her heart beats and her inside shakes.

She can't be a princess, that's bullshit.

The shadows reach out for C'yra wrapping around her and she has yanked away from protective arms. She screams and shouts for her momma's until she is face to face with a masked woman, red crystal sparkling on her forehead.

"... us both of you..."

The voice is cold and cruel and it makes C'yra's fur stand up in distress, she squeezes her eyes when one of the shadows nears her, caressing her teary cheeks. She shakes badly.

C'yra hisses at her, but can't hide how she shakes from fear.

"Hm. We will make use of you."

The woman says, her hands coming up to her temple, all she can see is red lights before everything blacks out.

Catra wakes up to Melog nudging her face with their nose and licking their tear-stained face. She heaves for air, grasping her

throat with a pained groan. She shuts her eyes, her dream and reality mixing.

She quickly kicks down the blanket, stumbling out of bed. Her legs are too weak to hold her up, she falls to the floor with a dull thud. She almost screams at the hammering headache, memories of stars, warm hugs, a lullaby, shadows around her and red lights are swirling in front of her. Catra heaves, lungs burning in pain all she can do is hold onto her hair and take a ragged breath.

We will make use of you.

C'yra come on!

We have to go back to them!

Where are momma and mom?!

A scream rips out of her throat as he relives the pain of the moment, again and again, she hears Shadow Weaver's laugh in her head. She can feel Melog around her, trying to calm down the catgirl, but not even they can help the way Catra's whole body hurts.

C'YRA!

She isn't aware of her own pained screams and cries, it all plays down in her mind as if it's another memory too.

" ***Get out of my head*** !"

Her door bursts open, or she assumes. Her hearing dulls down, it rings badly she can barely hear someone calling out her name.

"Kitten! What happened?!" Double Trouble comes near her first but is stopped by Melog. The magical cat jumps in front of them, growling and snarling at the two, blue turned to aggressive red.

"Leave me alone!" Catra cries out, question if it's for the two or her memories.

"Look, I don't want to hurt her. What happened?" the shapeshifter looks at Melog with urgency in their voice. "I promise you, we won't hurt her."

You are an orphan who the Horde took in.

The memory of Shadow Weaver looking down on Catra burns her mind, the sorcerer's voice is distant, yet disgusted. Catra relives her fear and uncertainty, the way she wanted to run away.

The Horde.

The Horde took her in.

No. They didn't. They kidnapped her.

The Horde kidnapped her.

Catra gasps, opening her eyes. Chest heaving heavily, sweat rolls down her temple with her tears. She pants looking up at the ceiling, the amulet on her bed glows with power.

"Darling?"

Catra slowly sits up, her back facing the two. Melog moves closer to her, aggression long gone. They nuzzle against Catra's wet cheeks, but the girl doesn't react at all. She just stares in front of herself, down to her legs. All she can see is its scars. At her ankle, her calf, thighs. Scars caused by Shadow Weaver's magic and her sick satisfaction with torturing Catra.

Her laugh comes as a surprise. It's not out of amusement, rather dry and painful. "Of course... *Of course* , they did, "She pushes her bangs back, it falls into her eyes regardless. "And I... I *helped* them... I served the Horde, I... The people who killed my kind, I..."

She reaches to her bed, trying to stand up, stumbling on her legs again. This time, Double Trouble holds onto her, carefully at her

shoulder. Catra doesn't even react. Melog pushes against her leg, looking up at her.

"What happened? What are you..."

Catra, once again, feels the way numbness takes over her brain, pushing a fog around it, blocking every thought that could run through it. Empty. That's how she can describe herself.

The most infuriating thing is that the Horde has destroyed her home, robbing Catra of her childhood, family and home. Took her, raised as a soldier, to do the same thing that happened with her. And she did such a good job being the bad guy, destroying kingdoms, cities, families, lives. She did it without care. She became like the ones who destroyed everything for her.

A monster. You are a monster. You are just like them, just like Shadow Weaver. Just like Hordak. A destroyer. A monster.

The wicked voice in her head tells her. The voice that's her own.

You don't deserve peace. You don't deserve to play the good guy. You don't deserve help.

She wants to open her mouth, say something, call for Melog, but the words are stuck in her throat. She is unable to utter out even one word.

Double Trouble cups her cheeks, forcing the catgirl to look at them, Catra needs time to focus on the shapeshifter.

"Everything is okay." They try to calm Catra down.

And suddenly she is all too aware of their closeness. It freaks her out, she fights her way out of Double Trouble's touch, taking a few steps back. She just stares at them with her frantic look.

"Everything?" She speaks finally, her voice is hoarse and dry. "No, nothing is okay! The Horde... They... They fucking took me!

Shadow Weaver wiped my memories! How could it be okay?!" She shouts, more out of pain and frustration than anger at the two.

Her memories are still not back, they are still hazy little fog. She can only remember the last few moments of her knowing about her childhood. The way Shadow Weaver's shadows wrap around her and the sorcerer plays with her brain as she wants.

Silence settles in the room, the other two clearly not knowing what she is talking about, or what has happened that triggered yet another panic attack for Catra. Maybe the worst yet.

Melog walks to her, pushing their head into her palm, trying to ground the distressed catgirl as she tries to cope with the fact that she in fact was kidnapped, her memories wiped and forced to grow up in the Horde as a soldier.

"Catra." The first time Double Trouble ever called her real name. "What did happen?"

Catra's eyes Double Trouble, still alert. Her ears are pinned down and her tail didn't stop lashing around for even a second.

They need a few minutes, mostly for Catra to calm down and gain some clarity in the midst of the storm that's happening inside of her.

"The Horde, they kidnapped me as a child. And they wiped my memories away." Catra takes a deep breath, her back straightens and pupils narrow down, the frenzy from her eye disappears. Instead, it radiates cold. Her shaking hand balls up to a fist. “And I will make them pay for it…”

“Darling-”

“You are either with me or get out of my way.”

moondusted cheeks

By the next day when the last moon dawns, Catra has demolished all of the Horde troops in Venus.

The robots are scattered around in pieces, even the tanks have been blown up, their weapons were taken so they could be used against the other camps here. Their communication with the other Horde camps has been severed, and Catra has a detailed map of where the other Horde settlements are. The soldiers are thrown into the oh so convenient Great Prison. Melog didn't say a word about it, but Catra knows they don't agree with her.

By the end of the week, the Horde has been purged out of the Crimson Waste.

There's this insatiable fury burning in her veins, she just wants to destroy and destroy everything.

Deep down Catra knows she is spiralling down again, the little control she had over her life slipping away. But at the same time, she can't make herself care about it. It feels like the portal all over again, or when she went against Hordak. Although, it feels much more suffocating and drowning.

She goes to sleep and wakes up with nightmares, screaming and clawing herself. Melog tries to talk with her, sometimes settling on Catra's chest, purring loudly and nuzzling her cheeks when the catgirl is out of it, trying to sink her claws into her arms. She tries to trigger more memories, now knowing that the throbbing headaches are happening because Shadow Weaver's magic tries to keep them at bay. Catra still tries, reading Lon's journals, going to the crypts just soaking in as much information about the Magicats as she can.

One time it fucked up her so bad she basically threw up from the pain or another time she passed out. She still remembers how angry Double Trouble was and tried to reason with her, needless

to say, it was useless. After that Double Trouble basically doesn't talk to her, their reasoning was *'I'm not watching your fall again'.* It's okay, Catra got used to silent treatments before and they still stick around, watching from the shadows.

She knows the shapeshifter speaks with Huntara through a pad they have recovered from one of the Horde camps. They are a few days away from Crimson Waste. Catra doesn't know more than that, refuses to know.

Catra recognizes some soldiers, their face or their name distantly ringing a bell to her. She has probably ordered them around when she was a commander, some of them look at the catgirl like she is a ghost or their worst nightmare coming back to life. After all, Catra is reported dead to the Horde.

It would be nice to waltz into the Fright Zone and just wreck everything once and for all. Maybe even kill Hordak. But first, Catra has more pressing matters. Getting the Horde out of the Crimson Waste was nothing but a poor attempt to soothe her anger. She still needs to know the full truth about what happened that night, how did the Horde infiltrate into the Magicat's kingdom if they have been hiding for centuries. So many questions, but not answers.

"We are going to Halfmoon, pack up." She announces once she is back from the last Horde settlement.

This time, Double Trouble didn't go with her, however, they have been waiting for her by the gate they have built around the valley. Catra doesn't spare a look at them, walking away, Melog moseying after her. Catra hides her bloody hand under her cloak, but the bruise on her jaw and neck shows, still healing.

"Are you sure you want to go? You are not in the best emotional state lately." Melog tells her, worry and concern in their voice.

Catra doesn't answer either of them.

Double Trouble reaches after her, grabbing the catgirl by her elbow. "You need to rest." They say harshly.

"No, I don't." Catra yanks her hand away. "If you don't want to come I can just go alone." She narrows her eyes on the shapeshifter. "You've been whining to finally go and now you want to stay?"

"It's not about that, darling. You didn't sleep in *two* days."

Catra growls lowly. "I'm okay."

“The princesses will be here tomorrow. I thought you said you want to stop running away.”

The magicat leaps away, Melog in her toe at some point they disappear from the two, Melog's magic concealing them from the world. Back in her house, she sheds her cloak with a pained face she inspects her arm. It got a cut from a robot. Melog sits down, watching as Catra, with expert moves, cleans it up and wraps up the cut sitting on the floor.

Melog eventually lays their head down on Catra's lap and the catgirl starts petting them gently.

"You were mean with them," Melog informs, voice mixed with soft purring.

Catra doesn't answer for a long time. "I know... I always am." She mumbles sadly.

"It's not their fault, they are just worried. Aren't you friends?"

"I don't need friends. We are just... Partners or whatever." She huffs, irritated. "They are helping with this whole Magicat thing, that's it."

"They are helping because you are friends." They glance up at Catra.

"Melog."

"Why are you sad when I mention friends?"

"Because, as I said, I don't need friends. They just leave you, use you. Friends are useless." Catra hisses with spite.

The silence stretches slowly between them. Catra is half relieved that Melog seemed to drop the topic, her joy isn't long-lived. "Is it because of Adora? Or because the princesses are close to the waste?"

"Melog, get out of my head!"

"I'm not *in* your head."

Catra groans, laying back on the ground. Her wild mane spreads on the floor, one of her hands comes up and shields her eyes. She takes a deep breath, trying to think clearly.

"I don't want to talk about Adora... Or friends, or anything in particular. I just want to get to Halfmoon." She whispers, and Melog lays down next to her in silence.

But of course, it's not that simple.

Catra has been rethinking her life in the Horde. Why did Shadow Weaver take her away if she did nothing but torment Catra? Why did the sorcerer keep her alive in the first place?

The answer is quite simple: *Adora.*

That little blonde dumbass was fond of Catra the moment they met. Catra was only at the Horde for a few days, some kid picked up on her because of her ears and tail, calling her an animal and joked about Catra having fleas. Adora beat them up (okay, that's a long stretch, she just kicked them in the shin), then Adora spent the next few hours trying to get Catra's name and making friends with her. Eventually, she named the catgirl Catra.

It wasn't that hard, Catra was just as equally attached to her, although she did claw on Adora's arm out of panic at first.

They have been attached by the hip since then, until that unfaithful day when Adora found that fucking sword.

Shadow Weaver liked - *enjoyed* - telling Catra her life was worth something because Adora liked her, and wanted Catra in her life. The sorcerer told her, not once not twice, that the moment she will become useless to Adora, it will be her last day too. Because Catra without Adora is useless.

Maybe that's why Catra tried to cling to Adora so badly, growl and hiss at everyone who tried to befriend the blonde. Maybe that's why Catra was so angry and furious when Adora just left because it meant Shadow Weaver was right. Right in the fact that Catra was nothing but a pet to her, someone who she can have fun with but kick aside the moment Adora doesn't need her.

Thinking back she has believed everything Shadow Weaver has told hold, subconsciously she *still* believes in them.

But Catra has to remind herself the sorcerer was wrong. Mad wrong.

Catra climbed up on that ladder, she accomplished more than what Shadow Weaver ever or Adora could have had if she stayed. She became a Force Captain. Hordak's second in command. She was a commander. She *ran* the Horde.

And what did you gain from it?

That little cruel voice whispers in her head. What did Catra gain?

More guilt and shame, which she can barely carry at this point. Scars that marred not just her body, but her soul too. Mistakes are piling up behind the wall she has built, hiding behind it, yet they are tumbling over, threatening to bury her.

Still, Catra stayed at the Horde for two long years. Trying to show everyone she is more than they thought. She is not a failure or a disappointment. She is strong and powerful.

She sits up, going to her desk and pulling out a sheet of paper.

Now, out of the spiderwebs of mind games running deep in the Horde, Catra sees a little bit clearer. And it hurts. So fucking much. She can't run away from them for so long, she knows it, yet she tries. She still tries to run away from facing her past. Even though a week ago she was the one asking Huntara to bring them here. As their arrival comes closer and closer, Catra is more terrified than ever.

Runaway from Entrapta, Scorpia, Shadow Weaver, Hordak, the Rebellion. Adora.

It's okay - she tells herself - it's okay as long as I can run.

And what if you can't run away anymore?

In exactly 20 minutes they are loaded to go. Catra jumps into the skiff from a rooftop, sitting down, back against the railing. She says nothing to Double Trouble who ignites the machine, which comes to life almost silently. Melog appears next to her.

She also notices a few bags shoved into the corner, and a few sleep bags rolled up together. They don't know how long their journey would be exactly, Melog can't tell either, being prepared is better than anything at this moment. Uncomfortable silence

settles among them, Catra tugs her knees closer to her chest, hiding them completely under her cloak.

Catra stubbornly looks ahead, Melog settling down next to her.

Double Trouble drives away, not initiating any conversation.

Melog instructs Catra where to go, what the catgirl passes on to Double Trouble

For now, their only direction is forward.

"So is this how our kingdom searching trip will go, in complete silence?" Double Trouble eventually breaks the unbearable silence.

Catra shrugs then realize the other can't see her. "You pester me about useless shits. I'm completely okay."

"Of course, blowing up approximately eleven Horde settlements must have put you in a good mood." The shapeshifter commented offhandedly.

"Yes, it was indeed therapeutic if you are wondering." Catra bites back eyes narrowing.

Double Trouble scoffs. "I at least hope it improved your mood because now the Horde will definitely be on our ass, darling."

"I told you-"

"Yes, that you want to make the Horde pay. But you can't see from your anger, again."

"What do you mean again?!" Catra stands up, tails thrashing around. Melog just looks between the two.

Double Trouble glances at them, slightly annoyed. "Do I have to list it to you how many times you acted on your anger and it ended up being catastrophic? Not to mention you were the one

who agreed on bringing the princesses here, and you are running away, once again!”

“It’s not that easy!” Catra growls. “I agreed to help, but… But it’s not the same... You... You wouldn’t understand.”

Double Trouble sighs, they clearly want to say something more but instead, they choose silence again. Catra settles back to the floor, curling into herself.

“I’m sorry.” Catra mumbles after a while. “It’s just… Hard. I hurt these people. A lot. I want to fix the things I have fucked up, I want to… I want to stand before them without feeling guilty or shameful, but it’s not easy… Running away is. It has always been easier.”

Double Trouble looks down at Catra, then ahead of themselves again. They don’t say anything for a while. “Easier doesn’t always mean it’s the best solution.”

“Yeah, it doesn’t.”

“You don’t have to tell me if you don’t want, kitten.”

“No, I... I want you to understand”

Talking about the Horde isn't easy. It's easier to reminiscence about it when she is alone and can either break something or cry. She never actually talked about it to other people, other than Adora.

"It was... Hard in the Horde, most of the time... Sometimes, it was a little bit easier. They never really cared about us, just enough so we could stay alive and train and then be deployed then either die or go to another mission." Catra plays with the amulet absentmindedly, staring in front of her. Melog scoots closer, she pets their head.

”I’ve never… Learned how to deal with my emotions, or myself in general. After Adora left... It got worse, I... I had to learn how to

survive alone. It didn’t end up well.” She scoffs humorlessly. "I don't need any of your sorry or pity." She quickly ads. "Whatever happened, it happened. Feeling sorry won't change anything."

"But killing your former bosses does?"

"Who knows." Catra shrugs. "I've always hated Shadow Weaver... I've had a complicated relationship with her." She formulates carefully. "Killing her would mean some peace. And Hordak is just a prick. I'm surprised he could bounce the Horde back."

"Turn to the right."

Catra glances down to Melog, who has their eyes closed, purring lightly. "Turn right."

"Are you sure you want to actually kill them?" Double Trouble arches an eyebrow, doubt in their eyes.

"Yes, I've killed people before if that's what you want to know. Why are you so stuck at this?" Catra asks, offended and confused at the same time.

"Murdering someone who you don't know is easy, anyone can do that." They shrug. "But you have a deep history with this two-person, I'm just asking so you won't self-loathe after that, kitten."

Catra huffs, ears moving forwards. "I don't do self-loathing! And even *if* I would, not because of them. They do deserve it." She murmurs lowly.

They drop the topic after this. Double Trouble spares her a curious look, as if they are trying to read her but can't do it, or they are just waiting for the right time to drop it.

"You feel better." Melog doesn't ask, they just announce it.

Catra simply nods.

"That's good. But you are still hurt. I can feel it."

The magicat sighs, closing her eyes, closing off the word from her mind.

Her tranquillity isn't long-lived, the faint headache builds up slowly and red lights flash behind her eyes. She snaps them open, trying to look as casual as she can without giving herself away to the other. She takes a deep breath, slowly exhaling it.

They navigate through the desert, oftentimes stopping so Double Trouble could force some food into Catra’s stomach because apparently neglecting food is also okay for her after not sleeping for 48 hours. This travel definitely is longer than Catra would have thought. Melog can feel the runestone but so weakly that they sometimes had to turn back or stop and figure out where to go.

Melog says they are approximately halfway through when they stop for the night.

"Why can't we just travel through the night too?" Catra asks, still helping set up their small camp for the night.

"You went through two days without sleeping, no way I'm letting you do it for the third time. Plus, you are easier to deal with if you slept at least 2 hours." Double Trouble ads, dropping their sleeping bags onto the floor.

They set up their camp eventually, their sleep bags rolled out. Double Trouble seems to be experienced in how to set up a camp quickly, they even lit a small bonfire for themselves.

"Exactly how long this kingdom hunt will take?" Double Trouble asks eventually.

Catra looks at Melog, who settled down next to her.

"Hard to tell. Sometimes I feel the runestone stronger, other times it's weaker. But I can definitely say that we are much closer." Melog tells Catra what she passes on to the others.

Double Trouble groans. "Great."

"Though you liked the desert?" Catra takes a bite from her dinner.

"I like the desert. I, however, do *not* like spending the night *in* the desert." They deadpan. "Thought it would be much faster too."

Melog rumbles annoyedly at the shapeshifter, Catra laughing at it.

They eventually settle into a comfortable conversation. Catra's mind is still a mess, she feels the anger simmering in her body, but Melog's call out helps her a little and the fact that the Horde is out of Crimson Waste relaxes her a bit. Not to mention their little conversation with Double Trouble helped her, and she hopes the shapeshifter will understand that she doesn't want to run, wants to fix things. But ultimately too afraid to do it.

She isn't okay, but she tries.

She thinks back to the letter she has written before leaving the valley, leaving it on her bed. She half hopes Adora wouldn't find it, but now it's too late to have second guesses right?

So Catra is sitting at the rock, her back facing the sleeping Double Trouble by the bonfire. Melog is curled around her, with closed eyes, but they are not asleep. The catgirl twirls the amulet in between her fingers, deep in her thought. Her ears twitch from time to time at the noises around them, either the shapeshifter moves around, or some nightly creature is hunting.

Catra tries to remind herself about sweeter memories, trying to find comfort in something other than herself or the thoughts they will soon find Halfmoon. Or so she hopes.

She harbours her memories to warm gold and blue eyes that have been constant in her dreams. Soft and radiating with love. She remembers them not just from dreams, but from the moment she has almost drowned in the Great Prison. They called her C'yra, Catra notes that trying to figure out what it could mean. Is it the name of a rank, a nickname, something else? She is unsure, not being familiar with her own culture is hard enough without trying to figure out confusing names.

There's familiarity in them, whenever Catra thinks back to the two figures all she feels is deep longing and warmth. She assumes they must have known her before.

"I hope we can meet again." She whispers wistfully.

Hours pass and Catra is still sitting on the rock. The catgirl trustfully, as afraid to sleep. She knows well nights don't grant her rest or calm, she rather not try just so she could be tormented with dreams again.

Melog nudges her thighs gently. “Sleep a little, tomorrow will be a long day.”

“Do you see the future now too?” She chuckles a little, but eventually, she leaves the rock and walks to their bonfire.

When the morning comes they all continue their journey, Catra much calmer although she can still feel the underlying fire of anger in her soul each time she thinks back to her memories, which is kind of inevitable since they are searching for Halfmoon.

Melog sits in front of Catra, enjoying the way the catgirl is petting them while they navigate where they should go.

"Turn back," Catra tells.

"This is the third time we are turning back!" Double Trouble shouts out of frustration, yanking the lever around and harshly turning around. "Not to disrespect your magic cat or anything, but are they sure where we are going?" They question.

"Tell them that yes, I know where we are going. The signal is getting stronger." Melog turns their head looking at Catra.

Catra nods, "They said yes."

The shapeshifter just grumbles.

"I just have a question," The shapeshifter starts. "How are we going to go inside Halfmoon?" They look at Catra and then Melog. "I mean we know that the kingdom is hidden somewhere, but I sincerely doubt it would welcome us so openly."

"We will figure something out if we get there." Catra thinks out loud. She stopped petting Melog, the magical cat looked back at her with unapproving eyes.

It takes them half of a day to reach the point where Melog says stop.

No matter in what direction they look at, there's nothing here. Not even an enormous bone, ruins or even rocks around. Just an enormous space. Melog walks next to Catra. The magicat stops, looking down at their familiar.

"Melog?"

"I feel it here. The runestone is somewhere here." They confirm with a confident voice, Catra simply nods. She believes them, but...

"Then where it is..." Catra wonders, looking around with almost desperate eyes.

"So?" The shapeshifter questions.

"Melog says the runestone is here." She parrots what the magical cat said. "Don't say a thing. I know what you are thinking." She turns eyeing Double Trouble.

The shapeshifter feigns innocence as they walk towards them. "I have no idea what you are talking about, darling." They bop Catra's nose."So, what are we going to do?"

"We are going to search for something... An opening, a trap, magical voice suddenly speaking in your head. Something."

"Oh yes, because hearing a voice in your head is *very* affirming." Double Trouble comments offhandedly.

"You know what I mean!"

Catra walks away with Melog on her side, she tries to sniff in the air - hoping maybe it would lead her somewhere, it doesn't -, try to listen to every little noise, but still nothing. There aren't a lot of noises in the desert either way, but here it's almost dead silent except their movement on the sand. Almost every part of the Crimson Waste Catra had been littered with either bones, rocks, small canyons or bigger ones. But here, everything is empty.

Too empty.

"Is everything okay Catra?" Melog asks, bumping their head against Catra's hip.

"Isn't it too... Empty? As if someone is missing from here." She narrows her eyes, her instincts going haywire expecting every bad outcome that could ever occur here. "Let's go a little farther."

Melog follows Catra, their tail lashing around anxiously just like Catra's. But Melog can feel the magic of the runestone clearly, they tell Catra. So the catgirl has no doubt they are pretty close.

You've come at last.

Catra stops the moment she hears the voice in her head. She turns around, ready to pounce and attack, but she sees nothing. Her ears move forward anxiously, the amulet's glow is getting stronger with each second.

"Did you hear it too Melog?" She glances down at the magical cat who shakes its head. "What?"

Come home, child. We are waiting for you.

Catra groans, pushing her bangs away. She takes a deep breath. "Okay, so it's only me again. Perfect. You've said I've come home, but there's nothing here." Catra reasons with the voice in her head. "Is it a trick?"

She doesn't notice that Double Trouble is looking at her curiously and mildly concerned, as she is almost yelling out of frustration.

There's no answer to her question. "Answer me! What the fuck is going on?!"

We are waiting.

"Then show me how I can go home!" Catra growls, her patience is getting worn out pretty quickly. "Please, how can I find Halfmoon?"

You are in Halfmoon. You have the key.

"What key? What are you talking about?" Catra questions, there's no answer. She waits for it, but nothing. Just silence. She growls and kicks the sand away. "I have no key!"

Double Trouble steps next to her. "Let me guess, the magical voice in the head?" They arch an eyebrow.

"A *very* annoying magical voice." She hopes it hears her and probably gets offended. If magical voices can get offended. Catra doesn't know much about magic.

"What did it say?"

"That we are in Halfmoon and I have the key. But I have no fucking key!" She groans angrily, her bangs flapping into her eyes. Then, Catra stops for second eyebrows furrowing then she quickly

takes off the amulet from her neck. She looks at the orange glowing crystal which seems to be brighter, even warmer here.

"The runestone shard?" Melog tilts their head.

"I mean, it's the only thing I can think of." Catra looks down at Melog. "But how do I use it? There's nothing here where I can use it."

Melog shakes their head. "I don't know either, I'm sorry."

"Would appreciate it if you let me into whatever you are talking about with Melog." Double Trouble suggests, arms crossed in front of them.

"The crystal is part of the runestone, so it might be the key." She holds the crystal towards them. "But I don't know how to use it as a key, neither Melog."

"Maybe say something to it? A code or something?"

Magic is far relevant here in the Crimson Waste, not a lot of people know anything about it, therefore Catra isn't surprised that none of them has a good idea on this matter.

That's how they ended up with Catra standing, jiggling around the amulet yelling words and names, while Double Trouble is seated on the sand, Melog sitting next to them. They, occasionally, offer some suggestions to the angry catgirl.

"Halfmoon! Magicat! Queen Nefi! Uh... Runestone! Crimson Waste!" Catra can feel her throat getting drier with each word she yells, her voice getting rougher. It's hot here, she is sweating badly and mad on top of that. "Oh come on!"

"Why don't you try ordering it to work?" The shapeshifter suggests, bored and clearly hot as well.

Catra looks back at them, then at the amulet. "Show me Halfmoon!" Nothing. "I command you to let me into Halfmoon!"

Nothing. "I demand entry to Halfmoon!" Nothing. Again. Catra growls at the amulet. "This is clearly not working."

"Do you know any other Magicat royalty? Maybe their name could be the key." Double Trouble speaks absentmindedly, way too fascinated by Melog's colour changing mane as Catra's anger gets worse their mane bleeds to a deeper red.

"Uh... Queen Harron?" Catra tries to work through her mind, she remembers reading about other royals too, and she explored the crypt hundreds of times too. "King Leondo? Queen Purga! Princess Peria. Princess Tabinea?" Catra sighs, nothing is happening. "Any more ideas? I'm out of them."

"Ask it?" Melog eventually speaks.

Catra furrows her brows, a bit confused. "Ask it?" She parrots.

"Ask it to let you into Halfmoon."

"Ugh, it's worth a try." She reluctantly agrees. "Please let me into Halfmoon." She asks the amulet, which is still glowing. They all wait in silence, in hopes that it will finally work. But silence again. "Please, let me find my home." She presses, her voice softer and urgent almost.

The amulet suddenly bursts into flames, Catra drops it with a hiss, Melog is at her side growling and snarling at the magical item. Instead of falling to the ground, it floats in the air, sparkling fire emitting from the single piece of crystal. Catra just looks at it with widened eyes, the other slowly walking to her side, equally as shocked.

"What just... happened?" Double Trouble mutters.

"I think I've activated the key." Catra breathes, unable to take her eyes away from the fire.

"That's uhm... That's great, but... What to do now?"

The outside world drowns out for Catra, it's all the flaming crystal and she. Feels like she has fallen into some kind of trance as her eyes bore into the dancing orange flames, familiarity washes over her once again. But it's not distant, barely even reachable. It's in front of her, a grasp away.

She slowly raises her arm, her hand lingering around the flame. Catra passes through the flames, grasping the crystal. Her pupils are glowing with an orange glow.

"C'yra of Halfmoon." She says softly, barely above a whisper.

The flames expand in a matter of seconds spreading out around them. It doesn't burn them, doesn't emit heat either. Catra feels a pull as if she is being hauled down to the ground by an invisible strong power, she grasps onto Double Trouble as they are falling. The fire disappears around them, the amulet falls to the ground just like the other four on a pile.

"Ugh!" Double Trouble grunts in pain, everyone falling onto them. "What was *that?* " they question, voice loud and it suddenly echoes around them.

Catra grumbles, climbing down from them Melog hopping down next to her. "Where are... we..."

They are in a tunnel, similar to what the crypt has. Chiselled marble floor, symbols carved into the wall, fire, stars and moons. Crystals etched into the walls, glowing softly, providing them with light. Catra turns around, there's only a wall behind them, even the ceiling of the tunnel is completely sealed. They were transported here by magic.

"Are you okay, Catra?" Melog asks.

Catra just nods wordlessly. Staring into the tunnel that leads them downwards. "We should go down... Not like we have any other choices." She huffs, taking the amulet from the ground and hanging it in her neck.

Melog stays close to Catra, walking next to the catgirl. They look up at Catra occasionally checking on her, probably feeling how disconnected Catra is from the world around them.

It's like she is floating in between the real world and the fog that surrounds part of her mind, keeping her away from the past. Ever since the amulet has fired up and she said that name, C'yra again. *Who* is C'yra and why did she know that it was the answer?

"Because you are a princess." Melog's voice interrupts her mess of thoughts. Catra glances down at them with sharp glances.

"I'm not a princess." Catra denies it, again and again. "Stop with this shit."

"What?" Double Trouble asks, suddenly very interested in the conversation. "You are what?"

"I'm nothing." Catra hisses. "Ugh, Melog thinks that I'm a princess because of the amulet. And I think it's absolutely stupid, so don't even ask or agree with it." She warns the other two with narrowed pupils.

"Well, it's not a bad theory." They start slowly. "I mean, the amulet works for you and everything... You also said that it's from the runestone. Plus, your magical cat seems to know a lot of things, so I'm siding with them." Double Trouble points at Melog who is smiling proudly.

"You are impossible." Catra groans, turning away and continuing her walk.

"Just think about it, kitten. It wouldn't be so bad to be a princess." The shapeshifter taunts her.

Catra scoffs. "No. It would be awful. Thank you very much, I don't want to be a sparkly princess, sit around all day and drink tea or whatever the fuck they do." She shrugs, trying to be as nonchalant as she can. "End of discussion."

"You are no fun."

Catra doesn't comment on Double Trouble's remark. Instead, she focuses ahead of herself, silence falls onto them, while Catra feels more and more anxious with each step she takes forward. Up until now, the possibility of getting close to the hidden Magicat kingdom was a distant thought for her for months. Now, basically at their doorstep Catra wants to run away, or at least wait around until she feels finally ready to face everything she has searched for so far.

Melog seems to feel Catra's troubling emotions, as they push their head gently against her thigh and hip, trying to calm her down.

And this fucking princess matter too. She doesn't care if her parents were simple people if they were warriors or her mother sold flowers, Catra really doesn't care. But being part of a royal bloodline, making her a princess is something Catra dreads from.

That would be a cruel joke from the universe.

She has fought against princesses, invaded their kingdom, hurt them, blamed them. And now, she would magically be one too.

Her tail lashes around anxious, and her ears are pinned back against her hair. Even if she wants to look absolutely nonchalant, she can't force her body.

Eventually, as they go deeper, the tunnel widens out. In between the crystals, mosaic pictures lay, similar to Queen Nefi's in the crypt. They are much smaller and instead of illustrating the first queen, they tell about stars and moons, battles and conquest, peace and harmony, fire and warriors. Catra soon realizes it tells the Magicat's history or at least a portion of that. The symbols are getting bigger until they reach a big, heavily decorated door made out of marble and gold accents, words etched into the surface.

Let the moons be your guide, the fire your light and the stars your companion,

May your journey bring glory and peace to your soul, warrior of fire, welcome home.

"Is... Is this..?" Double Trouble's voice trails off.

Catra steps forward, while her tail curls around her waist, with a heavily beating heart and troubled mind, she puts her hand on the door, pushing it open.

The door creaks loudly, dust and small rocks falling to the ground from above. It opens slowly as if it wasn't open for years, and remained closed until now. Once it's open, and the flying dust settles the gate of Halfmoon lays before them. It arches up, made out of stone and at the centre front a statue of Queen Nefi stands, a living flame in her hand.

Beyond the gate, there's a bridge stretching forward. It's massive, made out of stone and marble, at either side of the bridge's opening two magical cat statue sits, with an open mouth ready to attack.

It's hard to see beyond the bridge, as it's long. As Catra looks up, she sees stars and moons shining down upon them.

"What... How..." She mumbles, stepping inside, passing through the gate. She can't take her eyes away from the sky.

Can we look at the stars a little more?

Sudden pains stuck down, Catra winces her head pounding with sharp pain. Another memory. Catra forces it forward, concentrating on it, trying to grab the frayed end of it. But as it came so quickly, it vanished too with the pain.

Melog nuzzles her hand, wrapping their tail around Catra's calf. "Another memory?

"Fuck."

Double Trouble steps next to the magicat, their silence caused by their shock, jaw dropped and eyes widened. "This is... Unbelievable..." They mutter. "To have a place like this *under* the Crimson Waste is...Maddening." Double Trouble finishes, even their ability to come up with something snarky has disappeared since entering here.

It takes them time to come through their initial shock or at least part of it. Neither of them can believe that this has existed under them for centuries, and they didn't even see the city. They hear no noise, everything is so silent, almost feels empty looking at these two massive buildings and no life around them.

"Do you think they know someone opened the door?"

"I don't know... Judging from the empty welcome, I don't think so..."

Melog is unusually silent, which somehow sets Catra off a bit, but also the fact that everything seems so familiar yet so distant is playing tricks on her. She would hear fleet of a child laughing, patters of small legs, distant conversation, but no one else hears them except her. She looks over the stone rail, seeing a river running below the bridge, up from here is hard to say if it's shallow or not. Catra doesn't want to find out.

They walk in silence, expecting some attack or anything really. The silence is unsettling and nerve-wracking. Every inch of Catra's instinct tells her to draw her claws out and stands still until someone tries to ambush her. Instead, she tries to remain calm and collected.

Double Trouble stops suddenly. "We are not alone."

Catra's ear twitches, before she could react someone kicks her in the face, Catra stumbles back, back against the rail. She growls, claws unsheathed. Her enemy towers over her, they have a black uniform, Catra can't think much about it, trying to jump away

from another attack, but her opponent is much quicker sending Catra to the ground again.

Double Trouble is busy with their own attackers, Melog jumping in front of Catra biting into their opponent's arms. Catra takes the opportunity to attack, she kicks the guy in the chin, they just stumble back.

She is about to launch forward, but another attack, a magical ball sends her over the railing. Catra tries to grip the rail, missing it. With a scream, she falls, into the river.

Thankfully Melog was just as fast, jumping after her. They bite Catra's cloak, keeping her afloat as they jump onto a rock, still holding onto Catra. She climbs onto it too, coughing up water and gasping for water.

"What the fuck was that." She breathes, voice a little rough.

Melog looks up, they are directly under the bridge, no one could see them. "I think they must have been the guards."

Catra groans, annoyed. "Let's get out of this river then we can think about what to do. They are skilled fighters, Double Trouble must have gotten captured." She says, squeezing the water out of her cloak and hair, her fur bristled up in distress.

"What do you want to do?"

"Eh, I don't know yet." She sighs, jumping to the dry ground, looking up. It would be an easy climb. "I didn't expect to get attacked, so I need a minute or two to work out a plan."

Melog teleports up to the top of the rocky wall, while Catra climbs upon it. Melog suggested teleporting Catra too, but the magicat chewed her own leg off rather than teleport. The first time she tried, she was sick for almost half a day. With a huff, Catra lays down on the ground, catching her breath.

"I think I'm out of shape..." She sighs, standing up.

Melog stands too. "Well, you haven't been working out a lot recently."

Catra huffs. "You were not supposed to agree to that."

She turns, seeing the edge of the city a few meters away from her, it has a high wall around, possibly guarded - she assumes -. Catra looks around, spotting the end of the bridge far away, that's probably the only opening, it would be risky to take it, even with Melog's ability to make them invisible. She sniffs around, trying to pick up Double Trouble's scent, but nothing.

Without saying a word, Melog stands next to her, Catra touches their forehead and they are concealed from the world. They make their way to the wall, what Catra climbs with ease and Melog jumps up.

There's a small space on top of the wall, probably for patrol. Catra's eyes widen as the Magicat city, Halfmoon reveals itself in front of her. It's much bigger than she would have thoughts, maybe as big as the Fright Zone, possibly bigger. Houses tower each other, the streets are busy with people chatting around, kids laughing and running, playing. She spots various shops around her, orange crystals hanging around from marble columns.

What catches her eyes is the royal palace at the far east side, coming out of the enormous rock wall, a waterfall bracketing it from either side.

"Beautiful..." She whispers, stunned. She has half expected to have memories attacking her again, but nothing. Which is a little disappointing, but a big part of her is glad too. She needs to be focused on.

"Ready?" Melog asks, their blue eyes twinkling with happiness. Catra assumes hers would look the same.

"Yeah. Let's stay on the roof though."

The two of them jump around the houses with ease, Catra sometimes stops to observe a few things, like the fountain, or children playing tag, shops she has never heard about. What is a seamstress? Melog doesn't know either.

The city seems to have developed tech too, although not as advanced as what the Horde has used. No one seems to run around with a magical cat-like Melog either.

"Oh, what's that?" They stop abruptly on a rooftop, Catra peers down at a bakery. She tilts her head, one ear twitching, Melog mirrors her. "It smells delicious." She wonders, never smelt anything this sweat before. "Remind me to come back here, once we have Double Trouble."

"Do you feel any memories resurfacing?"

Catra shakes her head. "Well... It's not memories explicitly, but I feel like I know this place. I know specific routes, where to turn and when. I know this city, that's for sure. But I still have no memories." She says sadly, looking down at her legs. "Anyways, let's go."

They jump to another rooftop, Catra is letting her feet lead her, without thinking much about it. They pass through the market, the bazaar and probably the centre judging from the big bonfire in the middle of the huge street. A fleeting memory of fire kittens passed through her mind.

Melog doesn't ask where they are going, trusting Catra's instinct and their own too.

"You don't understand, I'm a true performer. I can't go to jail!"

Catra stops, her ears moving forward as she hears Double Trouble's voice from another street.

It's not hard to find them, both of them in some type of magical chain, or so Catra assumes because Double Trouble can get out of the stickiest situations. They are guarded by 5 magicats.

"You are not going to jail." One of the magicat says.

It takes them by surprise.

"Then where?" They ask, suspiciously eyeing their guards.

"You will be brought to the Queen."

Catra swears under her breath, this is not good. She wouldn't be able to get them out if they set afoot to the castle, but attacking even now would be foolish. None of them knows the territory to move along comfortably, they don't even know what magicats are capable of. Catra still hisses at the thought of how easily she was beaten down.

"What about the other one, who fell into the river?"

Catra could argue that she did not fall, she was kicked into it. The guard gets no answer.

"What are we going to do?" Melog looks at Catra, already feeling her uneasiness going out of tracks.

"I... I don't know. We should follow them for now, I will try to think of something until then." Catra groans, jumping to the next rooftop, following the guards.

The castle looks enormous even from far away, but as they are nearing the building Catra feels like it could swallow her like a gigantic monster would a simple ant. For some strange reason, this thought feels familiar, as if she is not hearing it for the first time. She stops, scaling the surroundings.

A handful of guards stand by the main gate that leads to the castle, Catra and Melog sneak around them, trying to keep up the pace with the guards, without causing any noise. The city didn't have any effect on her, no strange feeling or unusual memories. But this place?

There's so much emotion swirling in her heart, familiarity, longing, dread, love. Anxiety rises in her thinking back to what Melog has told her. She can't be a princess. There has to be another explanation of why the castle feels oh so familiar.

Her muscles tenses and relaxes, warmth enveloping her like an old friend, taunting her to abandon Melog's magic. The last time she had this reaction was when she was cuddled with Adora. Warm and safe.

Safe .

Why does she feel safe in enemy territory?!

Catra stops in her tracks, Melog bumping into her leg, overwhelmed by the storm of emotions.

"Catra?" They call for her, "Catra we are going to lose them."

Noooo! That's cheating! I won!

Catra turns around so fast she almost stumbles. There's an empty hallway behind her, wait. When did they get this far? Her question momentarily abandoned the moment she sees two kids running around, a red and a black-haired one. They wrestle on the floor, slapping each other with their tails and biting the other's arms while their laughing echoes in the hallways.

That little catgirl looked like her.

"What..." Catra whispers, stepping back shaking her head. They are gone.

"Catra-"

What are you doing here, kitten?

Another voice, without a body. It comes from the hallway from their right. Catra sets off, running by pure instincts and the need to find out what's going on. Is she going crazy? What's

happening? Melog is after her, but she isn't sure anymore if their disguise is up still.

Catra stops at another crossing, spotting a woman with short black hair and a decorative red dress. She crouches down with a soft smile, cradling through a child's wild mane. That child again.

What's wrong, sweetheart?

She asks, the voice and the nickname sounding so familiar, she can almost feel those gentle fingers brushing through her wild hair. Catra watches them with wide, confused eyes.

The child looks like her, a much softer and weaker form of her childhood self.

"No..." Catra takes a step back. "No, it can't be.." She trips back, falling to the floor. Melog nuzzles to her cheeks, trying to calm her down before her panic would spiral down.

Partly she knows Melog is speaking to her, however, everything just sounds blurred together, her headache strikes again, with full force, sending her into a grunting pained mess. She squeezes her eyes in pain, only for it to worsen.

These hallucinations are real. She knows. She feels it in her heart, the tugging, the tears in her eyes, the trembling of her body.

They are real.

Another groan of pain, another memory flash. They are not clear, only for seconds. Faces she has never seen, places she has never seen, voices she has never heard yet they feel homely. Comforting. Hers.

"Catra, Catra, please... I can... Someone is coming!"

She barely registers the words, Melog nudges her onto her knees, trying to push the catgirl to their back. The magic is long gone.

C'yra sweetheart, what are you doing?

I'm so proud of you.

I love you, sweetheart.

The runestone can wait, but not tea!

Come, I will sing you a song.

Did you have a nightmare?

One day, you will be a wonderful princess.

"It was fairly easy to track you down than I would have thought."

Melog freezes as they hear walks closing on them, Catra whimpers, clutching onto Melog as her body shakes. With laboured breath she tries to speak, unable to utter out any word.

Catra raises her head, the light around them hurting her eyes. Vision blurring and clearing with each blink, Catra sees a woman nearing them. Red mane pulled up into a high ponytail, her blue eyes are piercing, but also radiates sadness which has been sitting in her soul for a long time. Her dress is absolutely beautiful, white long pants with a matching white top, the end extending to the back around her calf. The dress is decorated with a red pattern, matching her headpiece and red jewellery hanging around her neck and ears.

Melog steps back, growling aggressively, their mane turning to red and spiking up.

"Your scent gave you away," She speaks again.

That voice. Catra *knows* that voice. Not that tone it's demanding and rough almost, in some way it reminds Catra of her own. But Catra knows this voice for its softness and the love that always weaved in her voice.

It's unclear for Catra what happens next, she feels Melog's grumbling growl resonating through their body, the magical cat moves then retracts with a hiss, they just try to move away again, but stopped.

"M-Melog." Her voice is so weak, barely a whisper. She clutches onto Melog again. "I... It's... okay..."

"But..."

"We can't..." She hisses, gritting her teeth. "We can't escape..."

The magical cat doesn't sound convinced, they back away either way. Trying to protect Catra, even if she wanted to, she is unable to fight. The pain paralyzes her body. It's not one that suddenly came and then suddenly goes, it sweeps into her bones, prickling and shocking her with each new coming memory.

Footsteps, again. Catra turns her head to the side, panting badly. Trying to take a look at the woman again. She forces herself to her elbows, bangs falling onto her eyes. She tries to smile, smugly and confidently, only a grimace comes out of her trial.

A hand comes to her, holding her jaw. Not roughly, but not gentle either. Melog growls and snarls at the woman, but doesn't attack her to Catra's request.

Catra can't tell really, but something twists in the woman's face, her eyes going wide as if she is looking at a ghost and not a living creature in front of her. She cradles Catra's face into her hands, leaning closer.

She wants to fight, her claws sheathing and unsheathing, her limbs, however, don't follow her order to move.

She is completely at the mercy of this woman, and she hates it. Her heart beats so fast, dizziness eventually takes over her.

"Look at me, child." The woman commands, and Catra slowly and tiredly locks eyes with the woman.

The woman gasps, or it was Catra? She doesn't know. But those blue eyes, Catra remembers them. Not clearly, from flashes, broken memories. She opens her mouth to say something, only to whimper her headache getting worse.

"Those eyes... What's happening with your child? Answer me!" The woman asks, demands almost in a panic. Catra can't answer, just shake her head, trying to break away from the woman. Melog snaps at the woman, her finally letting go of Catra.

"Catra, can you hear me?" Melog tries. "Catra, Catra!"

Catra wants to speak, damn she wants to scream either in pain or anger, both probably. She takes a harsh breath through her nose, trying to calm down. She needs to get herself together, she turns to the woman again. Shocked to see tears falling from her eyes.

"My... My... Are you really.." She reaches forward again but retracting them almost instantly. "Is it really you? C'yra, is it... Really you?"

That name again. It's not a stranger to her anymore. C'yra is her name. She is C'yra. Was, C'yra.

"Catra." She growls, sounding much more animalistic than she ever did before. "My name is... Cat-.. Catra!" She pants, closing her eyes again. "I'm Catra..."

Warmth radiates around her stomach, the amulet in her neck either reacting to something or trying to ground her from the pain. Either way, it works, a little.

"You have a piece of the runestone." She hears the woman again, Catra looks at her seeing a similar glow coming from the crystal on her headpiece.

"It's okay Catra, you can let go."

She hears Melog, her head spins around.

"She isn't a threat."

Catra wants to scream that everything in this fucking castle, in this place is a threat. She wants to rip her skin, tearing it apart just so the pain can subdue. Just so the fear flooding her heart can disappear.

Another pain, this time it's stronger than the rest. She yells, for a second she swears the world just blacked out because when she opens her eyes the woman is holding her, looking down at her with sadness and grief, shock maybe.

Catra wants to crawl away, her body doesn't move.

"You are okay, you are safe here." The woman whispers to her gently.

Safe.

heart so heavy

Chapter Summary

> "I'm sorry kid." A whisper nothing more, she walks away from the last memory she sees as C'yra.

Chapter Notes

> Well, here it is folks! The last chapter of the first part of this story. I hope you will like it. Hopefully, I will come back soon with the second part!

Visions and dreams intertwine, leading Catra along the way. Looking down at her memories from the outside. Seeing herself run and play around, laugh carelessly and be happy. Most memories are still blocked, corrupted or too broken to look at, magic still holding them back. Catra walks among them, for the first time, without pain she can look back at who she was. Who she could have been.

Her family, her mothers, her brother, grandparents, uncles. They are all there. Faces from the past, she can't connect a name to them, or any particular feelings except longing.

And then her times in the Horde. Shadow Weaver, the nagging of other cadets. Adora. These memories are much clearer, sharper. Feels real.

Adora is here, almost everywhere. In the dorm, during training, on the rooftop, they bandage each other, Shadow Weaver's sanctum. She can still feel her hand in hers, the warmth of it, the gentleness. The way Adora spoke to her, how afraid Adora was to lose Catra.

The sword. She-ra. The Rebellion. The princesses. Catra may never be able to forgive them for stealing the only person she loved from her, the only person *she* loved.

Force Captain, second in command, sitting on Hordak's throne. Commanding and fighting. She sees her own rise and fall. The fall she took.

She walks around in the dark space, memories floating around. She sees and hears them, stopping at the moment she hears the news of Scorpia. When she destroyed the control room, went against Hordak. The breakdowns. In those moments, Catra didn't look strong or unbeatable. She wasn't cold and rough. But she looked more herself than ever.

The broken child finally breaks down under all the weight on her shoulder. All the ghosts of her past finally catching up on her, and she wasn't able to fight them anymore.

Catra walks away.

She doesn't know how long she has been here, could be only seconds or even hours, maybe days, years. Everything blurs together with the memories as she explores them, spends time in them, trying to familiarize herself with the life she had as C'yra but feeling more and more distanced from it with each minute.

C'yra was a princess, someone who was destined to take the title of a Queen one day, be the protector of her home and rule with compassion and kindness. C'yra was supposed to be a good kid, following the path that was laid out for her, and grew up to be the good guy.

But Catra was nothing like her. Even in the Horde, Catra had to grow a thick skin, had to learn how to spit back, how to fight back, how to be strong, how to hide when she got hurt. Catra is rough, rude and lethal. That's what she had to be to survive for so long.

C'yra might have been Catra's past, but she has no connection with her anymore. Just a lost childhood, a wasted opportunity for a happier life that was taken away from her one night. A stranger to look at. The similarity is there, in their mismatched gold and

blue eyes, the stripes on their body, the ears and the tail, the way their eyes light up or the mischievous sideways smirk. But nothing more.

The little princess feels so strange it's hard to even call her Catra's past.

"I'm sorry kid." A whisper nothing more, she walks away from the last memory she sees as C'yra.

Happy, surrounded by her family, laughing.

Maybe it would have been better if they stay hidden.

Memories disappear into the darkness, the invisible ground she has walked upon disappearing too, Catra falling into the nothingness, eyes snapping open.

She is welcomed by pristine white walls, a soft mattress under her, warm blanket all over her. A minute or two passes before she realizes where she is. Obviously, the room is way too light and clean to belong to the Horde, she is not in the valley either. Oh, right. Halfmoon. She is probably in Halfmoon.

Catra stays still, not even moving an inch of her body, just staring up at the ceiling. She remembers most of her life here. It should comfort her, or at least she thought it would. Rather, it sets off a kind of flight or fight response in her she has never felt before. This place, this kingdom, the palace, was supposed to be her home, now it feels like a bubble trying to suffocate her. Maybe she is overwhelmed, maybe she understood she could never be the person she was before, maybe the realization of being a princess finally nailed the coffin.

Her ears perk up, sensitive to any sound around them, no one is coming to this room. She, however, feels Melog's eyes on her as they are carefully watching her from the foot of the bed.

How long was she out?

Catra's body moves on her own, as sudden like the snap of a stick. Melog jumps with her, Catra kicks down the blanket, feet touching the ground she dashes to the door. It's closed.

Her heart hammers against her ribcage, her chest borderline hurting. "Fuck!" She breathes heavily, kicking the door.

The room has no other exit, except the windows. Catra stares at them, her mind formulating a quick plan, she hurries to the window opening it with shaking hands. Her leg is already on the window ledge, ready to jump when Melog growls at her and bites her hand.

"Ah! Melog!" Catra looks at the magical cat with frantic eyes. "Leave me, we need to get out of here, *now* !"

Melog jumps at the window ledge, pushing away Catra's leg. "Why? Isn't it what you wanted?"

"I wanted to find Halfmoon, not getting to know I'm a fucking princess!"

"So you are going to just jump out of the window and run away?"

"Yeah, that's the plan!" Catra hisses, trying to climb over Melog, but the magical cat doesn't budge.

"You are panicking but running away isn't the answer Catra!" Melog pushes their head against Catra's chest, keeping her away from the window.

What will happen when you can't run away anymore?

The question echoes in her head, the question she has heard so many times and never had an answer for that. Is this a moment like this? Where she can't run away?

She just stares at Melog, her body frozen. Her heartbeat doesn't calm down, but at least her body doesn't shake anymore. The

magical cat looks back at her, Catra's emotions raging inside of Melog too. They tilt their head a little, a silent question.

"Then what should we do Melog?" Catra asks quietly. "We can't stay here."

Melog narrows their eyes, confused. "But they are your family. You wanted to find them."

"Well... Yeah, but... I'm not cut for being a princess. They are C'yra's family. Not mine. Not Catra's."

"C'yra is still you."

"No, she is *not* ." Catra harshly says. "They expect C'yra, but I'm not her... I'm a defected Horde soldier, half of Etheria, if not all, probably wants me dead, Melog." She reminds the magical cat with a sharp look.

"You don't know what they expect from you," Melog points out. "You didn't even talk with them."

At that Catra's snarky remarks silenced, logic slowly sweeping through the panic-induced fog around her mind. "I start to think you are not on my side."

"I'm on your side, but I also know how you feel. You are scared and confused and that's why you want to run away, you didn't even give them a chance."

"I..." Words die in her throat and Catra slowly closes her mouth. She just looks at Melog, narrowing her eyes with a forming pout. "I hate when you are in my head."

"I'm still not in your head," Melog says, voice much lighter this time. "So, do you still want to jump?"

"In fact, yes, I still do." Catra crosses her arms. "But I'm staying. Mainly because we need to get Double Trouble. Not because I want to be a royal or have anything to do with the crown." Catra

announces looking at Melog with intention. "And I still don't know how I ended up at the Horde."

"You still don't have all of your memories?"

"Most of them yes, but not all. I need to know how the Horde found this place."

Melog just nods, knowing and feeling that Catra has calmed down enough for her to see things logically and not with fear and panic influencing her judgement over the situation. They could still feel Catra's uneasiness, but at least the magical cat tried to push it away and control it. Melog was proud of her.

They nuzzled against Catra's cheeks, purring lightly. Catra chuckles, petting their head, tail swaying around lazily.

Their moment was interrupted by the click of the door, Catra turning around claws already unsheathed and ears pulled back in alarm, Melog reacting to her, growls loudly at the open door, their mane and tail turning red.

A tall figure walks into the room, his clothing expensive and a little over the top if you ask Catra, red suit decorated with gold and white. Half of his red hair is pulled up into a bun, the rest reaches until his chin. He has golden eyes, similar stripes over his body - from what peaks out of the suit - reaching even under his eyes. Two weapons strapped to his belt, she eyes them warily. Catra spots a similar crystal on his earring, glowing softly.

She instinctively reaches for her own, still hanging in her neck.

He is certainly familiar, a name comes to her mind: *Leo.*

The newcomer looks surprised to see Catra at the open window and Melog sitting on the window ledge.

"Am I interrupting something?" He asks, his voice sounds almost melodious, confusion mixing with it.

Catra takes her time to declare the newcomer is not someone who can be threatening to her. She straightened her posture, claws remained out of the world. She places her hand on Melog's head, the magical cat calming down. Tail lashing around anxiously.

Silence settles them, Catra eyeing the man with sharp eyes.

"Who are you?" She asks, eventually.

That surprises the man, even more, he takes a hesitant step towards her, then quickly changing his mind he stays in one place. He seems to be confused and puzzled over the situation and Catra starts to feel the same.

"Leo. I'm Leo. Uhm... You brother?" He says uncertainly. "Do you not remember? Mom said you were in pain and didn't recognize her, but-"

Catra blinks, furrowing her brows. Brother? Oh. Yes. She has a brother. Great.

"What's a *brother* ?"

Leo stops speaking, face morphing into suspicion. "Are you joking with me?" He questions.

"No." Catra shrugs. "I have no idea what a brother is. Although I know what a parent is, I think..." She whispers the last part to herself.

She looks at Melog and the magical cat at her, sharing a look. Neither Melog knows what a brother is.

"Maybe it's an allied force? Oh, or a code name for a guard?" Melog suggests, tilting their head in question.

"Are you a guard?"

Leo just blinks at them, getting more and more lost. "What-... No? No, I'm not. I'm the prince. And, your brother. You know."

"No, I don't. I already told you. I start to think you don't know what a brother is either since you are refusing to tell me." Catra narrows her eyes on him. "Are you trying to fight with me perhaps? It's not like I'm against it."

"A brother means a sibling who is a male. We are siblings, related, you know... Like a family? Do you know what a family is?" He asks cautiously.

"What do you think I am? An idiot? Of course, I know what a family is!" She hisses at him crossing her arms. "So...We are a family? Do I have more... Uhm, brothers?"

"No, it's only me. What... What is going on C'yra? You... Come back after 15 years, and sneak into the palace, and then... You don't remember mom? Or me? What happened? We all thought you..." His voice fades, looking away from the catgirl.

Catra looks at him, a little lost there. Oh. "You thought I died? Meh, I wish." She shrugs. "And stop calling me C'yra. I'm Catra."

"No, you are C'yra."

Catra moves swiftly across the room, cornering Leo to the wall, her arm against his neck. "I said my name is Catra." She growls at him. "Not C'yra. C'yra is dead."

Leo just looks at her, completely stunned. He probably searches for that little girl from the past, but fails to find it in Catra. She lets him go eventually after he weakly nods. Melog asks her if she is okay, she doesn't answer.

"What... Happened to you?" The man whispers.

"None of your business."

They stand there in silence, it's uncomfortable and suffocating making Catra's skin crawl with the need to escape from here. She looks at Melog, who moves around their tail wildly, mirroring how

Catra feels. Her own tail wraps around her waist slowly. The magical cat locks eyes with her, trying to calm her down.

"Everything is okay. Nothing bad will happen."

Catra chooses to believe them. What could be the worst that can happen? They would lock her here or something? She would eventually find her way out.

"Where am I?" She breaks the silence eventually.

"Oh, in the infirmary. Mom brought you here after you... Fainted." He speaks carefully with her. Catra doesn't mind. "You were out for 2 days."

Catra whips her head towards Leo's with wide eyes. "Two days? Oh, fuck." She hisses, pushing her overgrown bangs back.

Leo winces at the curse but says nothing.

"I need to get out of here, now." She turns walking to the door, Leo stepping in front of her, blocking the door.

"You can't leave the infirmary until a healer checks on you," Leo informs here with a rather strict voice. He is at least two heads taller.

Catra doesn't like it. "Okay, I will just jump out of the window then." She simply says, Melog even comes down from the ledge so Catra can take action.

"Wait... What? You wouldn't-"

"Wanna bet?" She grins up at him.

"It's too high! You would die!"

"I still have two lives."

"T-two... *Two* lives? What? What have you done with the other *seven* ?!" Leo finally lost his cool, freaking out to Catra's biggest

delight.

The royal siblings stare at each other, Catra stubbornly not budging neither Leo. That seems to be a common trait in the family, Catra draws out her claws, ears moving forward in alert. Attack or jump. Two possibilities, both of them very alluring.

"C'y-"

A grin, nothing more and Catra move.

The moment her body falls she feels the familiar tingling of Melog's magic, concealing them from the world. Catra chuckles to herself, sliding down along the roof of the side building attached to the palace. It was a fairly easy jump, nothing serious or dangerous, compared to the stunts she has pulled in the past.

"It would have been helpful if a healer checks on you," Melog tells her once they are on solid ground, still on a rooftop of one of the many buildings attached to the palace.

"I don't need a healer, I'm completely fine," Catra reassures them with a smile and a long pet. "Now, we need to find Double Trouble."

Melog looks up at her, blue eyes narrowing. "Are you sure you are okay?"

"Yeah, I told you."

"I don't mean physically. You just met with your brother." Melog points it out as if she doesn't know already. Catra rumbles at that walking forward to the edge of the rooftop. "And your mother."

"And?"

"Catra."

Catra stays silent, looking down at the rooftop. It's a garden below them or at least part of a garden. They have many different

flowers Catra has never seen before, although it was hard to see any in the Fright Zone.

"Are you trying to run away again?"

"No." She says stubbornly, turning towards Melog. "I just... I need time. Okay? It's a lot. We are not going to be a happy family, I... I can't tell them what happened in the Horde-... I don't even know them, they are strangers to me." Catra sighs, sitting down, drawing her knees to her chest hugging them.

Melog walks to her and sits down around her, purring lightly, knowing that it helps Catra when she is upset.

But it's more than simply being upset. It's fear, confusion, guilt mixing. Shadow Weaver's voice, just like always, echoes in the deepest part of her mind. Reminding her that no one would love her, and she is basically nothing. That she is just a waste of space.

"I never... I never had someone who I could... Call mom or, you know, a mom who loved me." She speaks softly, ears pinned back. "Shadow Weaver wasn't a... She uhm... She didn't love me, I always knew, but... Secretly I hoped that I was wrong... She raised me and Adora, but I was never enough for her, she never... She never worried for me, or really cared much, except when I fucked up, then..." Her voice falters, memories of red electrical lights, pain soothing through her body, words that still cut, they are all still something she remembers clearly.

Melog says nothing, just listens to her.

Catra shakes lightly, trying to control it by hugging herself closer. Memories of her childhood and teenage years come to the surface like wild water when the damn brokes.

She never told these to anybody, not even Adora. As a child it wasn't as easy, Adora would pick up on her limp or tear-soaked cheeks and red eyes. As they grew up, hiding became easier. She found her own places where she can hide and cry, where she can

hate Shadow Weaver and herself. Hiding her pain became easier, acting like the words didn't affect her.

The familiar feeling of numbness slowly spreads through her body. It's not out of panic or a coming breakdown, more like a protective mechanism from her mind and body. Trying to relive the memories without causing more damage, without sending her down to a spiral of self-blame and hate, pain.

"Then she would hurt me... I don't...I was a *child* . I never knew what I did wrong or why..." She speaks in a monotone tone. "Then, as I grew up I understood that no matter what I do, she will always find ways to hurt me. Physically or verbally."

Some wounds would heal, some would stay with her forever. Most of them stayed, forcing Catra to carry them on her body, a memory, a reminder of how useless she was, how much of a failure she was in Shadow Weaver's eyes.

She has learnt quickly how to stay out of her sight, how to minimize those punishments and scars. Two simple rules, never are better than Adora and never be the last. So she settled for the second-best. There were times when she knew she could beat Adora, but instead, she lost. It left a bad taste in her mouth, a bitter feeling harboured for the one who was so dear to her.

By the time they had reached their last cadet years, Catra knew all of the training grounds. Having secretly sneak into the training facility at night or early dawn when no one was around, going through them again and again, getting to know every possible outcome and coming up with strategies that were efficient and quick.

It was much easier, working under no pressure, no fear. Just Catra in her elements. People thought she was lazy for turning up late, when in reality she was already in, already running through the simulation and waiting for the others.

"She never said she was proud of me... Or that she loved me. She was never a mother to me, but now..." She stares at the old tile under her feet. "I know I'm not C'yra and what if they would hurt me again?" Catra questions, Melog probably never has heard her voice to be so empty. "What if they will hurt me too?"

Empty.

Probably that's the best to describe Catra right now. Empty. A gaping hole in her soul that's been growing deeper and bigger with each year, month, day, hour. She tried to fill it with so many things, burying herself into working out plans and strategies, throwing herself into fights even if it would endanger her, in hopes of feeling a little alive. Sometimes they have worked, other times it just made her more miserable. Trying to destroy the Princes Alliance. Well, that didn't go well either.

As much it hurts to admit, it was a little better, a little bearable with Adora. She seemed to understand how to handle Catra, who was Catra really. But eventually, Adora left too.

"After all, I'm only good at disappointing people." She scoffs humorlessly.

Melog says nothing, and Catra appreciates that. She isn't interested in sugar-coated words of how awesome or wonderful she is in reality. They don't help, they just make things worse. So they sit in silence on top of the rooftop, until Catra finds back to herself again, shaking off the shackles of the past that climbed back onto her back.

The fact that Melog can read her emotions so easily helps a lot with their connection and relationship, as Melog most of the time knows what Catra needs, a warm cuddle, a few words or space and silence. They also remind Catra to think before she acts on her emotions, like when she first wanted to jump off the window.

It takes time, they don't know how much exactly. The sky is always peppered with millions of stars and moons shining down

on them. A familiar scene Catra knows in her heart. Somehow calming.

Catra eventually stands up, dusting off her clothing. "Let's find Double Trouble."

Melog nods in agreement, both of them jumping down from the rooftop to the garden, still invisible to the world.

"Can you sense them?" Catra turns to Melog after another turn to an empty hallway. Melog shakes their head. Catra just sighs. She sniffs into the air, but no trace of Double Trouble. "I don't think that they have been let go." She wonders, continuing their walk.

"Maybe we should have asked Leo before jumping off the window."

Catra grimaces but nods shortly. "That wouldn't have been a bad idea, yeah."

Another turn, another empty hallway. Everything just looks damn same, guards are around some of the doors, Catra and Melog sneak around them easily, oftentimes choosing to walk on the bedposts instead of the ground. She heard guards talking about her, probably searching too at some point.

So far she has found the great library, the war room - or she thinks it is - and a few spare rooms. Eventually, the two leave this side of the palace by climbing out of the window up to the rooftop. Catra looks around with squinted eyes, there are a dozen other side buildings attached to the enormous palace.

It will be a nightmare to find them.

"Idea?"

"Not yet." Catra scowls. "This place is more confusing than the Fright Zone."

Catra's ear twitching as a familiar distant voice echoes out of a window. She looks down, seeing a balcony below themselves, she jumps Melog following her without a word. They are invisible either way, no one would see them anyways. They land easily, Catra crouches waiting for a few seconds to hear the voice again.

"At least their "prison" is fashionable and comfortable."

The catgirl's face lights up hearing Double Trouble's voice, standing up and hurrying to the door that leads into the room. The curtains are drawn from the inside, she pushes down the handle, but the door is closed.

"Oh for fuck's sake!" She growls, stepping back.

The noises from inside cease for a long minute, Catra freezes too. Maybe they are not alone? "Is that you, kitten?"

"No, your worst nightmare. " She rolls her eyes. "What do you think? Let me in."

The curtain is pulled away and Double Trouble fishes out some kind of rod out of their pocket, trying to open up the door, with one or two trials of errors, it clicks open. Catra takes them into account, no bruises or wounds, no one hurt them. Okay, that's good.

She can feel Melog's knowing eyes on herself, she rather pretends she doesn't.

"Well, look at you. The princess of Halfmoon came to save me!" Double Trouble mocks a small clap with a teasing smile. "I've heard about your entrance from one of the guards."

“Don’t mention it.”

"Are you well?"

Catra sighs, sitting down on one of the chairs. The room looks quite nice, not like a prison but an over-decorated guest room. Did her mother know they were with her?

"Some of my memories resurfaced and I fainted. But I'm okay now." She tells, Melog walking next to her sitting down. She pets their head. "What about you? Are you okay?"

"Aww, were you worried for me darling?" Double Trouble teases hopping onto the desk next to Catra and bopping her nose.

She hisses lightly, scrunching up her nose. "I was simply worried about my promised three-headed snake lessons." She scoffs crossing her arms.

The shapeshifter chuckles at that. "They just threw me in here, I tried to get out a few times but they caught me each time. They didn't even question me." They tell Catra with a weirded-out look.

That's certainly strange, yes.

"We can get out of here, Melog can spread their magic onto you two, making us invisible," Catra explains to them.

"Wait, are we not staying?" Double Trouble looks confused at her. "Wasn't the point of this whole ordeal to find your family? You certainly did, darling."

"It's... Complicated."

"What did you do?"

Catra looks at Double Trouble with wide shocked eyes. "I didn't do anything!" Melog looks up at her again, the other noticing it too. "Well... Okay, I may have jumped out of a window when my newfound brother didn't want to let me out of the infirmary. But

other than that I did not cause chaos or any trouble." She announces proudly.

Double Trouble blinks at her, then slowly they raise an eyebrow. "So you just jumped out of a window? A *window* !"

"Don't worry, I'm okay. I still have two lives." She flashes them a fanged grin.

"What?" Double Trouble looks more lost than ever. "You have multiple lives?"

"Duh."

"I think it's something that we should have talked about *beforehand* ."

"I thought it was obvious."

"How could it be obvious?!"

“I’m partly a cat?”

“And I’m partly a lizard, darling, yet I don’t break off my tail!”

“Wait, you can do that?”

“No!”

The door opens, interrupting them.

They look behind, Catra on her feet in a second recognizing the red-haired woman - her mother - from before, her blue eyes zero on Catra. The catgirl contemplates jumping out of the window again but eventually abandons the idea. The two guards behind the catwoman look equally afraid, so Catra assumes she has created some kind of chaos after all.

She will just play it cool.

"Hey," she waves simply.

"You have jumped out of a window." That's the first thing the woman says, strutting to the table the two sit.

"Why is everyone so freaked out because of that?"

"You could have gotten *hurt* !"

Catra just shrugs, not liking the worried expression from a stranger. "Well, I didn't. Can we get over that? Why did you lock up my friend?"

"So are we friends now?" The shapeshifter turns to Catra.

Their comment stays unanswered. "They have infiltrated into the kingdom. Of course, I'm not letting them roam freely? Besides, they had a very great accommodation for a prisoner." She points around the room with an unimpressed look. "I need to talk with you, Catra."

"Oh, so you people have learned my name finally. Wonderful." She says sarcastically, Melog nudging her thigh to be nicer.

The catwoman takes a deep breath. "Your brother mentioned you didn't like him calling you C'yra."

"Because that's not my name."

If Catra noticed the hurt flashing through her mother's eyes, she didn't react to that.

"Come with me, after that your friend will be free to go wherever they want." The catwoman says, turning around and walking out of the room expecting Catra to come too.

Catra huffs, "Please stay Melog, if you feel me getting upset just use your magic and we will meet at the gate." She simply says, petting the magical cat's head with a gentle smile.

"Wait-"

Double Trouble's voice dies down the moment the door closes.

Maybe leaving Melog there wasn't the best idea, but she has a hunch that this conversation will determine whether they would stay longer or not. She can easily slip away, but Double Trouble may not.

They really grew up on her, huh.

She follows the catwoman, staying behind by a few steps. She frequently looks behind, no guards are on their toes. Are they not afraid that Catra would attack or even kill their Queen? Part of her tells her that they are probably underestimating her, but again, her mother may have wanted to speak with her in private. Right, because Catra is really good with talking.

She takes a deep breath and pushes her hair down, collecting herself. She forces her ears straight up and commands her tail to a more calm movement. For the outside world, she looks completely collected and calm, while her mind might be in a storm of emotions. Her heart picks up, Catra ignores it.

They eventually reach a garden, a different one than where Melog and Catra ended after the jump. It's much wider and has red-leafed trees a bit far away from them, flower beds all around them, the catwoman walks to a stone bench. Catra follows her.

They sit, each at the other end. Catra would appreciate the view or even the nice scent of the flowers if she wouldn't be this nervous.

You don't owe them anything, you don't have to stay or tell them anything. She reminds herself. Her body winces when the catwoman starts to speak, breaking the silence between them.

"It would probably be strange or uncomfortable to you to call me mom, please, call me Kaira."

Catra looks at Kaira, she sits straight, shoulders rolled back and chin up high. Proud and collected. But Catra can see the way her

leg moves up and down, it's not just the catgirl who is full of emotions. She guesses it must not be easy for Kaira too.

"Yeah, that would be... Better."

Silence again.

She glances up at the sky, always filled with stars and moons. A familiar scenery. She hopes for a memory, a flashback, but nothing happens. Maybe it's for the better.

"I come here every year once, taking a tiger lily with myself, bringing it to the memorial and singing your lullaby," Kaira speaks up, her voice soft. "On your birthday, I would have grieved my daughter who I lost and couldn't see growing up. It's been 15 years... I've come to accept your absence every day a little more, but it hurt just the same. And then, one day, I sense your scent in the palace. I thought my mind was playing a game with me, but it was just too real. And here you are." She looks at Catra, her eyes misty a mix of pain and joy. "But you don't remember us, right?"

Catra glances away when Kaira looks at her. She rather stares at her own feet. "Right." She agrees shortly.

"How... What happened?"

Silence settles between them again. It's a question that seemed to be inevitable, after all, they would all want to know where she was for 15 years. How old was she again when they last saw her? Catra takes a deep sigh, pulling up one knee.

"I don't know... I don't remember that either. And before you would ask, I gained back a little bit of my memory. I remember faces, names and a few places, but nothing more." She finishes a little more harshly than she intended.

"I see." Kaira nods, looking at the trees in the distance. "Where were you for so long?"

"In the Horde." the answer tumbles out without even thinking about it. If they want to hurt me, better get over it quickly, she thinks.

Kaira whips towards her, eyes widened in shock and confusion. Her mouth opens but falls shut not knowing what to say. Probably thousands of theories run through her head before she collects herself again. She clears her throat, trying to control the shaking of her body. "How?"

Catra shrugs, trying to play nonchalant. "They wiped my memories. Raised as a soldier. That's it."

"A... A soldier? You were..."

Catra lets out a little humourless laugh. "Yes, I *fought* for the Horde. As a matter of fact, I became Force Captain just two years ago, the youngest. I reinforced the Horde, taking lead against the Princes Alliance. Then I became second in command. I basically co- *lead* the Horde." She scoffs, bitter anger bubbling in her veins, the desire to hurt Kaira awakens in her.

Because how dare she act like that? How dare Kaira act so surprised and play the victim here? Did she even search for Catra? Did she even try to find her? Or just hid in Halfmoon and wept for her while Catra grew up in a living hell fighting for a chance to survive.

She has no right to look at her like this, with pity and sadness. Catra doesn't need her pity.

Her collective and calm mask starts slipping off, her tail moving around angrily. Pupils narrowing down.

"Don't look at me like that." She growls at the catwoman. "I don't need your pity. I was doing fine, you know?" Lie. It burns her throat.

Catra feels herself slipping again, she sinks her claws into her palm, grounding herself with pain.

Kaira seemingly can't find her words. Stunned by the truth that her daughter was not just alive for so long, but raised as a child soldier, rising to the point where she commanded the Horde.

"I don't... Oh, Catra, I-"

"What? Do you want to say that you're sorry? Or do you wish you could change the past? Bet you would have liked if I was dea-"

Kaira suddenly stands up, her pupils in a thin slit. "Don't you even *dare* to finish that sentence!" Kaira's voice booms through the garden, petrifying Catra, words dying in her throat. She just stares at the catwoman. "Don't think - not even for a second - that I would wish death on you, no matter what you have done! You are still my daughter, my blood and kin."

Anger takes over Catra again, melting away her shock. She stands up on the bench, to be eye to eye with Kaira. "You are fucking crazy! How can you say that? You don't even know me! You don't even know what I did! I conquered Salineas! *Destroyed* a whole kingdom, worked up a plan to destroy the runestones and the princess, and it worked!! I almost destroyed the world! I almost killed my best friend! I hurt and killed people!" Catra's voice raises and raises with each word, almost screaming with a broken voice. "I'm not the good guy!"

She pants heavily as she finishes, her mind searching, digging into memories, painful and dark ones. Telling every bit of wrong she has even done, just so Kaira can hate her. Just so she can despise her, because how can she still love her? How can Kaira still look at her with eyes filled with love?

"Why are you not hating on me, cursing on me, hitting me?" She grits her teeth, hands balled into fists. "Why can't you just simply hate me? Why do you look at me like this?!" She doesn't understand, can't wrap her mind around it.

Kaira reaches out, holding Catra's shaking fists in her hand, gently prying away her claws from her palm. She looks at Catra again,

soft and warm.

She wants to run.

"I told you, you are my daughter. And I will love you until the day this world ceases to exist. I loved you the moment I got to know your momma was expecting you, I loved you always. You did terrible things, and it broke you. I can see it."

"Don't... Don't-!" Catra tries to yank her hands away, Kaira holds her wrist stronger.

"But you are here, not in the Horde." She continues, with the most gentle voice Catra has ever heard. "You left. You chose to change, you chose to do better, sweetheart."

Catra almost wheezes from how hard she breathes, she can feel her legs getting weaker too, her body shakes once again. The control she had over herself, slipped away, once again. She just stares at Kaira with wide eyes. Confused and lost.

"I don't know what happened with you in the Horde, and you don't have to tell me, I won't force you. But you should know, you *must* know that I will always love you Catra. Do you hear me? No matter what happened, no matter what will happen." She reassures her once again.

It's so weird. Strange. Her only mother figure was Shadow Weaver. She would have shocked her by now, hit her, made her regret even raising her voice. Calling her crazy. But Kaira just tells her she loves her no matter what. What kind of bullshit is that? Catra finally tears her hands away, looking at Kaira warily, ready to face any danger.

"Is it some kind of trap? Are you waiting for me to let my guard down?"

The words, even the implication, visibly hurt Kaira, retracting her hands.

"I would never hurt you. Not with words, not with actions."

"Bullshit." Catra growls, stepping back a little.

Footsteps. Catra's ears pick up quickly, twitching forward. That's it, a lie. Of course. They are probably the guards, coming for her. Oh no, she will not go down without a fight. She pounces at the figure stepping into the garden, Catra's mind too alerted, focused on fighting and surviving to notice who it is.

"CATRA! LEO!"

Kaira screams. Catra's claw slashes through the skin. Leo shouts in pain.

In a snap, Catra's mind clears up, enough for her to see the reality.

She kneeling on Leo's chest, three claw wounds bleeding on his forearm. Catra jumps back, stumbling on her legs, falling to the ground. Her chest heaves, her claws retract back immediately, ears pinned back. Kaira comes to Leo, kneeling next to him asking something from him, but Catra can't hear them. The noises blur together again, her ear starting to ring loudly, drowning out every sound. Her heart beats in her throat, she tries to stand up but her body doesn't obey her.

That's it, they are going to hate you. Throw you out. Hurt you.

Leo reaches towards her, Catra's first instinct was to wince, squeezing her eyes and shielding her face with her arms, tucking her knees to her chest.

A second passes, then another. Why didn't he attack her yet?

"Catra?" Leo calls, his voice comes closer. Not threatening.

Slowly, Catra opens her eyes. Her arms are still up in defence.

She sees Leo looking at her with worry, Kaira behind her. Catra is sure that by now the realization dawned on her mother at least. Normally people don't have reactions like this.

"I'm not going to hurt you." Leo tries to calm her down, it pushes Catra away instead.

They are talking with her as if she was a wild animal, and needs to be tamed and a break-in. She scoots away, at least arms brought down, looking warily at Leo then Kaira.

"I hurt you..." She mutters. "Why wouldn't you want to hurt me too?"

Leo furrows his brows. "This will heal quickly. You got scared. I shouldn't have eavesdrop and suddenly appear. I'm sorry."

Catra really doesn't understand them. Why are they like this? Why can't they just hate Catra, curse her out? It would have been easier, familiar in a morbid sense. She isn't used to this, kindness and compassion. Of course, Huntara showed her kindness and Double Trouble is basically considered her friend, but none of them was this tender to her. She only let Adora be like this with her.

They just want to hurt you, run away. Quick.

Catra swallows dryly. "I... It's okay..." She croaks out, voice rough.

Run away.

"Sorry."

Leo shakes his head, offering a hand to Catra to help her up from the ground.

They will hurt you, just like everyone.

Catra stares at his hand, hesitantly accepting it.

They will leave you.

Kaira eyes her daughter carefully, her mind clearly somewhere else. She doesn't say anything, Catra glances at her still expecting a slap or anything. But it never comes. Instead.

"Do you want to spend dinner with us? Your friend could join too." Kaira offers, Catra silently nods.

You will end up alone and hurt again.

The dinner is quite surreal if you ask Catra.

She sits with her long-lost family, Kaira at the head of the table, Leo at the other end. Another man has waltzed in, short black hair, golden eyes, and royal clothing, her uncle Leon, who looks rather stunned seeing her. Simply saying "So the rumours were true." His mate, Perra. Long, curly black hair and curious orange eyes. They all sit at the opposite side of Catra, while she and Double Trouble sit at the other side.

Double Trouble curiously eyes the royals, who are stunned and probably a tad uncomfortable in the presence of their presumed dead niece, her magical cat, a shapeshifter mercenary.

She is still trippy, the chaos in her head subdued but it still roars to some extent, her mind playing the scenario again and again. Confusion still taking over her, not quite understanding where this unconditional trust and care comes from towards her by Kaira and Leo. She doesn't buy the bullshit 'you are my daughter' line, for her, it feels like a trap, anxiety tugging on her heart.

Catra simply stares at her plate while the others indulge in small talk, she hears Double Trouble speak next to her. Amused at best. Well, they did want to find them Halfmoon too, although for completely different reasons.

Leon clears his throat, Catra looks up, golden eyes lock with her mismatched ones. A strange feeling taking over her. She didn't have the time or attention to take him into account.

He has a rather ugly scar spread from his left temple across his nose bridge, cheeks, ending at his jaw at the right side. His hair combed back, one small tendril falling to his forehead, he has a similar amulet like Catra, however, it is wrapped around with gold, the glow so weak it barely pulsates with fire. The clothing is expensive and almost more decorative than Kaira's herself. Strange.

"Yes?" Catra asks eventually after the man refuses to lower his gaze.

"Oh, I'm sorry." He speaks, his voice was croaky, almost gruff. A deep, but healed scar peaks out of his high collar. "It's just, last time I've seen you, you were only a little girl. No more than 5 years old, and now." His voice trails off, Catra doesn't urge him to continue.

Leon doesn't seem like someone who was built for battle. Unlike Leo, who obviously put up muscle or her mother, Leon seems like someone who never even tried to swing a sword or use their claw more than a toothpick. Then where do his scars come from?

"We are delighted to see you again, C'yra dear," Perra speaks up, her voice is gentle, melodic. A real lady, if Catra ever saw one. Hair held back elegantly, jewellery adorning her body, and a beautiful orange dress, suitable for lounging. Wait, how does Catra know that?

"Catra. My name is Catra." She reminds her dryly, cutting into the meat on her plate.

Confusion flashes through the two, their eyes falling on Kaira for answers. The woman doesn't answer, pretending like the pair doesn't even exist engaging in small talks with Double Trouble. On the other hand, her brother seems to be so rigid and just eats in silence, as if he knows already how this diner would end.

"I can speak for myself." Catra arches her slit eyebrow.

"O-of course, we didn't mean to... It's just." Perra tries to find the words, somehow flustered under Catra's slitted eyes.

Something is strange, that's for sure. Or they just really don't know where to put Catra's presence and her companion’s. Not to mention Melog, who lounges under the table, curled around Catra's leg. They haven't spoken for a while now, which worries Catra a little.

She can particularly feel Double Trouble vibrate next to her, with excitement or curiosity, perhaps both. They share a look, the shapeshifter's eyes almost sparkling. Someone at least having a good time.

"We at least know how old you are now. Do you want a birthday party, darling?" Double Trouble nudges her, whispering to her. Then, they drink from the wine.

Catra scoffs. She already put together that she might be 20 years old, or 21. Depends on the date she has been born. Does that consider old? Or young? She isn't sure.

"You seem to be having fun." She mentions, cutting another piece from the meat.

"Well, you can particularly cut through the tension and throw it at someone like a brick. They clearly don't like each other." They chuckle lowly, eyeing Leon and than Kaira. "Pretty interesting."

"Are you going to try and wreak havoc?" Catra questions.

Double Trouble just grins. "Oh, I won't be needed for that."

Catra observes the diner table. Perra fidgets around a little, stealing glances at Catra and Double Trouble. Not suspicious or dangerous, just, unsure. Which is a little understandable. Leon snaps for one of the maids to bring more wine, his tone bossy, the maid hurries away. Leo on the other hand has finished his meal, excusing himself to tend some paperwork with the council. He hurries away too, tense shoulder relaxing as he gets away from the table. Kaira, master of ignoring Perra and Leo still, posture completely relaxed and calm.

"Dear sister-in-law," As in cue, Leon speaks again. Eyes darted at Kaira. "When do you wish to announce that our beloved C'yra has come back?" He asks, Catra looking at him sharply by the use of the name.

Kaira turns her gaze at Leon, the slight mírth from the golden eyes disappearing. " *Catra* 's arrival will be announced to the court and the council whenever the time will be ready for that. Do not worry, Leon. Enjoy your meal."

"Wait, what? Why does it need to be announced?" Catra looks at her mother, confused.

"Artlessly, now that the princess has returned she must start her training to connect to the Tiger's eyes and take over the throne as the rightful heir and future Queen."

Catra turns to Leon. "I didn't ask *you* ."

"You do not dictate the future of the throne, Leon," Kaira speaks harshly at the same time as her daughter.

"I do not intend to dictate anything here, dear sister-in-law. I am simply concerned."

"She will start her training whenever she feels ready."

"She is already 15 years late!"

"You have no right-"

"I belong to this bloodline as well, as the brother of Norra!"

"Do *not* speak her name!"

Catra growls, standing up, her fist on the table, it shakes by the impact. Silence settles down, Double Trouble giggles to themselves. Melog is suddenly on the table, growling into Leon's face viciously. "Let me make something clear. I won't EVER touch a runestone let alone use its powers, I detest magic. If you ever bring that thing near me, I will make sure to break it into tiny pieces, and after, I will do the same with your bones." She zeroes her eyes on Leon, the magical cat snarling into his face. The man is stunned and terrified. "I don't like when people tell me what to do, especially if they do it as if I'm incapable of deciding for myself or as if I'm invisible."

"C'yra, dear-" Leon stutters.

"CATRA!" She yells. "My name is CATRA, you better learn it quickly." Her claws sink into the table, an indication of what will happen to Leon if he angers Catra further.

"Catra, please, sit. And drawback your Astral." Kaira asks her, voice calm and collected again.

The catgirl doesn't listen until Double Trouble holds onto her wrist. Not tightly or roughly, just a gentle, grounding gesture. Catra glances down at that, looking at the shapeshifter. They are looking back at her with a raised eyebrow, not in a challenge, more like in a question. 'Do you want to cause a fight?'

She sighs, tail twitching in irritation. "Melog. That's enough." She says, retracting her claws. Melog disappears then appears next to Catra, mane switching from red to purple, mixing into a muted purple sometimes. The familiar clearly visualizing how Catra tries to control her anger.

"I will be glad to bite his face off at any minute."

"I will hold you onto that," Catra promises in her head, Melog hearing her here too. "What's an Astral?"

"That's how they have called my kind."

The diner continues in silence, Leon, and Perra soon leaving without really finishing their meal. Leon looks like he is going to explode with rage, and Catra actually chuckles at that. Served you right, she thinks.

"You shouldn't have done that," Kaira speaks up once the door closes.

"What, are you trying to scold me?"

"No, Leon might be irritating at his best, but he holds power. He is your momma's brother after all."

"What can he possibly do?" It's Double Trouble who voices their question.

Kaira sighs. "There's... Well, I'm the Queen. I was crowned Queen after... After Norra's death," She looks away from Catra, taking a deep breath. "before, I was only Queen Consort. I could only hold onto the crown because your grandmother had my back and insisted that I should be the ruler since Norra was my mate and we had two children together, therefore securing the bloodline. Part of the council wanted Leon instead. It was messy, turning everything into a political mess. I'm half sure that Leon still wants the crown." She lets out a defeated sigh. "I'm sorry. It's your first day at Halfmoon and everything is already overwhelming.

"What's a home without drama and ploy."

Catra can't sleep. It's not new, everything is so new and unfamiliar to her.

She didn't even near the bed, only sitting in the middle of the floor holding the amulet in her hands. She wishes she would have brought the book with her. At least it would have calmed her down a little. Her thoughts wander to the valley, to the princesses, to Adora. Catra shakes her head stubbornly, she can't think about them now, she has plenty on her plate already. With a sigh, the magicat stands up, padding across her room and sneaking out Melog in her toe.

Their magic conceals them from the world.

"Where are we going?" Melog questions.

"I don't know... Just, around a little." Catra whispers, walking around the hallways, moonlight cascading into the building through the big and open windows.

Catra stops and looks out of them, the stars twinkling above the night sky, strangely there's only one moon above the sky. Catra assumes it's made out of magic. She continues walking around until she finds herself in a different kind of hallway.

It's more like an open room, from both sides, with many portraits hung on the walls and glass display cases scattered around. One holds a dagger, but Catra can see a necklace too or a book in the dimly lit room. She walks around, silently looking around. There's no text attached to the cases, so she doesn't exactly understand what are those and why they are being displayed.

Her eyes wander to the walls, the portraits. She spots Queen Nefi's at first. Then her eyes glide across the others, they show the previous queens of Halfmoon with their family or other times alone.

She stops at one, looking up at it with a tilted head.

She doesn't recognize the Queen or the King, who she recognizes is the young Leon, without the scar on his face or neck, looking just as insufferable on the portrait in his youth. Catra looks at the catwoman on the other side. She gasps, taking a step back.

The catwoman looks like Catra. Her mane kept in a low ponytail, eyes gold and mischievous almost. The only difference is that she doesn't have freckled cheeks.

Catra steps back again, looking at the other portrait right next to this one.

On the portrait, there's a catwoman, looking hauntingly like Catra again. But more mature, her golden eyes radiate power and kindness at the same time. Her black mane is short, although the top half of it is held back. Her dress is intricate, gold and purple. Just now, she notices the other people around her. She recognizes Kaira, standing next to the other Queen with a proud smile. Her red mane braided and wearing matching clothes, headpieces even.

A boy standing in front of Kaira, their mane is a little wild, reaching up to his shoulders. And, a baby girl in the unnamed queen's arms. Mismatched eyes, wild black mane, stripes all over her arms.

Catra reaches out slowly, touching the old portrait with a shaking hand.

She remembers Kaira's words, the name. *Norra* . Her other mother. Norra, the rightful queen of Halfmoon, her mate and her children.

" *Momma* ?"

2. days ago.

Adora feels like a naive idiot.

She actually hoped, believed that she would finally meet with Catra. She braced herself for this moment during the whole travel from the Whispering Woods to the valley. She rehearsed what to say to her in her head, rethought it hundreds of times, expecting every possible reaction from Catra. Anger, sadness, rejection, happiness. She imagined they would hug, or even maybe argue. Adora really didn't care, she just wanted to see Catra, alive and well.

Instead, they are welcomed by the news that Catra is not in the valley.

"What do you mean Catra is *not* in the valley, anymore *?* " Huntara questions someone called Dam, who is looking equally uncomfortable and worried about the vagabond team Huntara has just brought here.

They don't look good, and Adora knows it. Perfuma is still out of the world, Frosta barely can move her right arm, Mermista still has her thigh bandaged and Bow still can't stand on his legs for longer than 5 minutes. They are exhausted, injured and lost.

"Well... Did she leave? I mean, I don't know how much you know Huntara, but boss came back from the last Horde settlement, then took her skiff, Double Trouble, then left. Boss said you are the boss until she is back... Wait, should I call you boss?" He asks, visibly confused. Then, he looks behind Huntara. "Are they okay?"

Huntara looks back at them. "No. They are not." Adora looks away. "But... Where did she go? Did she even say anything?"

Dam shakes his head. "No. She uhm... She was strange in the past week, she blew up more than 10 Horde settlements and threw the soldiers to the underground prison she had found a few days ago."

"She did what??" Adora asks, not being able to stay silent anymore. "C-catra did what?"

Dam looks at her a little unsure, then back to Huntara. "It's a long story. I think you need a healer more than storytime."

To her biggest displeasure, they are brought to a healer in the valley, who looks through them. An old lady, with skilful hands tending them all and providing shelter over their injured head. Huntara says the others can stay at the unoccupied houses. After they are fed, Huntara is about to leave them.

"Wait Huntara." Adora rushes after her, despite being clearly instructed to stay in bed. "Are you going to search for Catra?"

"You should rest."

"I don't want to rest until I see Catra." She says stubbornly. "I just... Please? I need to know what happened..."

Huntara looks back at the others, most of them already asleep, Micah and Castaspella speaking with the healer. "Fine, but after that, you need to rest, understood?"

Adora nods, following Huntara out of the house. She doesn't even pay attention to where they are going, the valley is just as busy as she remembered. But her mind is mainly set on Catra. Why did she leave? And where to? She seriously just wants to slap Catra and hug her at the same time, trying to stay angry but her disappointment and sadness just take over her heart.

It was a rollercoaster really.

First getting to know that Catra has defected, leaving the Horde without any trail. Then Entrapta hacked into the Horde's system,

getting the news of the executed liquidation order for Catra. They went to the place where the signal came and found nothing but absolute destruction. Then, when Adora thought everything was lost, Catra sent Huntara for them. But then she disappears again?

Adora really doesn't know what to think, what to do.

She just wants to see Catra, wants to hold her.

She stops abruptly after Huntara gets a hold of her shoulder. Adora smiles sheepishly up at the, they are in a makeshift hangar, a few skiffs lined up. A man walks to them, his shirt littered with oil patches, even his face. His right arm is a mechanic.

"What do you need Huntara?" He asks.

"Do you know where C. took her skiff?"

"Ahh... You are searching for the boss." He sighs, throwing away the cloth he dried his hand up. "I have no damn idea where that crazy woman took the baby. She took it in the morning to the last Horde settlement, but never returned with it. Next thing I know Sam says she went away." He shrugs.

Adora listens carefully. "Why did she go to Horde camps?"

The man looks at Adora curiously. "Hm... I don't really know. Boss is absolutely terrifying, I ain't gonna line, so what I'm saying is staying between us. Someone got onto the boss, using fire magic on her and everything. Then one night, all I hear is a scream from her house. Double Trouble went in before anyone could, all I heard was she wanting to destroy the Horde. The next day all I know is that Venus is liberated from the Horde's power. Soldiers were thrown into some freaky underground Magicat prison. This went through a week, then she disappeared. That's all I know."

Adora has never felt this confused in her life, or at least it was a long time ago. Magicat? Venus? Underground prison? What happened to Catra? Who was after her? Too many questions, no answers.

"She didn't leave anything behind? A message? Or... Or a letter? Something?" Adora asks, almost desperate.

She is losing Catra all over again.

The man just shakes his head. "Sorry blondie, I don't know anything about that. Boss was close with Huntara and Double Trouble, but they... You know."

Yeah, Huntara was with them. And Double Trouble is with Catra.

They go through a few people, all of them giving all over the same story. Some say that Catra almost fainted after they came back, others say she has spent a lot of time in the crypt again, or that she had a weird alien cat. Some mention a glowing amulet too.

Adora, eventually, just sits down to a rock and buries her head into her hands. Her hair falls forward, she takes a deep breath trying not to cry. Huntara kneels, squeezing her shoulder reassuringly.

"I'm sorry... She said... She said she wouldn't run away again, but... Something clearly has happened."

"I just... I just want to see her again, Huntara..." Her voice is muffled by her hand. "We were enemies for so long, I thought... I thought it could be fixed when you came and said Catra sent you, I... I was so happy." Her voice shakes. "And now... Catra is nowhere, again. And I... I have no idea what this all Magicat thing they are talking about, I don't know if she is in trouble if she needs help..."

"I will tell you what I know... But maybe, she has left something behind..." Huntara thinks about it. "Do you want to see her house?"

Adora looks up, glossy eyes fixed on Huntara. "Her house?"

"Yeah, where she stayed in the past 5 months... Maybe she left something behind? I doubt she took her notes and other stuff with herself. Come, I will show it."

So Adora goes. Because even the simplest hope of finding Catra could lead her to the edge of the world and she would go. Without thinking.

The door opens, revealing the place where Catra has lived. Adora steps inside, finding various maps stuck to the wall, they are labelled with different place names, Huntara says they are in the Crimson Waste, Catra spent a lot of her time mapping out the desert. Her table has a few old notebooks stacked up, ink and pen. Rolled up papers, a little messy, but so Catra at the same time.

She steps to the table, noticing a book. She gasps, reaching out for it hesitantly, remembering it in an instant. This time, she doesn't try to hold back her tears.

"Do you want a few minutes alone?" Huntara questions, still standing in the door.

Instead of saying a word, Adora nods instead. The door closes behind her.

She sits down at the table, flipping through the pages of the children book. A sad smile plays on the corner of her mouth, bittersweet memories flooding her brain. She puts it aside, taking one of the notebooks, finding messy handwriting and sketches of places Adora has never seen before. They are not Catra's handwriting that's for sure.

Another, one, however, is Catra's. It's almost like a diary, Catra writes about weird dreams, and flashbacks she would experience. She writes about a crypt too, the prison, Melog, the amulet. The voice she has heard, and the strange magical person who left the amulet to her. Then, it changes. The pages tell about the Horde, her last dreams about Shadow Weaver, how the sorceress wiped

all of her dreams away before the Horde and raised her as a soldier.

By the end, Adora's tears dried off, instead of anger setting fire in her eyes. "Of course Shadow Weaver." She scoffs, closing the notebook.

Even the mention of her name sets of fury and rage in Adora.

She stands up from the table, only now noticing a folded piece of paper on the unmade bed. With a heavily beating heart she reaches for it, anticipation builds up in her as she notices what's written on the outside.

To Adora.

With shaking hands, she opens it.

Adora's eyes run through the lines, eyes going wide and jaw-dropping softly. It is almost like knives being thrown into her heart over and over again. She hastily wipes away the tears streaming from her eyes, biting her lip to keep her from sobbing or crying out loud. She whimpers, slowly lowering herself to the ground, back against the bed and knees tucked to her chest.

She rereads the letter, again and again, feeling Catra's hurt and pain through her words. And the last words. They hurt the most. Adora clutches the letter close to her chest, curling to herself.

"You idiot. Catra you idiot. Idiot. Idiot." She repeats, crying in the silence of the room.

~~Dear Adora~~, Hey dummy.

You are probably in the waste by now, I hope you are alright, that you are safe.

I don't know what I should write. I'm sorry? That wouldn't be enough. Please don't be angry at me? Please don't hate me? Please forgive me? They are all useless, I've hurt you too many times Adora to hope for a future where we could be like before. Where it's just us, no She-ra, no princesses or Horde. Maybe a time like this never existed, we just hid from everything and liked to think that it's just us.

But I want you to know that I'm sorry. That I regret everything I've done. That I should have gone with you, even though I never liked the princesses, even though the Horde was my home, no, that's not true. The Horde never was my home, it was a place of pain and torture. You Adora, you were my home. You were my everything. You were everything for me. And I pushed you away, hurt you because I couldn't face myself, of what you were to me.

I was a coward. Maybe I still am. If I wouldn't be I would be in the valley welcoming you, right? Or at least showing my face to you, but here I am, in the middle of nowhere or maybe in Halfmoon. I don't know. Huntara probably told you about the lost kingdom of the Crimson Waste and what I've been doing in the waste for the past 5 months.

I don't have a lot of things for me in the waste, or Etheria in general. Everything I've had I lost or pushed away, I don't even know if I should just return to the waste. Part of me wants to, but I'm afraid Adora. I'm terrified of meeting with you, with the princesses. I've hurt so many people, how could I even face them? With you? I understand if you hate me, believe me, I wouldn't blame you, I deserve it.

If I could go back, would I be so selfish of not letting you go back to the sword or would I go with you? I don't know, I hope it's the latest. Letting you go wasn't easy, maybe I still couldn't let you go completely. But I want you to know that I truly feel sorry for everything.

I can't undo my mistakes, but I can try and better myself. Second chances and all. I guess.

Writing down these things may be easier than facing you, I hope you understand. I don't know if I will return. I said I would stop running away, and this is what I'm doing again, running away. But I want you to understand, to know this Adora. I think I've changed since the last time we've met, at least that's what Double Trouble and Huntara says. I don't know for sure, I often find myself in the dark again, remembering Shadow Weaver or our childhood. The Horde was nothing but pain, thank you Adora for making it a little more bearable, a little lighter.

Sometimes I wish you would be here when the nightmares are back when I feel alone when I feel homesick. You always knew how to calm me down, how to comfort me, something I need to learn by myself.

I want to ask so many things from you, I want to hug you, I want to hold your hand just like before. I want to sleep next to you, so the nightmares would stay away, so I would feel less lonely, so I could pretend that everything is okay between us for a few hours.

Are you happy? Are you okay? Are you safe? Are you worried? Are you hurt? Are you tired?

I miss you. I miss your stupid snorty laugh, I miss the way you would smile before you would come up with a stupid plan. I miss your hands in mine up on the rooftop. I miss you sleeping next to me, I miss your hug. I miss you. I miss you so much it hurts Adora. And I don't know how to stop it. I don't know how to stop hurting, because every time I remember your stupid face it hurts more. I just want to throw away everything and run to you.

But it's not that simple, right? It stopped being so simple a long time ago. If we ever meet again, I will say every word of this letter to you, I promise. But if not, it still gives me some peace knowing you will read my letter.

I want you to know that I don't hate you, I could never. Even when I tried I wasn't able to. I hate She-ra. I hate her for taking

you away from me. But maybe you were never mine, to begin with.

Goodbye, Adora.

Catra

next part announcment

Hello,

It's been a long time coming, don't worry, I'm not cancelling the book series. I planned to start writing when my exams finished, but a lot happened that kept me away from writing any of the fics that I wanted.

I'm writing this little memo so old and new readers would know that the next part is coming, it's in the process of being written - and will be posted this year. Just like the last time, I will post the first chapter when the story will be half written.

I'm sorry for making you wait for so long but thank you for still being interested in the story and supporting it.

- winter

End Notes

Thank you for reading! Have a great morning/day/night ♥

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!